STUDY GUIDE

STATISTICS, PROBABILITY AND STATISTICAL MODELLING FOR DATA WORK

A hands-on mini-textbook: from probability puzzles to regression, GLMs, Bayesian models, time series and experiments, taught with real numbers and runnable Python.

Taught the IIT Professor Way — Real Numbers. Real Problems. Real Understanding.

CHAPTER 1 Probability Through Problem Solving

CHAPTER 2 Distributions in Depth

CHAPTER 3 Sampling, Estimation, Confidence Intervals and the Bootstrap

CHAPTER 4 Hypothesis Testing in Depth

CHAPTER 5 Effect Sizes, Multiple Testing and How Data Fools You

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APPENDIX Cheat Sheet

A Note From Your Professor

You already work with numbers every day. Whether you read exam results, delivery times or shop sales, you meet averages, percentiles and error rates, and you must decide whether a new process is really "faster". This document teaches you to do that with proof instead of feeling. We start with probability puzzles that fool smart people, move through distributions, sampling, tests and regression, and finish with Bayesian methods, forecasting, survival analysis, experiments and optimisation.

Be honest with yourself about one thing. Statistics is not about memorising formulas. It is about knowing *which question you are really asking* and *how data can fool you*. That is why every chapter shows a simulation: when a formula and a simulation agree, you understand it. When they disagree, you have learned something even more valuable.

You already own the Math PDF, which teaches the basics from zero (probability, Bayes, distributions, hypothesis testing, MLE, loss functions, information theory). This document does not repeat that. It goes deeper and wider, and it points back to the PDF ("see Math PDF, Pillar 3.2") when a basic idea is needed.

One rule matters more than any other: **never move on until the current topic feels obvious.** If a chapter feels foggy, redo its worked problems with different numbers, re-run the code and change the seed, and explain the idea aloud in three sentences. One hour a day, done honestly, is enough.

What Every Topic Contains

1. **INTUITION** callout: the problem the idea solves, in everyday language.
2. **Formal definition / how it works**: precise but plain, with a "Words you need" table.
3. **Worked problems with real numbers**: every step, a Check and a plain-language interpretation, with real code output.
4. **The picture**: a diagram, table or plot, explained fully.
5. **Connection to real work**: where it shows up in analytics, data engineering, ML and operations.
6. **Applications**: grouped by role, with concrete examples.
7. **COMMON MISTAKE** callouts: what beginners get wrong and how to catch it.
8. **Check yourself**: three short questions with answers.

Every chapter ends with a recap (with a formula table), a practice set (8 to 12 problems with answers) and a prompt pack (5 prompts to paste into an AI tutor).

Contents

1. **Probability Through Problem Solving**: counting, conditional probability, Bayes and base-rate traps, expectation and variance, descriptive statistics, Simpson's paradox.
2. **Distributions in Depth**: Bernoulli to Dirichlet, when to use which, chi-square/t/F, multivariate normal, LLN and Markov chains.
3. **Sampling, Estimation, Confidence Intervals and the Bootstrap**: sampling bias, standard error, CLT, MLE and method of moments, CIs, bootstrap.
4. **Hypothesis Testing in Depth**: z, t, paired, chi-square, ANOVA with Tukey, non-parametric tests, normality tests, power and sample size.
5. **Effect Sizes, Multiple Testing and How Data Fools You**: Cohen's d, odds ratios, Bonferroni, Holm, BH-FDR, p-hacking, winner's curse.
6. **Linear Regression Deeply**: OLS derivation, inference, assumptions, diagnostics, VIF, influential points, interpretation.
7. **Regularization and Model Selection**: ridge, lasso, elastic net, bias-variance, AIC/BIC, cross-validation, other multivariate and smoothing tools.
8. **Generalized Linear Models**: logistic, Poisson, negative binomial, link functions, deviance, odds ratios, marginal effects.
9. **Bayesian Statistics**: priors, posteriors, conjugacy, credible intervals, Bayesian A/B tests, MCMC intuition, PyMC awareness.
10. **Time Series Statistics**: stationarity, ACF/PACF, ARIMA/SARIMA, exponential smoothing, forecast evaluation.
11. **Survival Analysis and Mixed/Hierarchical Models**: Kaplan-Meier, Cox, random effects and partial pooling.
12. **Experimental Design and Causal Basics**: randomisation, confounding, difference-in-differences intuition.
13. **Optimization Techniques and Information Theory**: convexity, gradient descent variants, Lagrange/KKT, linear programming with scipy, entropy refresher.
14. **Statistics Interview Bank and Common Pitfalls**.

Appendix: **Cheat Sheet** (all key formulas and commands).

How To Study This Document

Use the five-step learning loop on every chapter:

1. **Build first.** Run the code of the chapter's first section before reading the explanation. Change a number and run it again.
2. **Ask.** Write down what confused you. Use the Prompt pack at the end of the chapter to ask an AI tutor those exact questions.
3. **Just-in-time theory.** Read the formal part only for the confusing pieces.
4. **Rebuild.** Close the document and recreate one simulation from a blank file. If you can reproduce the output, you understand it.
5. **Teach.** Explain the chapter's main idea in three sentences to a colleague (or a rubber duck).

Suggested pace: one chapter per week at about one hour a day (read, code, practice set, prompt pack). Chapters 4 to 6 deserve two weeks each if you want interview-level fluency. How to use the Prompt packs: paste one into any AI assistant, replace `[PASTE HERE]` with your own work when asked, and always attempt the exercise before reading the answer. The practice sets contain the answers directly below each question so you can check yourself honestly.

A note on tools: all numbers in this document were produced with Python (NumPy, SciPy, matplotlib, pandas, scikit-learn). Where the library `statsmodels`, `lifelines` or `PyMC` would be the normal choice, the early chapters rebuild the calculation by hand so you can see inside it, and the library calls are shown but marked "not run here" if they were not executed.

Prerequisites

- Basic Python (variables, loops, functions, lists, NumPy arrays).
- School algebra and logarithms.
- The learner's Math PDF, at least the Probability and Statistics chapter (Pillar 3), the Calculus chapter (derivatives, gradients) and the Linear Algebra chapter (matrices, dot product). These are referred to, not repeated.
- Curiosity about numbers. No advanced mathematics is required.

Tools you need

All free:

- **Python 3.10+** with `numpy`, `scipy`, `pandas`, `matplotlib`, `scikit-learn` (`pip install numpy scipy pandas matplotlib scikit-learn`).
- **Optional libraries** used later in the document: `statsmodels`, `lifelines`, `pymc`, `pingouin`.
- **Jupyter Notebook or VS Code** for running and editing code.
- A text editor and a notebook (paper) for the by-hand steps.

CHAPTER 1

PROBABILITY THROUGH PROBLEM SOLVING

Counting, conditional probability, Bayes and the traps that fool smart people.

Imagine your monitoring tool fires an alert at 3 a.m. The vendor says, "This detector catches 99 percent of real incidents." Should you wake up the whole team? Most engineers say yes. After this chapter you will know that the honest answer can be "only one alert in five is real", and you will be able to prove it with five lines of arithmetic. Probability is the language of uncertainty, and every later chapter (tests, regression, Bayesian models, forecasts) is built on it. You already met the definitions in the Math PDF (Pillar 3.1 and 3.2: probability fundamentals, Bayes, distributions, descriptive statistics, covariance and correlation). So here we do not repeat them from zero. We **solve problems**, because probability is learned by solving, not by reading. Every answer is checked by a short computer simulation. When a formula and a simulation agree, you can trust both.

PROFESSOR'S NOTE

Throughout this document, a line that starts with "Predict" asks you to guess the output before you look at it. Guessing first, even wrongly, is the fastest way to learn. Do not skip it.

1.1 Counting and Sample Spaces

INTUITION

Think of a restaurant menu: 3 starters, 4 mains and 2 desserts. How many different meals can you order? You do not list them all. You multiply: 3 × 4 × 2 = 24. Many probability questions are secretly counting questions. If every outcome is equally likely, then the probability of an event is (number of good outcomes) divided by (number of all outcomes). So the real work is counting without missing or double-counting. In a shop: 4 customer types, 3 regions and 5 parcel sizes give 4 × 3 × 5 = 60 delivery scenarios.

Words you need

Word	Plain meaning	Example

Experiment	Anything with an uncertain result	Place one order and see if it arrives late
Outcome	One possible result	"fail"
Sample space S	The list of ALL outcomes	{pass, fail}
Event	A group of outcomes we care about	"response is slower than 1 s"
Permutation	An arrangement where order matters	First, second, third prize
Combination	A selection where order does not matter	A team of 3 people
Factorial n!	n × (n−1) × ... × 1	4! = 24

The rules

- **Axioms** (the three basic laws): P(A) ≥ 0; P(S) = 1; if A and B cannot happen together, P(A or B) = P(A) + P(B).
- **Multiplication rule**: if a task has steps with n_1, n_2, ... choices, the total is $n_1 \times n_2 \times ...$
- **Permutations**: choosing k from n with order: `n! / (n − k)!`
- **Combinations**: choosing k from n without order: `C(n, k) = n! / (k! (n − k)!)`. We divide by k! because each group of k items was counted k! times in different orders.
- **Complement trick**: `P(at least one) = 1 − P(none)`. "None" is usually one simple product.

```
Does order matter?   Yes -> permutation  n!/(n-k)!
                     No  -> combination  C(n,k)
Repeats allowed?     Yes -> n^k (ordered)
```

Item	Example value	Where it appears in the job
Multiplication rule	4 × 3 × 5 = 60 scenarios	Counting test scenarios, feature crosses
Combinations	C(10,3) = 120	Choosing k depots, the "n choose k" in the binomial

C(n,k)		(Chapter 2)
Complement	1 − P(no collision)	Hash and ID collision risk

Problem 1.1.1 A company has 10 depots. You pick 3 at random (no repeats) to audit. How many different sets of 3 exist? How many ordered line-ups? What is the probability that one specific depot is in your set?

Formula	sets = C(10, 3) = 10! / (3! · 7!); line-ups = 10 · 9 · 8
Plug in	C(10, 3) = (10 · 9 · 8) / (3 · 2 · 1)
Compute	720 / 6 = 120 sets. Line-ups = 720. Sets that contain your depot: choose the other 2 from the remaining 9, C(9, 2) = 36. Probability = 36 / 120 = 0.3
Answer	There are 120 sets and 720 ordered line-ups. Your depot is chosen with probability 0.3.
Check	Simple logic: you pick 3 of 10 seats, so each depot has a 3/10 = 0.3 chance. Both ways agree. Also 720 / 120 = 6 = 3!, which matches "each set can be ordered 6 ways".
Why it matters	Two methods giving the same answer is the habit of a good analyst.

Predict: what do the three numbers below print?

```
from math import comb, perm
print(comb(10, 3), perm(10, 3), comb(9, 2) / comb(10, 3))
```

```
120 720 0.3
```

Line by line: `comb(10, 3)` counts sets, `perm(10, 3)` counts ordered line-ups, and the last expression divides the favourable sets by all sets.

Problem 1.1.2 (the birthday problem) In a team of 23 people, what is the chance that at least two share a birthday? Assume 365 equally likely days.

Formula	P(match) = 1 − P(all different)
Plug in	P(all different) = (365/365)(364/365)(363/365) ... (343/365). The first person has any day, the second must avoid 1 day, the third must avoid 2 days, and so on. There are 23 factors.
Compute	Multiply the 23 factors, then subtract from 1. We use code, because 23 multiplications by hand is slow.
Answer	About 0.507: a little more than 50 percent.
Check	We simulate 100,000 random teams of 23 and count matches. The simulated fraction must be near the exact value.
Why it matters	Humans guess "about 6 percent" (23/365). The truth is nearly 50 percent, so your intuition for collisions is poor.

Predict: will the simulated number be exactly equal to the exact one?

```
import numpy as np
def p_match(n):
    p = 1.0
    for i in range(n):
        p *= (365 - i) / 365
    return 1 - p
print("exact n=23:", round(p_match(23), 4), " n=50:", round(p_match(50),
4))
rng = np.random.default_rng(1)
teams = rng.integers(0, 365, size=(100_000, 23))
hits = sum(len(set(row)) < 23 for row in teams)
print("simulated n=23:", hits / 100_000)
```

```
exact n=23: 0.5073  n=50: 0.9704
simulated n=23: 0.50695
```

The simulated value is close but not identical, because it is random. With 100,000 teams the error is about ±0.003. That is the first lesson about simulation: it gives an *estimate with noise*.

The picture

```
# plot
import numpy as np, matplotlib.pyplot as plt
ns = np.arange(1, 81)
ps = [p_match(int(k)) for k in ns]
plt.figure(figsize=(6, 3.6))
plt.plot(ns, ps, color="#1f77b4", lw=2)
plt.axhline(0.5, color="gray", ls="--")
plt.axvline(23, color="gray", ls=":")
plt.xlabel("People in the team"); plt.ylabel("P(at least two share a
birthday)")
plt.title("Birthday problem: 23 people give about 50 percent")
plt.tight_layout(); plt.savefig(f"{IMG}/ch01_birthday.png", dpi=130);
plt.close()
```

Birthday problem: the probability of a match rises quickly and passes 50 percent at 23 people

How to read it: the x-axis is team size, the y-axis is the probability of at least one shared birthday. The dashed horizontal line marks 50 percent and the dotted vertical line marks 23 people. The curve crosses where the two lines meet. At 50 people it is already 97 percent.

KEY INSIGHT

The number of *pairs* grows like n²/2. With 23 people there are C(23, 2) = 253 pairs, and each pair is a chance for a match. The same idea explains **hash collisions**: a hash table or ID generator with N slots starts colliding after about √N items, not after N items.

Connection to the real job

Collision probability decides how long a random ID must be (order IDs, tracking numbers, UUIDs). Counting also appears in A/B test design (how many variant combinations), and as the "n choose k" inside the binomial distribution in Chapter 2.

Applications

- **Data Engineering:** choosing hash sizes and partition keys; estimating duplicate-key risk in a pipeline.
- **Quality testing:** pairwise test-case reduction when the full cross-product is too big.
- **Machine Learning:** counting feature crosses; sampling a train/test split without replacement.

- **Analytics:** counting possible segment combinations before a "slice and dice" analysis (more slices means more false findings, Chapter 5).

COMMON MISTAKE

Mixing up "order matters" and "order does not matter". Quick test: if swapping two chosen items gives a *different* result (first and second prize), use permutations. If not (a committee), use combinations. Always try a tiny case like n = 3, k = 2 and list it by hand.

Check yourself

1. How many 4-digit PINs exist if digits may repeat? Answer: 10^4 = 10,000.
2. How many ways to pick a team of 2 from 6 people? Answer: C(6,2) = 15.
3. Why is "at least one" usually easier through the complement? Answer: "None" is one product of simple terms, while "at least one" has many cases.

1.2 Conditional Probability and Independence

INTUITION

You are in a hotel lobby with 100 people. 40 are engineers. Now someone says "everyone who speaks Hindi, raise a hand", and you look only at the raised hands. Inside that smaller group, the fraction of engineers may be different. That is conditional probability: the chance of A *inside the smaller world where B is true*. New information shrinks the world, and probabilities must be recalculated inside it.

Words you need

Word	Plain meaning	Example
P(A | B)	Probability of A, given B happened	
Joint P(A and B)	Both happen	Slow AND uses database
Partition	Groups that do not overlap and cover	Depot 1, 2 or 3

	everything	
Independent	Knowing one tells you nothing about the other	Two fair coin flips

The rules

- **Definition**: $P(A \mid B) = P(A \text{ and } B) / P(B)$, for P(B) > 0. In words: of all the B cases, what fraction also has A.
- **Multiplication rule**: $P(A \text{ and } B) = P(A \mid B) \cdot P(B)$.
- **Law of total probability**: if B_1, B_2, ... partition the world, $P(A) = \Sigma\, P(A \mid B_i) \cdot P(B_i)$. It is a weighted average of the within-group probabilities.
- **Independence**: $P(A \text{ and } B) = P(A) \cdot P(B)$, equivalently $P(A \mid B) = P(A)$.
- **Conditional independence**: A and B may be dependent overall, but independent once we know C. The Naive Bayes classifier assumes this for all features.

Item	Example value	Where it appears in the job
P(A \	B)	P(purchase \
Total probability	0.5·0.02 + 0.3·0.03 + 0.2·0.05	Overall return rate from per-depot rates
Independence	P(A and B) = P(A)·P(B)	Assumption behind many tests and Naive Bayes

Problem 1.2.1 A shop ships from three depots. Depot 1 handles 50 percent of orders and 2 percent of them are returned. Depot 2 handles 30 percent and 3 percent are returned. Depot 3 handles 20 percent and 5 percent are returned. What is the overall return rate?

Formula	P(fail) = Σ P(fail | S_i) · P(S_i) (law of total probability)
Plug in	0.02·0.5 + 0.03·0.3 + 0.05·0.2
Compute	0.010 + 0.009 + 0.010 = 0.029
Answer	The overall return rate is 2.9 percent, which means about 29 returns per 1,000 orders.
Check	The answer must lie between the smallest (2 percent) and the largest (5 percent) rate, because it is a weighted average. It does. A simple average (3.3 percent) would be wrong because it ignores traffic weights.
Why it matters	"Combined rate = weighted average" is the rule behind every dashboard roll-up.

Problem 1.2.2 (two children) A family has two children. (a) You learn that at least one is a girl. What is the probability that both are girls? (b) You learn instead that the *older* child is a girl. What is the probability that both are girls?

Formula	P(both | info) = P(both and info) / P(info). Because outcomes are equally likely, count outcomes.
Plug in	The four equally likely outcomes (older first) are GG, GB, BG, BB.
Compute	(a) "at least one girl" leaves GG, GB, BG, so P = 1/3. (b) "older is a girl" leaves GG, GB, so P = 1/2.
Answer	(a) 1/3, (b) 1/2. The *way* the information arrives changes the answer.
Check	We simulate a million families below.
Why it matters	Be careful about exactly what a condition says. Data filters such as "at least one error in the session" and "the first order was late" select different worlds.

Predict: roughly 0.33 and 0.50? Run it.

```
import numpy as np
rng = np.random.default_rng(2)
older = rng.integers(0, 2, 1_000_000)   # 1 = girl
younger = rng.integers(0, 2, 1_000_000)
atleast = (older == 1) | (younger == 1)
both = (older == 1) & (younger == 1)
print("P(both | at least one girl):", round(both[atleast].mean(), 4))
print("P(both | older is girl):   ", round(both[older == 1].mean(), 4))
```

```
P(both | at least one girl): 0.3344
P(both | older is girl):    0.5009
```

The line `both[atleast].mean()` keeps only families where the condition holds, then takes the fraction with both girls. This is exactly "shrink the world, then count".

The picture

A probability tree: each branch carries a probability, and you multiply along a path.

```
           0.5 -- S1 -- fail 0.02 -> 0.5 x 0.02 = 0.010
start ---  0.3 -- S2 -- fail 0.03 -> 0.3 x 0.03 = 0.009
           0.2 -- S3 -- fail 0.05 -> 0.2 x 0.05 = 0.010
                                    total fail = 0.029
```

Read it left to right. The first split chooses a depot. The second split (not drawn for "pass") chooses fail or pass. Add up the fail endings to get the total.

Connection to the real job

Every funnel metric is a conditional probability. In reliability work, P(late delivery | peak hour) differs from P(late delivery). In ML, a classifier output is an estimate of P(class | features).

Applications

- **Data Analytics:** funnel conversion, churn given a segment.
- **Data Science:** Naive Bayes spam filters (conditional independence of words).
- **Reliability / SRE:** fault trees, failure rates per component.
- **Healthcare analytics:** probability of disease given a symptom.

COMMON MISTAKE

Treating P(A | B) as if it equals P(B | A). "Most marathon runners are healthy" does not mean "most healthy people run marathons". This is the **prosecutor's fallacy**, and the next section shows its cost.

Check yourself

1. P(A)=0.4, P(B)=0.5, independent. What is P(A and B)? Answer: 0.2.
2. P(A and B)=0.1, P(B)=0.25. What is P(A | B)? Answer: 0.4.
3. Can two events with non-zero probability be independent and mutually exclusive at once? Answer: No. If they cannot happen together, knowing one occurred tells you the other did not, so they are dependent.

1.3 Bayes' Theorem and the Base-Rate Trap

INTUITION

A smoke alarm rings for 99 percent of real fires. It also rings when you make toast. If real fires are very rare and toast is common, then most rings are toast. To judge a ring you must ask two questions: how good is the alarm, and how common is a real fire in the first place? The second question is the **base rate**. Ignoring it is called **base-rate neglect**, and it is the most expensive probability mistake in data work. Bayes' theorem is the machine that combines both questions into one correct answer.

Words you need

Word	Plain meaning	Example
Prior P(H)	Belief before seeing evidence (the base rate)	0.5 percent of minutes have a real incident
Likelihood P(E | H)	How likely the evidence is if H is true	
Posterior P(H | E)	Belief after seeing the evidence	

Sensitivity	P(positive |	condition present) (also recall)
Specificity	P(negative |	condition absent)
False positive rate	1 − specificity	0.02
Odds	p / (1 − p)	0.2 means 1 to 4

The theorem

`P(H | E) = P(E | H) · P(H) / P(E)`, where `P(E) = P(E | H)·P(H) + P(E | not H)·P(not H)`.

The odds version is easiest for repeated updates: `posterior odds = prior odds × likelihood ratio`, where the likelihood ratio is `sensitivity / false positive rate`.

Item	Example value	Where it appears in the job
Prior	0.005	Fraud rate, incident rate, class balance
Likelihood ratio	0.99 / 0.02 = 49.5	How strongly one alert should move you
Posterior	0.199	Precision of an alert system

Problem 1.3.1 An anomaly detector flags 99 percent of real incidents (sensitivity 0.99) and wrongly flags 2 percent of normal minutes (false positive rate 0.02). Real incidents occur in 0.5 percent of minutes. An alert fires. What is the probability that it is a real incident?

Formula	P(H | E) = P(E | H)·P(H) / [P(E | H)·P(H) + P(E | not H)·P(not H)]
Plug in	(0.99 · 0.005) / (0.99 · 0.005 + 0.02 · 0.995)
Compute	top = 0.00495. Bottom = 0.00495 + 0.0199 = 0.02485. Ratio = 0.00495 / 0.02485 = 0.1992.
Answer	Only about 19.9 percent of alerts are real incidents. About 4 of every 5 alerts are false alarms, although the detector looks excellent on paper.
Check	Natural frequencies. Take 100,000 minutes. 500 are incidents and the detector fires on 495 of them. 99,500 are normal and the detector fires on 1,990 of them. Real alerts = 495 out of 2,485 total alerts = 19.9 percent. Same answer.
Why it matters	If the on-call team learns that 80 percent of pages are noise, they stop trusting the system. Detector quality means nothing without the base rate.

Predict: what happens to the posterior if incidents become 10 times rarer (prior 0.0005)? Higher or lower than 0.199?

```
def posterior(prior, sens, fpr):
    pe = sens * prior + fpr * (1 - prior)
    return sens * prior / pe
print("posterior:", round(posterior(0.005, 0.99, 0.02), 4))
for prior in [0.0005, 0.005, 0.05, 0.2, 0.5]:
    print(f"prior={prior:<7} posterior={posterior(prior, 0.99,
0.02):.4f}")
```

```
posterior: 0.1992
prior=0.0005  posterior=0.0242
prior=0.005   posterior=0.1992
prior=0.05    posterior=0.7226
prior=0.2     posterior=0.9252
prior=0.5     posterior=0.9802
```

The function computes the denominator `pe` (the total chance of an alert) first, then the share of it that comes from real incidents. The table shows the key lesson: with the *same* detector, precision runs from 2.4 percent to 98 percent depending only on the prior.

Problem 1.3.2 (two independent alerts) Two independent monitors both fire. Each has sensitivity 0.99 and false positive rate 0.02. With prior 0.005, what is the posterior after both

alert?

Formula	posterior odds = prior odds × LR_1 × LR_2 (independent evidence multiplies)
Plug in	prior odds = 0.005 / 0.995 = 0.005025. LR = 0.99 / 0.02 = 49.5.
Compute	odds = 0.005025 × 49.5 × 49.5 = 0.005025 × 2450.25 = 12.31. Probability = odds / (1 + odds) = 12.31 / 13.31 = 0.925.
Answer	About 92.5 percent. A second independent signal moves belief from 20 percent to over 90 percent.
Check	Updating one at a time must give the same: after the first alert odds = 0.005025 × 49.5 = 0.2487 (probability 0.199, as before). Multiply by 49.5 again: 12.31. Same.
Why it matters	This is why alert rules like "two of three checks fail" cut noise so strongly. The word *independent* is critical: if both checkers look at the same faulty scanner, the second one adds almost nothing.

```
prior_odds = 0.005 / 0.995
lr = 0.99 / 0.02
odds = prior_odds * lr**2
print("posterior after two alerts:", round(odds / (1 + odds), 4))
```

```
posterior after two alerts: 0.9249
```

Problem 1.3.3 (Monty Hall) You pick door 1 of 3. The host, who knows where the car is, opens door 3 (a goat). Should you switch to door 2?

Formula	P(car behind door k) before any door opens = 1/3 each.
Plug in	Your door has 1/3. The other two doors together have 2/3.
Compute	The host never opens the car door and never opens yours. Opening door 3 does not change the chance that your door is right (still 1/3), so the whole 2/3 now sits on door 2.
Answer	Switching wins with probability 2/3. Staying wins with 1/3.
Check	In the simulation a switcher wins exactly when the first pick was wrong, because the host then removes the only other goat.
Why it matters	The host's action is evidence, and its meaning depends on his rule. Always ask "how was this evidence produced?" before updating.

```
import numpy as np
rng = np.random.default_rng(3)
n = 200_000
car = rng.integers(0, 3, n)
pick = np.zeros(n, dtype=int)            # always pick door 0
stay = (car == pick).mean()
switch = (car != pick).mean()
print("stay:", round(stay, 3), " switch:", round(switch, 3))
```

```
stay: 0.334  switch: 0.666
```

The picture: natural frequencies

Read it as a funnel from top to bottom.

```
100,000 minutes
  500 real incidents        -> 495 alerts (99%)
  99,500 normal minutes     -> 1,990 alerts (2%)
Total alerts = 2,485;  real = 495  -> 495 / 2,485 = 19.9%
```

The 1,990 false alerts come from the huge normal group, even though only 2 percent of it fires. Small rate times huge group still gives a big number.

Connection to the real job

Precision of a classifier is exactly P(positive class | predicted positive), and it depends on prevalence. The **naive Bayes** classifier multiplies likelihoods under conditional independence. Fraud teams with a 0.1 percent fraud rate face this trap every day.

Applications

- **Data Analytics:** judging whether a dashboard anomaly flag is trustworthy.
- **Machine Learning:** precision, recall and prevalence (Math PDF, confusion matrix); Naive Bayes.
- **MLOps / SRE:** alert tuning, drift detectors with false alarms.
- **GenAI:** content-safety filters where the unsafe class is rare.

COMMON MISTAKE

Quoting only sensitivity ("our model catches 99 percent of fraud") without the false positive rate and base rate. Always ask: what is the prevalence, and what is the precision?

INTERVIEW TIP

When given a Bayes question, say "I will use natural frequencies" and draw 100,000 cases. Interviewers like it because it shows you understand instead of memorising.

Check yourself

1. Prior 1 percent, sensitivity 90 percent, false positive rate 9 percent. Rough posterior? Answer: 0.009 / (0.009 + 0.0891) is about 9.2 percent.
2. What does the likelihood ratio 49.5 mean? Answer: A positive result is 49.5 times more likely under "incident" than under "normal".
3. If the base rate rises, does precision rise or fall, with sensitivity and false positive rate fixed? Answer: It rises.

1.4 Random Variables, Expectation and Variance

INTUITION

A random variable is a number produced by a random process, like the delivery time of the next order. You cannot predict one value, but you can describe the pattern. The **expectation** is the balance point (the long-run average) and the **variance** says how widely the values scatter. Expectation has a superpower called linearity: the average of a sum is the sum of the averages, always, with no conditions. It turns hard-looking counting questions into one-line answers.

Words you need (see Math PDF Pillar 3.2 for fuller definitions)

Word	Plain meaning	Example
Random variable X	A number from a random process	Delivery time of the next order
Expectation E[X]	Probability-weighted average	250 minutes
Variance Var(X)	Average squared distance from E[X]	70,500 min²
Standard deviation	√Var, same unit as X	265 minutes
Covariance	Do two variables move together?	Two services slow at the same time
Indicator variable	1 if something happens, else 0	1 if call i fails

The rules

- $E[X] = \Sigma\ x \cdot P(X = x)$; $E[aX + b] = a \cdot E[X] + b$; $E[X + Y] = E[X] + E[Y]$ **always**.
- $Var(X) = E[X^2] - (E[X])^2$; $Var(aX + b) = a^2 \cdot Var(X)$.
- $Var(X + Y) = Var(X) + Var(Y) + 2 \cdot Cov(X, Y)$; the covariance term is zero for independent variables.
- $Cov(X, Y) = E[XY] - E[X] \cdot E[Y]$ and $Corr(X, Y) = Cov\ /\ (\sigma_x \cdot \sigma_y)$.

Item	Example value	Where it appears in the job
E[X]	250 minutes	Mean delivery time, expected cost, expected revenue
Linearity	20 × 0.03 = 0.6 failures	Error budgets, expected counts
Var(X+Y) with covariance	1,900 vs 1,300	End-to-end time of a multi-leg delivery

Problem 1.4.1 A shop offers 3 delivery options. Delivery takes 100 minutes with probability 0.6, 300 minutes with probability 0.3 and 1000 minutes with probability 0.1. Find the mean, the variance and the standard deviation.

Formula	$E[X] = \Sigma\, x \cdot p$; $\text{Var} = E[X^2] - E[X]^2$
Plug in	$E[X] = 100 \cdot 0.6 + 300 \cdot 0.3 + 1000 \cdot 0.1$; $E[X^2] = 100^2 \cdot 0.6 + 300^2 \cdot 0.3 + 1000^2 \cdot 0.1$
Compute	$E[X] = 60 + 90 + 100 = 250$. $E[X^2] = 6{,}000 + 27{,}000 + 100{,}000 = 133{,}000$. $\text{Var} = 133{,}000 - 250^2 = 133{,}000 - 62{,}500 = 70{,}500$. $\text{SD} = \sqrt{70{,}500} = 265.5$.
Answer	The mean is 250 minutes and the standard deviation is about 265.5 minutes. The SD is larger than the mean: the 10 percent slow tail dominates the spread.
Check	The mean (250) lies between the smallest (100) and the largest (1000) value, and the probabilities add to 0.6 + 0.3 + 0.1 = 1. The code below confirms.
Why it matters	A mean of 250 minutes hides that 1 order in 10 takes 1000 minutes. This is why percentiles matter in delivery reports.

Problem 1.4.2 (linearity of expectation) A parcel of 20 independent items is packed. Each item is damaged with probability 0.03. (a) Find the expected number of failed calls and its variance. (b) Ten people drop their hats in a box and each takes one hat back at random. What is the expected number of people who get their own hat?

Formula	Write the count as a sum of indicators: Total = I_1 + ... + I_n with $E[I_i] = P(\text{event } i)$.
Plug in	(a) $E[I_i] = 0.03$ for i = 1..20. (b) Person i gets own hat with probability 1/10.
Compute	(a) E = 20 × 0.03 = 0.6. Calls are independent, so Var = 20 × 0.03 × 0.97 = 0.582. (b) E = 10 × (1/10) = 1. The hat events are dependent, but linearity does not need independence.
Answer	Expect 0.6 failed calls per page view (variance 0.582). In the hat puzzle the expected number of lucky people is exactly 1, for any number of people.
Check	Simulation below: mean near 0.6, variance near 0.582, hats near 1.
Why it matters	Over 1,000,000 page views you should expect about 600,000 failed calls. Also, P(at least one failure on a page) = $1 - 0.97^{20} = 0.456$, so a small 3 percent per-call failure rate makes almost half of all page loads show at least one failure. Small per-call rates multiply across many calls.

```
import numpy as np
v = np.array([100, 300, 1000]); p = np.array([0.6, 0.3, 0.1])
m = (v * p).sum(); var = (v**2 * p).sum() - m**2
print("mean", m, "var", var, "sd", round(var**0.5, 2))
rng = np.random.default_rng(4)
fails = rng.binomial(1, 0.03, size=(500_000, 20)).sum(axis=1)
print("fails mean/var:", round(fails.mean(), 3), round(fails.var(), 3))
print("P(at least one failure):", round(1 - 0.97**20, 4), " simulated:",
round((fails > 0).mean(), 4))
n_people = 10
matches = [(rng.permutation(n_people) == np.arange(n_people)).sum() for _
in range(100_000)]
print("expected own hats:", round(np.mean(matches), 3))
```

```
mean 250.0 var 70500.0 sd 265.52
fails mean/var: 0.597 0.58
P(at least one failure): 0.4562  simulated: 0.4544
expected own hats: 1.003
```

Problem 1.4.3 (correlated sum) Two legs of a delivery (warehouse to hub, hub to door) have time variances 400 and 900 (min²) and covariance 300. What is the standard deviation of their total time? Compare with the case of independence.

Formula	$\mathrm{Var}(X+Y) = \mathrm{Var}(X) + \mathrm{Var}(Y) + 2\cdot\mathrm{Cov}(X, Y)$
Plug in	$400 + 900 + 2 \times 300$
Compute	$\mathrm{Var} = 1{,}900$, so SD = $\sqrt{1{,}900} = 43.6$ minutes. If independent: $\mathrm{Var} = 1{,}300$, SD = 36.1 minutes.
Answer	The total has SD 43.6 minutes, which is about 21 percent more than the independent value of 36.1 minutes.
Check	The correlation is $300 / (20 \cdot 30) = 0.5$. The rule is only valid if the covariance matrix is possible: $\lvert\mathrm{Cov}\rvert \le \sigma_X\sigma_Y = 600$. Yes.
Why it matters	Positive correlation (both slow when the weather is bad) makes the total more variable, so the tail of delivery times is worse than a model with independence predicts.

The picture

```
Independent:  spread of X+Y = sqrt(400+900)     = 36.1
Correlated:   spread of X+Y = sqrt(400+900+600) = 43.6
```

Think of two people walking together. If they step randomly, their combined position wobbles a little. If they step in unison, it wobbles more.

Connection to the real job

Indicator variables plus linearity give expected counts for error budgets. The variance-of-sum rule explains why a multi-leg delivery's time is more variable than a naive calculation, and why diversification works in finance.

Applications

- **Operations:** service-promise error budgets, staffing plans with expected counts.
- **Finance analytics:** portfolio variance.
- **Machine Learning:** variance of averaged models (bagging) depends on their correlation.
- **Data Engineering:** expected duplicates or failed records in a batch.

COMMON MISTAKE

Adding standard deviations. Variances add (for independent variables), standard deviations do not. For independent SD = 3 and SD = 4, the SD of the sum is 5, not 7.

Check yourself

1. E[X] = 5. What is E[3X − 2]? Answer: 13.
2. Var(X) = 4. What is Var(3X − 2)? Answer: 36.
3. Does E[X + Y] = E[X] + E[Y] need independence? Answer: No. Only the variance rule needs it (or a covariance term).

1.5 Descriptive Statistics and Correlation Done Properly

INTUITION

Before any model, you summarise the data with a few numbers. But each number is like one photo of a building: it hides the other sides. The mean hides the tail, and a correlation hides the shape. Think of delivery times: an average of 200 minutes can hide a 99th percentile of 5 hours. A summary is good only if you know what it hides.

Words you need

Word	Plain meaning	Example
Nominal	Labels, no order	Browser name
Ordinal	Ordered labels, gaps unequal	Rating 1 to 5
Interval	Equal gaps, no true zero	Temperature in Celsius
Ratio	Equal gaps and a true zero	Delivery time, weight
Robust	Not easily moved by outliers	Median
MAD	Median of |	x_i − median|
IQR	Q3 − Q1, the middle 50 percent	Robust spread

Skewness	0 = symmetric, positive = long right tail	Delivery time
Excess kurtosis	0 for a normal, large for heavy tails	Bad-sensor spikes
Monotonic	Always rising (or always falling)	$y = x^3$ for $x > 0$

The data type decides what you may compute: average ratio data, take the median of ordinal data, and only count nominal data.

Correlation family

- **Pearson r**: strength of a *straight-line* relationship. Sensitive to outliers.
- **Spearman ρ**: Pearson computed on the *ranks* (1st, 2nd, 3rd smallest). Detects any monotonic relationship.
- **Kendall τ**: counts concordant pairs (both go up together) minus discordant pairs, divided by all pairs. Robust, good with ties and small samples.

Item	Example value	Where it appears in the job
Median, MAD	202 minutes, 67 minutes	Robust delivery-time summary
p95, p99	461 minutes, 590 minutes	Promise-to-customer targets
Spearman	1.0 for $y = x^3$	Feature screening on curved relations

Problem 1.5.1 Simulate 1,000 delivery times (minutes) from a log-normal distribution (a typical shape for waiting and delivery times; its logarithm is normal). Compare mean, median, SD, MAD, IQR, skewness, kurtosis, p95 and p99. Then add 5 huge outliers (20,000 minutes) and see what moves.

Formula	MAD = median($\lvert x_i - \text{median}(x)\rvert$); IQR = Q3 − Q1
Plug in	Generate the data, compute, then append five values of 20,000.
Compute	See the output.
Answer	The mean jumps from about 227 to 325 and the SD from 119 to 1397, while the median, MAD and IQR hardly move.
Check	Five outliers out of 1,005 values are 0.5 percent of the data. A robust statistic should barely react to that, and it does (median changes by about 1 minutes).
Why it matters	If one bad measurement can move your summary a lot, use a robust summary or investigate the outliers.

Predict: which of the two lines (clean, with outliers) will show the larger p99?

```
import numpy as np
from scipy import stats
rng = np.random.default_rng(5)
delivery_minutes = rng.lognormal(mean=5.3, sigma=0.5, size=1000)   #
median about 200 minutes
def describe(x):
    return {"mean": x.mean(), "median": np.median(x), "sd": x.std(ddof=1),
            "MAD": stats.median_abs_deviation(x), "IQR": stats.iqr(x),
            "skew": stats.skew(x), "kurt": stats.kurtosis(x),
            "p95": np.percentile(x, 95), "p99": np.percentile(x, 99)}
a = describe(delivery_minutes)
b = describe(np.concatenate([delivery_minutes, np.full(5, 20000.0)]))
print(f"{'stat':8}{'clean':>12}{'with outliers':>16}")
for k in a:
    print(f"{k:8}{a[k]:12.2f}{b[k]:16.2f}")
```

```
stat           clean   with outliers
mean          226.76          325.13
median        202.32          203.26
sd            119.06         1396.97
MAD            67.14           68.10
IQR           141.81          143.14
skew            1.63           13.92
kurt            4.56          193.14
p95           461.16          475.15
p99           590.08          681.91
```

Line by line: `ddof=1` makes the SD use n−1 (the sample SD). The dictionary holds all statistics so we can print them side by side. Even p99 moved (590 to 682), because with 5 extreme points the top 1 percent now contains them.

Problem 1.5.2 Compare Pearson, Spearman and Kendall for (a) $y = x^3$ with $x = 1..20$ and (b) the straight line $y = 2x$ with one wild outlier replacing the last value by −200.

Formula	Spearman = Pearson of ranks. For (a) the ranks of y equal the ranks of x.
Plug in	$x = 1..20$, $y = x^3$; then $y_2 = 2x$ with $y_2[20] = -200$.
Compute	(a) rank correlation is exactly 1 because y rises with x at every step. Pearson is below 1 because the curve is not a line. (b) One point ruins Pearson.
Answer	For the cubic: Pearson 0.922, Spearman 1.000, Kendall 1.000. For the outlier case: Pearson −0.168 (wrong sign!), Spearman 0.714, Kendall 0.800.
Check	In (b), 19 of 20 points lie on a perfect rising line, so a sensible measure must be clearly positive. Only the rank-based ones are.
Why it matters	Pearson can be fooled by one bad row. Rank correlations are safer for messy data.

```
x = np.arange(1, 21, dtype=float)
y = x**3
print("cubic   pearson %.3f spearman %.3f kendall %.3f" % (
    stats.pearsonr(x, y)[0], stats.spearmanr(x, y)[0], stats.kendalltau(x,
y)[0]))
y2 = 2 * x; y2[-1] = -200
print("outlier pearson %.3f spearman %.3f kendall %.3f" % (
    stats.pearsonr(x, y2)[0], stats.spearmanr(x, y2)[0],
stats.kendalltau(x, y2)[0]))
```

```
cubic   pearson 0.922 spearman 1.000 kendall 1.000
outlier pearson -0.168 spearman 0.714 kendall 0.800
```

The picture

```
Pearson high:  points near a straight line
Spearman high: points rise together, line or curve
Both near 0:   no rank relation (but a U-shape can still be strongly
dependent!)
```

Connection to the real job

EDA (exploratory data analysis) starts here. Report median and percentiles for delivery times, never only the mean. Use Spearman for feature screening when relations are curved. Skewed targets often need a log transform before regression (Chapter 6).

Applications

- **Data Analytics:** delivery-time and on-time-rate reports, KPI distributions.
- **Data Science:** feature screening, outlier detection.
- **Data Engineering:** data-quality checks (a kurtosis spike reveals a faulty sensor).
- **ML:** choosing between mean and median imputation.

COMMON MISTAKE

Concluding "no relationship" from r near 0. A perfect U-shape $y = x^2$ on a symmetric range has Pearson r of 0 yet y is fully determined by x. Always plot the data.

Check yourself

1. Which is robust: SD or MAD? Answer: MAD.
2. Which correlation gives exactly 1 for y = exp(x)? Answer: Spearman and Kendall (not Pearson).
3. Is a 1-5 satisfaction score ratio data? Answer: No, it is ordinal.

1.6 Simpson's Paradox and Why Correlation Is Not Causation

INTUITION

Suppose Depot B looks faster than Depot A in your overall results. You are about to ship B. Then you notice that B was mostly tested on a quiet network and A mostly on a busy one. In *each* network condition, A is actually better. The overall comparison was unfair because the two builds faced different conditions. A trend that holds in every subgroup can flip when the groups are merged. This is **Simpson's paradox**.

Words you need

Word	Plain meaning	Example
Confounder	A hidden variable linked to both the "treatment" and the outcome	Traffic level
Stratify	Compare inside each group separately	Compare A and B only under heavy traffic
Adjust	Include the confounder in a model	Regression (Chapter 6)
Randomise	Assign treatments by coin flip so confounders balance out	A/B test (Chapter 12)

Problem 1.6.1 Two depots were compared on a light day and a busy day. The numbers are parcels delivered within the promised time.

	Quiet day	Busy day
Depot A	81 / 87 pass (93.1%)	192 / 263 pass (73.0%)
Depot B	234 / 270 pass (86.7%)	55 / 80 pass (68.8%)

- **Formula** pass rate = passed / total; combined rate = (sum of passed) / (sum of total)
- **Plug in** A: (81 + 192) / (87 + 263). B: (234 + 55) / (270 + 80).
- **Compute** A: 273 / 350 = 78.0%. B: 289 / 350 = 82.6%. Inside light traffic A wins (93.1 vs 86.7). Inside heavy traffic A wins again (73.0 vs 68.8).
- **Answer** A is better in both conditions, but B looks better in the combined table, because 270 of B's 350 tests ran under easy light traffic while 263 of A's 350 ran under hard heavy

traffic.

- **Check** Compute A's weights: 87/350 = 25 percent light, 75 percent heavy. B's weights: 77 percent light, 23 percent heavy. Different mixes explain the flip. Verify with code below.
- **Why it matters** The fair comparison is within the traffic level (or after adjusting for it). Looking only at the dashboard total would ship the worse build.

Predict: will the printed combined rate for B be higher than for A?

```
import pandas as pd
d = pd.DataFrame({"build": ["A","A","B","B"], "traffic":
["light","heavy","light","heavy"],
                  "pass": [81, 192, 234, 55], "n": [87, 263, 270, 80]})
d["rate"] = (d["pass"] / d["n"]).round(3)
print(d)
tot = d.groupby("build")[["pass", "n"]].sum()
tot["rate"] = (tot["pass"] / tot["n"]).round(3)
print(tot)
```

```
  build traffic  pass    n   rate
0     A   light    81   87  0.931
1     A   heavy   192  263  0.730
2     B   light   234  270  0.867
3     B   heavy    55   80  0.688
       pass    n   rate
build
A       273  350  0.780
B       289  350  0.826
```

The picture

```
          Quiet day        Busy day        Combined
A         93%  (n=87)          73%  (n=263)         78%
B         87%  (n=270)         69%  (n=80)          83%   <- reversal
```

Read across a row: A's combined rate is dominated by its hard heavy-traffic tests, B's by its easy light-traffic tests.

Connection to the real job

This is the daily danger in observational analysis: dashboards compare groups that differ in

many ways. The fixes are stratification (compare within groups), regression that includes the confounder (Chapter 6) and randomised experiments (Chapter 12).

Applications

- **Operations:** comparing depots, regions, or suppliers under unequal volumes.
- **Data Analytics:** conversion rates by device, campaign or country.
- **Data Science:** feature importance when features are correlated with a hidden driver.
- **Healthcare and policy:** treatment comparisons where sicker patients get stronger treatments.

COMMON MISTAKE

Believing that "more data" fixes this. The paradox comes from structure, not sample size. You need a causal story (what influences what) to decide whether to aggregate or to split.

Check yourself

1. What creates Simpson's paradox? Answer: A confounder plus unequal group mixes.
2. Does the paradox mean the numbers are wrong? Answer: No, the numbers are right; the combined table answers a different question.
3. Name two fixes. Answer: Stratify, adjust in a regression, or randomise.

Chapter recap

- Many probability questions reduce to counting; the complement trick makes "at least one" easy.
- The birthday problem shows collisions appear after about $\sqrt{N}$ items.
- Conditional probability is "probability inside a smaller world"; $P(A \mid B)$ is not $P(B \mid A)$.
- Bayes' theorem needs the prior (base rate); a great detector can still give mostly false alarms when the event is rare.
- Natural frequencies (100,000 cases) make Bayes easy to explain and check.
- Expectation is linear even without independence; variance adds only with independence or with a covariance term.
- Report median, MAD, IQR and percentiles for skewed data like delivery times; mean and SD are fragile.

- Pearson measures straight-line links; Spearman and Kendall measure monotonic links; always plot.
- Simpson's paradox can reverse a trend; confounders must be handled by design or adjustment.

Formula / pattern	Meaning
`C(n,k) = n!/(k!(n−k)!)`	Unordered choices
`P(≥1) = 1 − P(none)`	Complement trick
`P(A\	B) = P(A and B)/P(B)`
`P(H\	E) = P(E\
`posterior odds = prior odds × LR`	Odds-form update
`E[aX+b] = aE[X]+b` , `Var(aX+b) = a²Var(X)`	Linear transforms
`Var(X+Y) = VarX + VarY + 2Cov`	Variance of a sum
`scipy.stats.spearmanr / kendalltau / pearsonr`	Correlations

Practice set

Problem 1.7.1 How many different 5-letter passwords are possible using 26 lowercase letters with no repeated letter?

Answer: 26·25·24·23·22 = 7,893,600.

Problem 1.7.2 Two fair dice are rolled. What is P(sum = 8)?

Answer: Pairs (2,6),(3,5),(4,4),(5,3),(6,2) = 5 out of 36, so 5/36 = 0.139.

Problem 1.7.3 What is the output? `from math import comb; print(comb(5,2)*comb(4,1))`

Answer: 10 × 4 = 40.

Problem 1.7.4 P(A) = 0.3, P(B) = 0.6, P(A or B) = 0.72. Are A and B independent?

Answer: P(A and B) = 0.3 + 0.6 − 0.72 = 0.18 = 0.3 × 0.6. Yes, independent.

Problem 1.7.5 A disease affects 1 in 1,000 people. A test has 95 percent sensitivity and a 5 percent false positive rate. What is the posterior after a positive test?

Answer: 0.95·0.001 / (0.95·0.001 + 0.05·0.999) = 0.00095 / 0.05090 = 1.87 percent.

Problem 1.7.6 Find the bug: "Three depots have return rates 1%, 4% and 10%. The average is 5%, so the combined error rate is 5%."

Answer: The depots handle different volumes. The combined rate must be weighted by order counts (law of total probability).

Problem 1.7.7 X has mean 10 and SD 2; Y has mean 4 and SD 1; their correlation is 0.5. Find the SD of X − Y.

Answer: Var = 4 + 1 − 2·(0.5·2·1) = 5 − 2 = 3. SD = √3 = 1.73.

Problem 1.7.8 A coin is flipped 10 times. What is the expected number of positions where heads is followed by heads?

Answer: There are 9 adjacent pairs, each HH with probability 1/4. By linearity, 9/4 = 2.25.

Problem 1.7.9 (interview) "A fraud test is 90 percent accurate and it says 'fraud' for a transaction. Is the transaction 90 percent likely to be fraud?" Explain.

Answer: No. Accuracy is not the posterior. You need the base rate. If fraud is 0.1 percent and the test has 90 percent sensitivity and a 10 percent false positive rate, the posterior is 0.0009 / 0.1008 = 0.89 percent.

Problem 1.7.10 (interview) In a team of 10 people, what is the probability that at least two share a birth month (12 equally likely months)?

Answer: P(all different) = (12·11·10·...·3) / 12^{10} = 239,500,800 / 61,917,364,224 = 0.00387. So the probability of a match is 1 − 0.00387 = 99.6 percent.

Prompt pack

✨ **AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI**

```
You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional
moving into data roles, and English is my second language. Teach me
Chapter 1 topic "counting, sample spaces and the birthday problem" step by
step in simple English. Use everyday examples (shop orders, menu
combinations, hash collisions, IDs). After each idea, ask me one check
```

question and wait for my answer. Finish by giving me 5 small exercises and checking my answers when I paste them.

✨ AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI

You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional moving into data roles. Explain conditional probability and the law of total probability using examples such as faulty parcels from several depots. Use trees and real numbers. Then give me 8 graded exercises from easy to hard WITHOUT solutions, and wait. When I reply with my answers, mark each one and explain every mistake slowly.

✨ AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI

You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional moving into data roles. The topic is Bayes' theorem and base-rate neglect, using fraud alerts, hospital screening and medical tests. Quiz me one question at a time with natural-frequency problems (100,000 cases). Start easy, get harder, and after each answer tell me if I used the base rate correctly. Stop after 8 questions and summarise my weak spots.

✨ AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI

You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional moving into data roles. Review my work on expectation, variance, covariance and linearity of expectation. Here are my solutions: [PASTE HERE]. Check every step, find errors, explain the right method in simple English, and then give me two new similar problems to try.

✨ AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI

You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional moving into data roles. Run a mock interview on probability and descriptive statistics: Bayes traps, Simpson's paradox, Pearson versus Spearman, robust statistics for delivery times. Ask one question at a time, wait for my answer, then give a score out of 10 with a model answer I can learn from. Ask 8 questions in total.

CHAPTER 2

DISTRIBUTIONS IN DEPTH

Which probability shape fits which real-world number, and how to check by simulation.

Every dataset you will ever analyse was produced by some random process, and a **distribution** is the shape that describes that process. If you pick the right shape, you can answer questions like "how many orders will be returned in the next hour?", "how long until the next outage?" and "what is the chance that conversion is above 5 percent?" without more data. If you pick the wrong shape, your delivery-promise numbers, your confidence intervals and your forecasts are all wrong. The Math PDF (Pillar 3.2) introduced the common distributions. In this chapter you go deeper: the *story* behind each one, how to tell them apart, how they connect to each other, and how to simulate them in Python so you can test your intuition. By the end you will be able to look at a column of numbers and say which two or three distributions are sensible candidates.

Our running example is an online shop: orders arrive, some are returned, each takes some time to deliver, and visitors buy or not. Each section picks one part of that story.

2.1 Discrete Distributions: Counting Successes and Events

INTUITION

A discrete variable counts things: failures, arrivals, clicks. Think of a cashier at a counter. How many customers arrive in one minute? How many of the next 20 customers pay by card? How many customers must you serve until the first one complains? Each question has its own distribution, and the *question you ask* decides which one you need.

Words you need

Word	Plain meaning	Example
PMF (probability mass function)	P(X = k) for each whole number k	P(exactly 3 failures)
CDF (cumulative distribution function)	P(X ≤ k)	P(at most 3 failures)

Trial	One attempt with a yes/no result	One order
Rate λ (lambda)	Average number of events per unit time	4 orders per minute

The families

Distribution	Story	PMF	Mean	Variance
Bernoulli(p)	One yes/no trial	p or 1−p	p	p(1−p)
Binomial(n, p)	Number of yes in n independent trials	$C(n,k)\ p^k\ (1-p)^{n-k}$	np	np(1−p)
Geometric(p)	Trials until the first yes	$(1-p)^{k-1}\ p$	1/p	$(1-p)/p^2$
Poisson(λ)	Events in a fixed time, events independent	$e^{-\lambda}\ \lambda^k / k!$	λ	λ
Multinomial(n, p_1..p_m)	n trials, each lands in one of m categories	$n!/(k_1!...k_m!)\ \prod p_i \hat{}\ k_i$	np_i	$np_i(1-p_i)$

Two facts to remember. First, Binomial is just a sum of n Bernoulli variables. Second, **Poisson has mean = variance**. If your count data has variance much larger than its mean, Poisson is the wrong model (this is called overdispersion, we use it in Chapter 8).

Item	Example value	Where it appears in the job
Binomial(20, 0.03)	Failed calls among 20	Error counts per page view
Poisson(4)	Orders per minute	Arrival counts at a checkout
Geometric(0.1)	Pages viewed until first purchase	Time-to-first-event in discrete steps
Multinomial	Clicks across 4 buttons	Click distribution, language-model word counts

Problem 2.1.1 A parcel of 20 independent items is packed and each item is damaged with

probability 0.03. What is P(exactly 2 fail), P(at most 1 fails) and P(at least 3 fail)?

Formula	$P(X = k) = C(20, k) \cdot 0.03^{k} \cdot 0.97^{20-k}$
Plug in	$P(X = 2) = C(20, 2) \cdot 0.03^{2} \cdot 0.97^{18} = 190 \cdot 0.0009 \cdot 0.5780$
Compute	$190 \times 0.0009 = 0.171$; $0.171 \times 0.5780 = 0.0988$. $P(X \le 1) = P(0) + P(1) = 0.5438 + 0.3364 = 0.8802$. $P(X \ge 3) = 1 - P(X \le 2) = 1 - (0.8802 + 0.0988) = 0.0210$.
Answer	About 9.9 percent for exactly 2 failures, 88.0 percent for at most 1 failure, and 2.1 percent for 3 or more.
Check	The code below gives the same numbers, and the three probabilities for "0 or 1", "2" and "3 or more" add to 1.
Why it matters	Even if each call is 97 percent reliable, about 1 page load in 48 will have three or more failed calls. Capacity and retry designs depend on such tail counts.

```
from scipy import stats
b = stats.binom(20, 0.03)
print("P(X=2)  =", round(b.pmf(2), 4))
print("P(X<=1) =", round(b.cdf(1), 4))
print("P(X>=3) =", round(b.sf(2), 4), "  (sf = survival function = 1 - cdf)")
print("check sum:", round(b.cdf(1) + b.pmf(2) + b.sf(2), 6))
```

```
P(X=2)  = 0.0988
P(X<=1) = 0.8802
P(X>=3) = 0.021   (sf = survival function = 1 - cdf)
check sum: 1.0
```

Problem 2.1.2 (Poisson arrivals) A service receives on average 4 orders per minute, arrivals being independent. What is P(0 orders in a minute), P(more than 8 in a minute), and how many orders per minute should you staff for so that you are overwhelmed less than 1 percent of the time?

Formula	$P(X = k) = e^{-4}\, 4^k / k!$
Plug in	$P(0) = e^{-4} = 0.0183$
Compute	$P(X > 8) = 1 - P(X \le 8)$. We use the CDF in code. For the capacity, we need the smallest c with $P(X > c) < 0.01$, which is the 99th percentile of Poisson(4).
Answer	$P(0) = 1.8$ percent, $P(X > 8) = 2.1$ percent, and the 99th percentile is 9 orders per minute. A capacity of 9 orders per minute is exceeded only 0.8 percent of the time, so it meets the 1 percent target.
Check	Simulate 1,000,000 minutes. The fraction of minutes with more than 9 orders must be below 1 percent (we get 0.8 percent), and the fraction above 8 must be near 2.1 percent.
Why it matters	Poisson tells you that "average 4 per second" does not mean "never above 4". Burst capacity is always larger than the average. This is the same fact that makes a queue grow even when average load is below capacity.

```
import numpy as np
p = stats.poisson(4)
print("P(0)   =", round(p.pmf(0), 4))
print("P(>8)  =", round(p.sf(8), 4))
print("99th percentile:", p.ppf(0.99), "  P(>9) =", round(p.sf(9), 4))
sim = np.random.default_rng(10).poisson(4, 1_000_000)
print("simulated P(>8):", round((sim > 8).mean(), 4), " P(>9):",
round((sim > 9).mean(), 4))
```

```
P(0)   = 0.0183
P(>8)  = 0.0214
99th percentile: 9.0   P(>9) = 0.0081
simulated P(>8): 0.0214  P(>9): 0.0082
```

Problem 2.1.3 (Poisson as limit of Binomial; mean vs variance) A batch has 10,000 records and each is corrupt with probability 0.0005. Compare Binomial(10000, 0.0005) with Poisson(5) for P(X = 8). Then simulate counts to see the mean and variance of each.

Formula	Poisson(λ) approximates Binomial(n, p) when n is large, p is small and λ = np.
Plug in	λ = 10,000 × 0.0005 = 5.
Compute	Compare pmf(8) for both and the sample variance.
Answer	Both give P(X = 8) of about 0.0653, and both have mean 5 and variance about 5.
Check	Binomial variance = np(1−p) = 4.9975, which is almost 5 because 1−p is almost 1.
Why it matters	When you only know "average 5 bad records per batch", Poisson is the natural model, and you do not need n or p.

```
rng = np.random.default_rng(11)
bin_pmf, poi_pmf = stats.binom(10000, 0.0005).pmf(8),
stats.poisson(5).pmf(8)
print("binom pmf(8):", round(bin_pmf, 5), " poisson pmf(8):",
round(poi_pmf, 5))
xb = rng.binomial(10000, 0.0005, 200_000); xp = rng.poisson(5, 200_000)
print("binom   mean/var:", round(xb.mean(), 3), round(xb.var(), 3))
print("poisson mean/var:", round(xp.mean(), 3), round(xp.var(), 3))
```

```
binom pmf(8): 0.06527  poisson pmf(8): 0.06528
binom   mean/var: 5.005 4.988
poisson mean/var: 5.0 4.981
```

The picture

```
Binomial(20,0.03): sharp spike at 0–1, thin right tail
Poisson(4):        hill centred near 4, right tail longer than left
Geometric(0.1):    highest at 1, then smoothly falling (the "waiting"
shape)
```

Connection to the real job

Binomial and Poisson are the building blocks of A/B testing (conversions are Binomial), log analysis (error counts per minute are Poisson-like) and queueing models for capacity planning. Multinomial is the model behind text count features and softmax outputs in classification.

Applications

- **Data Analytics:** conversion counts (Binomial), support tickets per day (Poisson).
- **Operations:** order arrivals, returns per batch, number of attempts until a delivery succeeds (Geometric).
- **Machine Learning:** Naive Bayes for counts (Multinomial), Poisson regression (Chapter 8).
- **GenAI:** next-token counts and sampling from a categorical distribution.

COMMON MISTAKE

Using Poisson when counts are clumpy. If the variance is far above the mean (for example, errors come in bursts), Poisson will make you under-estimate risk. Compare sample mean and sample variance first.

Check yourself

1. What is the variance of Poisson(7)? Answer: 7.
2. Binomial(10, 0.5): what is the mean? Answer: 5.
3. You count "number of trials until the first success". Which distribution? Answer: Geometric.

2.2 Continuous Distributions for Time, Size and Noise

INTUITION

A continuous variable is a measurement on a ruler: time, bytes, money. A single exact value has probability zero, so we talk about *density* (how crowded the values are near a point) and about intervals. Imagine pouring sand on a line: the height of the pile at a point is the density, and the area under the pile between two points is the probability.

Words you need

Word	Plain meaning	Example
PDF (density)	Height of the pile at x; area = probability	Density of delivery time near 200 minutes
Quantile /	The value below which a given fraction lies	99th-percentile delivery time

percentile		
Scale and shape	Parameters that stretch the curve and bend its tail	Weibull(k, λ)
Memoryless	The future wait does not depend on how long you already waited	Exponential

The families

Distribution	Story	When to use	Mean
Uniform(a, b)	Every value equally likely	Random jitter, random IDs	(a+b)/2
Normal(μ, σ²)	Sum of many small independent effects	Measurement noise, averages (Chapter 3)	μ
Log-normal	Product of many small positive effects; log is normal	Delivery times, file sizes, incomes	e^(μ+σ²/2)
Exponential(λ)	Waiting time between independent Poisson events	Time between arrivals or failures	1/λ
Gamma(k, θ)	Waiting time for k events	Total time of k stages, rainfall	kθ
Weibull(k, λ)	Lifetime with changing failure rate	Hardware failure (k<1 early failures, k>1 wear-out)	λΓ(1+1/k)

The exponential and Poisson distributions are two views of the same process: if events arrive as a Poisson process with rate λ per second, then the gaps between events are Exponential with mean 1/λ seconds.

Item	Example value	Where it appears in the job
Log-normal(5.3, 0.5)	median 200 minutes, long tail	Delivery times
Exponential(rate 4)	mean gap 0.25 minutes	Gaps between customer orders
Weibull(k = 1.5)	wear-out failures	Disk and SSD lifetime modelling

Problem 2.2.1 The gaps between customer orders are Exponential with mean 0.25 minutes (rate 4 per minute). What is P(gap > 1 minute), the median gap, and given that you have already waited 1 minute, what is the chance you wait more than 1 more minute (memoryless check)?

Formula	P(T > t) = e^(−λt); median = ln 2 / λ
Plug in	λ = 4: P(T > 1) = e^(−4); median = 0.6931 / 4
Compute	e^(−4) = 0.0183. Median = 0.1733 minutes. Memoryless: P(T > 2 | T > 1) = e^(−8) / e^(−4) = e^(−4) = 0.0183.
Answer	1.8 percent of gaps exceed 1 minute, the median gap is 0.173 minutes (smaller than the mean 0.25 minutes because of the right tail), and the chance of waiting another minute is still 1.8 percent no matter how long you have waited.
Check	The Poisson rate 4 per minute gave P(0 arrivals in 1 minute) = e^{-4} = 0.0183 in 2.1.2. "No arrival in one minute" and "gap longer than one minute" are the same event. They match.
Why it matters	Simulation tools that generate random customer arrivals (a queue at a bank, calls to a help line) use exactly this kind of random gap. Memorylessness is also why a "bathtub" failure model needs Weibull instead.

```
import numpy as np
from scipy import stats
ex = stats.expon(scale=0.25)           # scale = mean = 1/rate
print("P(gap>1)       :", round(ex.sf(1), 4))
print("median gap     :", round(ex.median(), 4))
print("P(T>2 | T>1)   :", round(ex.sf(2) / ex.sf(1), 4))
gaps = np.random.default_rng(12).exponential(0.25, 1_000_000)
print("sim mean/median:", round(gaps.mean(), 4), round(np.median(gaps),
4))
```

```
P(gap>1)       : 0.0183
median gap     : 0.1733
P(T>2 | T>1)   : 0.0183
sim mean/median: 0.25 0.1734
```

Problem 2.2.2 (fit a distribution to delivery times) We have 2,000 delivery times (minutes). Is Normal or Log-normal a better description? Fit both by maximum likelihood (MLE, the Math PDF Pillar 3.2 idea of choosing parameters that make the data most likely) and compare the log-

likelihood and the 99th percentile prediction against the data.

Formula	For the log-normal, MLE is simple: $\hat{\mu}$ = mean of ln(x), $\hat{\sigma}$ = SD of ln(x) (divide by n). For the normal: $\bar{x}$ and the SD of x.
Plug in	Take the logs of the data, compute their mean and SD. Compute the sum of log-densities for each model.
Compute	See the output. A higher total log-likelihood means a better fit (same number of parameters, 2, so the comparison is fair).
Answer	The log-normal has a far higher log-likelihood (about −12,045 against −12,481). The normal even puts 3.4 percent of its probability on negative delivery times and under-estimates the 99th percentile (516 minutes against the data's 670; the log-normal says 639).
Check	The empirical 99th percentile from the data should be close to the log-normal 99th percentile and far from the normal one.
Why it matters	If you used a Normal model with mean ± 3 SD to set a delivery promise, you would set the 99th-percentile target about 150 minutes too low and promise too much.

```
rng = np.random.default_rng(13)
data = rng.lognormal(5.3, 0.5, 2000)          # pretend these are
measured delivery times (minutes)
mu, sd = np.log(data).mean(), np.log(data).std()
m, s = data.mean(), data.std()
ll_log = stats.lognorm(s=sd, scale=np.exp(mu)).logpdf(data).sum()
ll_nor = stats.norm(m, s).logpdf(data).sum()
print(f"lognormal MLE mu={mu:.3f} sigma={sd:.3f}   loglik={ll_log:.1f}")
print(f"normal    MLE mean={m:.1f} sd={s:.1f}  loglik={ll_nor:.1f}")
print("empirical 99th percentile:", round(np.percentile(data, 99), 1))
print("lognormal p99:", round(stats.lognorm(s=sd,
scale=np.exp(mu)).ppf(0.99), 1))
print("normal    p99:", round(stats.norm(m, s).ppf(0.99), 1))
print("normal P(time < 0):", round(stats.norm(m, s).cdf(0), 4))
```

```
lognormal MLE mu=5.300 sigma=0.498   loglik=-12045.0
normal    MLE mean=227.2 sd=124.2  loglik=-12481.3
empirical 99th percentile: 670.5
lognormal p99: 638.6
normal    p99: 516.1
normal P(time < 0): 0.0337
```

Problem 2.2.3 (Weibull and hardware failure) A disk has Weibull lifetime with shape k = 1.5 and scale λ = 4 years. Find the probability of surviving 3 years, the median lifetime, and the hazard (failure rate) at 1 year and at 5 years.

Formula	Survival S(t) = exp(−(t/λ)^k); hazard h(t) = (k/λ)(t/λ)$^{k-1}$; median = λ(ln 2)^(1/k)
Plug in	S(3) = exp(−(3/4)^1.5); h(1) = (1.5/4)(1/4)^0.5; h(5) = (1.5/4)(5/4)^0.5
Compute	(3/4)^1.5 = 0.6495, S(3) = e^(−0.6495) = 0.5222. Median = 4 × 0.6931^(0.6667) = 4 × 0.7832 = 3.13 years. h(1) = 0.375 × 0.5 = 0.1875 per year; h(5) = 0.375 × 1.1180 = 0.4193 per year.
Answer	52.2 percent of disks survive 3 years (0.5223), half are dead by 3.13 years, and the failure rate more than doubles from 0.19 to 0.42 per year, which is the signature of wear-out (k > 1).
Check	With k = 1 the hazard is a constant 1/λ (exponential). Here k = 1.5 > 1 so the hazard must rise with age. It does.
Why it matters	Weibull is the standard starting model in reliability and in the survival analysis of Chapter 11.

```
w = stats.weibull_min(c=1.5, scale=4)
print("S(3) =", round(w.sf(3), 4), " median =", round(w.median(), 3))
h = lambda t: w.pdf(t) / w.sf(t)
print("hazard at 1 yr:", round(h(1), 4), " at 5 yr:", round(h(5), 4))
```

```
S(3) = 0.5223  median = 3.133
hazard at 1 yr: 0.1875  at 5 yr: 0.4193
```

The picture

```
# plot
import matplotlib.pyplot as plt
fig, ax = plt.subplots(2, 3, figsize=(10, 5.2))
x = np.linspace(0, 12, 400)
ax[0,0].bar(range(0, 13), stats.poisson(4).pmf(range(0, 13)),
color="#1f77b4"); ax[0,0].set_title("Poisson(4)")
ax[0,1].plot(x, stats.expon(scale=0.25).pdf(x), color="#d62728");
ax[0,1].set_title("Exponential (mean 0.25 min)"); ax[0,1].set_xlim(0, 2)
xs = np.linspace(0.01, 1200, 600)
ax[0,2].plot(xs, stats.lognorm(0.5, scale=200).pdf(xs), label="log-
normal"); ax[0,2].plot(xs, stats.norm(227, 119).pdf(xs), ls="--",
label="normal fit"); ax[0,2].legend(fontsize=7);
ax[0,2].set_title("Delivery time (minutes)")
xt = np.linspace(0, 10, 300)
for k in (0.7, 1.0, 1.5, 3.0): ax[1,0].plot(xt, stats.weibull_min(k,
scale=4).pdf(xt), label=f"k={k}")
ax[1,0].legend(fontsize=7); ax[1,0].set_title("Weibull (scale 4)")
xb = np.linspace(0, 1, 300)
for a_, b_ in [(1,1),(2,5),(8,2),(0.5,0.5)]: ax[1,1].plot(xb,
stats.beta(a_, b_).pdf(xb), label=f"Beta({a_},{b_})")
ax[1,1].legend(fontsize=7); ax[1,1].set_ylim(0, 4);
ax[1,1].set_title("Beta")
xg = np.linspace(0, 20, 300)
for k_ in (1, 2, 5, 10): ax[1,2].plot(xg, stats.chi2(k_).pdf(xg),
label=f"df={k_}")
ax[1,2].legend(fontsize=7); ax[1,2].set_ylim(0, 0.5);
ax[1,2].set_title("Chi-square")
plt.tight_layout(); plt.savefig(f"{IMG}/ch02_distributions.png", dpi=120);
plt.close()
```

Six distributions side by side: Poisson, exponential, log-normal versus normal, Weibull, beta and chi-square

How to read it: each small panel shows the PDF (or PMF bars for Poisson) on the y-axis against the value on the x-axis. In the "Delivery time" panel the dashed normal curve puts probability on negative numbers and misses the long right tail of the log-normal. In the Weibull panel, k below 1 starts very high (early failures), k = 1 is the exponential, and larger k is a hill (wear-out).

Connection to the real job

Choosing between log-normal, Gamma and Weibull for a positive skewed variable is a daily modelling task. Wrong-shape assumptions lead to wrong delivery promises, wrong anomaly

thresholds and wrong simulated demand.

Applications

- **Operations:** delivery-time models, gaps between orders, failure and lifetime models.
- **Data Science:** choosing the response distribution for a GLM (Gamma for positive skewed targets).
- **Finance / Insurance:** log-normal claims and prices, Weibull for time to default.
- **Simulation:** generating realistic synthetic load and test data.

COMMON MISTAKE

Fitting a normal curve to anything positive and skewed, then reporting "mean ± 2 SD". Check with a histogram of the log of the data. If the log looks bell-shaped, the data is log-normal.

Check yourself

1. If events arrive as Poisson(rate 10 per minute), what is the mean gap? Answer: 0.1 minute (6 seconds).
2. Which distribution has a constant failure rate? Answer: Exponential (Weibull with k = 1).
3. If ln(X) is normal, what is X called? Answer: Log-normal.

2.3 The Distributions That Come From the Normal: Chi-square, t and F

INTUITION

You will meet three distributions in almost every statistical test: chi-square, t and F. Do not memorise them as separate objects. They are all built from normal variables. Imagine building with the same Lego bricks (standard normal numbers): stack their squares and you get chi-square, divide a normal by a chi-square-based spread and you get t, divide two chi-squares and you get F. Tests use them because they describe how noisy an estimate is *when you must estimate the spread from the data*.

Words you need

Word	Plain meaning	Example
Standard normal Z	Normal with mean 0 and SD 1	Z-score
Degrees of freedom (df)	How many independent pieces of information are available	n − 1 for a sample variance
Critical value	The cut-off beyond which a test statistic is "rare"	1.96 for z at 5 percent two-sided

The recipes

- **Chi-square(k)** = $Z_1^2 + Z_2^2 + \ldots + Z_k^2$. Mean k, variance 2k.
- **Student t(k)** = $Z / \sqrt{(\chi^2_k / k)}$. Looks like the normal but with heavier tails. When k is large it becomes normal.
- **F(d_1, d_2)** = $(\chi^2_\{d_1\} / d_1) / (\chi^2_\{d_2\} / d_2)$. It is a ratio of two variance estimates, used in ANOVA and in the F-test of regression.

Item	Example value	Where it appears in the job
t(9) critical value (two-sided 5%)	2.262	Small-sample confidence intervals
Chi-square(1) 95th percentile	$3.841 = 1.96^2$	Chi-square tests and likelihood-ratio tests
F(3, 20) 95th percentile	3.098	ANOVA decisions

Problem 2.3.1 Show by simulation that $Z/\sqrt{(\chi^2/k)}$ with k = 5 behaves like a t distribution with 5 degrees of freedom, by comparing the 97.5th percentile and the tail probability beyond 2.

Formula	T = Z / √(V / k), where V is chi-square(k) built from k squared normals
Plug in	k = 5. Simulate Z and V = sum of 5 squared normals, 500,000 times.
Compute	Take the 97.5th percentile of T and P(T > 2). Compare with `stats.t(5)`.
Answer	The simulated percentile is close to the exact 2.571 and P(T > 2) is close to 0.051. For the normal, the same numbers are 1.960 and 0.023.
Check	The exact t(5) percentile (2.571) is larger than the normal's (1.960), confirming heavier tails.
Why it matters	When you estimate the SD from only 6 data points, you must use the wider t cut-offs, otherwise your intervals are too narrow and you will be over-confident.

```
rng = np.random.default_rng(14)
N, k = 500_000, 5
Z = rng.standard_normal(N)
V = (rng.standard_normal((N, k)) ** 2).sum(axis=1)
T = Z / np.sqrt(V / k)
print("sim  97.5% :", round(np.percentile(T, 97.5), 3), " P(T>2):",
round((T > 2).mean(), 4))
print("t(5) exact :", round(stats.t(5).ppf(0.975), 3), " P(T>2):",
round(stats.t(5).sf(2), 4))
print("normal     :", round(stats.norm.ppf(0.975), 3), " P(Z>2):",
round(stats.norm.sf(2), 4))
```

```
sim  97.5% : 2.564  P(T>2): 0.0505
t(5) exact : 2.571  P(T>2): 0.051
normal     : 1.96  P(Z>2): 0.0228
```

Problem 2.3.2 (critical values you will use all the time) Find the 5-percent critical values for: z (two-sided), t with 9, 29 and 1000 degrees of freedom, chi-square with 1 and 4 df, and F(3, 20).

Formula	critical value = the quantile at 1 − α/2 (two-sided t) or 1 − α (chi-square, F which are one-sided)
Plug in	`ppf(0.975)` for two-sided, `ppf(0.95)` for chi-square and F
Compute	See the output.
Answer	t falls from 2.262 (df 9) toward 1.962 (df 1000), approaching the z value 1.960.
Check	Chi-square(1) = z²: 1.960² = 3.841. It matches.
Why it matters	Knowing these by heart makes you quick in interviews: "about 2 for t with 30 df, 1.96 for z, 3.84 for chi-square with 1 df".

```
print("z 97.5%:", round(stats.norm.ppf(0.975), 3))
for df in (9, 29, 1000):
    print(f"t({df}) 97.5%:", round(stats.t(df).ppf(0.975), 3))
print("chi2(1) 95%:", round(stats.chi2(1).ppf(0.95), 3), " chi2(4) 95%:",
round(stats.chi2(4).ppf(0.95), 3))
print("F(3,20) 95%:", round(stats.f(3, 20).ppf(0.95), 3), "  1.96^2 =",
round(1.96**2, 3))
```

```
z 97.5%: 1.96
t(9) 97.5%: 2.262
t(29) 97.5%: 2.045
t(1000) 97.5%: 1.962
chi2(1) 95%: 3.841  chi2(4) 95%: 9.488
F(3,20) 95%: 3.098   1.96^2 = 3.842
```

The picture

```
Normal :  ...../‾‾‾\.....     thin tails
t(5)   :  ...../‾‾‾‾‾\.....   same centre, more mass in the tails
chi2   :  starts high (df small), becomes a hump to the right as df grows
F      :  starts at 0, long right tail, only positive values
```

Connection to the real job

A t-test (Chapter 4) compares a mean difference to a t distribution. ANOVA and regression F-tests use F. Chi-square is used for tests on counts (Chapter 4) and in deviance tests for GLMs

(Chapter 8). You rarely compute these by hand, but you must understand *why* the library picks them.

Applications

- **Data Analytics:** t-tests for before/after comparisons, chi-square for category association.
- **Data Science:** F-test for regression significance, likelihood-ratio tests.
- **Machine Learning:** comparing two models with a paired t-test over cross-validation folds.
- **Quality engineering:** control charts and variance tests.

COMMON MISTAKE

Using the normal (z) cut-off 1.96 with small samples. With 10 observations the right cut-off is 2.262, a difference of 15 percent in interval width.

Check yourself

1. What does t(k) approach when k is large? Answer: The standard normal.
2. What is the mean of chi-square with k df? Answer: k.
3. Which distribution compares two variances? Answer: F.

2.4 Beta and Dirichlet: Distributions Over Probabilities

INTUITION

Suppose 10 visitors saw a new page and 3 converted. What is the true conversion rate? It is not exactly 0.3; it is uncertain. The **Beta distribution** is a curve over the possible values of a rate between 0 and 1. A tall narrow curve means "we are sure", a wide flat curve means "we know very little". The **Dirichlet distribution** is the same idea for several rates at once that must sum to 1, like the shares of clicks on 4 buttons. These two are the backbone of Bayesian A/B testing (Chapter 9).

The definitions

- **Beta(a, b)** lives on (0, 1). Mean = a / (a + b). Variance = ab / ((a+b)²(a+b+1)). Think of a as "successes + 1" and b as "failures + 1" when you start from a flat view.
- **Dirichlet(α_1, ..., α_m)** lives on vectors (p_1, ..., p_m) with sum 1. Mean of $p_i = \alpha_i / \Sigma\alpha$. A draw

from it is a random probability vector.

- Beta(1, 1) is the flat Uniform(0, 1). Beta is the Dirichlet with two categories.

Item	Example value	Where it appears in the job
Beta(4, 8)	3 successes in 10 trials, flat prior	Posterior for a conversion rate
Beta(0.5, 0.5)	U-shaped	Jeffreys prior
Dirichlet(5,3,1,1)	Click shares for 4 buttons	Topic models (LDA), multi-variant tests

Problem 2.4.1 After 3 conversions in 10 visits, a flat prior gives Beta(1 + 3, 1 + 7) = Beta(4, 8). Find its mean, its 95 percent central interval, and P(rate > 0.5). Then compare with 300 conversions in 1,000 visits, Beta(301, 701).

Formula	mean = a / (a + b); interval = the 2.5th and 97.5th percentiles
Plug in	a = 4, b = 8 gives mean 4/12 = 0.333; a = 301, b = 701 gives 301/1002 = 0.3004
Compute	Use `ppf` and `sf`.
Answer	With 10 visits the rate could be anywhere from about 0.11 to 0.61 and P(rate > 0.5) is about 0.11. With 1,000 visits the interval shrinks to about 0.27 to 0.33.
Check	The width shrinks roughly by a factor of √100 = 10 when the data grows 100 times. The width ratio 0.500 / 0.057 is about 9, close to 10.
Why it matters	The same observed rate (30 percent) carries very different certainty depending on sample size. Good analysts always show the uncertainty.

```
for a_, b_ in [(4, 8), (301, 701)]:
    d = stats.beta(a_, b_)
    lo, hi = d.ppf([0.025, 0.975])
    print(f"Beta({a_},{b_}): mean={d.mean():.4f} 95% interval=({lo:.3f},
{hi:.3f}) width={hi-lo:.3f} P(>0.5)={d.sf(0.5):.4f}")
```

```
Beta(4,8): mean=0.3333 95% interval=(0.109, 0.610) width=0.500
P(>0.5)=0.1133
Beta(301,701): mean=0.3004 95% interval=(0.272, 0.329) width=0.057
P(>0.5)=0.0000
```

Problem 2.4.2 (Dirichlet) Four buttons got click counts 50, 30, 15 and 5. Using a flat Dirichlet(1,1,1,1) prior, the posterior is Dirichlet(51, 31, 16, 6). Find the mean share for each button and the probability that button 1 truly has the highest share.

Formula	posterior α = prior α + counts; mean share = α_i / Σα
Plug in	Σα = 51 + 31 + 16 + 6 = 104
Compute	Shares: 0.490, 0.298, 0.154, 0.058. For P(button 1 is best), draw 200,000 random vectors and count how often component 1 is the largest.
Answer	The posterior mean shares are 49.0, 29.8, 15.4 and 5.8 percent. Button 1 is the best with probability very close to 1 (about 0.99).
Check	The shares must add to 1: 0.490 + 0.298 + 0.154 + 0.058 = 1.000.
Why it matters	The same method compares several design variants without running pairwise tests.

```
alpha = np.array([51, 31, 16, 6])
print("mean shares:", np.round(alpha / alpha.sum(), 3), " sum:",
round((alpha / alpha.sum()).sum(), 3))
draws = np.random.default_rng(15).dirichlet(alpha, 200_000)
print("P(button 1 highest):", round((draws.argmax(axis=1) == 0).mean(),
4))
```

```
mean shares: [0.49  0.298 0.154 0.058]  sum: 1.0
P(button 1 highest): 0.9876
```

The picture

Beta(4, 8) is a hump near 0.33 that spreads from 0.1 to 0.6. Beta(301, 701) is a spike near 0.30 with width 0.06. See the Beta panel in the figure above for other shapes: Beta(1,1) is flat, Beta(0.5, 0.5) is a U.

Connection to the real job

Conversion rates, click-through rates and defect rates are probabilities with uncertainty. Beta and Dirichlet express this uncertainty directly. They also appear as the output layer logic (softmax gives a probability vector) and in topic models.

Applications

- **Data Analytics:** A/B test credible intervals for conversion.
- **Data Science:** Thompson sampling in bandit experiments.
- **GenAI / NLP:** Latent Dirichlet Allocation (topic modelling).
- **Quality:** defect-rate estimates from small samples.

COMMON MISTAKE

Reporting the raw rate (3/10 = 30 percent) as if it were a fact. With 10 visits, the plausible range is huge. Show an interval.

Check yourself

1. What is the mean of Beta(2, 6)? Answer: 2/8 = 0.25.
2. Which distribution over 5 categories gives a random probability vector? Answer: Dirichlet.
3. What is Beta(1,1)? Answer: Uniform(0, 1).

2.5 Joint, Marginal and Conditional Distributions; the Multivariate Normal; Transforming Variables

INTUITION

So far we looked at one number at a time. Real data has many columns that move together: order size and delivery time, height and weight. The **joint distribution** is the full table of how the variables go together. The **marginal** distribution is what you see if you ignore the other variable (add up the row or column totals). The **conditional** distribution is what you see after fixing the other variable. A **multivariate normal** is the bell curve in many dimensions: an ellipse of points described by a mean vector and a covariance matrix.

Words you need

Word	Plain meaning	Example
Joint P(X, Y)	Probability of each pair of values	A 2D table
Marginal P(X)	Sum the joint over Y	Row totals
Conditional P(Y | X)	Joint divided by marginal	
Covariance matrix Σ	Table of all variances (diagonal) and covariances (off-diagonal)	2 × 2 for two variables
Transformation	A new variable defined from old ones, Y = g(X)	log of delivery time
MGF	M(t) = E[e^(tX)], a "fingerprint" of a distribution	Used to prove sums of variables

Key facts

- Independent variables: joint = product of marginals.
- For a bivariate normal with means μ, SDs σ_x, σ_Y and correlation ρ: $E[Y \mid X = x] = \mu_Y + \rho\,(\sigma_Y/\sigma_x)(x - \mu_x)$ and $Var(Y \mid X = x) = \sigma_Y^2\,(1 - \rho^2)$. Knowing X *reduces* the spread of Y by the factor $(1 - \rho^2)$.
- Any linear combination of normal variables is normal.
- If Y = e^X and X is normal, Y is log-normal. If Z is standard normal, Z^2 is chi-square(1).
- MGF fact: the MGF of a sum of independent variables is the product of their MGFs. For a Bernoulli(p), $M(t) = 1 - p + p \cdot e^t$. So the sum of n of them has $M(t) = (1 - p + p \cdot e^t)^n$, which is the Binomial MGF. This is a short proof that sums of independent Bernoullis are Binomial.

Item	Example value	Where it appears in the job
Covariance matrix	[[400,300],[300,900]]	PCA, Mahalanobis anomaly distance
Conditional mean	E[Y|	X=x] straight line
Log transform	delivery time → log delivery time	Making skewed data close to normal

Problem 2.5.1 Order size X in items (mean 50, SD 10) and delivery time Y in minutes (mean 200, SD 40) are bivariate normal with correlation 0.8. (a) Given 70 items, what is the expected delivery time and its SD? (b) How much of the variance of delivery time is explained by order size?

Formula	$E[Y \mid x] = \mu_Y + \rho(\sigma_Y/\sigma_x)(x - \mu_x)$; $SD(Y \mid x) = \sigma_Y \sqrt{(1 - \rho^2)}$
Plug in	$E = 200 + 0.8 \times (40/10) \times (70 - 50)$; $SD = 40 \times \sqrt{(1 - 0.64)}$
Compute	$E = 200 + 0.8 \times 4 \times 20 = 200 + 64 = 264$. $SD = 40 \times \sqrt{0.36} = 40 \times 0.6 = 24$. Variance explained = $\rho^2 = 0.64$.
Answer	At 70 items expect about 264 minutes with SD 24 minutes (instead of the unconditional SD 40), and order size explains 64 percent of delivery-time variance.
Check	Simulate many pairs, keep those with order size in [69, 71], and compute the mean and SD of delivery time in that slice.
Why it matters	This is regression in one line: the conditional mean is a straight line with slope $\rho\sigma_Y/\sigma_x = 3.2$ minutes per item.

```
mean = [50, 200]
cov = [[100, 0.8 * 10 * 40], [0.8 * 10 * 40, 1600]]
xy = np.random.default_rng(16).multivariate_normal(mean, cov, 2_000_000)
sl = xy[(xy[:, 0] > 69) & (xy[:, 0] < 71)]
print("cov matrix:", cov)
print("slice size:", len(sl), " mean delivery time:", round(sl[:,
1].mean(), 1), " sd:", round(sl[:, 1].std(), 1))
print("theory: 264.0 and 24.0;  corr:", round(np.corrcoef(xy.T)[0, 1], 3))
```

```
cov matrix: [[100, 320.0], [320.0, 1600]]
slice size: 21555  mean delivery time: 263.7  sd: 24.1
theory: 264.0 and 24.0;  corr: 0.8
```

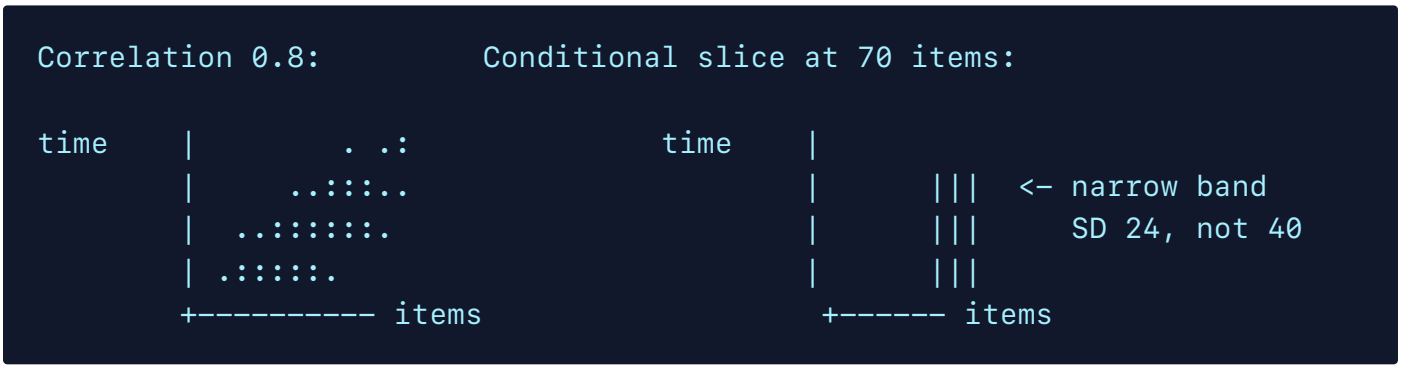
Problem 2.5.2 (transformations and MGF) (a) If X is standard normal, Y = e^X is log-normal. Find E[Y] by theory (e^(1/2)) and by simulation; note it is NOT $e^0 = 1$. (b) Check with the MGF that the sum of 3 independent Bernoulli(0.2) variables has the Binomial(3, 0.2) distribution at t = 0.5.

Formula	(a) E[e^X] = M_X(1) = e^(σ²/2) with σ = 1. (b) $(1 - p + p\,e^{t})^{n}$ versus Σ P(k) e^(tk).
Plug in	(a) e^0.5. (b) p = 0.2, n = 3, t = 0.5.
Compute	(a) e^0.5 = 1.6487. (b) $(0.8 + 0.2 \times 1.6487)^3 = (1.12974)^3 = 1.4419$. And Σ P(k)e^(0.5k) for the Binomial gives the same.
Answer	(a) The simulation gives 1.6508 against the theory 1.6487. The mean of the log-normal is bigger than 1, because the average of exponentials is dominated by large values (Jensen's inequality). (b) Both MGF calculations give 1.4419.
Check	The two numbers in (b) are computed in different ways and match to many decimals.
Why it matters	"Average of the log is not the log of the average." This explains why the mean delivery time sits above the median delivery time (mean 227 versus median 202 earlier).

```
x = np.random.default_rng(17).standard_normal(2_000_000)
print("E[e^X] simulated:", round(np.exp(x).mean(), 4), " theory:",
round(np.exp(0.5), 4))
t, p, n = 0.5, 0.2, 3
mgf_product = (1 - p + p * np.exp(t)) ** n
mgf_binom = sum(stats.binom(n, p).pmf(k) * np.exp(t * k) for k in range(n
+ 1))
print("MGF product:", round(mgf_product, 6), " binomial MGF:",
round(mgf_binom, 6))
```

```
E[e^X] simulated: 1.6508  theory: 1.6487
MGF product: 1.441918  binomial MGF: 1.441918
```

The picture



The cloud is an ellipse; cutting it with a vertical line gives a narrower slice.

Connection to the real job

The covariance matrix drives PCA (Math PDF) and the Mahalanobis distance used for anomaly detection. Conditional distributions are exactly what regression models. Log transforms use the log-normal story and are used before linear models on skewed targets.

Applications

- **Data Science:** Gaussian mixture models, anomaly detection with Mahalanobis distance.
- **Machine Learning:** Gaussian processes, naive Bayes (conditional independence), Kalman filters.
- **Finance:** portfolio models with correlated returns.
- **Operations:** modelling joint behaviour of order size, distance and delivery time.

COMMON MISTAKE

Assuming "uncorrelated" means "independent". For normal variables this is true, but in general it is not. $Y = X^2$ is uncorrelated with X (for symmetric X) yet completely dependent.

Check yourself

1. A correlation of 0.6 reduces the conditional variance of Y by what factor? Answer: (1 − 0.36) = 0.64.
2. Joint distribution of independent X, Y equals what? Answer: The product of the marginals.
3. Why is E[e^X] bigger than e^E[X]? Answer: Jensen's inequality: the exponential is convex.

2.6 Law of Large Numbers and Markov Chains

INTUITION

If you flip a coin many times, the share of heads settles near 0.5. That is the **Law of Large Numbers (LLN)**: sample averages converge to the true mean as the sample grows. A **Markov chain** is a process that jumps between states where tomorrow depends only on today (not on the longer past), like a user moving between pages. Run it for a long time and the share of time in each state settles to a **stationary distribution**. Both ideas say "randomness calms down in the long run", and both are the basis for simulation and for MCMC (Chapter 9).

Definitions

- **LLN**: if X_1, X_2, ... are independent with mean μ, then the average $\bar{X}_n \to \mu$ as $n \to \infty$. It says nothing about speed, and it fails for some heavy-tailed laws (Cauchy has no mean).
- **Markov property**: P(next state | all past) = P(next state | current state). A chain is described by a **transition matrix** P where row i lists the probabilities of moving from state i to each state.
- **Stationary distribution π**: a probability vector with $\pi P = \pi$. If you start from π you stay at π.
- **Poisson process**: events occur independently at rate λ; counts in a window are Poisson, gaps are exponential (see 2.2).

Problem 2.6.1 A website has three page states: Home, Search, Buy. From Home, 60 percent stay Home, 30 percent go to Search, 10 percent go to Buy. From Search: 20 percent to Home, 50 percent stay, 30 percent to Buy. Buy is final-ish: from Buy, 50 percent go Home, 0 to Search, 50 percent stay. Find the long-run share of time in each state.

Formula	Solve $\pi P = \pi$ with $\pi_1 + \pi_2 + \pi_3 = 1$.
Plug in	P = [[0.6, 0.3, 0.1], [0.2, 0.5, 0.3], [0.5, 0.0, 0.5]]
Compute	The stationary vector is the eigenvector of P^T for eigenvalue 1, scaled to sum to 1. We compute it with NumPy and also by multiplying a start vector by P many times.
Answer	In the long run the chain spends about 46.3 percent of its time in Home, 27.8 percent in Search and 25.9 percent in Buy.
Check	Applying P once more to π must give π back. The code prints the difference.
Why it matters	This is how PageRank works (a random surfer on the web), and how MCMC samplers are designed (build a chain whose stationary distribution is the one you want).

```
P = np.array([[0.6, 0.3, 0.1], [0.2, 0.5, 0.3], [0.5, 0.0, 0.5]])
w, v = np.linalg.eig(P.T)
pi = np.real(v[:, np.argmin(abs(w - 1))]); pi = pi / pi.sum()
print("stationary (eigen):", np.round(pi, 4))
x = np.array([1.0, 0.0, 0.0])
for _ in range(100): x = x @ P
print("after 100 steps   :", np.round(x, 4))
print("max |pi P - pi|   :", np.abs(pi @ P - pi).max().round(12))
```

```
stationary (eigen): [0.463  0.2778 0.2593]
after 100 steps   : [0.463  0.2778 0.2593]
max |pi P - pi|   : 0.0
```

Problem 2.6.2 (LLN in action, and when it fails) Compare the running mean of 100,000 draws from a Normal(10, 2) and from a Cauchy distribution. Report the running mean at n = 100, 10,000 and 100,000.

Formula	Running mean at n = $(X_1 + ... + X_n) / n$
Plug in	n = 100, 10,000 and 100,000
Compute	See the output.
Answer	The normal's running mean settles near 10. The Cauchy's running mean keeps jumping, because the Cauchy has no finite mean and the LLN does not apply.
Check	For the normal the standard error is 2/√n: 0.2 at n = 100, 0.02 at n = 10,000, 0.0063 at n = 100,000. The values should be within a couple of these.
Why it matters	Averages of heavy-tailed data (some network delays, extreme loss amounts) can be unstable. Use medians or trimmed means when tails are very heavy.

```
rng = np.random.default_rng(18)
norm = rng.normal(10, 2, 100_000); cau = rng.standard_cauchy(100_000)
for n in (100, 10_000, 100_000):
    print(f"n={n:<7} normal mean={norm[:n].mean():7.3f}   cauchy mean=
{cau[:n].mean():9.3f}")
```

```
n=100     normal mean=  9.962   cauchy mean=   -0.503
n=10000   normal mean=  9.988   cauchy mean=    0.326
n=100000  normal mean= 10.002   cauchy mean=   -0.108
```

The picture

```
Home --0.6--> Home      Home --0.3--> Search     Home --0.1--> Buy
Search --0.2--> Home    Search --0.5--> Search   Search --0.3--> Buy
Buy --0.5--> Home       Buy --0.5--> Buy
```

Each arrow carries the probability of that move; the outgoing arrows from each state add to 1.

Connection to the real job

Markov chains model user journeys, state machines of services, and are the engine inside MCMC samplers. The LLN justifies simulation: "run it 100,000 times and average" works because averages converge.

Applications

- **Data Analytics:** customer journey and funnel models.
- **Data Science:** PageRank, hidden Markov models, MCMC.
- **GenAI:** text generation is a (very long-memory) sequence model; Markov chains are the simple ancestor.
- **Operations:** queue and state models, Monte Carlo simulation of demand.

COMMON MISTAKE

Believing that a short run "evens out". The LLN is about the long run. After 10 coin flips, 7 heads is quite normal. There is no force that "corrects" streaks (the gambler's fallacy).

Check yourself

1. What does the Markov property say? Answer: The future depends on the present only, not the earlier past.
2. Rows of a transition matrix add up to what? Answer: 1.
3. Why does the LLN fail for the Cauchy distribution? Answer: It has no finite mean.

Chapter recap

- Choose a distribution by the *story*: yes/no (Bernoulli), count of yes in n (Binomial), count of events in time (Poisson), wait for an event (Exponential), skewed positive size (log-normal), lifetime (Weibull).
- Poisson has mean = variance; if variance is much bigger, the data are overdispersed.
- Exponential gaps and Poisson counts describe the same process.
- Delivery and waiting times are typically log-normal; fitting a normal gives negative values and a wrong 99th percentile.
- Chi-square, t and F are built from normal variables; t has heavier tails and is used when the SD is estimated.
- Beta and Dirichlet are distributions over probabilities; they express uncertainty about rates.
- A bivariate normal's conditional mean is a straight line; the conditional variance shrinks by $(1 - \rho^2)$.
- The LLN says averages converge (when a mean exists); Markov chains settle to a stationary distribution.

- Always check a fitted distribution against the data (percentiles, histogram, log-likelihood).

Formula / pattern	Meaning
`stats.binom(n,p).pmf/cdf/sf`	Binomial probabilities
`stats.poisson(lam).ppf(0.99)`	Capacity quantile
`stats.expon(scale=1/rate)`	Exponential (scale = mean)
`stats.lognorm(s=sigma, scale=exp(mu))`	Log-normal parameterisation
`stats.weibull_min(c=k, scale=lam)`	Weibull
`t = Z/√(χ²/k)`, `F = (χ²₁/d₁)/(χ²₂/d₂)`	t and F recipes
`E[Y|	x] = $\mu_Y + \rho\sigma_Y/\sigma_x\,(x-\mu_x)$`
`π P = π`	Stationary distribution

Practice set

Problem 2.7.1 X is Binomial(10, 0.5). What is P(X = 5)?

Answer: C(10,5) × 0.5^{10} = 252 / 1024 = 0.246.

Problem 2.7.2 The mean of a count variable is 6 and its sample variance is 6.2. Which model first?

Answer: Poisson, because mean and variance are almost equal.

Problem 2.7.3 What is the output? `from scipy import stats; print(round(stats.poisson(3).pmf(0), 4))`

Answer: e^{-3} = 0.0498.

Problem 2.7.4 Orders arrive as Poisson with rate 12 per minute. What is the mean gap between orders in seconds and P(gap > 10 s)?

Answer: Mean gap = 60/12 = 5 s. Rate per second = 0.2, so P(gap > 10) = e^(−0.2 × 10) = e^{-2} = 0.135.

Problem 2.7.5 Find the bug: an analyst sets the late-delivery alert at mean + 3 × SD using a normal model on log-normal delivery times (mean 227, SD 119). What is wrong?

Answer: The threshold is 227 + 3 × 119 = 584 minutes. A normal model says only 0.13 percent of orders exceed it. For log-normal delivery times with median 200 minutes and sigma 0.5, the real exceedance is 1.6 percent, about 12 times more alerts than planned. Use percentiles of the data or a log-scale model.

Problem 2.7.6 Beta(2, 8) represents a click rate. Find the mean. After 10 more visits with 5 clicks, what is the new Beta and the new mean?

Answer: Mean = 2/10 = 0.2. New Beta = (2 + 5, 8 + 5) = Beta(7, 13), mean = 7/20 = 0.35.

Problem 2.7.7 Z is standard normal. What is the distribution of $Z_1^2 + Z_2^2 + Z_3^2$? What is its mean and variance?

Answer: Chi-square with 3 df, mean 3, variance 6.

Problem 2.7.8 A Markov chain has P = [[0.9, 0.1], [0.5, 0.5]]. Find the stationary distribution.

Answer: Solve $\pi_1 = 0.9\pi_1 + 0.5\pi_2$, giving $0.1\pi_1 = 0.5\pi_2$, so $\pi_1 = 5\pi_2$. With $\pi_1 + \pi_2 = 1$: $\pi = (5/6, 1/6) = (0.833, 0.167)$.

Problem 2.7.9 (interview) "Delivery-time data has mean 200 minutes and median 150 minutes. What does this tell you about the distribution, and what would you report?"

Answer: Mean greater than median means a right-skewed distribution with a long tail (likely log-normal). Report the median and percentiles (p90, p95, p99), not only the mean.

Problem 2.7.10 (interview) "Why does the t distribution have heavier tails than the normal?"

Answer: The t statistic divides by an *estimated* SD, which is itself noisy. When the estimate is small by chance, the ratio becomes large. This extra uncertainty gives heavier tails, especially with few degrees of freedom.

Prompt pack

✨ AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI

```
You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional
moving into data roles, and English is my second language. Teach me
Chapter 2 topic "discrete distributions (Bernoulli, Binomial, Geometric,
```

Poisson, Multinomial) and how to choose between them" in simple English. Use web-service examples with real numbers, show Python simulation for each, and ask me one check question after each distribution. End with 6 exercises and mark my answers.

✨ AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI

You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional moving into data roles. Explain log-normal, exponential, Gamma and Weibull distributions for delivery times, gaps between orders and machine failure. Explain how to fit each with maximum likelihood in scipy and how to check the fit with percentiles and Q-Q plots. Give me 8 graded exercises WITHOUT solutions and wait for my answers before correcting them.

✨ AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI

You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional moving into data roles. The topic is how chi-square, t and F distributions are built from normal variables and why tests use them. Walk me through building each by simulation in NumPy, then quiz me one question at a time on degrees of freedom and critical values. Stop after 8 questions and summarise my weak points.

✨ AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI

You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional moving into data roles. Review my work on Beta, Dirichlet, bivariate normal conditional distributions and Markov chain stationary distributions. Here is my work: [PASTE HERE]. Check every number, show where I went wrong in simple English, and give me two new problems of the same kind.

✨ AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI

You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional moving into data roles. Run a mock interview on probability distributions for data roles: which distribution for which data, Poisson overdispersion, why delivery time is log-normal, LLN versus CLT, Markov chains. Ask one question at a time, wait for my answer, then give a score out of 10 and a model answer. Ask 8 questions.

CHAPTER 3

SAMPLING, ESTIMATION, CONFIDENCE INTERVALS AND THE BOOTSTRAP

How to learn about millions of parcels from a few hundred, and how sure you can be.

An online shop checks 400 parcels and finds the average delivery time is 480 minutes. Your manager asks: "So what is the real average for all customers?" You cannot know it exactly, because you only measured a small part of the world. Statistics gives you a clear way to answer: "Probably between 450 and 510 minutes, and here is how I know." In this chapter you learn how samples are chosen (and how bad choices poison everything), how the noise of an average shrinks as the sample grows (the Central Limit Theorem), how to turn one sample into an honest range (confidence intervals), how to estimate parameters (maximum likelihood and method of moments), and how to get intervals for *any* statistic, such as p95, using the bootstrap. Every concept is checked by simulation, so you will see the theory work.

Our running example is the delivery time of an online shop: the full population has about 100,000 parcels per week, and we look at samples of 25 to 1,000.

3.1 Sampling Methods and Sampling Bias

INTUITION

To taste a big pot of soup you stir it first, then taste one spoon. Stirring makes every part of the pot equally likely to be in the spoon. If you only taste the top, where the salt has not mixed, you get a wrong idea no matter how many top-spoonfuls you taste. Statistics calls "stirring" **random sampling**, and "tasting the top" **sampling bias**. More data does not fix bias. Only a better way of choosing the data does.

Words you need

Word	Plain meaning	Example
Population	Everything you want to know about	All parcels delivered this week
Sample	The part you actually measured	400 parcels

Parameter	A true number about the population	True mean delivery time μ
Statistic (estimator)	A number computed from the sample	Sample mean $\bar{x}$
Simple random sample	Every item has the same chance of being picked	Pick 400 log lines by random index
Stratified sample	Split the population into groups (strata), sample inside each	Sample mobile and desktop users separately, in proportion
Cluster sample	Pick whole groups at random, measure everyone in them	Pick 10 depots, measure all drivers there
Sampling bias	The way you pick makes some items more likely than others	Only measuring parcels that were delivered

Method	Strength	Weakness	Job example
Simple random	Easy, unbiased	Can miss small groups	Random sample of log lines
Stratified	Lower variance when strata differ	You need to know the strata	Survey per country
Cluster	Cheap (visit few places)	Higher variance if clusters are alike inside	Audit 10 of 100 warehouses
Convenience / self-selected	Cheapest	Usually biased	Only surveying users who complain

Problem 3.1.1 A shop has 100,000 customers: 70 percent mobile (average spend 20) and 30 percent desktop (average spend 60). The true mean spend is $0.7 \times 20 + 0.3 \times 60 = 32$. (a) Draw a simple random sample of 200 customers, many times, and see how the estimate behaves. (b) Draw a stratified sample (140 mobile, 60 desktop). (c) Draw a biased sample where desktop users are 4 times more likely to respond. Compare the average and the spread of the three estimators over 2,000 repeats.

Formula	Stratified estimate = Σ (stratum weight × stratum sample mean). The biased estimate is just the plain sample mean of the people who responded.
Plug in	weights 0.7 and 0.3; response probability proportional to 1 for mobile and 4 for desktop, so the expected desktop share among responders is 0.3×4 / (0.7×1 + 0.3×4) = 1.2 / 1.9 = 0.632.
Compute	Biased expected mean = 0.368 × 20 + 0.632 × 60 = 7.37 + 37.9 = 45.3, far above 32. The code repeats each method 2,000 times.
Answer	Simple random and stratified samples both centre on 32, and stratified has about half the spread (0.74 against 1.47). The biased sample centres on about 45.2, which is wrong, and gathering more data would not help.
Check	The theoretical biased mean 45.3 matches the simulation. The spread of a random sample of 200 is about √(var / 200) where the population SD is 21.1 (we compute it in the code), so 21.1 / √200 = 1.49. The simulation gives 1.47.
Why it matters	A survey of "customers who answered" or a tracker that only logs parcels that arrived (so lost parcels vanish) gives confident wrong answers. Always ask: how did this data get to me?

Predict: which estimator has the smallest spread, and which one is centred on the wrong value?

```
import numpy as np
rng = np.random.default_rng(20)
N = 100_000
seg = rng.random(N) < 0.7                        # True = mobile
spend = np.where(seg, rng.normal(20, 8, N), rng.normal(60, 15, N))
print("true mean:", round(spend.mean(), 3), " population sd:",
round(spend.std(), 2))
mob, desk = spend[seg], spend[~seg]
srs, strat, biased = [], [], []
p_resp = np.where(seg, 1.0, 4.0); p_resp = p_resp / p_resp.sum()
for _ in range(2000):
    srs.append(rng.choice(spend, 200, replace=False).mean())
    strat.append(0.7 * rng.choice(mob, 140, replace=False).mean() + 0.3 *
rng.choice(desk, 60, replace=False).mean())
    biased.append(spend[rng.choice(N, 200, replace=False,
p=p_resp)].mean())
for name, a in [("simple random", srs), ("stratified", strat), ("biased
(desktop x4)", biased)]:
    print(f"{name:22} mean of estimates={np.mean(a):7.3f}  sd of
estimates={np.std(a):6.3f}")
```

```
true mean: 31.997  population sd: 21.11
simple random          mean of estimates= 31.990  sd of estimates= 1.473
stratified             mean of estimates= 31.979  sd of estimates= 0.742
biased (desktop x4)    mean of estimates= 45.212  sd of estimates= 1.622
```

Problem 3.1.2 (cluster sampling and its cost) A courier company has 100 depots, each with 50 drivers. Drivers inside one depot have similar average delivery times because they share the same roads and dispatcher. You can measure 500 drivers. Compare (a) a random sample of 500 drivers across all depots with (b) a cluster sample of 10 whole depots.

Formula	Variance of the estimate rises with the similarity of items inside a cluster (the intra-cluster correlation).
Plug in	Each depot has its own mean delivery time (minutes) drawn from Normal(50, 10); each driver varies around the depot mean with SD 5.
Compute	Repeat both methods 2,000 times and compare the SD of the estimated overall mean.
Answer	The cluster sample is much noisier (SD 2.67 versus 0.42 for random sampling, about 6 times larger), although both use 500 drivers.
Check	Theory for 10 clusters: SD ≈ 10 / √10 = 3.2 (between-depot noise dominates); it is a little smaller in the simulation (2.67) because we sample 10 of only 100 depots, so some of the variation is removed. For 500 random drivers: √((10² + 5²) / 500) = 0.5, and the simulation gives 0.42 for the same reason.
Why it matters	If your data come in groups (pupils in classes, orders in deliveries, patients in hospitals), the *effective* sample size is closer to the number of groups than to the number of rows. This will matter again for mixed models in Chapter 11.

```
rng = np.random.default_rng(21)
depot_means = rng.normal(50, 10, 100)
drivers = depot_means[:, None] + rng.normal(0, 5, (100, 50))
flat = drivers.ravel()
a, b = [], []
for _ in range(2000):
    a.append(rng.choice(flat, 500, replace=False).mean())
    b.append(drivers[rng.choice(100, 10, replace=False)].mean())
print("true mean:", round(flat.mean(), 2))
print("random 500 drivers : sd of estimate =", round(np.std(a), 3))
print("10 whole clusters  : sd of estimate =", round(np.std(b), 3))
```

```
true mean: 50.51
random 500 drivers : sd of estimate = 0.424
10 whole clusters  : sd of estimate = 2.665
```

The picture

```
Simple random:  . x . . x . x . . x .     (x = chosen, spread over
everything)
Stratified:     [ mobile: x x x x ] [ desktop: x x ]    (each group
represented)
Cluster:        [ ALL of DC3 ]   [ ALL of DC8 ]         (whole groups)
Biased:         only the top of the pot                 (some parts never
chosen)
```

Connection to the real job

In analytics you rarely control collection, so you must *detect* sampling bias: survivorship (only successful deliveries logged), non-response, and time bias (measuring only on Monday morning). Even the measuring tool can bias results: a stopwatch that is only started when the parcel leaves the depot misses the slow waiting time before dispatch, so the slow cases are under-counted.

Applications

- **Data Analytics:** survey analysis, A/B test assignment, data auditing by stratum.
- **Data Science / ML:** stratified train/test splits (`stratify=y`) so rare classes appear in both parts.
- **Data Engineering:** sampling big tables for quality checks.
- **MLOps:** monitoring on a sample of traffic; make sure the sample is random.

COMMON MISTAKE

Thinking "my sample is large, so it is trustworthy". A million biased rows are worse than 200 random ones, because the large number gives false confidence. Check *how* the sample was collected before checking *how big* it is.

Check yourself

1. Which method fixes "small groups get missed"? Answer: Stratified sampling.
2. Why can 10 clusters of 50 drivers be less informative than 500 random drivers? Answer: Drivers in one cluster are alike, so they add little new information.
3. Does more data reduce bias? Answer: No, it only reduces random noise.

3.2 Standard Error and the Central Limit Theorem

INTUITION

Weigh yourself on a wobbly bathroom scale five times and average the readings. The average wobbles much less than a single reading. If you average 100 readings it wobbles even less. The wobble of an average is called the **standard error**. The wonder is the **Central Limit Theorem (CLT)**: no matter how weird the original data look (skewed delivery times, 0/1 conversions), the *average* of many values has a bell-shaped distribution around the true mean. That is why the normal curve is everywhere in statistics.

Words you need

Word	Plain meaning	Example
Sampling distribution	The distribution of a statistic over many repeated samples	The distribution of $\bar{x}$ for n = 36
Standard error (SE)	The standard deviation of a statistic	SE of the mean = $\sigma/\sqrt{n}$
CLT	For large n, $\bar{x}$ is approximately Normal(μ, σ^2/n)	
z-score	(value − mean) / SD	z = 2 means 2 SDs above

The rules

- $SE(\bar{x}) = \sigma / \sqrt{n}$, estimated by $s / \sqrt{n}$ where s is the sample SD.
- Quadrupling the sample size halves the SE (the **square-root law**). Going from n = 100 to n = 10,000 gives only 10 times less noise.
- For a proportion: $SE(\hat{p}) = \sqrt{(p(1 - p) / n)}$.
- The CLT needs a finite variance. The more skewed the data, the larger n must be. Heavy tails (like the Cauchy) break it.
- **SD versus SE:** SD describes how spread out *individual values* are. SE describes how precisely you know the *mean*. Do not mix them.

Item	Example value	Where it appears in the job

SE of mean delivery time	121 / √36 = 20.2 min	Error bars on a monthly average
SE of conversion rate	√(0.05×0.95/10,000) = 0.0022	A/B test precision
Square-root law	4× the data → 2× the precision	Deciding how long to run a test

Problem 3.2.1 Delivery time (minutes) in a population is log-normal with mean 227.0 min and SD 121.0 min (heavily right-skewed). You take samples of size n and compute the mean. (a) What is the SE for n = 36 and n = 400? (b) Simulate 20,000 sample means for each n and check the SD of the means. (c) How skewed are the sample means?

Formula	SE = σ / √n
Plug in	n = 36: 121.0 / 6; n = 400: 121.0 / 20
Compute	121.0 / 6 = 20.2 min; 121.0 / 20 = 6.05 min.
Answer	The simulated SDs of the means are 20.24 and 6.08 min, as theory says. The individual delivery times have skewness 1.77, the means for n = 36 have 0.28, and the means for n = 400 have skewness 0.10, so they are almost symmetric.
Check	The simulated mean of the sample means must be near 227.0 (unbiasedness). The simulated values are 227.2 and 227.0.
Why it matters	A 400-parcel sample pins the mean down to about ±12 minutes (2 SE), even though single parcels vary by hundreds of minutes.

```
import numpy as np
from scipy import stats
rng = np.random.default_rng(22)
mu_ln, sg_ln = 5.3, 0.5
pop_mean = np.exp(mu_ln + sg_ln**2 / 2)
pop_sd = pop_mean * np.sqrt(np.exp(sg_ln**2) - 1)
print("population mean %.1f  sd %.1f" % (pop_mean, pop_sd))
one = rng.lognormal(mu_ln, sg_ln, 200_000)
print("single-parcel skewness: %.2f" % stats.skew(one))
for n in (36, 400):
    means = rng.lognormal(mu_ln, sg_ln, (20_000, n)).mean(axis=1)
    print(f"n={n:<4} theory SE={pop_sd/np.sqrt(n):6.2f}  simulated SD of
means={means.std():6.2f}  mean of means={means.mean():6.1f}  skew=
{stats.skew(means):5.2f}")
```

```
population mean 227.0  sd 121.0
single-parcel skewness: 1.77
n=36   theory SE= 20.16  simulated SD of means= 20.24  mean of means=
227.2  skew= 0.28
n=400  theory SE=  6.05  simulated SD of means=  6.08  mean of means=
227.0  skew= 0.10
```

Problem 3.2.2 (how big must n be?) Conversions are 0/1 with success probability 0.02. For n = 50, 500 and 5,000, how skewed is the distribution of the sample proportion, and is a normal approximation reasonable? Use the rule of thumb: need $n \cdot p \geq 10$ and $n \cdot (1-p) \geq 10$.

Formula	$n \cdot p \geq 10$ and $n \cdot (1 - p) \geq 10$ for the normal approximation to a proportion
Plug in	n = 50: 50 × 0.02 = 1; n = 500: 10; n = 5,000: 100
Compute	The rule is satisfied for n = 500 (exactly 10) and n = 5,000, but not n = 50. The code measures the skewness of $\hat{p}$ from 50,000 simulated samples.
Answer	With n = 50 the proportion is very skewed (the most common sample has 0 or 1 successes), so a normal interval would be poor. At n = 500 skewness is about 0.3 and at n = 5,000 it is 0.08.
Check	Theoretical skewness of a Binomial(n, p) is $(1 - 2p) / \sqrt{(n\, p\, (1 - p))}$: for n = 50 it is 0.96 / 0.99 = 0.97. The simulation should agree.
Why it matters	Rare events need big samples before the usual formulas work. Checking $n \cdot p$ is a quick safety test before you trust a z-test or a normal interval.

```
for n in (50, 500, 5000):
    ph = rng.binomial(n, 0.02, 50_000) / n
    th = (1 - 2 * 0.02) / np.sqrt(n * 0.02 * 0.98)
    print(f"n={n:<5} n*p={n*0.02:6.1f}  sim skew={stats.skew(ph):5.2f}
theory skew={th:5.2f}  SE={np.sqrt(0.02*0.98/n):.4f}")
```

```
n=50    n*p=   1.0  sim skew= 0.97  theory skew= 0.97  SE=0.0198
n=500   n*p=  10.0  sim skew= 0.32  theory skew= 0.31  SE=0.0063
n=5000  n*p= 100.0  sim skew= 0.08  theory skew= 0.10  SE=0.0020
```

The picture

```
# plot
import matplotlib.pyplot as plt
fig, ax = plt.subplots(1, 3, figsize=(10, 3.2), sharey=False)
ax[0].hist(one[:20000], bins=60, range=(0, 900), color="#1f77b4");
ax[0].set_title("Single parcels (skewed)")
for a_, n in zip(ax[1:], (5, 100)):
    m = rng.lognormal(mu_ln, sg_ln, (20_000, n)).mean(axis=1)
    a_.hist(m, bins=60, color="#2ca02c", density=True)
    xs = np.linspace(m.min(), m.max(), 200)
    a_.plot(xs, stats.norm(pop_mean, pop_sd / np.sqrt(n)).pdf(xs), "k--")
    a_.set_title(f"Means of n={n} (dashed: normal)")
for a_ in ax: a_.set_xlabel("delivery time (min)")
plt.tight_layout(); plt.savefig(f"{IMG}/ch03_clt.png", dpi=120);
plt.close()
```

CLT: single delivery times are skewed; means of 5 are still slightly skewed; means of 100 follow the dashed normal curve

How to read it: the left panel is a histogram of single parcels (long right tail). The middle panel shows averages of 5 parcels: narrower and nearly symmetric, but still a bit lopsided compared with the dashed normal curve. The right panel shows averages of 100: the histogram sits right on the normal curve. The x-axis is delivery time in minutes, the height shows how often.

Connection to the real job

The CLT is why a t-test or z-test can compare *average* delivery time between two depots even when delivery time itself is far from normal. The SE formula tells you how many parcels to

sample: halving the error bar needs four times the samples.

Applications

- **Operations:** error bars on average delivery or waiting times, deciding how many items to sample.
- **Data Analytics:** margin of error in survey and A/B test reports.
- **Machine Learning:** noise in cross-validation scores shrinks as folds and data grow.
- **Quality control:** control charts on subgroup means.

COMMON MISTAKE

Using SD where SE belongs (or the reverse). If someone says "mean 480 min ± 100", ask: is 100 the SD of parcels or the SE of the mean? They differ by a factor of $\sqrt{n}$.

Check yourself

1. Sample SD is 50 and n = 100. What is the SE of the mean? Answer: 50 / 10 = 5.
2. How much more data halves the SE? Answer: 4 times as much.
3. Does the CLT say individual values become normal? Answer: No, only averages (or sums) do.

3.3 Point Estimation: Maximum Likelihood and Method of Moments

INTUITION

You see 50 gaps between failures and you believe they come from an exponential distribution, but you do not know the rate. You must pick one number for the rate. Two clever strategies exist. **Method of moments**: choose the rate so that the model's average equals your data's average. **Maximum likelihood (MLE)**: choose the rate that makes the data you actually saw *most probable*. The Math PDF (Pillar 3.2) gave you the MLE idea. Here we practise it and compare the two.

Words you need

Word	Plain meaning	Example
Estimator	A recipe that turns data into a guess for a parameter	$\bar{x}$ for the mean
Bias	Average error of an estimator over many samples	Sample variance with n in the denominator is biased low
Likelihood $L(\theta)$	Probability of the observed data as a function of the parameter θ	
Log-likelihood	$\ln L(\theta)$; sums instead of products, easier to maximise	
Fisher information	How sharply the log-likelihood curves at its top; more curve means less uncertainty	$SE(\hat{\theta}) \approx 1/\sqrt{(I(\theta))}$

The recipes

- **Method of moments (MoM)**: set sample moments equal to theoretical moments (sample mean = E[X], sample variance = Var(X)) and solve for the parameters.
- **MLE**: maximise $\Sigma \ln f(x_i; \theta)$. Take the derivative, set it to zero.
- Examples: Exponential rate $\hat{\lambda} = 1/\bar{x}$. Poisson $\hat{\lambda} = \bar{x}$. Normal: $\hat{\mu} = \bar{x}$, $\hat{\sigma}^2 = \Sigma(x_i - \bar{x})^2/n$ (biased; divide by $n-1$ for unbiased).
- For large samples MLEs are approximately unbiased, normal and have the smallest possible variance (they are "efficient"). That is why they are the default.

Item	Example value	Where it appears in the job
Exponential MLE	$\hat{\lambda}$ = 1/mean gap = 4.1 per second	Failure/arrival rate
Gamma MoM / MLE	shape, scale from delivery stages	Positive skewed data
Logistic regression	Fitted by MLE (Math PDF)	Every classifier trained with log-loss

Problem 3.3.1 (exponential MLE by hand) Five gaps between failures (in hours) are 2, 5, 1, 4,

3. (a) Find the MLE of the failure rate λ. (b) Find its approximate standard error. (c) Give the log-likelihood at λ = 0.2 and at the MLE to show the MLE is higher.

Formula	$L(\lambda) = \prod \lambda\, e^{(-\lambda x_i)}$, so $\ln L = n \ln \lambda - \lambda \Sigma x_i$. Setting the derivative $n/\lambda - \Sigma x_i = 0$ gives $\hat{\lambda} = n / \Sigma x_i$. Fisher information $I(\lambda) = n / \lambda^2$, so SE $= \hat{\lambda} / \sqrt{n}$.
Plug in	$n = 5$, $\Sigma x = 15$
Compute	$\hat{\lambda} = 5 / 15 = 0.3333$ per hour. SE $= 0.3333 / \sqrt{5} = 0.1491$. $\ln L(0.2) = 5 \ln 0.2 - 0.2 \times 15 = -8.047 - 3 = -11.047$. $\ln L(0.3333) = 5 \ln 0.3333 - 0.3333 \times 15 = -5.493 - 5 = -10.493$.
Answer	The MLE is one failure every 3 hours (rate 0.333 per hour), with standard error about 0.149. The log-likelihood at the MLE (−10.49) beats that at 0.2 (−11.05).
Check	The MLE equals 1 / (mean gap) = 1 / 3 = 0.333, as the formula says. A numerical optimiser gives the same value (code below).
Why it matters	With only 5 observations the SE (0.149) is almost half the estimate: the data say very little. The relative error is $1/\sqrt{n} = 45$ percent. You need about 100 failures for 10 percent.

```
from scipy import optimize
x = np.array([2, 5, 1, 4, 3.0])
ll = lambda lam: len(x) * np.log(lam) - lam * x.sum()
res = optimize.minimize_scalar(lambda l: -ll(l), bounds=(0.01, 5),
method="bounded")
print("MLE closed form:", round(len(x) / x.sum(), 4), " numeric:",
round(res.x, 4))
print("SE:", round((len(x) / x.sum()) / np.sqrt(len(x)), 4))
print("loglik at 0.2 :", round(ll(0.2), 3), " at MLE:", round(ll(len(x) /
x.sum()), 3))
```

```
MLE closed form: 0.3333  numeric: 0.3333
SE: 0.1491
loglik at 0.2 : -11.047  at MLE: -10.493
```

Problem 3.3.2 (method of moments versus MLE for Gamma) Service time at a bank counter is Gamma distributed with shape 3 and scale 50 seconds (mean 150). From a sample of 300, estimate shape and scale by MoM and MLE. Repeat for 1,000 samples and compare the spread (variance) of the two estimators.

Formula	For Gamma(k, θ): mean = kθ, variance = kθ². MoM: $\hat{\theta} = s^2 / \bar{x}$ and $\hat{k} = \bar{x}^2 / s^2$.
Plug in	Example: if $\bar{x} = 150$ and $s^2 = 7{,}500$ then $\hat{\theta} = 50$ and $\hat{k} = 22{,}500 / 7{,}500 = 3$.
Compute	The MLE has no closed form and is found numerically by `stats.gamma.fit(data, floc=0)`.
Answer	Both are close to the truth, but the MLE has a smaller spread across repeated samples, which is its advantage (efficiency).
Check	Both estimators should average near the true shape 3 across 1,000 samples. Compare printed averages.
Why it matters	Use MoM for a quick start (and as the starting point for an optimiser); use MLE for final results.

```
rng = np.random.default_rng(23)
mom_k, mle_k = [], []
for _ in range(1000):
    d = rng.gamma(3, 50, 300)
    mom_k.append(d.mean()**2 / d.var(ddof=1))
    mle_k.append(stats.gamma.fit(d, floc=0)[0])
print("true shape 3.0")
print("MoM : mean %.3f  sd %.3f" % (np.mean(mom_k), np.std(mom_k)))
print("MLE : mean %.3f  sd %.3f" % (np.mean(mle_k), np.std(mle_k)))
```

```
true shape 3.0
MoM : mean 3.035  sd 0.278
MLE : mean 3.033  sd 0.234
```

Problem 3.3.3 (bias of the variance estimator) Why do we divide by n − 1? Draw 200,000 samples of size 5 from Normal(0, 1) (true variance 1) and average the two versions of the sample variance.

Formula	Biased: $\Sigma(x - \bar{x})^2 / n$. Unbiased: $\Sigma(x - \bar{x})^2 / (n - 1)$.
Plug in	n = 5: expected biased value is $(n-1)/n \times \sigma^2 = 0.8$
Compute	Simulate.
Answer	The divide-by-n version averages about 0.80, the divide-by-(n−1) version about 1.00.
Check	0.8 = 4/5, exactly as theory predicts.
Why it matters	The sample mean is fitted from the same data, so deviations from $\bar{x}$ are a little smaller than deviations from the true mean. Dividing by n−1 corrects that. In NumPy, `np.var` uses n by default; `ddof=1` gives n−1. Pandas `.var()` uses n−1 by default.

```
s5 = np.random.default_rng(24).standard_normal((200_000, 5))
print("divide by n  :", round(s5.var(axis=1, ddof=0).mean(), 4))
print("divide by n-1:", round(s5.var(axis=1, ddof=1).mean(), 4))
```

```
divide by n  : 0.8006
divide by n-1: 1.0008
```

The picture

```
log-likelihood
   |            ___
   |         __/   \__        <- peak at the MLE (lambda = 0.333)
   |      __/         \___
   |   __/               \___
   +---------------------------- lambda
        0.2   0.333     0.6
A sharp peak = small SE (much data). A flat peak = big SE (little data).
```

Connection to the real job

Every model you train by minimising a loss is doing MLE in disguise: squared error is the MLE for normal noise; log-loss (cross-entropy) is the MLE for Bernoulli labels. Knowing this lets you pick a loss that matches the data.

Applications

- **Data Science:** fitting distributions to delivery times, claim size or time-to-event.
- **Machine Learning:** logistic regression, Poisson regression, neural network losses.
- **Reliability engineering:** failure-rate estimation from few failures.
- **Finance:** volatility estimation.

COMMON MISTAKE

Reporting a rate estimated from very few events without its uncertainty. "MTBF is 3 hours" from 5 failures could easily be 1.5 or 8 hours.

Check yourself

1. MLE for Poisson rate from counts 3, 5, 4? Answer: The mean, 4.
2. Why is the divide-by-n variance biased low? Answer: It measures deviations from $\bar{x}$, which is fitted to the same data.
3. Name one advantage of MLE over MoM. Answer: It has a lower variance for large samples (efficiency).

3.4 Confidence Intervals

INTUITION

A single number like "480 minutes" sounds precise but is a guess. A **confidence interval (CI)** gives a range, like "480 ± 41 minutes". The meaning of "95 percent" is subtle and often misunderstood. Imagine an archer who hits within a 1-metre circle 95 times out of 100. Before shooting you can say "my arrow will land in the circle with 95 percent chance". The CI procedure is that archer: if you repeat the whole study many times, 95 percent of the intervals you build will contain the true value. For your *one* interval, the truth is either in it or not; you just do not know which.

Words you need

Word	Plain meaning	Example
Confidence	How often the method captures the truth in	95 percent

level	repeated use	
Margin of error	Half the width of the interval	±41 minutes
Coverage	The actual fraction of intervals that contain the truth	Should be about 95 percent
Wald interval	$\hat{p} \pm z\sqrt{\hat{p}(1-\hat{p})/n}$, simple but poor for small n or rare events	
Wilson interval	A better interval for proportions	

The rules

- **Mean (unknown SD)**: $\bar{x} \pm t^* \cdot s/\sqrt{n}$, where t* is the t quantile with n−1 df (Chapter 2). For n > 100, t* is almost 1.96.
- **Proportion**: Wald $\hat{p} \pm 1.96\sqrt{\hat{p}(1-\hat{p})/n}$; Wilson and exact (Clopper-Pearson) intervals are safer for small n or p near 0 or 1.
- **Rule of three**: if you see 0 failures in n trials, the 95 percent upper limit on the failure rate is about 3/n.
- **Width**: halving the width needs four times the data.
- A wide interval is information: it says "we do not know yet".

Item	Example value	Where it appears in the job
CI for mean delivery time	480 ± 41 min	Service reports
CI for a conversion rate	4.5% (2.8% to 7.0%)	A/B test summary
Rule of three	0 errors in 200 runs → < 1.5%	Release sign-off with zero failures

Problem 3.4.1 A delivery audit has n = 25 parcels with mean 480 minutes and sample SD 100 minutes. Build the 95 percent CI for the true mean with the t distribution, and compare with the (wrong for small n) z interval.

Formula	$\bar{x} \pm t^* \times s / \sqrt{n}$, with $t^* = t(24\text{ df}, 97.5\%) = 2.064$
Plug in	SE = 100 / √25 = 20; margin = 2.064 × 20
Compute	margin = 41.3. The interval is 480 − 41.3 = 438.7 to 480 + 41.3 = 521.3. The z version: 1.96 × 20 = 39.2, giving 440.8 to 519.2.
Answer	We are 95 percent confident that the true mean is between 438.7 and 521.3 minutes. The z interval is about 5 percent too narrow.
Check	The code computes the interval with `stats.t.interval` and gets the same numbers.
Why it matters	"480 minutes" alone hides that the data cannot tell 440 from 520. If the shop promises delivery within 500 minutes on average, this audit is **inconclusive**, not a pass.

```
n, xbar, s = 25, 480, 100
se = s / np.sqrt(n)
lo, hi = stats.t.interval(0.95, n - 1, loc=xbar, scale=se)
print("t interval: (%.1f, %.1f)  t*=%.3f" % (lo, hi, stats.t.ppf(0.975, n
- 1)))
print("z interval: (%.1f, %.1f)" % (xbar - 1.96 * se, xbar + 1.96 * se))
```

```
t interval: (438.7, 521.3)  t*=2.064
z interval: (440.8, 519.2)
```

Problem 3.4.2 (proportions: Wald, Wilson and the rule of three) (a) 18 of 400 parcels were delivered damaged. Give the Wald and Wilson 95 percent intervals. (b) In another audit 0 of 200 parcels were damaged. What can you say about the true damage rate?

Formula	Wald: $\hat{p} \pm 1.96 \sqrt{\hat{p}(1-\hat{p})/n}$. Rule of three: upper limit $\approx 3 / n$.
Plug in	(a) $\hat{p} = 18/400 = 0.045$, SE $= \sqrt{0.045 \times 0.955 / 400} = 0.01036$. (b) 3/200.
Compute	(a) Wald margin $= 1.96 \times 0.01036 = 0.0203$, interval 0.0247 to 0.0653. Wilson is slightly shifted (see output). (b) Wald gives (0, 0), which is absurd. Rule of three gives an upper limit of 0.015; the exact interval gives about 0.0183.
Answer	(a) The damage rate is likely between 2.5 and 6.5 percent (Wald); the better Wilson interval says 2.9 to 7.0 percent. (b) With zero damaged parcels in 200, the true damage rate could still be as high as about 1.5 to 1.8 percent. "No damage seen" does not mean "no damage".
Check	The exact Clopper-Pearson upper bound for 0 of 200 is $1 - 0.025^{(1/200)} = 0.0183$, consistent with 3/200 = 0.015 as a rough approximation.
Why it matters	Quality teams often say "zero defects in the check, so it is safe". The interval tells you how safe: with 200 items checked you can only claim the defect rate is below about 1.8 percent.

```
r = stats.binomtest(18, 400)
print("Wald  :", np.round(0.045 + np.array([-1, 1]) * 1.96 * np.sqrt(0.045
* 0.955 / 400), 4))
print("Wilson:", np.round([r.proportion_ci(method="wilson").low,
r.proportion_ci(method="wilson").high], 4))
print("Exact :", np.round([r.proportion_ci(method="exact").low,
r.proportion_ci(method="exact").high], 4))
z = stats.binomtest(0, 200)
print("0 of 200 exact upper:", round(z.proportion_ci(method="exact").high,
4), " rule of three:", 3 / 200)
```

```
Wald  : [0.0247 0.0653]
Wilson: [0.0287 0.07  ]
Exact : [0.0269 0.0702]
0 of 200 exact upper: 0.0183  rule of three: 0.015
```

Problem 3.4.3 (what does 95 percent really mean?) Draw 10,000 samples of size 15 from the skewed delivery-time population (true mean 227.0). Build a 95 percent t interval from each. What fraction contain the true mean? Repeat with n = 100.

Formula	coverage = fraction of intervals containing μ
Plug in	n = 15 and n = 100, 10,000 repetitions each
Compute	See output.
Answer	With n = 15 on skewed data the coverage is a bit below 95 percent (92.9 percent); with n = 100 it is 94.6 percent, very close to 95.
Check	If coverage were 95 percent then about 500 of 10,000 intervals should miss. The code counts misses.
Why it matters	The CI promise holds only if its assumptions hold. Skewed data with a small sample slightly breaks it. The bootstrap (next section) is one remedy.

```
rng = np.random.default_rng(25)
def coverage(n, reps=10_000):
    d = rng.lognormal(mu_ln, sg_ln, (reps, n))
    m, s = d.mean(1), d.std(1, ddof=1)
    tcrit = stats.t.ppf(0.975, n - 1)
    lo, hi = m - tcrit * s / np.sqrt(n), m + tcrit * s / np.sqrt(n)
    return ((lo <= pop_mean) & (pop_mean <= hi)).mean()
print("coverage n=15 :", coverage(15))
print("coverage n=100:", coverage(100))
```

```
coverage n=15 : 0.9286
coverage n=100: 0.9458
```

The picture

```
# plot
d = rng.normal(480, 100, (40, 25))
m, s = d.mean(1), d.std(1, ddof=1); mg = stats.t.ppf(0.975, 24) * s / 5
fig, ax = plt.subplots(figsize=(6, 4.2))
for i in range(40):
    miss = not (m[i] - mg[i] <= 480 <= m[i] + mg[i])
    ax.plot([m[i] - mg[i], m[i] + mg[i]], [i, i], color="#d62728" if miss
else "#1f77b4", lw=2)
ax.axvline(480, color="k", ls="--"); ax.set_xlabel("mean delivery time
(min)"); ax.set_ylabel("repeated experiment #")
ax.set_title("40 repeated 95% intervals (red = missed the truth)")
plt.tight_layout(); plt.savefig(f"{IMG}/ch03_ci_coverage.png", dpi=120);
plt.close()
```

Forty repeated 95 percent confidence intervals: most contain the true mean, the red ones miss it

How to read it: each horizontal line is the interval from one repeated experiment (the y-axis just numbers the experiments). The dashed vertical line is the true mean. About 1 or 2 out of 40 intervals miss it (red). You never see this picture in real life, because you only run one experiment. The picture is what the "95 percent" promise means.

Connection to the real job

Every dashboard number should have an interval or at least a sample size. In A/B testing, an interval that includes zero effect means "we cannot tell". In capacity testing, the *upper* end of the interval is what you plan for.

Applications

- **Data Analytics:** margin of error for KPIs, polls, conversion rates.
- **Data Science:** reporting model accuracy with an interval (CI on a test-set accuracy).
- **Operations:** declaring whether a depot meets its promised delivery time with confidence.
- **Reliability:** upper bounds on failure rates after zero-failure tests.

COMMON MISTAKE

Saying "there is a 95 percent chance that the true mean lies in *this* interval". The true mean is fixed; the interval is random. The correct statement is about the procedure: "95 percent of intervals built this way contain the true mean". (A Bayesian credible interval, Chapter 9, does allow the first statement.)

Check yourself

1. n = 100, s = 20, $\bar{x}$ = 50. Rough 95 percent CI? Answer: 50 ± 1.98 × 2 ≈ 50 ± 4, so (46, 54).
2. Why should you not use Wald for 0 failures out of 200? Answer: It gives a zero-width interval; use Wilson, exact, or the rule of three.
3. To halve the margin of error, how much more data? Answer: Four times.

3.5 The Bootstrap

INTUITION

You want an error bar for the 95th percentile of delivery time, but no neat formula exists. The bootstrap says: your sample is your best picture of the population, so *treat the sample as the population*. Draw many new samples *from your sample*, with replacement (like pulling numbered balls from a bag and putting each back), compute your statistic each time, and look at how much it varies. You are "pulling yourself up by your own bootstraps". It works for medians, percentiles, ratios, correlations, and almost anything else.

Words you need

Word	Plain meaning	Example
Resample	A new sample of the same size, drawn from the data with replacement	500 values drawn from 500
Bootstrap distribution	The statistic computed on each resample	10,000 medians
Percentile interval	The 2.5th and 97.5th percentiles of the bootstrap distribution	A 95 percent CI

The recipe

1. Take your sample of n values.
2. Repeat B times (say 10,000): draw n values *with replacement*; compute the statistic.
3. The standard deviation of the B results is the bootstrap SE. Their 2.5th and 97.5th percentiles give a 95 percent **percentile interval**.

The bootstrap works best for smooth statistics (mean, median, p90). It struggles for extremes (the maximum, the 99.99th percentile), for very small samples, and for dependent data (time series need a *block* bootstrap).

Item	Example value	Where it appears in the job
CI for p95 delivery time	438 to 521 min	Reporting the slow tail with honesty
CI for the difference of medians	−12 to 35 min	Comparing two depots
CI for a correlation or AUC	0.71 to 0.79	Model reporting

Problem 3.5.1 From 500 measured delivery times in minutes (log-normal, true median 200 min), compute the bootstrap 95 percent CI for the mean, the median and p95. Compare the bootstrap SE of the mean with s/√n.

Formula	bootstrap SE = SD of the B resampled statistics; percentile CI = (2.5%, 97.5%) of them
Plug in	n = 500, B = 10,000
Compute	Vectorised: draw an index matrix of size 10,000 × 500.
Answer	See the output. The bootstrap SE of the mean agrees with s/√n, and the p95 interval is much wider than the median's in relative terms.
Check	The true median is 200 and the true p95 is exp(5.3 + 1.645 × 0.5) = 456.0. Both should fall inside their intervals (they usually do, about 95 percent of the time).
Why it matters	Tail percentiles are estimated from few points, so they are much less precise than the median. A report saying "p95 = 475 min" without a range overclaims.

```
rng = np.random.default_rng(26)
x = rng.lognormal(5.3, 0.5, 500)
B = 10_000
idx = rng.integers(0, len(x), (B, len(x)))
boot = x[idx]
stats_b = {"mean": boot.mean(1), "median": np.median(boot, axis=1), "p95":
np.percentile(boot, 95, axis=1)}
point = {"mean": x.mean(), "median": np.median(x), "p95": np.percentile(x,
95)}
for k, v in stats_b.items():
    lo, hi = np.percentile(v, [2.5, 97.5])
    print(f"{k:6} point={point[k]:7.1f}  boot SE={v.std():6.2f}  95% CI=
({lo:6.1f}, {hi:6.1f})")
print("analytic SE of mean s/sqrt(n):", round(x.std(ddof=1) /
np.sqrt(len(x)), 2))
print("true median 200.0, true p95", round(np.exp(5.3 + 1.645 * 0.5), 1))
```

```
mean   point=  233.9  boot SE=  5.60  95% CI=( 223.2,  245.2)
median point=  208.7  boot SE=  6.32  95% CI=( 196.4,  219.8)
p95    point=  489.1  boot SE= 23.71  95% CI=( 438.4,  521.4)
analytic SE of mean s/sqrt(n): 5.58
true median 200.0, true p95 456.0
```

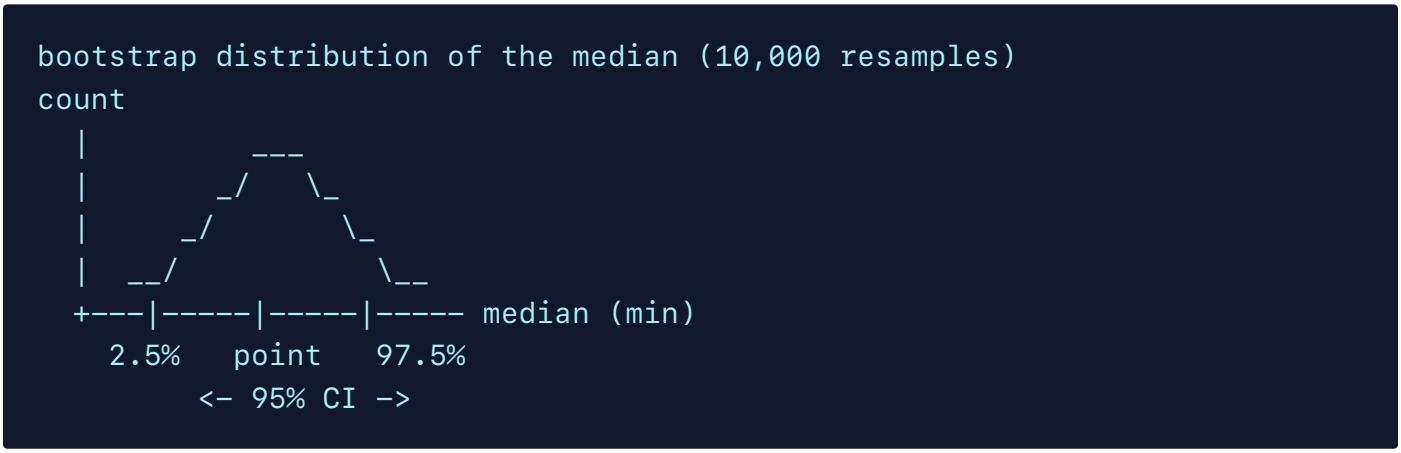
Problem 3.5.2 (comparing two depots with a bootstrap) Depot A delivery times (n = 300) and Depot B delivery times (n = 300) are log-normal with medians 200 and 190 minutes. Estimate the difference of medians and a 95 percent bootstrap CI, then say whether B is really faster.

Formula	statistic = median(B) − median(A); resample each group separately
Plug in	B = 5,000 resamples of each group
Compute	See output.
Answer	The point estimate is a difference of −14 minutes, but the 95 percent interval (−33.8 to +9.0) includes zero, so with 300 parcels per depot we cannot say that B is faster. With 1,200 samples the interval (−22.7 to −1.5) excludes zero, and now we can.
Check	Four times the data (n = 1,200) should halve the width (square-root law). It does: 42.8 to 21.2.
Why it matters	When comparing two depots you must decide between "different" and "not enough data". An interval tells you which.

```
rng = np.random.default_rng(27)
def diff_ci(n):
    a = rng.lognormal(np.log(200), 0.5, n); b = rng.lognormal(np.log(190),
0.5, n)
    ia = rng.integers(0, n, (5000, n)); ib = rng.integers(0, n, (5000, n))
    d = np.median(b[ib], axis=1) - np.median(a[ia], axis=1)
    return np.median(b) - np.median(a), np.percentile(d, [2.5, 97.5])
for n in (300, 1200):
    est, (lo, hi) = diff_ci(n)
    print(f"n={n:<5} diff of medians={est:6.1f}  95% CI=({lo:6.1f},
{hi:6.1f})  width={hi-lo:5.1f}")
```

```
n=300   diff of medians= -14.0  95% CI=( -33.8,    9.0)  width= 42.8
n=1200  diff of medians= -12.9  95% CI=( -22.7,   -1.5)  width= 21.2
```

The picture



Connection to the real job

Bootstrap is the go-to when no formula exists: p95 delivery time, differences in medians, AUC, ratios of two means, and complicated business metrics. It is also the tool behind "confidence band on a model's accuracy" and behind bagging and random forests (each tree sees a bootstrap sample).

Applications

- **Operations:** CI on percentiles, detecting whether one depot really became slower.
- **Data Science:** intervals for AUC, F1, or any custom metric.
- **Machine Learning:** bagging and random forests.
- **Finance:** risk measures such as Value at Risk.

COMMON MISTAKE

Bootstrapping dependent data (a time series of daily delivery times) as if every row were independent. The resamples destroy the time structure and the interval becomes too narrow. Use a block bootstrap, or analyse per-test summaries instead.

Check yourself

1. Why do we resample *with* replacement? Answer: Without it every resample would be identical to the original sample.
2. Name one statistic where the bootstrap fails. Answer: The maximum of a sample (or extreme quantiles like the 99.99th percentile).
3. Bootstrap SE of the mean is close to what formula? Answer: s / √n.

Chapter recap

- A sample can only be trusted if the *way* it was chosen is fair; bias is not cured by size.
- Stratified sampling reduces noise when groups differ; cluster sampling is cheap but noisy when items inside a cluster are alike.
- The standard error of a mean is $\sigma/\sqrt{n}$; quadruple the data to halve the noise.
- The CLT says averages become normal even if the data are skewed; proportions need $n \cdot p \geq 10$.
- Estimators: method of moments matches averages; MLE maximises the likelihood and is efficient for large n.
- Sample variance divides by $n-1$ to remove bias.
- A 95 percent CI describes the procedure, not a single interval; use t for the mean and Wilson or exact for proportions.
- Zero failures in n trials still allows a failure rate up to about 3/n.
- The bootstrap gives an SE and CI for almost any statistic, including p95; it fails for extremes and for dependent data unless adapted.

Formula / pattern	Meaning
`SE = s/√n`	Standard error of a mean
`x̄ ± t*·SE` (`stats.t.interval`)	CI for a mean
`SE(p̂) = √(p̂(1−p̂)/n)`	SE of a proportion
`stats.binomtest(k, n).proportion_ci(method="wilson")`	Proportion CI
`upper ≈ 3/n`	Rule of three
`λ̂ = n/Σx` (exponential)	MLE
`x[rng.integers(0, n, (B, n))]`	Bootstrap resample matrix
`np.percentile(stat, [2.5, 97.5])`	Percentile CI

Practice set

Problem 3.6.1 A sample of 64 values has SD 16. What is the SE of the mean?

Answer: 16 / √64 = 2.

Problem 3.6.2 A proportion is 0.30 from n = 100. Wald 95 percent CI?

Answer: SE = √(0.3 × 0.7 / 100) = 0.0458; margin = 0.0898; interval (0.210, 0.390).

Problem 3.6.3 What is the output? `import numpy as np; print(np.var([2,4,6], ddof=1))`

Answer: Mean 4, squared deviations 4 + 0 + 4 = 8, divided by 2 gives 4.0.

Problem 3.6.4 n = 16, mean 50, SD 8. Give the 95 percent t interval (t* for 15 df is 2.131).

Answer: SE = 8 / 4 = 2; margin = 4.26; interval (45.74, 54.26).

Problem 3.6.5 By what factor must n grow to reduce the margin of error from ±6 to ±2?

Answer: The margin scales as 1/√n, so we need 3 times smaller, which is 9 times more data.

Problem 3.6.6 Poisson counts: 2, 0, 3, 1, 4, 2. What is the MLE of λ and its SE?

Answer: Mean = 12/6 = 2. SE = √(λ̂ / n) = √(2/6) = 0.577.

Problem 3.6.7 Find the bug: "The mean delivery time is 300 min ± 5 min (SD of 5), so 95 percent of parcels are between 290 and 310 min."

Answer: The ±5 is the SE of the mean, not the SD of parcels. With n = 400 the parcel SD would be 5 × 20 = 100 min. Individual parcels range far more widely.

Problem 3.6.8 A survey of 1,000 people who visited the help page says 90 percent are unhappy with the product. Why is this unreliable?

Answer: Sampling bias (self-selection): people visiting a help page are those who have a problem. Size does not repair it.

Problem 3.6.9 (interview) "Explain a 95 percent confidence interval to a manager in two sentences."

Answer: "If we repeated this measurement many times and built an interval each time, about 95 of 100 intervals would contain the true value. For this study the plausible range for the average is 438 to 521 minutes, so we cannot yet say it meets a 500-minute target."

Problem 3.6.10 (interview) "You must report the 99th percentile of delivery time from 2,000 parcels. How do you quantify its uncertainty and why is it hard?"

Answer: Use a bootstrap percentile interval. It is hard because the 99th percentile depends on only about 20 data points in the tail, so it is noisy, and the bootstrap itself is less reliable for such extreme quantiles. Report the interval and consider collecting more data or fitting a tail model.

Prompt pack

✨ **AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI**

```
You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional
moving into data roles, and English is my second language. Teach me
Chapter 3 topic "sampling methods and sampling bias (simple random,
stratified, cluster, survivorship)" with simulations in Python. Show me
with real numbers how a biased sample gives a wrong answer even when it is
large. After each idea ask one check question and wait for my answer. End
with 6 exercises.
```

✨ **AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI**

```
You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional
moving into data roles. Explain the standard error of the mean and the
Central Limit Theorem. Walk me through a NumPy simulation using skewed
delivery-time data and plots, and explain the difference between SD and
SE. Then give me 8 graded exercises WITHOUT solutions and wait for my
answers.
```

✨ **AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI**

```
You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional
moving into data roles. Teach me maximum likelihood estimation and the
method of moments for exponential, Poisson, normal and gamma data. Derive
each MLE step by step with simple algebra, then verify it with
scipy.optimize. Quiz me one question at a time and give feedback after
each answer. Stop after 8 questions.
```

✨ **AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI**

```
You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional
moving into data roles. Review my confidence interval work: [PASTE HERE].
```

Check whether I chose t, Wald, Wilson or exact correctly, check my arithmetic, and check whether I explained the meaning of 95 percent correctly in plain English. Show me any mistakes and a corrected version.

✨ AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI

You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional moving into data roles. Run a mock interview on sampling, standard error, CLT, confidence intervals and the bootstrap, with everyday scenarios (p95 with CI, zero damaged parcels in an audit, comparing two depots). Ask one question at a time, wait for my answer, then give a score out of 10 and a model answer. Ask 8 questions.

CHAPTER 4

HYPOTHESIS TESTING IN DEPTH

Choosing the right test, reading it correctly, and knowing how much data you need.

Your delivery company introduces a "faster sorting process" and the average delivery time drops from 250 minutes to 225 minutes in a trial. Is the fix real, or did you just get a lucky run? A hypothesis test answers that question with a probability instead of a feeling. The Math PDF (Pillar 3.2) showed you the idea of a null hypothesis and a p-value. In this chapter you learn how the machinery works in practice: how to pick between the z-test, t-test, paired test, chi-square, ANOVA and the non-parametric tests; how to check assumptions; and how to calculate, *before* the test, how much data you need. Every test is run on real numbers, and every p-value is checked by simulation, so you will see what a p-value really is.

We use one story throughout: you are comparing delivery depots of an online shop on delivery time, damage rates and the mix of customers.

4.1 The Logic of Testing, Seen Through Simulation

INTUITION

A court assumes the defendant is innocent until the evidence is strong enough to doubt that. A test does the same: it assumes "nothing happened" (the **null hypothesis H_0**: the fix has no effect) and asks, "if nothing happened, how surprising is my data?" The **p-value** is that surprise measure: the probability of seeing a result at least this extreme *if H_0 were true*. A small p-value says the data are hard to explain by luck alone. It does **not** say the fix works with probability 1−p, and it does **not** say the effect is large.

Words you need

Word	Plain meaning	Example
Null hypothesis H_0	The "nothing happening" claim	Mean delivery time is unchanged
Alternative H_1	What you suspect	Mean delivery time changed (two-sided)

		or dropped (one-sided)
Test statistic	A number that measures how far the data are from H_0	$t = (\bar{x} - \mu_0) / SE$
p-value	P(data this extreme or more \	H_0 true)
Significance level α	The p-value cut-off you set before the test	0.05
Type I error	Rejecting a true H_0 (false alarm), probability α	Declaring a fix real when it is not
Type II error	Failing to reject a false H_0 (miss), probability β	Missing a real improvement
Power	1 − β, the chance of detecting a real effect	0.80
One-tailed vs two-tailed	Looking for change in one direction or either	"dropped" vs "changed"

The five-step recipe

1. State H_0 and H_1 and choose α (before looking at data).
2. Choose the test that matches the data type and design.
3. Compute the test statistic and p-value.
4. Compare: $p \leq \alpha$ means "reject H_0", else "not enough evidence".
5. Report the **effect size and its interval** (Chapter 5), not just the p-value.

KEY INSIGHT

If H_0 is true, the p-value is uniformly distributed between 0 and 1. That means "$p < 0.05$" happens by luck 5 percent of the time. This is the exact meaning of the Type I error rate, and it is why running 20 tests on pure noise gives one "discovery" on average (Chapter 5).

Item	Example value	Where it appears in the job
α = 0.05	1 false alarm in 20 null tests	Regression detection in CI

		pipelines
Power = 0.8	80 percent chance to catch a real 20-minute gain	Planning the trial size
One-tailed	"Did delivery time get *worse*?"	Quality gates (only worse matters)

Problem 4.1.1 (what a p-value is) The null is "mean delivery time = 500 minutes". A sample of n = 25 has mean 480 and SD 100. Compute the t statistic and the two-sided p-value by hand, then show by simulation that the p-value is the fraction of null-world samples as extreme as ours.

Formula	$t = (\bar{x} - \mu_0) / (s / \sqrt{n})$; two-sided $p = 2 \times P(T_{24} > \lvert t \rvert)$
Plug in	$t = (480 - 500) / (100 / 5)$
Compute	$t = -20 / 20 = -1.00$. With 24 degrees of freedom, $P(T > 1) = 0.1635$, so $p = 2 \times 0.1635 = 0.327$.
Answer	p = 0.327. If the true mean were really 500 minutes, about 1 sample in 3 would be at least this far from 500 just by chance. So we have no evidence that the mean differs from 500.
Check	The simulation draws 200,000 null-world samples (true mean 500, SD 100, n = 25) and counts how many have $\lvert t \rvert \geq 1$. The share should be near 0.327.
Why it matters	"Not significant" does not prove the promise of 500 minutes is met. It says the data cannot tell 480 from 500.

Predict: will the simulated share be exactly 0.327?

```
import numpy as np
from scipy import stats
n, xbar, s, mu0 = 25, 480, 100, 500
t = (xbar - mu0) / (s / np.sqrt(n))
p = 2 * stats.t.sf(abs(t), n - 1)
print("t = %.3f  p = %.4f" % (t, p))
rng = np.random.default_rng(30)
sim = rng.normal(500, 100, (200_000, n))
tsim = (sim.mean(1) - mu0) / (sim.std(1, ddof=1) / np.sqrt(n))
print("simulated share with |t|>=1:", round((abs(tsim) >= 1).mean(), 4))
```

```
t = -1.000  p = 0.3273
simulated share with |t|>=1: 0.3276
```

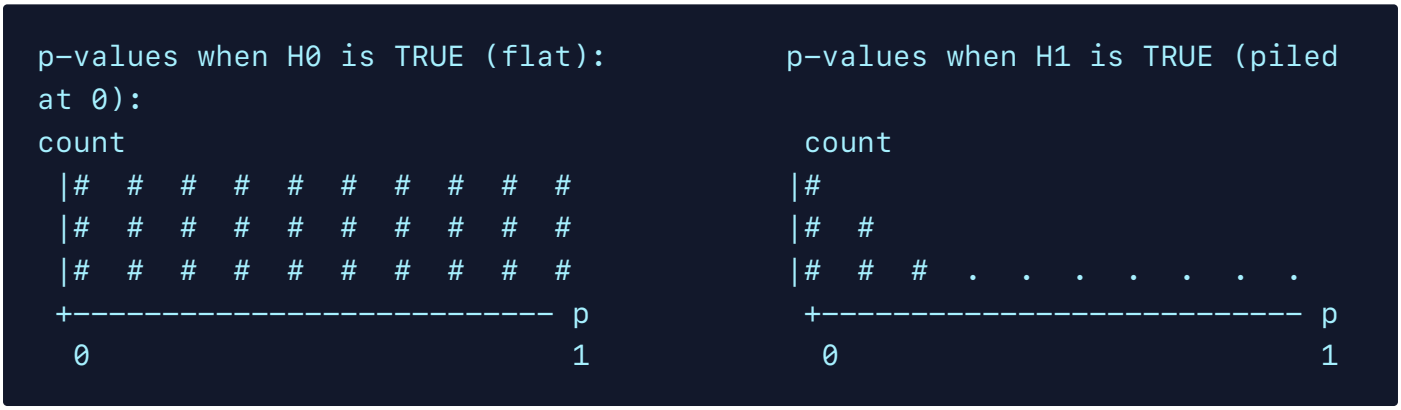
Problem 4.1.2 (p-values under a true null, and the Type I error rate) Run 20,000 experiments in which both depots have the *same* delivery-time distribution (Normal, mean 250, SD 60, n = 40 each). Run a two-sample t-test in each. What share of p-values are below 0.05? What does the histogram of p-values look like?

Formula	Under H_0 the p-value is Uniform(0, 1), so $P(p < \alpha) = \alpha$.
Plug in	$\alpha = 0.05$, 20,000 experiments
Compute	See output: the share below 0.05, below 0.10, and below 0.50.
Answer	About 5 percent of true-null experiments give $p < 0.05$, about 10 percent give $p < 0.10$, and about 50 percent give $p < 0.50$. The p-values are spread evenly.
Check	Uniform means each bin of width 0.1 holds about 10 percent of the values (2,000 of 20,000).
Why it matters	If you test 100 meaningless metrics, expect about 5 "significant" ones. This is the origin of false discoveries.

```
a = rng.normal(250, 60, (20_000, 40)); b = rng.normal(250, 60, (20_000,
40))
pv = stats.ttest_ind(a, b, axis=1).pvalue
print("share p<0.05: %.4f   p<0.10: %.4f   p<0.50: %.4f" % ((pv <
.05).mean(), (pv < .10).mean(), (pv < .5).mean()))
print("counts per 0.1-wide bin:", np.histogram(pv, bins=10, range=(0, 1))
[0])
```

```
share p<0.05: 0.0496   p<0.10: 0.0998   p<0.50: 0.5064
counts per 0.1-wide bin: [1997 2043 2016 2031 2041 1938 1966 2007 2055
1906]
```

The picture



How to read it: each bar is how many experiments produced a p-value in that bin. A flat histogram means the test has no real effect to find. A pile near zero means a real effect was found often (high power).

Connection to the real job

Routine quality checks are hypothesis tests: "is this month's delivery slower than last month's?" A threshold p = 0.05 means 1 false alarm in 20 perfectly normal months, which is a real cost when managers must investigate each alarm. This is why teams use smaller α, repeated checks, or effect-size thresholds.

Applications

- **Data Analytics:** A/B tests on conversion and revenue.
- **Operations:** quality gates, pilot-versus-rollout comparison.
- **Data Science:** feature relevance tests, model comparison.
- **Healthcare / pharma:** clinical trials (pre-registered hypotheses).

COMMON MISTAKE

Reading p = 0.03 as "3 percent chance the null is true" or "97 percent chance the fix works". The p-value is calculated *assuming* H_0 is true; it cannot tell you the probability of H_0. (Chapter 9 shows how to compute that probability with Bayes.)

Check yourself

1. If H_0 is true and α = 0.05, how often do you reject? Answer: 5 percent of the time.
2. Does "p > 0.05" prove H_0 is true? Answer: No, it only says the data are not strong enough evidence against H_0.
3. What is power? Answer: The probability of rejecting H_0 when a real effect exists.

4.2 z-Tests, t-Tests (One-sample, Two-sample, Paired) and the F-test

INTUITION

A t-test asks: "is the gap between two averages big compared with the noise in those averages?" The gap divided by its standard error is the t statistic. A gap of 2 standard errors or more is rarely luck. Think of comparing two runners over several races: one-sample (against a standard time), two-sample (runner A against runner B on different days), paired (the same runner before and after new shoes). The paired design is much more powerful, because the day-to-day variation cancels.

Words you need

Word	Plain meaning	Example
z-test	Test using the normal distribution; needs known SD or very large n	Proportions with large n
One-sample t	Compare one mean to a fixed value	Mean delivery time vs a 500-minute promise
Two-sample (independent) t	Compare means of two separate groups	Depot A vs Depot B
Welch's t-test	Two-sample t that does not assume equal variances (the safe default)	
Paired t	Test on within-pair differences	Same routes before and after a change
Levene / F test	Tests whether two groups have equal variances	

The formulas

- **One-sample**: $t = (\bar{x} - \mu_0) / (s/\sqrt{n})$, df = n − 1.
- **Welch two-sample**: $t = (\bar{x}_1 - \bar{x}_2) / \sqrt{(s_1^2/n_1 + s_2^2/n_2)}$; df from the Welch-

Satterthwaite formula (computed by software).

- **Paired**: compute d_i = after − before for each pair; then do a one-sample t-test on d against 0.
- **Two-proportion z**: $z = (\hat{p}_1 - \hat{p}_2) / \sqrt{\hat{p}(1-\hat{p})(1/n_1 + 1/n_2)}$ with pooled $\hat{p}$.
- **F-test for variances**: $F = s_1^2 / s_2^2$ with (n_1-1, n_2-1) df. It is very sensitive to non-normality, so prefer **Levene's test** in practice.
- Assumptions: independent observations; roughly normal means (CLT helps when n ≥ 30 or so); for Welch, no equal-variance assumption.

Item	Example value	Where it appears in the job
Welch t	t = 2.07, p = 0.04	Depot A vs Depot B average delivery time
Paired t	mean difference −18 min, p < 0.001	Same 12 routes before/after a change
Two-proportion z	5.0% vs 6.2% conversion	A/B test

Problem 4.2.1 (Welch two-sample t) Depot A: n = 40 parcel batches, mean 250 min, SD 60. Depot B: n = 45, mean 225 min, SD 50. Test whether the means differ.

Formula	$t = (\bar{x}_1 - \bar{x}_2) / \sqrt{(s_1^2/n_1 + s_2^2/n_2)}$
Plug in	SE = $\sqrt{(60^2/40 + 50^2/45)} = \sqrt{(90 + 55.56)}$
Compute	SE = $\sqrt{145.56}$ = 12.07. t = 25 / 12.07 = 2.072. Welch df is about 77. The p-value is about 0.04.
Answer	t = 2.07, p ≈ 0.041. At α = 0.05 we reject H_0: Depot B's mean is lower, by 25 minutes with a 95 percent interval of roughly 1 to 49 minutes.
Check	|t| just above 2 with ~77 df gives p ≈ 0.04, consistent with the rule of thumb "|t| > 2 means p < 0.05".
Why it matters	The interval (1 to 49 minutes) tells the full story: B is faster, but the data are consistent with an almost useless 1-minute gain or a large 49-minute gain.

```
res = stats.ttest_ind_from_stats(250, 60, 40, 225, 50, 45,
equal_var=False)
se = np.sqrt(60**2 / 40 + 50**2 / 45)
dfw = (60**2/40 + 50**2/45)**2 / ((60**2/40)**2/39 + (50**2/45)**2/44)
ci = 25 + np.array([-1, 1]) * stats.t.ppf(0.975, dfw) * se
print("t = %.3f  p = %.4f  Welch df = %.1f  SE = %.2f" % (res.statistic,
res.pvalue, dfw, se))
print("95%% CI for the difference: (%.1f, %.1f)" % tuple(ci))
```

```
t = 2.072  p = 0.0416  Welch df = 76.3  SE = 12.06
95% CI for the difference: (1.0, 49.0)
```

Problem 4.2.2 (paired versus unpaired) 12 delivery routes are timed before and after a new dispatch rule. The routes differ a lot from each other (base times 100 to 900 minutes) but the rule gives each a similar saving (about 20 minutes, noise SD 10). Compare the paired test with the wrong unpaired test on the same data.

Formula	Paired: $t = \bar{d} / (s_d / \sqrt{n})$, $df = n - 1$
Plug in	Differences d_i = after − before for each route.
Compute	The code generates the data and runs both tests.
Answer	The paired test finds a clearly significant drop: mean difference −19.1 min, $t = -5.86$, $p = 0.0001$. The unpaired test, which treats the routes as unrelated, does not see it at all ($p = 0.87$), because route-to-route variation (SD ~250 min) swamps the 20-minute gain.
Check	The SE of the paired difference is $s_d/\sqrt{12} = 11.3/3.46 = 3.3$ min, while the unpaired SE is about 100 min (route SD of about 250 min): roughly 30 times larger.
Why it matters	Whenever the same units are measured twice, use a paired design and a paired test. It is one of the cheapest ways to gain power.

```
rng = np.random.default_rng(31)
base = rng.uniform(100, 900, 12)
before = base + rng.normal(0, 10, 12)
after = base - 20 + rng.normal(0, 10, 12)
d = after - before
print("mean diff %.1f  sd of diff %.1f" % (d.mean(), d.std(ddof=1)))
print("paired   : t=%.2f p=%.2e" % tuple(stats.ttest_rel(after, before)))
print("unpaired : t=%.2f p=%.3f" % tuple(stats.ttest_ind(after, before,
equal_var=False)))
```

```
mean diff -19.1  sd of diff 11.3
paired   : t=-5.86 p=1.09e-04
unpaired : t=-0.16 p=0.873
```

Problem 4.2.3 (two proportions and the F/Levene test) Variant A: 500 of 10,000 visitors convert (5.0%). Variant B: 600 of 10,000 convert (6.0%). Test the difference with the z-test. Then compare delivery-time variances of two groups with the F-test and Levene's test.

Formula	$z = (\hat{p}_1 - \hat{p}_2) / \sqrt{\hat{p}(1-\hat{p})(1/n_1 + 1/n_2)}$, pooled $\hat{p} = (500 + 600) / 20{,}000 = 0.055$
Plug in	$SE = \sqrt{0.055 \times 0.945 \times (2/10{,}000)} = \sqrt{0.0000104} = 0.003224$
Compute	$z = (0.06 - 0.05) / 0.003224 = 3.10$; two-sided $p = 0.0019$.
Answer	$z = 3.10$, $p = 0.0019$. B's conversion is higher by 1.0 percentage point, and this is unlikely to be luck. For the delivery-time groups (log-normal with sigma 0.5 and 0.7) both the F-test ($p = 1.7e\text{-}7$) and Levene's test ($p = 0.00034$) say the variances differ; with skewed data trust Levene, because the F-test is overly sensitive to non-normality.
Check	The chi-square test on the same 2×2 table gives $\chi^2 = z^2 = 9.6$ and the same p.
Why it matters	At 5 percent base rate, a 20 percent relative lift needs about 10,000 visitors per arm to be detected. That is typical A/B planning.

```
x1, n1, x2, n2 = 500, 10_000, 600, 10_000
pp = (x1 + x2) / (n1 + n2)
z = (x2/n2 - x1/n1) / np.sqrt(pp * (1 - pp) * (1/n1 + 1/n2))
print("z = %.3f  p = %.4f  z^2 = %.2f" % (z, 2 * stats.norm.sf(z), z**2))
chi = stats.chi2_contingency([[x1, n1 - x1], [x2, n2 - x2]],
correction=False)
print("chi-square = %.2f  p = %.4f" % (chi[0], chi[1]))
rng = np.random.default_rng(32)
g1 = rng.lognormal(5.3, 0.5, 200); g2 = rng.lognormal(5.3, 0.7, 200)
F = g1.var(ddof=1) / g2.var(ddof=1); pF = 2 * min(stats.f.cdf(F, 199,
199), stats.f.sf(F, 199, 199))
print("F test: F=%.3f p=%.2e   Levene: stat=%.2f p=%.2e" % ((F, pF) +
tuple(stats.levene(g1, g2))))
```

```
z = 3.102  p = 0.0019  z^2 = 9.62
chi-square = 9.62  p = 0.0019
F test: F=0.472 p=1.66e-07   Levene: stat=13.05 p=3.42e-04
```

The picture

```
Paired design (lines join the same route):   Unpaired view (just two
clouds):

 min |  o------o   <- all drop by ~20           min | o  o     o        o
o
    |      o------o                                |   o   o     o  o
    |           o------o                           |  o     o   o o
    +------------------                           +--- before ---- after
---
```

The paired picture shows every line sloping down by the same small amount; the unpaired picture hides that signal inside the spread between routes.

Connection to the real job

Choose Welch by default for two independent groups (never assume equal variances), paired for before/after on the same units, and two-proportion z-tests for conversion and error rates. In delivery or retail comparisons a paired design means measuring both versions of a process on the same routes, shops or customers.

Applications

- **Data Analytics:** A/B tests on revenue per visit (Welch) and conversion (z).
- **Operations:** before-and-after comparisons on the same routes or shops.
- **Machine Learning:** paired t-test of two models over the same cross-validation folds.
- **Manufacturing quality:** comparing batch means.

COMMON MISTAKE

Running an unpaired test on paired data (loses power) or a paired test on unrelated groups (nonsense). Another one: using the F-test for equal variances as a gate before the t-test. It is fragile; just use Welch.

Check yourself

1. t = 2.5 with large df: is p below 0.05? Answer: Yes (about 0.012 two-sided).
2. Which test fits "same 20 shops before and after a new layout"? Answer: The paired t-test.
3. Why prefer Welch over the pooled t-test? Answer: It stays valid when the group variances differ.

4.3 Chi-square Tests for Counts

INTUITION

Suppose a supermarket manager says shoppers choose 4 checkout counters equally. After 1,000 shoppers you count how many used each. They will never be exactly 250 each. The chi-square test measures how far the *observed counts* are from the *expected counts*, by adding up (observed − expected)² / expected over all cells. A small total means "looks like luck", a large total means "something is off". The same idea tests whether two category variables are linked (independence).

Words you need

Word	Plain meaning	Example
Goodness-of-fit	Do observed counts match a stated distribution?	Equal use of 4 counters

Contingency table	Counts split by two categories	Browser × converted
Expected count	Count we would see if H_0 were true	250 per counter
Independence	Knowing one category tells nothing about the other	Browser does not affect conversion

The formulas

- $\chi^2 = \Sigma\ (O - E)^2\ /\ E$.
- Goodness-of-fit: df = (number of categories − 1) minus the number of parameters estimated.
- Independence in an r × c table: expected count = (row total × column total) / grand total; df = (r − 1)(c − 1).
- Rule of thumb: every expected count should be at least 5. For small 2×2 tables use **Fisher's exact test**.
- Strength of association: **Cramér's V** = $\sqrt{(\chi^2 / (n \cdot \min(r-1, c-1)))}$.

Item	Example value	Where it appears in the job
Goodness-of-fit	280, 240, 260, 220 vs 250 each	Load-balancer fairness, random-number check
Independence	Browser × conversion	Segment analysis
Cramér's V	0.08 = weak	Effect size for categorical association

Problem 4.3.1 (goodness-of-fit by hand) 1,000 shoppers used 4 checkout counters: 280, 240, 260, 220. If shoppers choose freely it should be equal (250 each). Test the fairness.

Formula	$\chi^2 = \Sigma\,(O - E)^2 / E$, df = 4 − 1 = 3
Plug in	$(280-250)^2/250 + (240-250)^2/250 + (260-250)^2/250 + (220-250)^2/250$
Compute	900/250 + 100/250 + 100/250 + 900/250 = 3.6 + 0.4 + 0.4 + 3.6 = 8.0. For $\chi^2(3)$, $P(\chi^2 \geq 8.0) = 0.046$.
Answer	$\chi^2 = 8.0$, p = 0.046. This is just below 0.05, so there is weak evidence that the traffic split is not equal.
Check	The 5 percent critical value for 3 df is 7.815, and 8.0 exceeds it. The code agrees.
Why it matters	A borderline result like this should trigger a larger sample, not a declaration of victory or defeat. With a count of 10,000 shoppers and the same proportions, χ^2 would be 80 and p tiny.

```
obs = np.array([280, 240, 260, 220])
r = stats.chisquare(obs, f_exp=[250] * 4)
print("chi2 = %.2f  p = %.4f  critical(5%%, 3 df) = %.3f" % (r.statistic,
r.pvalue, stats.chi2.ppf(.95, 3)))
r10 = stats.chisquare(obs * 10, f_exp=[2500] * 4)
print("same shares, 10x data: chi2 = %.1f  p = %.2e" % (r10.statistic,
r10.pvalue))
```

```
chi2 = 8.00  p = 0.0460  critical(5%, 3 df) = 7.815
same shares, 10x data: chi2 = 80.0  p = 3.07e-17
```

Problem 4.3.2 (independence in a contingency table) Conversion by browser: Chrome 300 converted and 2,700 did not; Safari 120 and 1,380; Firefox 60 and 940. Are browser and conversion independent? Report Cramér's V.

Formula	E = (row total × column total) / grand total; $\chi^2 = \Sigma(O - E)^2/E$; df = (3−1)(2−1) = 2
Plug in	Row totals 3,000; 1,500; 1,000. Column totals 480 converted; 5,020 not. Grand total 5,500.
Compute	E for Chrome-converted = 3,000 × 480 / 5,500 = 261.8. The code prints all cells, χ^2 and p.
Answer	χ^2 = 16.43 with 2 df and p = 0.0003, so conversion differs between browsers (Chrome 10.0%, Safari 8.0%, Firefox 6.0%). But Cramér's V is only 0.055: the link is statistically clear but weak in size.
Check	All expected counts are above 5, so the test is valid. Observed and expected totals agree: both sum to 5,500.
Why it matters	With large n, tiny effects become "significant". Always add an effect size.

```
tab = np.array([[300, 2700], [120, 1380], [60, 940]])
chi2, p, dof, exp = stats.chi2_contingency(tab)
V = np.sqrt(chi2 / (tab.sum() * min(tab.shape[0] - 1, tab.shape[1] - 1)))
print("expected counts:\n", np.round(exp, 1))
print("chi2 = %.2f  dof = %d  p = %.4f  Cramer's V = %.3f" % (chi2, dof,
p, V))
print("conversion rates:", np.round(tab[:, 0] / tab.sum(1), 3))
print("Fisher exact p on tiny table [[3,1],[1,3]]: %.4f" %
stats.fisher_exact([[3, 1], [1, 3]])[1])
```

```
expected counts:
 [[ 261.8 2738.2]
 [ 130.9 1369.1]
 [  87.3  912.7]]
chi2 = 16.43  dof = 2  p = 0.0003  Cramer's V = 0.055
conversion rates: [0.1  0.08 0.06]
Fisher exact p on tiny table [[3,1],[1,3]]: 0.4857
```

The picture

```
Observed          Expected if independent
Chrome  300|2700   261.8|2738.2
Safari  120|1380   130.9|1369.1
Firefox  60| 940    87.3| 912.7
```

Compare cell by cell. Firefox has fewer conversions than expected (60 against 87.3), and Chrome has more (300 against 261.8). Those two cells contribute most to χ^2.

Connection to the real job

Chi-square is the fast screening test for categorical columns: "does device type matter for churn?" It also checks data quality (does a hash-based split give equal buckets?) and is the basis for chi-square feature selection in scikit-learn.

Applications

- **Data Analytics:** segment analysis, survey cross-tabs.
- **Data Engineering:** testing that a partitioning key distributes evenly.
- **Machine Learning:** `SelectKBest(chi2)` for categorical features; checking class balance in splits.
- **Security:** testing random-number generators.

COMMON MISTAKE

Running chi-square on percentages instead of counts. The test needs raw counts, because the sample size is part of the evidence.

Check yourself

1. What is the df for a 3×4 table? Answer: $(3-1)(4-1) = 6$.
2. When do you prefer Fisher's exact test? Answer: Small counts, especially a 2×2 table with an expected count below 5.
3. Is a significant chi-square always a strong association? Answer: No. With large n, weak associations are significant; check Cramér's V.

4.4 ANOVA and Post-hoc Tests

INTUITION

You have three depots and want to know if *any* differs in mean delivery time. You could run three t-tests (A vs B, A vs C, B vs C), but each carries a 5 percent false-alarm risk, so together the risk is nearly 14 percent. ANOVA (analysis of variance) asks one question first: "is the variation *between* the group means larger than the variation we would expect from random noise *within* groups?" Their ratio is the F statistic. If F is large, at least one group is different. Then a **post-hoc test** (such as Tukey's HSD) tells you which pairs.

Words you need

Word	Plain meaning	Example
Factor	A category you vary	Depot
Level	A value of a factor	Depot A, B, C
SS between (SSB)	Spread of group means around the grand mean, weighted by group size	
SS within (SSW)	Spread of values around their own group mean	
Mean square (MS)	SS divided by its df	
Post-hoc test	Pairwise comparisons after a significant ANOVA	Tukey HSD
Interaction	The effect of one factor depends on the other	Depot effect is larger for vans than for bikes

The formulas

- One-way: $F = MSB / MSW$, with $MSB = SSB / (k - 1)$ and $MSW = SSW / (N - k)$. k groups, N total observations.
- $SSB = \Sigma\, n_j\, (\bar{x}_j - \bar{x})^2$, $SSW = \Sigma\, \Sigma\, (x_{ij} - \bar{x}_j)^2$.

- **Eta-squared** η^2 = SSB / SST is the share of variance explained (an effect size).
- **Two-way ANOVA** splits the variation into factor A, factor B, interaction A×B and error.
- Assumptions: independent observations, roughly normal residuals, equal variances (check with Levene). If violated, use Kruskal-Wallis (Section 4.5).
- **Tukey HSD** compares all pairs and controls the overall error rate.

Item	Example value	Where it appears in the job
One-way ANOVA	3 depots, F = 9.8	Compare many variants at once
Two-way ANOVA	Vehicle × depot	Does the depot effect depend on the vehicle?
Tukey HSD	A-C differ, A-B do not	Find which pairs differ

Problem 4.4.1 (one-way ANOVA by hand, tiny data) Three depots, 4 parcels each (delivery minutes): A = 10, 12, 11, 13; B = 14, 15, 13, 16; C = 20, 19, 21, 20. Compute F by hand.

Formula	F = [SSB / (k−1)] / [SSW / (N−k)]
Plug in	Group means: A = 11.5, B = 14.5, C = 20. Grand mean = (46 + 58 + 80) / 12 = 15.333.
Compute	SSB = $4(11.5 - 15.333)^2 + 4(14.5 - 15.333)^2 + 4(20 - 15.333)^2$ = 4(14.69) + 4(0.694) + 4(21.78) = 58.78 + 2.78 + 87.11 = 148.67. SSW: A: 2.25+0.25+0.25+2.25 = 5; B: 0.25+0.25+2.25+2.25 = 5; C: 0+1+1+0 = 2; total 12. F = (148.67 / 2) / (12 / 9) = 74.33 / 1.333 = 55.75.
Answer	F = 55.75 with (2, 9) degrees of freedom, p = 0.0000085: the three depots do not all have the same mean. η^2 = 148.67 / 160.67 = 0.925, so the depot explains 92.5 percent of the variance.
Check	SST = SSB + SSW must hold: 148.67 + 12 = 160.67. The code confirms.
Why it matters	Computing it once by hand shows that F is just "between-group spread over within-group spread".

```
A = [10, 12, 11, 13]; B = [14, 15, 13, 16]; C = [20, 19, 21, 20]
allv = np.concatenate([A, B, C]); gm = allv.mean()
ssb = sum(len(g) * (np.mean(g) - gm) ** 2 for g in (A, B, C))
ssw = sum(((np.array(g) - np.mean(g)) ** 2).sum() for g in (A, B, C))
F = (ssb / 2) / (ssw / 9)
print("SSB=%.2f SSW=%.2f SST=%.2f  F=%.2f  eta2=%.3f" % (ssb, ssw, ((allv
- gm) ** 2).sum(), F, ssb / (ssb + ssw)))
print("scipy f_oneway:", stats.f_oneway(A, B, C))
print("Tukey HSD (group 0 = A, 1 = B, 2 = C):")
print(stats.tukey_hsd(A, B, C))
```

```
SSB=148.67 SSW=12.00 SST=160.67  F=55.75  eta2=0.925
scipy f_oneway: F_onewayResult(statistic=np.float64(55.74999999999986),
pvalue=np.float64(8.504515585506145e-06))
Tukey HSD (group 0 = A, 1 = B, 2 = C):
Pairwise Group Comparisons (95.0% Confidence Interval)
Comparison  Statistic  p-value  Lower CI  Upper CI
 (0 - 1)     -3.000     0.013    -5.280    -0.720
 (0 - 2)     -8.500     0.000   -10.780    -6.220
 (1 - 0)      3.000     0.013     0.720     5.280
 (1 - 2)     -5.500     0.000    -7.780    -3.220
 (2 - 0)      8.500     0.000     6.220    10.780
 (2 - 1)      5.500     0.000     3.220     7.780
```

Problem 4.4.2 (two-way ANOVA with interaction, by hand in NumPy) A balanced experiment: factor Vehicle (Van, Bike) and factor Depot (A, B, C), with 10 parcels per cell. Depot C is much faster for vans but not for bikes. Compute the sums of squares for OS, Build, the interaction and the error, and the F-tests.

Formula	$SS_A = b \cdot n \, \Sigma(\bar{y}_{i\cdot\cdot} - \bar{y})^2$, $SS_B = a \cdot n \, \Sigma(\bar{y}_{\cdot j \cdot} - \bar{y})^2$, $SS_{AB} = n \, \Sigma\Sigma(\bar{y}_{ij\cdot} - \bar{y}_{i\cdot\cdot} - \bar{y}_{\cdot j \cdot} + \bar{y})^2$, $SS_E = \Sigma\Sigma\Sigma(y_{ijk} - \bar{y}_{ij\cdot})^2$. Each $F = MS / MS_E$.
Plug in	$a = 2$ levels of Vehicle, $b = 3$ depots, $n = 10$ per cell, error df $= 2 \times 3 \times (10 - 1) = 54$.
Compute	The function below does all sums. We set cell means Van: 200, 190, 150 and Bike: 210, 205, 200, with SD 12.
Answer	Vehicle, Depot and the Vehicle × Depot interaction are all significant. The significant interaction means "the depot effect is not the same for both vehicle types", so you must not report one overall "depot effect".
Check	The sums of squares must add up to the total: SS_Vehicle + SS_Depot + SS_Inter + SS_Error = SS_Total. The printed check shows the difference of 0.
Why it matters	Interactions are common in everyday data (a new route plan helps vans and not bikes). Looking only at main effects would hide it.

```
rng = np.random.default_rng(33)
means = {"Van": [200, 190, 150], "Bike": [210, 205, 200]}
y = np.array([[rng.normal(m, 12, 10) for m in means[o]] for o in ("Van",
"Bike")])   # shape (2, 3, 10)
a_, b_, n_ = y.shape
gm = y.mean(); mA = y.mean((1, 2)); mB = y.mean((0, 2)); mAB = y.mean(2)
ssA = b_ * n_ * ((mA - gm) ** 2).sum()
ssB = a_ * n_ * ((mB - gm) ** 2).sum()
ssAB = n_ * ((mAB - mA[:, None] - mB[None, :] + gm) ** 2).sum()
ssE = ((y - mAB[:, :, None]) ** 2).sum()
dfE = a_ * b_ * (n_ - 1)
rows = [("Vehicle", ssA, a_ - 1), ("Depot", ssB, b_ - 1), ("Vehicle x
Depot", ssAB, (a_ - 1) * (b_ - 1))]
print(f"{'source':12}{'SS':>10}{'df':>4}{'F':>9}{'p':>12}")
for name, ss, df in rows:
    Fv = (ss / df) / (ssE / dfE)
    print(f"{name:12}{ss:10.1f}{df:4d}{Fv:9.2f}{stats.f.sf(Fv, df,
dfE):12.2e}")
print(f"{'Error':12}{ssE:10.1f}{dfE:4d}")
print("sum of SS minus SS_total:", abs(round(ssA + ssB + ssAB + ssE - ((y
- gm) ** 2).sum(), 9)))
print("cell means:\n", np.round(mAB, 1))
```

```
source              SS  df        F           p
Vehicle        12628.6   1   104.89    2.92e-14
Depot          10740.0   2    44.60    3.66e-12
Vehicle x Depot    6113.2   2    25.39    1.69e-08
Error           6501.3  54
sum of SS minus SS_total: 0.0
cell means:
 [[203.  186.7 147.5]
 [214.4 205.1 204.8]]
```

The picture

```
Delivery time (min)
 210 |  W-----W-----W          Bike: lines almost flat
 190 |  L-----L
 150 |           \
     |            L           Van: drops sharply at Depot C
     +---A-----B-----C--- depot
Lines that are NOT parallel = interaction.
```

How to read it: each line is one vehicle type, plotted over the three depots. If the lines were parallel, the depot effect would be the same for both vehicles. They are not, so there is an interaction.

Connection to the real job

ANOVA is used when you compare more than two configurations (shop layouts, price levels, advert designs) and is the engine behind "which factor matters" experiments (design of experiments, Chapter 12). The F-test inside regression (Chapter 6) is the same mathematics.

Applications

- **Operations:** factor experiments on a process (staffing level × opening hours).
- **Data Science:** comparing several models or feature sets across folds.
- **Marketing analytics:** several email variants.
- **Agriculture and manufacturing:** the original home of ANOVA.

COMMON MISTAKE

Running ANOVA and then reading the individual group differences from the ANOVA itself. A significant F only says "not all means are equal". Use a post-hoc test (Tukey) to find which pairs differ, and do not run many uncorrected t-tests instead.

Check yourself

1. Why not run three t-tests for three groups? Answer: The false-alarm risk grows to about 14 percent ($1 - 0.95^3$).
2. What does F compare? Answer: Between-group variance with within-group variance.
3. What does a significant interaction mean? Answer: The effect of one factor depends on the level of the other factor.

4.5 Non-parametric Tests, Permutation Tests and Normality Tests

INTUITION

The t-test assumes means are roughly normal. With small samples of heavily skewed data (delivery times with a long tail) that can fail. **Non-parametric tests** use ranks (1st, 2nd, 3rd smallest) instead of raw values, so a huge outlier counts as just "the largest", not as 20,000 minutes. The **permutation test** is even simpler and more general: if the two groups really had no difference, then the group labels are arbitrary, so shuffle the labels many times and see how often the shuffled difference is as large as the real one.

Words you need

Word	Plain meaning	Example
Parametric	Assumes a distribution shape (normal)	t-test
Non-parametric	Uses ranks or resampling, fewer assumptions	Mann-Whitney
Mann-Whitney U (Wilcoxon rank-sum)	Do values in one group tend to be larger than in the other? (two independent groups)	

Wilcoxon signed-rank	Paired version	Before/after
Kruskal-Wallis	Rank version of one-way ANOVA	3+ groups
Permutation test	Shuffle labels to build the null distribution	
Shapiro-Wilk	Test of normality (H_0: data are normal)	
Kolmogorov-Smirnov (KS)	Compares an empirical distribution with a reference (or two samples)	

When to use which

Situation	Parametric	Non-parametric
2 independent groups	Welch t	Mann-Whitney U
Paired	Paired t	Wilcoxon signed-rank
3+ groups	One-way ANOVA	Kruskal-Wallis
Any statistic (median, p95)	(no formula)	Permutation test

Trade-off: with truly normal data non-parametric tests lose only a little power (Mann-Whitney is about 95 percent as efficient as t). With heavy tails they can be much *more* powerful.

Problem 4.5.1 (Mann-Whitney and Welch on skewed data) Delivery times (minutes) for two depots (n = 30 each) are log-normal. Depot B's true median is 20 percent lower than A's. Compare the Welch t-test, the Mann-Whitney test and a permutation test on the difference of means. Also run Wilcoxon signed-rank on 15 paired measurements.

Formula	Permutation p-value = (number of shuffles with |difference| ≥ observed) / (number of shuffles)
Plug in	10,000 permutations
Compute	Run the three tests on the same data.
Answer	See the output. The medians are 221 and 137 minutes. Welch gives p = 0.035, Mann-Whitney p = 0.0067 and the permutation test p = 0.025 (manual) or 0.020 (scipy; the two differ a little because shuffles are random). All three point the same way. The rank test is the most sensitive here because it is not distracted by the long tail. The paired data (15 pairs, about 15 percent faster after the change) are clearly significant under both paired tests (Wilcoxon p = 6e-5).
Check	`scipy.stats.permutation_test` and our own manual loop give p-values within about 0.01 of each other (0.020 and 0.025).
Why it matters	If tests disagree strongly, look at the data (histograms) before choosing the result you like. Choosing after seeing p-values is a form of p-hacking (Chapter 5).

```
rng = np.random.default_rng(34)
A = rng.lognormal(np.log(200), 0.6, 30)
B = rng.lognormal(np.log(160), 0.6, 30)
print("medians:", round(np.median(A), 1), round(np.median(B), 1), "
means:", round(A.mean(), 1), round(B.mean(), 1))
print("Welch t        : p = %.4f" % stats.ttest_ind(A, B,
equal_var=False).pvalue)
print("Mann-Whitney U : p = %.4f" % stats.mannwhitneyu(A, B,
alternative="two-sided").pvalue)
obs = A.mean() - B.mean(); pool = np.concatenate([A, B]); cnt = 0
for _ in range(10_000):
    rng.shuffle(pool)
    cnt += abs(pool[:30].mean() - pool[30:].mean()) >= abs(obs)
print("permutation (manual): p = %.4f" % ((cnt + 1) / 10_001))
pt = stats.permutation_test((A, B), lambda x, y: x.mean() - y.mean(),
n_resamples=9999, random_state=1)
print("permutation (scipy)  : p = %.4f" % pt.pvalue)
before = rng.lognormal(np.log(200), 0.5, 15); after = before *
rng.lognormal(np.log(0.85), 0.1, 15)
print("Wilcoxon signed-rank on 15 pairs: p = %.2e   paired t: p = %.2e" %
(stats.wilcoxon(before, after).pvalue, stats.ttest_rel(before,
after).pvalue))
```

```
medians: 221.3 136.5  means: 244.3 172.3
Welch t        : p = 0.0351
Mann–Whitney U : p = 0.0067
permutation (manual): p = 0.0246
permutation (scipy)  : p = 0.0196
Wilcoxon signed-rank on 15 pairs: p = 6.10e-05   paired t: p = 4.45e-06
```

Problem 4.5.2 (Kruskal-Wallis and normality tests) Compare three groups of 25 delivery times each (log-normal) with Kruskal-Wallis and ANOVA. Then test normality with Shapiro-Wilk and KS on raw and on log-transformed data. Finally, see what Shapiro says on 5,000 slightly non-normal values.

Formula	Shapiro-Wilk: H_0 = "data come from a normal distribution"; a small p-value means "not normal".
Plug in	75 log-normal values; then 5,000 values from a t distribution with 10 df (nearly normal).
Compute	Run all tests.
Answer	See the output below the code. Shapiro rejects normality of the raw skewed data ($p = 0.0000077$) but not of their logs ($p = 0.31$). Neither ANOVA ($p = 0.15$) nor Kruskal-Wallis ($p = 0.24$) finds a difference among the three groups of 25, even though the true medians are 180, 200 and 260: $n = 25$ per group is too small for such noisy data (a power problem). On the 5,000 values from a t distribution with 10 df, which look normal to the eye, Shapiro still rejects ($p < 0.0001$): with big n it flags harmless differences. A KS test whose reference curve uses parameters estimated from the same data is too lenient, so prefer Shapiro (or the Lilliefors version of KS) for normality.
Check	log of a log-normal is exactly normal, so the log-transformed data should pass.
Why it matters	With big samples, normality tests flag tiny harmless deviations; with small samples they miss big ones. Look at a Q-Q plot too, and think about whether the *mean's* distribution is normal (CLT), not whether the raw data are.

```
rng = np.random.default_rng(35)
g = [rng.lognormal(np.log(m), 0.6, 25) for m in (180, 200, 260)]
print("ANOVA p = %.4f   Kruskal-Wallis p = %.4f" %
(stats.f_oneway(*g).pvalue, stats.kruskal(*g).pvalue))
allx = np.concatenate(g)
print("Shapiro raw  : W=%.3f p=%.2e" % stats.shapiro(allx))
print("Shapiro log  : W=%.3f p=%.3f" % stats.shapiro(np.log(allx)))
print("KS (params estimated) on log data: p=%.3f" %
stats.kstest((np.log(allx) - np.log(allx).mean()) /
np.log(allx).std(ddof=1), "norm").pvalue)
big = stats.t(10).rvs(5000, random_state=7)
print("Shapiro on 5000 t(10) values (almost normal): p=%.4f" %
stats.shapiro(big).pvalue)
```

```
ANOVA p = 0.1544   Kruskal-Wallis p = 0.2414
Shapiro raw  : W=0.889 p=7.66e-06
Shapiro log  : W=0.981 p=0.309
KS (params estimated) on log data: p=0.764
Shapiro on 5000 t(10) values (almost normal): p=0.0000
```

The picture

```
Ranks, not values:   10  12  14  200  9000   ->   1  2  3  4  5
The 9000-minute outlier is just "rank 5": it cannot drag the result.
```

Connection to the real job

Delivery times, revenue and many business metrics are skewed, so rank tests and permutation tests are everyday tools. The permutation test is also how you can test *any* odd metric, like the difference of p95s, without a formula.

Applications

- **Operations:** Mann-Whitney on delivery-time samples from two depots.
- **Data Analytics:** comparing median revenue per user.
- **Machine Learning:** Wilcoxon test to compare two models across many datasets.
- **Healthcare:** small-sample trials with skewed outcomes.

COMMON MISTAKE

Treating Mann-Whitney as a test of medians. It tests whether one group tends to produce larger values (stochastic dominance). It equals a median test only when the two distributions have the same shape.

Check yourself

1. What replaces the values in rank tests? Answer: Their ranks.
2. Which test is the non-parametric partner of one-way ANOVA? Answer: Kruskal-Wallis.
3. Does a significant Shapiro-Wilk test on 5,000 rows mean you cannot use a t-test? Answer: Not necessarily. With big n the CLT protects the mean and Shapiro flags tiny deviations.

4.6 Power and Sample Size

INTUITION

Power is the chance that your test notices a real effect. Think of a metal detector: a weak detector will miss a small coin. Before the test you decide what "small coin" you care about (the smallest effect that matters, say 20 minutes), how noisy the data are (SD 100 minutes), your false-alarm tolerance ($\alpha = 0.05$) and your wanted detection chance (power = 0.8). Those four numbers fix the sample size. Skipping this step is the most common reason tests are "inconclusive".

Words you need

Word	Plain meaning	Example
Minimum detectable effect (MDE)	The smallest real difference you want to detect	20 minutes
Effect size d	Difference divided by SD (Cohen's d)	20 / 100 = 0.2
Power $1 - \beta$	Probability of detecting the MDE	0.80
Sample size n	Observations per group	392

The formulas

- Two-sample t (equal n per group): $n = 2\,(z_{1-\alpha/2} + z_{1-\beta})^2\,\sigma^2 / \delta^2$ where δ is the true difference and σ the SD. With α = 0.05 and power 0.8: $(1.96 + 0.84)^2 = 7.85$, so $n \approx 15.7 / d^2$ per group.
- Two proportions: $n = (z_{\alpha/2}\sqrt{(2\,\bar{p}\,\bar{q})} + z_{\beta}\sqrt{(p_1q_1 + p_2q_2)})^2 / (p_1 - p_2)^2$.
- Power rises with n, effect size and α, and falls with noise.
- The statsmodels library has `TTestIndPower` and `NormalIndPower`; it is not installed here, so we use the formula and simulation (both are shown, and they agree).

Item	Example value	Where it appears in the job
Delivery time: δ = 20 min, σ = 100 min	n = 392 per group	Planning how many parcels to time
Conversion 5% → 6%	about 8,158 per arm	A/B test duration
Rule of thumb	$n \approx 16 / d^2$ per group	Quick mental check

Problem 4.6.1 (sample size for a delivery-time trial) You want to detect a 20-minute improvement when the SD of a single delivery time is 100 minutes, with α = 0.05 (two-sided) and power 0.80. How many parcels per depot? Verify power by simulation, and show how power changes with n.

Formula	$n = 2\,(z_{1-\alpha/2} + z_{1-\beta})^2\,\sigma^2 / \delta^2$
Plug in	$z_{1-\alpha/2} = 1.960$, $z_{1-\beta} = 0.842$; $\sigma = 100$, $\delta = 20$
Compute	$(1.960 + 0.842)^2 = 7.849$. $n = 2 \times 7.849 \times 10{,}000 / 400 = 392.4$, so 393 per group.
Answer	You need about 393 measurements per depot. With only 100 per depot the power is about 29 percent: you would miss a real 20-minute gain 7 times out of 10.
Check	Simulation: run 5,000 experiments at n = 393 per group and count how often the t-test rejects. It should be near 0.80.
Why it matters	If a stakeholder gives you only 100 samples, you can tell them honestly: "this test will usually not detect a gain of 20 minutes".

```
za, zb = stats.norm.ppf(0.975), stats.norm.ppf(0.80)
n_req = 2 * (za + zb) ** 2 * 100**2 / 20**2
print("required n per group: %.1f  (z_alpha/2=%.3f, z_beta=%.3f)" %
(n_req, za, zb))
rng = np.random.default_rng(36)
def power(n, delta=20, sd=100, reps=5000):
    a = rng.normal(0, sd, (reps, n)); b = rng.normal(delta, sd, (reps, n))
    return (stats.ttest_ind(a, b, axis=1).pvalue < 0.05).mean()
for n in (50, 100, 200, 393, 600):
    print("n=%-4d simulated power = %.3f" % (n, power(n)))
```

```
required n per group: 392.4  (z_alpha/2=1.960, z_beta=0.842)
n=50   simulated power = 0.167
n=100  simulated power = 0.293
n=200  simulated power = 0.504
n=393  simulated power = 0.805
n=600  simulated power = 0.931
```

Problem 4.6.2 (sample size for an A/B conversion test) Baseline conversion is 5 percent. You want to detect a lift to 6 percent with $\alpha = 0.05$ and power 0.8. How many visitors per arm? How does the number change if you want to detect 5.5 percent instead?

Formula	$n = (z_{\alpha/2}\sqrt{(2\,\bar{p}\,\bar{q})} + z_{\beta}\sqrt{(p_1q_1 + p_2q_2)})^2 / (p_1 - p_2)^2$
Plug in	$p_1 = 0.05$, $p_2 = 0.06$, $\bar{p} = 0.055$
Compute	The code evaluates the formula for both lifts.
Answer	About 8,158 visitors per arm for 5 to 6 percent. For 5 to 5.5 percent you need about 31,233 per arm: halving the effect needs about four times as many visitors.
Check	Simulating the test at n = 8,158 gives power 0.816, close to the target 0.80.
Why it matters	At 1,000 visitors a day per arm, the 5→6 percent test needs about 8 days, but the 5→5.5 percent test needs a month. Agree on the MDE before the test.

```
def n_prop(p1, p2, alpha=0.05, power=0.8):
    za, zb = stats.norm.ppf(1 - alpha / 2), stats.norm.ppf(power)
    pb = (p1 + p2) / 2
    return (za * np.sqrt(2 * pb * (1 - pb)) + zb * np.sqrt(p1 * (1 - p1) +
p2 * (1 - p2))) ** 2 / (p1 - p2) ** 2
for p2 in (0.06, 0.055):
    print("5%% -> %.1f%%: n per arm = %.0f" % (p2 * 100, n_prop(0.05,
p2)))
nn = int(np.ceil(n_prop(0.05, 0.06)))
rng = np.random.default_rng(37); rej = 0; reps = 4000
for _ in range(reps):
    x1, x2 = rng.binomial(nn, 0.05), rng.binomial(nn, 0.06)
    pp = (x1 + x2) / (2 * nn)
    z = (x2 - x1) / nn / np.sqrt(pp * (1 - pp) * 2 / nn)
    rej += 2 * stats.norm.sf(abs(z)) < 0.05
print("simulated power at n=%d: %.3f" % (nn, rej / reps))
```

```
5% -> 6.0%: n per arm = 8158
5% -> 5.5%: n per arm = 31233
simulated power at n=8158: 0.816
```

The picture

```
# plot
import matplotlib.pyplot as plt
ns = np.array([20, 50, 100, 200, 300, 393, 500, 700, 1000])
plt.figure(figsize=(6, 3.6))
for d_, c_ in [(10, "#2ca02c"), (20, "#1f77b4"), (30, "#d62728")]:
    plt.plot(ns, [power(int(k), delta=d_, reps=2000) for k in ns],
marker="o", color=c_, label=f"true gain {d_} min")
plt.axhline(0.8, color="gray", ls="--"); plt.xlabel("parcels per depot");
plt.ylabel("power"); plt.legend(); plt.title("Power curves (SD = 100 min,
alpha = 0.05)")
plt.tight_layout(); plt.savefig(f"{IMG}/ch04_power.png", dpi=120);
plt.close()
```

Power versus sample size for true gains of 10, 20 and 30 minutes: larger effects need fewer samples to reach 80 percent power

How to read it: the x-axis is parcels per depot, the y-axis is power (the chance of detecting the real gain). The dashed line is the usual target, 80 percent. A 30-minute gain reaches it near 180 samples, 20 minutes near 390, and 10 minutes needs more than 1,000.

Connection to the real job

In A/B testing, test duration is decided from power analysis before launch. In operations, it tells you how many parcels or days of data are needed before a "no change detected" result means anything.

Applications

- **Data Analytics / Product:** planning experiment length and traffic share.
- **Operations:** deciding how many parcels or days to measure.
- **Machine Learning:** how large a test set must be to tell two models apart.
- **Clinical research:** sample size justification is mandatory.

COMMON MISTAKE

Computing power *after* the test using the observed effect ("post-hoc power"). It is just a restatement of the p-value and gives no new information. Do power analysis before, with the smallest effect that matters.

Check yourself

1. If the SD doubles, what happens to the required n? Answer: It quadruples ($n \propto \sigma^2$).
2. If you want to detect half the effect, what happens to n? Answer: It becomes about four times larger.
3. What are the four ingredients of a sample-size calculation? Answer: α, power, effect size (MDE) and noise (σ or base rate).

Chapter recap

- A p-value is P(data this extreme | H_0); under a true null it is uniform, so 5 percent of null tests "succeed" by luck at α = 0.05.
- Use Welch for two independent means, paired t for before/after on the same units, z or chi-square for proportions.
- Chi-square compares observed and expected counts: goodness-of-fit (df = k − 1) and independence (df = (r−1)(c−1)); add Cramér's V.
- ANOVA's F is between-group variance over within-group variance; follow with Tukey; two-way ANOVA reveals interactions.
- Non-parametric tests (Mann-Whitney, Wilcoxon, Kruskal-Wallis) use ranks; permutation tests work for any statistic.
- Normality tests are too strict on big samples and too weak on small ones; check plots and think about the CLT.
- Power analysis comes before the test: $n = 2(z_{1-\alpha/2} + z_{1-\beta})^2\sigma^2/\delta^2$ per group; halving the MDE quadruples n.
- Never say "no significant difference" means "no difference"; report effect size and interval.

Task	Function
One-sample t	`stats.ttest_1samp(x, mu0)`
Welch t	`stats.ttest_ind(a, b, equal_var=False)`
Paired t	`stats.ttest_rel(a, b)`
Chi-square GOF / independence	`stats.chisquare`, `stats.chi2_contingency`

Fisher exact	`stats.fisher_exact(table)`
ANOVA, Tukey	`stats.f_oneway`, `stats.tukey_hsd`
Rank tests	`stats.mannwhitneyu`, `stats.wilcoxon`, `stats.kruskal`
Permutation	`stats.permutation_test`
Normality, variance	`stats.shapiro`, `stats.kstest`, `stats.levene`
Sample size	`n = 2(zα+zβ)²σ²/δ²`

Practice set

Problem 4.7.1 A test statistic is z = 2.58 (two-sided). Is the p-value below 0.01?

Answer: Yes. The two-sided p for z = 2.58 is 0.0099.

Problem 4.7.2 n = 36, mean 52, SD 12; H_0: μ = 50. Compute t and say whether p < 0.05 (critical t for 35 df is 2.03).

Answer: SE = 12 / 6 = 2; t = 2 / 2 = 1.0. Since 1.0 < 2.03, p > 0.05 (p is about 0.32). Not significant.

Problem 4.7.3 What is the output? `from scipy import stats; print(round(stats.chi2.ppf(0.95, 1), 3))`

Answer: 3.841.

Problem 4.7.4 Three groups, 10 per group; SSB = 60, SSW = 135. Compute F and the df.

Answer: df = (2, 27). MSB = 30, MSW = 135 / 27 = 5. F = 6.0, p ≈ 0.007.

Problem 4.7.5 Expected counts are 200, 300, 500 and observed are 220, 280, 500. Compute χ^2 and df.

Answer: 400/200 + 400/300 + 0 = 2 + 1.333 = 3.333; df = 2; p = 0.189. No evidence of a difference.

Problem 4.7.6 Find the bug: "We compared 5 depots with 10 pairwise t-tests at α = 0.05 each. Two were significant, so those two depots are different."

Answer: Ten uncorrected tests give a family-wise false alarm risk of $1 - 0.95^{10} = 40$ percent. Run ANOVA (or Kruskal-Wallis) first, then Tukey, or use a multiple-testing correction (Chapter 5).

Problem 4.7.7 Required n per group to detect d = 0.5 (medium effect) at α = 0.05, power 0.8?

Answer: n ≈ 15.7 / 0.25 = 63 per group (more exactly 64 for a t-test).

Problem 4.7.8 Delivery-time data are heavily skewed with n = 20 per group. Which test and why?

Answer: Mann-Whitney (or a permutation or bootstrap test), because the CLT has not yet made the means normal and outliers inflate the t-test's SD.

Problem 4.7.9 (interview) "Our A/B test shows p = 0.049 for +0.2 percent revenue. Do we ship?"

Answer: Not on the p-value alone. Ask for the effect size and its confidence interval, whether the metric was chosen before the test, how many other metrics were tested, and whether the effect is large enough to matter commercially. p = 0.049 is a borderline result.

Problem 4.7.10 (interview) "Why do we use the t distribution instead of the normal, and when are they the same?"

Answer: We estimate σ from the sample, which adds uncertainty, so the t distribution has heavier tails. They become practically the same when df is large (about 100 or more).

Prompt pack

✨ **AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI**

```
You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional
moving into data roles, and English is my second language. Teach me
Chapter 4 topic "the logic of hypothesis testing: null, alternative, p-
value, Type I and II errors, one and two-tailed". Use simulations that
show p-values under a true null. Ask me one check question after each idea
and wait. End with 6 exercises and mark my answers.
```

✨ **AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI**

```
You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional
```

moving into data roles. Teach me the z-test, one-sample, Welch two-sample and paired t-tests with depot-comparison examples. For each, give the formula, the assumptions, a hand-worked example, and the scipy call. Then give me 8 graded exercises WITHOUT solutions and wait for my answers.

✨ AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI

You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional moving into data roles. Explain chi-square tests (goodness-of-fit and independence), one-way and two-way ANOVA with interaction, and Tukey post-hoc tests, using checkout-counter and depot examples. Work through one example of each by hand with all steps. Then quiz me one question at a time and stop after 8.

✨ AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI

You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional moving into data roles. Review my analysis: [PASTE HERE]. It should include the choice of test, assumption checks (normality, equal variance, independence), the test result, an effect size and a confidence interval, and a plain-English conclusion. Find the mistakes, explain them simply, and rewrite it correctly.

✨ AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI

You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional moving into data roles. Run a mock interview on hypothesis testing for data roles: p-value meaning, Type I and II errors, choosing a test, non-parametric alternatives, and power and sample size for A/B tests. Ask one question at a time, wait for my answer, then give a score out of 10 and a model answer. Ask 8 questions.

CHAPTER 5

EFFECT SIZES, MULTIPLE TESTING AND HOW DATA FOOLS YOU

A significant result is not necessarily a big result, and the more you look, the more you will "find".

A product manager runs 40 A/B tests this quarter. Three come back "significant at 5 percent" and the team celebrates. A data scientist who knows this chapter asks three questions: how big are the effects, how many tests were run, and how many of those three would we expect by luck alone? (Answer to the last: about 2.) This chapter teaches you to measure the *size* of an effect, to correct for looking many times, and to recognise the ways data tricks honest people: peeking at results, slicing into subgroups, picking winners, and regression to the mean. These skills separate analysts whose findings hold up from those whose findings disappear when repeated. You will build each correction by hand so you understand what it does, then check it against a library.

The running example continues from Chapter 4: delivery-time comparisons between two depots and A/B tests on a web shop.

5.1 Effect Sizes: How Big Is the Difference?

INTUITION

A p-value is like a smoke detector: it tells you whether there is *something* there, not how big the fire is. With enough data, even a 0.5 minute difference becomes "highly significant". An **effect size** is the measuring tape: it tells you *how much* the groups differ, in units you can judge. Always report both: the p-value says "is it real?", the effect size says "does it matter?".

Words you need

Word	Plain meaning	Example
Effect size	A number measuring the size of a difference or link	25 minutes, d = 0.45, odds ratio 1.21

Cohen's d	Difference of means divided by the pooled SD	0.2 small, 0.5 medium, 0.8 large (rough guide)
Hedges' g	Cohen's d with a small-sample correction	
η^2 (eta-squared)	Share of total variance explained by a factor (ANOVA)	0.06 medium
Risk difference	$p_2 - p_1$	1.0 percentage point
Relative risk (risk ratio)	p_2 / p_1	1.20
Odds ratio (OR)	$[p_2/(1-p_2)] / [p_1/(1-p_1)]$	1.21
Probability of superiority	P(random value from B beats random value from A)	0.63
Practical significance	Large enough to matter to the business	A 5-minute gain on a 5-hour delivery window

The formulas

- $d = (\bar{x}_1 - \bar{x}_2) / s_p$, pooled SD $s_p = \sqrt{[((n_1-1)s_1^2 + (n_2-1)s_2^2) / (n_1 + n_2 - 2)]}$.
- Hedges' g = d × (1 − 3 / (4(n_1 + n_2) − 9)).
- SE of d ≈ $\sqrt{[(n_1+n_2)/(n_1 n_2) + d^2/(2(n_1+n_2))]}$, so an approximate 95 percent CI is d ± 1.96 SE.
- Probability of superiority for normal data = Φ(d/√2), where Φ is the normal CDF.
- **Odds ratio** CI: compute on the log scale, $\ln OR \pm 1.96 \sqrt{(1/a + 1/b + 1/c + 1/d)}$ using the four counts of the 2×2 table, then exponentiate.
- The guide "0.2 small, 0.5 medium, 0.8 large" is a rough convention. In your field the right yardstick is the business or engineering consequence.

Item	Example value	Where it appears in the job
Cohen's d	0.45	Standardised depot-to-depot difference

Relative risk	1.20	"20 percent more conversions"
Odds ratio	1.21	Logistic regression coefficients (Chapter 8)
η^2	0.925	Share of delivery-time variance explained by the depot

Problem 5.1.1 (Cohen's d with a confidence interval) Use the Depot A/Depot B summary from Chapter 4: A has n = 40, mean 250, SD 60; B has n = 45, mean 225, SD 50. Compute d, Hedges' g, a 95 percent interval for d, and the probability of superiority.

Formula	$s_p = \sqrt{[((n_1-1)s_1^2 + (n_2-1)s_2^2)/(n_1+n_2-2)]}$; d = difference / s_p
Plug in	$s_p = \sqrt{[(39 \times 3600 + 44 \times 2500) / 83]} = \sqrt{[(140{,}400 + 110{,}000) / 83]}$
Compute	$s_p = \sqrt{3{,}017.1} = 54.93$. $d = 25 / 54.93 = 0.455$. Correction factor $1 - 3/(4 \times 85 - 9) = 1 - 3/331 = 0.991$, so $g = 0.451$. $SE(d) = \sqrt{(85/1{,}800 + 0.455^2/170)} = \sqrt{(0.04722 + 0.00122)} = 0.220$, so the interval is $0.455 \pm 0.431 = (0.024, 0.886)$. Probability of superiority = $\Phi(0.455/1.414) = \Phi(0.322) = 0.626$.
Answer	The effect is medium (d = 0.45), but uncertain: it could be anywhere from nearly nothing (0.02) to large (0.89). A random delivery from B beats a random delivery from A in about 63 percent of pairs.
Check	The p-value from Chapter 4 (0.042) is just below 0.05, and the interval for d just excludes zero. Both tell the same story, as they must.
Why it matters	"Significant" here hides a wide range of possible effects. A stakeholder needs to see "somewhere between trivial and large".

```
import numpy as np
from scipy import stats
n1, m1, s1, n2, m2, s2 = 40, 250, 60, 45, 225, 50
sp = np.sqrt(((n1 - 1) * s1**2 + (n2 - 1) * s2**2) / (n1 + n2 - 2))
d = (m1 - m2) / sp
g = d * (1 - 3 / (4 * (n1 + n2) - 9))
se = np.sqrt((n1 + n2) / (n1 * n2) + d**2 / (2 * (n1 + n2)))
print("pooled sd %.2f  d %.3f  hedges g %.3f  SE(d) %.3f" % (sp, d, g,
se))
print("95%% CI for d: (%.3f, %.3f)" % (d - 1.96 * se, d + 1.96 * se))
print("probability of superiority: %.3f" % stats.norm.cdf(d / np.sqrt(2)))
```

```
pooled sd 54.93  d 0.455  hedges g 0.451  SE(d) 0.220
95% CI for d: (0.024, 0.887)
probability of superiority: 0.626
```

Problem 5.1.2 (statistically significant but tiny) A giant experiment has 2,000,000 orders per arm. Mean delivery time differs by 0.5 minutes (SD 100 minutes). Compute the z statistic, the p-value and d. Is this worth a change of process?

Formula	z = difference / $\sqrt{(2\sigma^2/n)}$; d = difference / σ
Plug in	SE = 100 × $\sqrt{(2 / 2{,}000{,}000)}$ = 100 × 0.001 = 0.1
Compute	z = 0.5 / 0.1 = 5.0. Two-sided p = 5.7×10^{-7}. d = 0.5 / 100 = 0.005.
Answer	The result is extremely significant (z = 5, p ≈ 6×10^{-7}) yet d = 0.005 is about 40 times smaller than the "small" benchmark 0.2. A half-minute gain on a 200-minute delivery is invisible to customers.
Check	Doubling the data raises z by $\sqrt{2}$ but leaves d unchanged. That is the key difference between significance and size.
Why it matters	In big-data settings *everything* is significant. Always decide beforehand what effect is large enough to matter (the MDE from Chapter 4).

```
n, diff, sd = 2_000_000, 0.5, 100
se = sd * np.sqrt(2 / n)
print("SE %.3f  z %.2f  p %.2e  d %.4f" % (se, diff / se, 2 *
stats.norm.sf(diff / se), diff / sd))
```

```
SE 0.100  z 5.00  p 5.73e-07  d 0.0050
```

Problem 5.1.3 (risk difference, relative risk, odds ratio) Variant A: 500 of 10,000 convert. Variant B: 600 of 10,000 convert. Compute the risk difference, the relative risk, the odds ratio and a 95 percent interval for the odds ratio.

Formula	RD = p_B − p_A; RR = p_B / p_A; OR = [p_B/(1−p_B)] / [p_A/(1−p_A)]
Plug in	p_A = 0.05, p_B = 0.06. Odds_A = 0.05/0.95 = 0.05263; odds_B = 0.06/0.94 = 0.06383.
Compute	RD = 0.01; RR = 1.20; OR = 0.06383 / 0.05263 = 1.2128. SE(ln OR) = √(1/600 + 1/9,400 + 1/500 + 1/9,500) = √(0.001667 + 0.000106 + 0.002 + 0.000105) = 0.0623. Interval: exp(ln 1.2128 ± 1.96 × 0.0623) = (1.073, 1.370).
Answer	B converts 1 percentage point more (a 20 percent relative lift). The odds ratio is 1.21, with 95 percent interval 1.07 to 1.37, which excludes 1.
Check	When the event is rare (5 percent), the OR (1.21) is close to the RR (1.20). For common events the OR exaggerates the RR.
Why it matters	"Odds went up 21 percent" and "probability went up 20 percent" sound alike but are different things. In an interview, always say which one you mean.

```
a, b, c, dd = 600, 9400, 500, 9500     # B convert, B not, A convert, A
not
pA, pB = c / (c + dd), a / (a + b)
OR = (a / b) / (c / dd); se = np.sqrt(1/a + 1/b + 1/c + 1/dd)
print("RD %.3f  RR %.3f  OR %.4f" % (pB - pA, pB / pA, OR))
print("95%% CI OR: (%.3f, %.3f)" % (np.exp(np.log(OR) - 1.96 * se),
np.exp(np.log(OR) + 1.96 * se)))
# rare vs common event: OR vs RR
for pa, pb in [(0.05, 0.06), (0.40, 0.48)]:
    print("pA=%.2f pB=%.2f RR=%.3f OR=%.3f" % (pa, pb, pb / pa, (pb / (1 -
pb)) / (pa / (1 - pa))))
```

```
RD 0.010  RR 1.200  OR 1.2128
95% CI OR: (1.073, 1.370)
pA=0.05 pB=0.06 RR=1.200 OR=1.213
pA=0.40 pB=0.48 RR=1.200 OR=1.385
```

The picture

```
Effect size on a ruler (Cohen's d):
0 ---- 0.2 ---- 0.5 ---- 0.8 ---- 1.2
tiny   small    medium   large    very large
        Depot B vs A: 0.455 with interval [0.02 ........ 0.89]
```

How to read it: the dot is the estimate, and the bracket is the plausible range. The wide bracket tells you the data have not pinned down the effect.

Connection to the real job

Every experiment readout should have: the effect size in business units (minutes, percentage points, revenue per customer), its confidence interval and the p-value. Regression coefficients in Chapter 6 are effect sizes too (minutes per extra 100 orders waiting). In machine learning, "model A is 0.3 percent more accurate" needs an interval to be meaningful.

Applications

- **Data Analytics:** experiment readouts, KPI change reports.
- **Data Science:** feature importance, uplift modelling.
- **Machine Learning:** differences in AUC or F1 with intervals.
- **Operations:** deciding whether a change in delivery time is large enough to justify changing a process.

COMMON MISTAKE

Reporting only "p < 0.05". The reader cannot tell if the gain is 0.5 minutes or 50 minutes. Also, do not apply "d = 0.2 is small" blindly. A d of 0.05 on revenue for millions of users may be worth a lot, while d = 0.8 on a vanity metric is worthless.

Check yourself

1. Means 105 and 100, pooled SD 10. What is Cohen's d? Answer: 0.5.
2. When does the odds ratio differ a lot from the relative risk? Answer: When the event is common.
3. Does a larger sample change Cohen's d? Answer: Not on average; it only makes the estimate of d more precise.

5.2 Multiple Testing: Bonferroni, Holm and Benjamini-Hochberg

INTUITION

If you buy one lottery ticket, winning is unlikely. If you buy 20 tickets, a win somewhere is likely. Every test at α = 0.05 is a ticket in the "false discovery lottery". The more tests you run, the more likely at least one is a false alarm. Corrections for multiple testing make each ticket harder to win so that the *group* of tests stays honest. Two goals are common: control the chance of *any* false alarm (strict, called FWER) or control the *share of false alarms among your discoveries* (looser, called FDR).

Words you need

Word	Plain meaning	Example
Family of tests	The set of tests that you interpret together	40 A/B metrics
FWER (family-wise error rate)	P(at least one false positive in the family)	Without correction, $1 - 0.95^{40}$ = 87 percent for 40 tests
FDR (false discovery rate)	Expected share of false positives among the discoveries	At most 5 percent of the flagged metrics
Adjusted p-value	The p-value you compare to α after correction	
q-value	Adjusted p-value for FDR	

The three methods (sort the p-values $p_{(1)} \le p_{(2)} \le \ldots \le p_{(m)}$)

- **Bonferroni**: reject if $p \le \alpha / m$. Simple, controls FWER, but loses power when m is large.
- **Holm** (step-down): compare the smallest p to α/m, the next to α/(m−1), and so on, stopping at the first failure. Controls FWER and is never worse than Bonferroni, so always prefer it to plain Bonferroni.
- **Benjamini-Hochberg (BH)**: find the largest k with $p_{(k)} \le (k / m) \cdot q$. Reject

hypotheses 1..k. It controls FDR at q (for independent or positively dependent tests), and finds many more discoveries than Bonferroni.

- When to use which: confirmatory tests with serious consequences (clinical, safety): Bonferroni or Holm. Exploratory screening of many features, genes or metrics: BH.

Item	Example value	Where it appears in the job
Bonferroni threshold	0.05 / 40 = 0.00125	A/B test dashboards with 40 metrics
BH at q = 0.05	Allows about 5 percent false among flagged	Feature screening, anomaly flags across many services
Holm	Same strictness as Bonferroni, more power	Safe default for FWER

Problem 5.2.1 (by hand, five tests) Five p-values: 0.001, 0.008, 0.020, 0.041, 0.300. With α = 0.05, which are rejected under Bonferroni, Holm and BH?

Formula	Bonferroni: $p \le 0.05/5 = 0.01$. Holm thresholds: 0.05/5, 0.05/4, 0.05/3, 0.05/2, 0.05/1. BH thresholds: $(k/5) \times 0.05$.
Plug in	Holm thresholds 0.0100, 0.0125, 0.0167, 0.0250, 0.0500. BH thresholds 0.010, 0.020, 0.030, 0.040, 0.050.
Compute	Bonferroni: 0.001 and 0.008 pass (≤ 0.01); 0.020 fails. So 2 rejections. Holm: 0.001 ≤ 0.0100 yes; 0.008 ≤ 0.0125 yes; 0.020 ≤ 0.0167 no, stop. So 2 rejections. BH: 0.001 ≤ 0.010 yes; 0.008 ≤ 0.020 yes; 0.020 ≤ 0.030 yes; 0.041 ≤ 0.040 no; 0.300 ≤ 0.050 no. The largest passing k is 3, so 3 rejections.
Answer	Bonferroni and Holm reject the first two hypotheses; BH rejects the first three. Adjusted p-values: Bonferroni 0.005, 0.040, 0.100, 0.205, 1.0; Holm 0.005, 0.032, 0.060, 0.082, 0.300; BH 0.005, 0.020, 0.033, 0.051, 0.300.
Check	Our hand-built functions are compared with `scipy.stats.false_discovery_control` (the BH adjustment) in the code.
Why it matters	The third test (p = 0.020) is a "discovery" under FDR control but not under FWER control. Which rule you pick depends on the cost of a false alarm.

```
def bonferroni(p):
    p = np.asarray(p); return np.minimum(p * len(p), 1)
def holm(p):
    p = np.asarray(p); m = len(p); o = np.argsort(p)
    run = 0; out = np.empty(m)
    for rank, i in enumerate(o):
        run = max(run, (m - rank) * p[i]); out[i] = min(run, 1)
    return out
def bh(p):
    p = np.asarray(p); m = len(p); o = np.argsort(p)
    adj = p[o] * m / (np.arange(m) + 1)
    adj = np.minimum.accumulate(adj[::-1])[::-1]
    out = np.empty(m); out[o] = np.minimum(adj, 1); return out
p = [0.001, 0.008, 0.020, 0.041, 0.300]
print("Bonferroni:", np.round(bonferroni(p), 3))
print("Holm      :", np.round(holm(p), 3))
print("BH        :", np.round(bh(p), 4))
print("scipy BH  :", np.round(stats.false_discovery_control(p), 4))
print("rejected at 0.05 -> Bonf", (bonferroni(p) <= .05).sum(), " Holm",
(holm(p) <= .05).sum(), " BH", (bh(p) <= .05).sum())
```

```
Bonferroni: [0.005 0.04  0.1   0.205 1.    ]
Holm      : [0.005 0.032 0.06  0.082 0.3   ]
BH        : [0.005  0.02   0.0333 0.0512 0.3   ]
scipy BH  : [0.005  0.02   0.0333 0.0512 0.3   ]
rejected at 0.05 -> Bonf 2  Holm 2  BH 3
```

Problem 5.2.2 (simulation: 1,000 metrics, 100 real effects) Suppose 1,000 metrics are tested with a two-sample t-test (n = 40 per group). For 100 of them there is a real effect of d = 0.8; for 900 there is none. Compare four approaches: no correction, Bonferroni, Holm and BH (q = 0.05). Count true discoveries, false discoveries and the realised false discovery proportion.

Formula	false discovery proportion = false discoveries / all discoveries
Plug in	m = 1,000, true effects 100, α = q = 0.05
Compute	The code simulates the data, runs 1,000 t-tests and applies each rule.
Answer	Without correction there are 150 discoveries, 94 true and 56 false, so 37 percent of the discoveries are false alarms. Bonferroni and Holm give the same result: 29 discoveries, none false, but 71 of the 100 real effects are missed (power 0.29). BH finds 79 discoveries, 76 true and 3 false (false discovery proportion 3.8 percent, below the 5 percent target) and detects 76 percent of the real effects.
Check	Uncorrected false alarms should be near 900 × 0.05 = 45; we got 56, a bit high by chance (the SD of that count is about 6.5). Also the uncorrected rule detects 94 percent of real effects, which is the power of a t-test with d = 0.8 and n = 40.
Why it matters	"Correct or not" is a trade-off between false alarms and misses. FDR control is the practical choice when you scan many things and will follow up on the shortlist.

```
rng = np.random.default_rng(40)
m, k, n = 1000, 100, 40
true = np.zeros(m, bool); true[:k] = True
a = rng.normal(0, 1, (m, n)); b = rng.normal(0, 1, (m, n)) +
np.where(true, 0.8, 0.0)[:, None]
pv = stats.ttest_ind(a, b, axis=1).pvalue
rules = {"no correction": pv <= 0.05, "Bonferroni": bonferroni(pv) <=
0.05, "Holm": holm(pv) <= 0.05, "BH (q=0.05)": bh(pv) <= 0.05}
print(f"{'rule':16}{'discoveries':>12}{'true':>6}{'false':>7}{'FDP':>8}
{'power':>8}")
for name, rej in rules.items():
    tp = (rej & true).sum(); fp = (rej & ~true).sum()
    print(f"{name:16}{rej.sum():12d}{tp:6d}{fp:7d}{fp / max(rej.sum(),
1):8.3f}{tp / k:8.2f}")
```

```
rule             discoveries  true  false     FDP   power
no correction            150    94     56   0.373    0.94
Bonferroni                29    29      0   0.000    0.29
Holm                      29    29      0   0.000    0.29
BH (q=0.05)               79    76      3   0.038    0.76
```

The picture

```
# plot
import matplotlib.pyplot as plt
o = np.sort(pv); ranks = np.arange(1, m + 1)
plt.figure(figsize=(6.2, 3.8))
plt.plot(ranks[:250], o[:250], ".", color="#1f77b4", label="sorted p-
values")
plt.plot(ranks[:250], 0.05 * ranks[:250] / m, color="#d62728", label="BH
line: 0.05 k/m")
plt.axhline(0.05 / m, color="gray", ls="--", label="Bonferroni: 0.05/m")
plt.axhline(0.05, color="black", ls=":", label="no correction")
plt.xlabel("rank k of the p-value"); plt.ylabel("p-value"); plt.ylim(0,
0.12); plt.legend(fontsize=7)
plt.title("1,000 tests: three decision lines")
plt.tight_layout(); plt.savefig(f"{IMG}/ch05_multiple_testing.png",
dpi=120); plt.close()
```

Sorted p-values with three decision lines: no correction at 0.05, the BH rising line, and the Bonferroni line near zero

How to read it: the x-axis is the rank of each p-value (1 = smallest) and the y-axis is the p-value. Blue dots rise as rank increases. BH rejects every test up to the last point where the dots are below the red rising line. Bonferroni (dashed grey line, almost at zero) is far stricter. The dotted line at 0.05 is "no correction" and lets in a crowd of false alarms.

Connection to the real job

A/B test platforms track dozens of metrics per test; anomaly detectors scan thousands of series; feature selection tests thousands of columns. Without correction the shortlist is full of noise. BH is the standard way to produce a shortlist with a known error budget.

Applications

- **Data Analytics:** many-metric A/B test readouts, segment scans.
- **Data Science:** screening features, genes or keywords.
- **Machine Learning:** comparing many models or hyperparameters on the same test set.
- **Operations:** flagging changes across hundreds of delivery routes or branches after a process change.

COMMON MISTAKE

Applying a correction only to the tests you "remember". The family is *all* tests that could have been reported, including the ones you ran and dropped. Also, don't use Bonferroni with 10,000 tests when a shortlist for follow-up is what you need; use BH.

Check yourself

1. 20 independent tests at $\alpha = 0.05$: P(at least one false alarm)? Answer: $1 - 0.95^{20} = 0.64$.
2. Which is never worse than Bonferroni? Answer: Holm.
3. Which method controls the share of false alarms among discoveries? Answer: Benjamini-Hochberg (FDR).

5.3 p-Hacking: Peeking, Slicing and Forking Paths

INTUITION

Imagine flipping a coin until you see 5 heads in a row and then claiming the coin is biased. Of course you will find it if you keep going. **p-hacking** means (often innocently) doing things that raise the chance of a "significant" result: stopping the test when the p-value dips below 0.05, trying many subgroups, trying many metrics, many outlier rules, many models. Each choice is a lottery ticket. The final result looks like one test but is really the best of many.

Words you need

Word	Plain meaning	Example
Optional stopping / peeking	Checking the p-value repeatedly and stopping when it is "good"	Checking an A/B test every day
Forking paths	Many analysis choices, each of which could have been different	Which outliers to drop, which metric to use
Fishing / data dredging	Testing many hypotheses and reporting only the hits	20 subgroups

Pre-registration	Writing down the hypothesis and analysis plan before seeing data	An experiment document

Problem 5.3.1 (peeking at an A/B test) An A/A test (no real difference) has two arms with conversion 5 percent. You look at the data after every 1,000 visitors per arm, up to 10 looks, and stop at the first look where p < 0.05. What share of A/A tests will you wrongly declare a winner? Compare with a single look at the end.

Formula	At each look compute the two-proportion z-test on all data so far; "declare" if any look has p < 0.05.
Plug in	10 looks, α = 0.05, 5,000 simulated A/A experiments
Compute	The code uses cumulative counts, which is exactly what a dashboard does.
Answer	A single look at the end has a false-positive rate near 5 percent (we get 5.2). Peeking 10 times raises it to 19.6 percent, nearly 4 times the promised rate. Using Bonferroni across the 10 looks (0.005 each) brings it back down to 2.4 percent, which is safe but a little conservative.
Check	A single look must give about 5 percent, which validates the simulation.
Why it matters	Peeking at a dashboard and stopping when it looks good is the most common source of false wins in A/B testing.

```
rng = np.random.default_rng(41)
S, looks, step, p0 = 5000, 10, 1000, 0.05
xa = np.cumsum(rng.binomial(step, p0, (S, looks)), axis=1)
xb = np.cumsum(rng.binomial(step, p0, (S, looks)), axis=1)
nn = step * np.arange(1, looks + 1)
pp = (xa + xb) / (2 * nn)
z = (xb - xa) / nn / np.sqrt(np.maximum(pp * (1 - pp) * 2 / nn, 1e-12))
pvals = 2 * stats.norm.sf(np.abs(z))
print("single look at the end        : false positive rate = %.3f" %
(pvals[:, -1] < .05).mean())
print("peek at all 10 looks, stop on p<.05: false positive rate = %.3f" %
(pvals < .05).any(axis=1).mean())
print("Bonferroni over 10 looks (0.005 each): %.3f" % (pvals <
.005).any(axis=1).mean())
```

```
single look at the end        : false positive rate = 0.052
peek at all 10 looks, stop on p<.05: false positive rate = 0.196
Bonferroni over 10 looks (0.005 each): 0.024
```

Problem 5.3.2 (fishing in subgroups) An A/A test is sliced into 20 subgroups (country, device and so on). What is the probability that at least one subgroup shows p < 0.05 by luck? Simulate it, and show the corrected result.

Formula	P(at least one) = 1 − (1 − 0.05)^{20}
Plug in	1 − 0.95^{20} = 1 − 0.3585
Compute	0.6415 by theory. Simulate 5,000 experiments of 20 independent null tests.
Answer	About 64 percent of null experiments contain at least one "significant" subgroup (0.6424 simulated, 0.6415 theory), and the average number of such subgroups is 1.01. With Holm correction, the false-alarm rate returns to 4.6 percent.
Check	The simulated fraction should be near 0.64.
Why it matters	"The new design works for users in Brazil on Android" is a typical headline from a slice scan. Unless you planned that slice in advance, treat it as a hypothesis to test on new data.

```
S, G = 5000, 20
pv_sub = rng.uniform(0, 1, (S, G))             # null p-values are uniform
print("theory P(at least one): %.4f" % (1 - 0.95**G))
print("simulated, uncorrected : %.4f   mean number significant: %.2f" %
((pv_sub < .05).any(1).mean(), (pv_sub < .05).sum(1).mean()))
holm_any = np.array([(holm(row) <= .05).any() for row in pv_sub[:2000]])
print("simulated, Holm        : %.4f" % holm_any.mean())
```

```
theory P(at least one): 0.6415
simulated, uncorrected : 0.6424   mean number significant: 1.01
simulated, Holm        : 0.0460
```

The picture

```
Look 1   Look 2   Look 3   ...  Look 10
 p=.31    p=.12    p=.04 <-- "significant!" stop and ship
 (the p-value random-walks; given 10 chances it will cross 0.05 often)
```

Connection to the real job

Experiment platforms increasingly use *sequential* methods (always-valid p-values, alpha-spending) that allow continuous monitoring safely. If yours does not, fix the sample size in advance (Chapter 4) and look once.

Applications

- **Data Analytics / Product:** fixed-horizon A/B tests, sequential testing tools.
- **Data Science:** pre-registered analysis plans, train/validation/test discipline.
- **Machine Learning:** hyperparameter search results must be confirmed on untouched data.
- **Research:** reproducibility.

COMMON MISTAKE

"We only looked at the data to check progress." Looking is fine; *deciding* based on the look is the problem. Decide the stopping rule before the test starts.

Check yourself

1. 20 subgroups, all null. Expected number "significant" at 5 percent? Answer: 1.
2. Why does peeking inflate false positives? Answer: Each look is another chance to cross the threshold by luck.
3. Name a fix for peeking. Answer: Fix the sample size in advance, or use a sequential method such as alpha-spending.

5.4 More Ways Data Fools You: Winner's Curse, Regression to the Mean, and Low Prior Odds

INTUITION

If you pick the tallest person from a big crowd, they are probably tall *and* lucky (they happened to be measured on a good day). Next time they will likely be a bit shorter. Selecting extreme results from noisy measurements always selects some luck, and luck does not repeat. This is the **winner's curse** (when you pick the best of many) and **regression to the mean** (when you pick the worst or best and measure again). A third trap: if most hypotheses you test are false to begin with, many "significant" results are false even at α = 0.05.

Words you need

Word	Plain meaning	Example
Winner's curse	The best-looking option's measured effect overstates its true effect	The best of 200 test variants
Regression to the mean	Extreme values tend to be less extreme when measured again	The 10 slowest delivery branches today
Prior probability of a true effect	The share of tested ideas that really work	Maybe 10 percent
PPV (positive predictive value) of a "significant" result	P(effect is real |	significant)

The formula for the third trap

```
PPV = (power × prior) / (power × prior + α × (1 − prior))
```

This is just Bayes' theorem from Chapter 1 with "significant" as the positive test.

Problem 5.4.1 (winner's curse) You test 200 landing-page variants. True effects on conversion (in percentage points) are Normal(mean 0, SD 0.3). Each test measures its effect with noise SD 0.5. You ship the top 5 by measured lift. What is the average measured lift of the top 5, and what is their average true lift?

Formula	observed = true + noise. Selecting the top observed values selects both large true effects and large positive noise.
Plug in	200 variants, true SD 0.3, noise SD 0.5
Compute	Simulate 2,000 repeated "tournaments" and average the top-5 results.
Answer	The top 5 show a measured lift of about 1.34 points, but their true lift is only about 0.35 points: about three-quarters of the apparent gain is luck. The same measured numbers will not be seen again when you re-test.
Check	The theory for the expected true effect of a selected unit is the "shrinkage" factor $\sigma^2_{true} / (\sigma^2_{true} + \sigma^2_{noise}) = 0.09 / 0.34 = 0.26$ times the measured value, so $1.34 \times 0.26 = 0.35$. The simulation agrees.
Why it matters	When you pick the best of many variants, the forecast of the gain must be shrunk, or confirmed in a fresh test. Bayesian shrinkage (Chapter 9, 11) formalises this.

```
rng = np.random.default_rng(42)
obs_top, true_top = [], []
for _ in range(2000):
    true = rng.normal(0, 0.3, 200); obs = true + rng.normal(0, 0.5, 200)
    top = np.argsort(obs)[-5:]
    obs_top.append(obs[top].mean()); true_top.append(true[top].mean())
print("top-5 measured lift: %.2f   top-5 true lift: %.2f   shrink factor
%.2f" % (np.mean(obs_top), np.mean(true_top), 0.09 / 0.34))
```

```
top-5 measured lift: 1.34   top-5 true lift: 0.35   shrink factor 0.26
```

Problem 5.4.2 (regression to the mean) 500 delivery branches have a "true" average delivery time of 200 minutes (with branch-specific differences, SD 20) and each day's measurement has noise SD 30. On day 1 you flag the 25 worst branches and "fix" them by doing nothing at all. On day 2 you measure again. What happens to their average?

Formula	Day measurement = branch's true level + daily noise. Flagging the worst picks high noise.
Plug in	Branch SD 20, noise SD 30, top 5 percent
Compute	Simulate and compare day 1 and day 2 averages for the flagged branches.
Answer	The flagged branches average 272 minutes on day 1 and drop to 225 minutes on day 2 with *no change at all*. A team that "retrained the staff" at those branches would believe it fixed 47 minutes.
Check	Expected day-2 value = 200 + (20^2 / (20^2 + 30^2)) × (day-1 mean − 200) = 200 + 0.308 × 72.3 = 222.2 (the simulation gave 224.9).
Why it matters	Any "fix the worst offenders" programme, and any "treat the sickest patients" study, will look successful without a control group. This is why randomised comparison (Chapter 12) matters.

```
rng = np.random.default_rng(43)
true = rng.normal(200, 20, 500)
d1 = true + rng.normal(0, 30, 500); d2 = true + rng.normal(0, 30, 500)
worst = np.argsort(d1)[-25:]
print("flagged branches: day 1 mean %.1f -> day 2 mean %.1f (nothing was
changed)" % (d1[worst].mean(), d2[worst].mean()))
print("theory for day 2: %.1f" % (200 + 20**2 / (20**2 + 30**2) *
(d1[worst].mean() - 200)))
```

```
flagged branches: day 1 mean 272.3 -> day 2 mean 224.9 (nothing was
changed)
theory for day 2: 222.2
```

Problem 5.4.3 (why most findings can be false) A team tests ideas of which only 10 percent really work. Their tests have power 0.8 and α = 0.05. (a) What share of "significant" results is real? (b) If the tests are underpowered (power 0.3), what share is real? (c) If only 2 percent of ideas work and power is 0.8?

Formula	PPV = (power × prior) / (power × prior + α × (1 − prior))
Plug in	(a) 0.8 × 0.1 = 0.08; false = 0.05 × 0.9 = 0.045.
Compute	(a) 0.08 / (0.08 + 0.045) = 0.64. (b) 0.03 / (0.03 + 0.045) = 0.40. (c) 0.016 / (0.016 + 0.049) = 0.246.
Answer	(a) 64 percent, (b) 40 percent, (c) only 24.6 percent of "wins" are real.
Check	Verify (a) with natural frequencies: of 1,000 ideas, 100 work and 80 are detected; of 900 duds, 45 are falsely detected; 80 / (80 + 45) = 64 percent.
Why it matters	If your organisation tries many long-shot ideas, a large share of the "wins" are noise. Underpowered tests make it worse. This is the same base-rate trap as the alert example in Chapter 1.

```
def ppv(power, prior, alpha=0.05):
    return power * prior / (power * prior + alpha * (1 - prior))
for pw, pr in [(0.8, 0.1), (0.3, 0.1), (0.8, 0.02), (0.8, 0.5)]:
    print("power=%.1f prior=%.2f -> PPV=%.3f" % (pw, pr, ppv(pw, pr)))
```

```
power=0.8 prior=0.10 -> PPV=0.640
power=0.3 prior=0.10 -> PPV=0.400
power=0.8 prior=0.02 -> PPV=0.246
power=0.8 prior=0.50 -> PPV=0.941
```

The picture

```
Measured lift of 200 variants (true effect + noise)

 true effects:     ........(narrow cloud around 0)........
 measured effects: ....................(wider cloud)....................
 the 5 you pick:                                          ###  <- far right
 their true values: back inside the narrow cloud, near +0.35
```

The winners come from the right edge of the wide (noisy) cloud, but their true values come from the narrow cloud.

Connection to the real job

Winner's curse explains why launched features rarely deliver the lifts seen in experiments ("the lift decays"). Regression to the mean explains the success of many "rescue the worst" programmes and the failure of many "reward the best" ones. PPV explains why replication matters: confirm surprising findings with a fresh test before betting on them.

Applications

- **Data Analytics / Product:** forecasting the impact of winning variants; holdout groups.
- **Machine Learning:** the best of 500 hyperparameter runs overstates the true score; use an untouched test set.
- **Operations:** "fix the slowest routes" without a control looks like a miracle.
- **Education and health:** programmes aimed at the worst performers.

COMMON MISTAKE

Reporting the lift of the best variant as the expected lift after launch. Shrink it, or re-test the winner. Also: concluding a treatment works because the worst cases improved afterwards, with no control group.

Check yourself

1. Why does the best of many noisy measurements look better than it is? Answer: It was selected partly for good luck (positive noise).
2. What do you need to rule out regression to the mean? Answer: A control group (or randomisation).
3. If power is low, does the share of true findings among significant ones rise or fall? Answer: It falls.

5.5 An Honest Reporting Checklist

INTUITION

Think of a lab notebook: each step is written before and after the experiment, including the failures. A good analysis report is the same: another person can see what you tried, not just what worked.

Problem 5.5.1 (write the paragraph) From this chapter's numbers, write a short honest

summary of the Depot A vs Depot B comparison (Chapter 4 and 5.1): Welch t = 2.07, p = 0.042, difference 25 minutes with a 95 percent interval of 1 to 49 minutes, d = 0.45 (0.02 to 0.89), pre-agreed MDE 20 minutes, only this one metric tested.

Formula	A good summary has: question, design, estimate with interval, effect size, caveats, decision rule.
Plug in	Use the numbers above.
Compute	(writing task)
Answer	"We compared Depot B with Depot A on mean delivery time (one pre-planned metric, 40 and 45 deliveries). B was faster by 25 minutes (95 percent CI 1 to 49 minutes; Welch t = 2.07, p = 0.042; Cohen's d = 0.45, CI 0.02 to 0.89). The estimate is above our 20-minute threshold, but the interval is wide and includes gains below it, so we recommend a larger confirmation run (about 400 deliveries per depot) before concluding that the gain is practically important."
Check	Every number is traceable to the earlier problems; the decision rule links to the MDE (20 minutes).
Why it matters	This format protects you in a review, because it states what is known and what is not.

The checklist to copy:

1. State the question, the primary metric and the MDE before collecting data.
2. Fix the sample size or the stopping rule in advance.
3. Report all tests that were run, and correct for them (Holm or BH).
4. Report effect sizes with confidence intervals, not p-values alone.
5. Label unplanned findings as "exploratory" and confirm them on fresh data.
6. Say what the data cannot tell you.

Chapter recap

- Effect size tells how much; the p-value tells whether it is likely luck. Report both, with an interval.
- Cohen's d = difference / pooled SD; odds ratios and relative risks differ when the event is common.

- With enough data, tiny effects become significant; decide the practical threshold beforehand.
- Running m tests at α inflates false alarms: P(any) = 1 − (1 − α)^m.
- Bonferroni and Holm control the chance of any false alarm (Holm is never worse); BH controls the share of false discoveries and is the exploration default.
- Peeking at p-values and fishing in subgroups can raise a nominal 5 percent false-positive rate to 20 percent or 64 percent.
- Winner's curse and regression to the mean make the best and worst results look more extreme than they are; use controls and re-tests.
- When few ideas are truly good, many "significant" results are false (PPV).
- Plan, pre-register, correct, report intervals, and confirm surprises on new data.

Formula / pattern	Meaning
`d = (x̄₁ − x̄₂)/s_p`, `g = d(1 − 3/(4N − 9))`	Cohen's d and Hedges' g
`OR = (a/b)/(c/d)`, `SE(ln OR) = √(1/a+1/b+1/c+1/d)`	Odds ratio and CI
Bonferroni `p·m`; Holm step-down; BH `p·m/k`	Adjusted p-values
`stats.false_discovery_control(p)`	BH adjustment in scipy
`1 − (1 − α)^m`	Chance of at least one false alarm
`PPV = power·prior / (power·prior + α(1−prior))`	Share of real findings

Practice set

Problem 5.6.1 Means 80 and 70, pooled SD 20. What is d, and is it small, medium or large?

Answer: d = 10 / 20 = 0.5, medium.

Problem 5.6.2 You run 12 independent tests at α = 0.05. Chance of at least one false positive?

Answer: 1 − 0.95^{12} = 1 − 0.5404 = 0.46.

Problem 5.6.3 What is the Bonferroni threshold for 25 tests at α = 0.05?

Answer: 0.05 / 25 = 0.002.

Problem 5.6.4 Four p-values: 0.003, 0.012, 0.030, 0.200. Which are rejected by BH at q = 0.05?

Answer: Thresholds (k/4) × 0.05 = 0.0125, 0.025, 0.0375, 0.05. 0.003 ≤ 0.0125 yes; 0.012 ≤ 0.025 yes; 0.030 ≤ 0.0375 yes; 0.200 ≤ 0.05 no. The first three are rejected. Bonferroni (0.0125) would reject only 0.003.

Problem 5.6.5 What is the output? `print(round(0.8*0.1 / (0.8*0.1 + 0.05*0.9), 3))`

Answer: 0.08 / 0.125 = 0.64.

Problem 5.6.6 Find the bug: "We watched the test for two weeks, and on day 9 the p-value was 0.03, so we stopped and shipped."

Answer: Optional stopping inflates false positives (up to about 20 percent with 10 looks). The stopping rule must be fixed before the test, or a sequential method used.

Problem 5.6.7 2×2 counts: exposed 30 events of 100; unexposed 10 events of 100. Compute RR and OR.

Answer: RR = 0.30 / 0.10 = 3.0. OR = (30/70) / (10/90) = 0.4286 / 0.1111 = 3.857. The OR is larger because the event is not rare.

Problem 5.6.8 The 10 branches with the longest waits are given to a team that "optimises" them. The next week their average wait drops 15 percent. List two reasons to doubt the team's effect.

Answer: Regression to the mean (the worst branches were partly unlucky) and no control group (other changes or seasonality could also explain it). Compare with similar branches that were left untouched.

Problem 5.6.9 (interview) "You ran 50 metrics in an A/B test and 3 are significant at 0.05. What do you do?"

Answer: Expected false positives are 50 × 0.05 = 2.5, so 3 hits is what noise alone would give. Apply BH or Holm, ask which metrics were pre-specified as primary, look at effect sizes and intervals, and confirm any promising metric in a follow-up test.

Problem 5.6.10 (interview) "Explain the difference between FWER and FDR and when you

would use each."

Answer: FWER is the probability of at least one false positive; use it (Bonferroni, Holm) when any false positive is costly, as in a confirmatory safety decision. FDR is the expected proportion of false positives among the discoveries; use it (Benjamini-Hochberg) for screening many hypotheses when you will validate the shortlist later.

Prompt pack

✨ **AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI**

```
You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional
moving into data roles, and English is my second language. Teach me
Chapter 5 topic "effect sizes: Cohen's d, Hedges' g, eta-squared, risk
difference, relative risk, odds ratio, and confidence intervals for them".
Use delivery-time and conversion examples with real numbers. Ask one check
question after each idea. End with 6 exercises and mark my answers.
```

✨ **AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI**

```
You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional
moving into data roles. Teach me multiple testing: FWER versus FDR,
Bonferroni, Holm and Benjamini-Hochberg. Work one example with five p-
values by hand and then verify in Python. Then give me 8 graded exercises
WITHOUT solutions and wait for my answers before correcting.
```

✨ **AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI**

```
You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional
moving into data roles. Explain p-hacking: peeking at A/B tests, subgroup
fishing, forking paths and optional stopping. Show Python simulations of
the inflated false positive rate and the correct fixes (fixed horizon,
sequential testing, alpha spending). Quiz me one question at a time and
stop after 8 questions.
```

✨ **AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI**

```
You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional
moving into data roles. Review this experiment readout I wrote: [PASTE
HERE]. Check whether I reported effect sizes with intervals, corrected for
multiple testing, avoided peeking, and described the limits of the data.
```

```
Rewrite it using the honest reporting checklist and explain every change
in simple English.
```

✨ AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI

```
You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional
moving into data roles. Run a mock interview on effect sizes, multiple
testing, p-hacking, winner's curse and regression to the mean. Use A/B
test and before-and-after comparison scenarios. Ask one question at a
time, wait for my answer, then give a score out of 10 and a model answer.
Ask 8 questions.
```

CHAPTER 6

LINEAR REGRESSION DEEPLY

From the OLS formula to residual diagnostics: how to fit a line, trust it, and break it on purpose.

Your manager asks, "If we expect 800 orders waiting at the depot on Friday, what delivery time should we promise customers, and which factor matters most: the number of orders, the distance or the express courier option?" Linear regression is the tool that answers both questions at once. It gives you a prediction, an effect for each factor (in minutes per unit), an uncertainty for each number, and a set of diagnostic checks that tell you when the model is lying. You already know regression as a machine-learning model (the Math PDF, Pillar 2 and Pillar 5, covered gradients and loss functions). Here we treat it as a *statistical* model: we derive the OLS formula, compute standard errors and tests by hand, check the assumptions, find influential points, detect collinearity, and learn what the coefficients really mean. By the end you will be able to explain every number in a regression table, which is exactly what interviewers and stakeholders ask.

Since the library `statsmodels` is not installed in our environment, we build everything in NumPy so you see inside the box. The statsmodels equivalent (`sm.OLS(y, X).fit().summary()`) is shown at the end of the chapter as "not run here"; it reports the same numbers.

6.1 Simple Linear Regression and the OLS Derivation

INTUITION

You plot delivery time against orders waiting and the points rise in a cloud. You want the single straight line that best describes the cloud. "Best" means: the total of the squared vertical gaps between points and line is as small as possible. Imagine a rigid rod attached to every point by springs: the rod settles where the springs pull equally. That position is the **ordinary least squares (OLS)** line. The squares make big misses count a lot, and make the maths clean.

Words you need

Word	Plain meaning	Example
Response (y)	What you predict	Delivery time in min
Predictor (x)	What you use to predict	Orders waiting
Intercept β_0	Predicted y when x = 0	Delivery time with no orders waiting
Slope β_1	Change in predicted y for 1 more unit of x	min per extra user
Fitted value $\hat{y}$	The model's prediction for a point	
Residual e	$y - \hat{y}$: what the line misses	
SSE	Sum of squared residuals Σe^2	The quantity OLS minimises
R^2	1 − SSE/SST, share of variance explained	0.6

The model and the derivation

The model is $y = \beta_0 + \beta_1 x + \varepsilon$. The ε (epsilon) is random noise. In matrix form, with one row per observation and a column of ones for the intercept: $y = X\beta + \varepsilon$.

OLS chooses β to minimise $SSE(\beta) = (y - X\beta)^T(y - X\beta)$.

1. Take the derivative with respect to β: $-2\ X^T(y - X\beta)$.
2. Set it to zero: $X^T(y - X\beta) = 0$, giving the **normal equations** $X^TX\ \beta = X^Ty$.
3. Solve: $\hat{\beta} = (X^TX)^{-1}\ X^T\ y$.

For one predictor this reduces to $\hat{\beta}_1 = Sxy\ /\ Sxx$ and $\hat{\beta}_0 = \bar{y} - \hat{\beta}_1\ \bar{x}$, where $Sxy = \Sigma(x - \bar{x})(y - \bar{y})$ and $Sxx = \Sigma(x - \bar{x})^2$.

Geometry (picture it as a shadow): the vector y lives in n-dimensional space. The columns of X span a flat sheet (a subspace). The fitted vector $\hat{y} = X\hat{\beta}$ is the **shadow** (orthogonal projection) of y on that sheet, and the residual vector is the part sticking out at a right angle. That is why $X^Te = 0$: residuals are orthogonal to every predictor.

Under the standard assumptions (Section 6.3) the variance of the estimate is $\mathrm{Var}(\hat{\beta}) = \sigma^2 (X^\top X)^{-1}$, estimated with $s^2 = \mathrm{SSE} / (n - p)$, where p is the number of coefficients. The Math PDF (Pillar 2) showed the same minimisation through gradient descent. The normal equation is the one-step shortcut.

Item	Example value	Where it appears in the job
Slope β_1	0.6 min per order	Planning: cost of one more waiting order
R^2	0.60	How much of the variation the model explains
s (residual SE)	0.89 min	Typical prediction error

Problem 6.1.1 (five points, every number by hand) x = 1, 2, 3, 4, 5 (load in hundreds of orders) and y = 2, 4, 5, 4, 5 (delivery time in tens of min). Find the OLS line, R^2, the SE of the slope, its t statistic and p-value.

Formula	$\hat{\beta}_1 = Sxy/Sxx$; $\hat{\beta}_0 = \bar{y} - \hat{\beta}_1\bar{x}$; $s^2 = SSE/(n-2)$; $SE(\hat{\beta}_1) = \sqrt{(s^2/Sxx)}$; $t = \hat{\beta}_1/SE$
Plug in	$\bar{x} = 3$, $\bar{y} = 4$. $Sxy = (-2)(-2) + (-1)(0) + (0)(1) + (1)(0) + (2)(1) = 4 + 0 + 0 + 0 + 2 = 6$. $Sxx = 4 + 1 + 0 + 1 + 4 = 10$.
Compute	$\hat{\beta}_1 = 6/10 = 0.6$. $\hat{\beta}_0 = 4 - 0.6 \times 3 = 2.2$. Fitted: 2.8, 3.4, 4.0, 4.6, 5.2. Residuals: −0.8, 0.6, 1.0, −0.6, −0.2. $SSE = 0.64 + 0.36 + 1.0 + 0.36 + 0.04 = 2.4$. $SST = \Sigma(y - \bar{y})^2 = 4 + 0 + 1 + 0 + 1 = 6$. $R^2 = 1 - 2.4/6 = 0.6$. $s^2 = 2.4/3 = 0.8$. $SE = \sqrt{(0.8/10)} = 0.283$. $t = 0.6/0.283 = 2.12$ with 3 df, $p = 0.124$.
Answer	The line is $\hat{y} = 2.2 + 0.6x$: each extra 100 orders adds 6 min on average. The line explains 60 percent of the variance, but with only 5 points the slope is not statistically significant (p = 0.12).
Check	The residuals add to zero: −0.8 + 0.6 + 1.0 − 0.6 − 0.2 = 0. They are orthogonal to x: $\Sigma\, x \cdot e = -0.8 + 1.2 + 3.0 - 2.4 - 1.0 = 0$. The code confirms both.
Why it matters	A decent R^2 with 5 points proves little. Always look at the standard error and the interval, not only at the slope.

Predict: will `X.T @ e` print exactly zero?

```
import numpy as np
from scipy import stats
x = np.array([1, 2, 3, 4, 5.0]); y = np.array([2, 4, 5, 4, 5.0])
X = np.column_stack([np.ones_like(x), x])
beta = np.linalg.solve(X.T @ X, X.T @ y)           # normal equations
e = y - X @ beta
n, p = X.shape
s2 = e @ e / (n - p)
cov = s2 * np.linalg.inv(X.T @ X)
se = np.sqrt(np.diag(cov)); t = beta / se
print("beta:", beta, " SSE:", round(e @ e, 3), " R2:", round(1 - e @ e /
((y - y.mean()) ** 2).sum(), 3))
print("SE:", np.round(se, 4), " t:", np.round(t, 3), " p:", np.round(2 *
stats.t.sf(abs(t), n - p), 4))
print("X'e (should be ~0):", np.round(X.T @ e, 12))
print("lstsq check:", np.linalg.lstsq(X, y, rcond=None)[0])
```

```
beta: [2.2 0.6]  SSE: 2.4  R2: 0.6
SE: [0.9381 0.2828]  t: [2.345 2.121]  p: [0.1007 0.124 ]
X'e (should be ~0): [0. 0.]
lstsq check: [2.2 0.6]
```

Line by line: `np.linalg.solve(XtX, Xty)` solves the normal equations without forming the inverse (more stable). `X.T @ e` is the orthogonality check. In real code prefer `np.linalg.lstsq` (or QR), which stays accurate even when columns are nearly collinear.

Problem 6.1.2 (a realistic dataset: delivery time versus orders) We simulate 200 delivery days where delivery time = 80 + 0.15 × orders + noise (SD 25). Fit the line, interpret the slope, and report the 95 percent CI, R^2 and the residual standard error. Then make a prediction for 800 orders with both a confidence interval (for the *mean* delivery time at 800 orders) and a prediction interval (for *one new run*).

Formula	CI for mean: $\hat{y}_0 \pm t^* \cdot s \sqrt{(x_0^T(X^TX)^{-1}x_0)}$. Prediction interval: $\hat{y}_0 \pm t^* \cdot s \sqrt{(1 + x_0^T(X^TX)^{-1}x_0)}$.
Plug in	$x_0 = (1, 800)$
Compute	The code builds a reusable function `ols()` that we will use for the rest of the chapter.
Answer	The fitted slope is 0.156 min per order (about 15.6 min per extra 100 orders, true value 0.15) with a 95 percent CI of (0.144, 0.168), which contains the truth. The prediction at 800 orders is 203.3 min. The interval for the mean at 800 orders is narrow (±4.4 min) while the prediction interval for a single run is wide (about ±47 min), because single days carry the full noise SD.
Check	The true mean at 800 orders is 80 + 0.15 × 800 = 200 min. The CI 203.3 ± 4.4 = (198.9, 207.7) contains 200.
Why it matters	Stakeholders usually want the prediction interval ("how long will tomorrow's delivery take?"), not the CI for the mean. Mixing them up is a very common error.

```
def ols(X, y, names=None):
    X = np.asarray(X, float); y = np.asarray(y, float)
    n, p = X.shape
    XtXi = np.linalg.inv(X.T @ X)
    beta = XtXi @ X.T @ y
    fit = X @ beta; e = y - fit
    sse = e @ e; sst = ((y - y.mean()) ** 2).sum()
    s2 = sse / (n - p)
    se = np.sqrt(s2 * np.diag(XtXi))
    t = beta / se; pv = 2 * stats.t.sf(abs(t), n - p)
    h = np.einsum("ij,jk,ik->i", X, XtXi, X)              # leverage =
diag of hat matrix
    r2 = 1 - sse / sst; adj = 1 - (1 - r2) * (n - 1) / (n - p)
    F = ((sst - sse) / (p - 1)) / s2; pF = stats.f.sf(F, p - 1, n - p)
    cooks = e**2 / (p * s2) * h / (1 - h) ** 2
    return dict(beta=beta, se=se, t=t, p=pv, resid=e, fitted=fit, h=h,
r2=r2, adj=adj, F=F, pF=pF,
                s=np.sqrt(s2), n=n, k=p, cooks=cooks, XtXi=XtXi, sse=sse,
names=names)
def show(m):
    print(f"{'term':12}{'coef':>10}{'se':>9}{'t':>8}{'p':>10}")
    for nm, b, s_, t_, p_ in zip(m["names"], m["beta"], m["se"], m["t"],
m["p"]):
        print(f"{nm:12}{b:10.4f}{s_:9.4f}{t_:8.2f}{p_:10.4f}")
    print(f"R2={m['r2']:.4f} adjR2={m['adj']:.4f} F={m['F']:.1f} (p=
{m['pF']:.2e}) resid SE={m['s']:.2f} n={m['n']}")

rng = np.random.default_rng(60)
n = 200
orders = rng.uniform(100, 1000, n)
dmin = 80 + 0.15 * orders + rng.normal(0, 25, n)
X1 = np.column_stack([np.ones(n), orders])
m1 = ols(X1, dmin, ["intercept", "orders"])
show(m1)
tcrit = stats.t.ppf(0.975, n - 2)
print("95%% CI slope: (%.4f, %.4f)" % (m1["beta"][1] - tcrit * m1["se"]
[1], m1["beta"][1] + tcrit * m1["se"][1]))
x0 = np.array([1, 800.0]); yhat0 = x0 @ m1["beta"]; q = x0 @ m1["XtXi"] @
x0
print("prediction at 800 orders: %.1f min" % yhat0)
print("CI for the mean   : +/- %.1f" % (tcrit * m1["s"] * np.sqrt(q)))
print("prediction interval: +/- %.1f" % (tcrit * m1["s"] * np.sqrt(1 +
q)))
```

```
term              coef       se       t         p
intercept      78.1250   3.7600   20.78    0.0000
orders          0.1564   0.0061   25.71    0.0000
R2=0.7695 adjR2=0.7684 F=661.2 (p=5.07e-65) resid SE=23.65 n=200
95% CI slope: (0.1444, 0.1684)
prediction at 800 orders: 203.3 min
CI for the mean   : +/- 4.4
prediction interval: +/- 46.8
```

The picture

```
# plot
import matplotlib.pyplot as plt
fig, ax = plt.subplots(figsize=(6.2, 3.8))
ax.scatter(orders, dmin, s=10, alpha=.6, color="#1f77b4", label="days")
xs = np.linspace(100, 1000, 100)
Xs = np.column_stack([np.ones(100), xs]); ys = Xs @ m1["beta"]
sem = m1["s"] * np.sqrt(np.einsum("ij,jk,ik->i", Xs, m1["XtXi"], Xs))
sep = m1["s"] * np.sqrt(1 + np.einsum("ij,jk,ik->i", Xs, m1["XtXi"], Xs))
ax.plot(xs, ys, color="k", label="OLS line")
ax.fill_between(xs, ys - tcrit * sem, ys + tcrit * sem, color="#d62728",
alpha=.5, label="95% CI of mean")
ax.fill_between(xs, ys - tcrit * sep, ys + tcrit * sep, color="gray",
alpha=.2, label="95% prediction interval")
ax.set_xlabel("orders waiting"); ax.set_ylabel("delivery time (min)");
ax.legend(fontsize=7)
plt.tight_layout(); plt.savefig(f"{IMG}/ch06_fit.png", dpi=120);
plt.close()
```

Scatter of delivery time against orders with the OLS line, a narrow red band for the confidence interval of the mean and a wide grey band for the prediction interval

How to read it: each blue dot is one delivery day. The black line is the OLS fit. The narrow red band is the confidence interval for the *average* delivery time at each order level; it is narrowest in the middle of the data (where we know most) and fans out at the edges. The wide grey band is the prediction interval for a *single new run*; about 95 percent of dots fall inside it.

Connection to the real job

Regression is the first model to try for any numeric target: capacity forecasts, cost models, sales

drivers. The coefficient is an effect size in natural units (min per order), which is why regression is the workhorse of analytics reporting.

Applications

- **Operations:** delivery time vs order volume, capacity forecasts.
- **Data Analytics:** driver analysis ("what moves revenue?").
- **Machine Learning:** baseline model and the starting point for GLMs and neural nets.
- **Finance and economics:** beta of a stock, demand curves.

COMMON MISTAKE

Treating R^2 as "model quality". A high R^2 can come from a trend or from overfitting; a low R^2 can still hold a useful, significant slope. R^2 says nothing about whether the assumptions hold or the model is causal.

Check yourself

1. The slope is 0.15 min/order. What is the predicted change for 100 more orders? Answer: 15 min.
2. Which interval is wider: CI for the mean or prediction interval? Answer: The prediction interval.
3. What does $X^Te = 0$ mean geometrically? Answer: The residual vector is perpendicular to the space spanned by the predictors.

6.2 Multiple Regression: Coefficients, t-tests, the F-test, R^2 and Adjusted R^2

INTUITION

In real systems delivery time depends on several things at once. Multiple regression gives each factor its own coefficient that means "the effect of this factor *holding the others fixed*". It is like asking, "compare two deliveries that have the same distance and the same express status but differ by 100 orders". That "holding fixed" is the big idea, and it is also why the coefficient can change when you add or remove other variables.

Words you need

Word	Plain meaning	Example
Partial effect	Effect of one predictor with the others held constant	min per order, at fixed distance
Dummy (indicator) variable	0/1 column for a category	express = 1
Adjusted R^2	R^2 penalised for the number of predictors	
F-test (overall)	H_0: all slopes are zero	
t-test on a coefficient	H_0: this slope is zero, others kept in the model	
Degrees of freedom	n − p, with p the number of coefficients	196

The formulas

- Same OLS as before, $\hat{\beta} = (X^TX)^{-1}X^Ty$, with more columns in X.
- $t_j = \hat{\beta}_j / SE(\hat{\beta}_j)$ with n − p df.
- Overall F: $F = [(SST - SSE)/(p - 1)] / [SSE/(n - p)]$.
- $Adjusted\ R^2 = 1 - (1 - R^2)(n - 1)/(n - p)$. Plain R^2 never decreases when you add a variable (even a useless one); adjusted R^2 can.
- **Nested model F-test**: to compare a smaller model with a larger one: $F = [(SSE_small - SSE_big)/q] / [SSE_big/(n - p_big)]$, where q is the number of extra variables.
- Interpretation of transformed variables: in $log(y) = \beta_0 + \beta_1 x$, one unit of x changes y by about $100 \cdot \beta_1$ percent (when β_1 is small). In $log(y) = \beta_0 + \beta_1\ log(x)$, β_1 is an **elasticity**: a 1 percent change in x gives a β_1 percent change in y.

Item	Example value	Where it appears in the job
Coefficient for distance	0.8 min per km	Which factor matters most
Dummy for express courier	−40 min	Effect of a categorical factor
Adjusted R^2	0.90	Compare models of different size

Problem 6.2.1 (three predictors) Simulate 200 days. Delivery time = 80 + 0.15 × orders + 0.8 × distance_km − 40 × express + noise (SD 25). Fit the model, read the table, check the overall F-test and compare R^2 with adjusted R^2. Then add a pure-noise column and see what happens to R^2 and adjusted R^2.

Formula	$\hat{\beta} = (X^TX)^{-1}X^Ty$; adj $R^2 = 1 - (1-R^2)(n-1)/(n-p)$
Plug in	n = 200, p = 4 (intercept + 3 predictors), then p = 5 with the noise column
Compute	The code prints both tables.
Answer	Estimated coefficients are close to the truth: orders 0.138 (true 0.15), distance 0.75 (true 0.8), express −43.1 min (true −40). The overall F-test is overwhelming (F = 241.7). Adding a pure-noise column raises R^2 from 0.7872 to 0.7904 (as it always does). Here adjusted R^2 also rose slightly (0.7840 to 0.7861) because the noise column happened to get t = 1.73: adjusted R^2 rises whenever $\|t\| > 1$, and a pure-noise column reaches $\|t\| > 1$ about one time in three. Its p-value (0.086) is not significant. So adjusted R^2 is a gentle penalty, not a strict test; the t-test or AIC (Chapter 7) is stricter.
Check	True values are known, so compare. Each estimate should be within about 2 standard errors of the truth: orders is 1.9 SE below, distance 0.5 SE, express 0.9 SE away.
Why it matters	The coefficient on express ("−40 min") is the clean estimate of the benefit of the express courier option holding order volume and distance fixed, which is the number the operations team wants.

```
rng = np.random.default_rng(61)
n = 200
orders = rng.uniform(100, 1000, n)
distance = rng.lognormal(3.0, 0.6, n)                    # km
express = rng.binomial(1, 0.6, n)
dmin = 80 + 0.15 * orders + 0.8 * distance - 40 * express + rng.normal(0,
25, n)
X3 = np.column_stack([np.ones(n), orders, distance, express])
m3 = ols(X3, dmin, ["intercept", "orders", "distance_km", "express"])
show(m3)
junk = rng.normal(size=n)
m4 = ols(np.column_stack([X3, junk]), dmin, ["intercept", "orders",
"distance_km", "express", "noise_col"])
print("--- adding a pure-noise column ---")
show(m4)
print("R2 %.5f -> %.5f   adjR2 %.5f -> %.5f" % (m3["r2"], m4["r2"],
m3["adj"], m4["adj"]))
```

```
term              coef       se       t         p
intercept      88.5149   5.1144   17.31    0.0000
orders          0.1381   0.0063   21.74    0.0000
distance_km     0.7505   0.0930    8.07    0.0000
express       -43.0774   3.5524  -12.13    0.0000
R2=0.7872 adjR2=0.7840 F=241.7 (p=1.36e-65) resid SE=24.56 n=200
--- adding a pure-noise column ---
term              coef       se       t         p
intercept      88.9722   5.0956   17.46    0.0000
orders          0.1377   0.0063   21.78    0.0000
distance_km     0.7414   0.0927    8.00    0.0000
express       -43.1175   3.5347  -12.20    0.0000
noise_col       2.8642   1.6584    1.73    0.0857
R2=0.7904 adjR2=0.7861 F=183.9 (p=5.26e-65) resid SE=24.44 n=200
R2 0.78723 -> 0.79044   adjR2 0.78397 -> 0.78614
```

Problem 6.2.2 (nested F-test and log interpretation) (a) Test whether `distance_km` and `express` together add anything beyond `orders` alone using the nested F-test. (b) Fit log(delivery time) on log(orders) and interpret the elasticity.

Formula	F = [(SSE_small − SSE_big)/q] / [SSE_big/(n − p_big)]
Plug in	small model: intercept + orders (p = 2). Big model: p = 4, so q = 2 extra variables.
Compute	Use the SSE values from the fits.
Answer	(a) F(2, 196) = 108.8 with p = 1.7e-32: distance and express matter jointly. (b) The elasticity is 0.451 (SE 0.034): a 1 percent increase in orders raises delivery time by about 0.45 percent, less than proportionally because delivery time has a fixed base of about 80 min.
Check	Our F-test should equal the square of the t-statistic when q = 1. We verify this with a one-variable comparison.
Why it matters	The nested F-test is the right tool to ask "does this *group* of variables help?". Elasticities are ideal for scaling arguments such as "double the orders, how much slower?".

```
m_small = ols(np.column_stack([np.ones(n), orders]), dmin, ["i",
"orders"])
q = 2
F = ((m_small["sse"] - m3["sse"]) / q) / (m3["sse"] / (n - 4))
print("nested F(%d,%d) = %.1f  p = %.2e" % (q, n - 4, F, stats.f.sf(F, q,
n - 4)))
m_cache = ols(np.column_stack([np.ones(n), orders, distance]), dmin, ["i",
"u", "p"])
F1 = ((m_cache["sse"] - m3["sse"]) / 1) / (m3["sse"] / (n - 4))
print("one-variable check: F=%.2f  t^2=%.2f" % (F1, m3["t"][3] ** 2))
ml = ols(np.column_stack([np.ones(n), np.log(orders)]), np.log(dmin),
["i", "log_users"])
print("elasticity of delivery time w.r.t. orders: %.3f  (se %.3f)" %
(ml["beta"][1], ml["se"][1]))
```

```
nested F(2,196) = 108.8  p = 1.65e-32
one-variable check: F=147.05  t^2=147.05
elasticity of delivery time w.r.t. orders: 0.451  (se 0.034)
```

The picture

```
        delivery time
          ^
  (express=0)|   . . ./ .      <- same slope on orders,
          |    . ./ .          two parallel lines
  (express=1)|  . ./ .  .      <- shifted down by 40 min
          +---------------> orders
```

A dummy variable moves the whole line up or down without changing the slope. (To let the slope differ, add an interaction `orders × express`.)

Connection to the real job

This is the "driver analysis" at the centre of many analytics projects. In an interview you will be asked to interpret a coefficient table, to explain "holding other variables constant", and to say why adjusted R^2 or a nested F-test is used.

Applications

- **Data Analytics:** driver models for conversion, revenue, churn (as a linear probability baseline).
- **Operations:** which factors (vans, distance, express option) explain delivery time.
- **Machine Learning:** feature screening and a linear baseline.
- **Economics:** wage equations, price elasticities.

COMMON MISTAKE

Reading a coefficient without "holding the others fixed", or comparing raw coefficients of variables on different scales (0.15 min per order vs 40 min for a dummy). To compare importance, standardise predictors (subtract the mean, divide by SD) or look at effect sizes in realistic ranges.

Check yourself

1. A model has $R^2 = 0.80$ and a new variable raises it to 0.801. Does that prove the variable helps? Answer: No. R^2 always rises; check adjusted R^2 or an F-test.
2. In log(y) = 2 + 0.03x, what is the effect of one more x? Answer: About a 3 percent increase in y.
3. What does the overall F-test test? Answer: Whether all slopes are zero.

6.3 The Assumptions, and How to Check Them

INTUITION

OLS gives you numbers even for nonsense data. A calculator also gives you a division even when the question is silly. The assumptions tell you when the numbers can be trusted. The check is mostly looking at the leftovers (residuals): if the model captured everything systematic, the leftovers should look like pure random noise with no pattern. A pattern in the residuals is the model telling you what it missed.

The assumptions (the "LINE" mnemonic, plus no collinearity)

1. **L**inearity: the mean of y is a straight-line function of the predictors. *Check:* residuals vs fitted values should show no curve. *Fix:* transform, add squared terms, or use splines.
2. **I**ndependence: errors are unrelated to each other. *Check:* Durbin-Watson (values near 2 are fine), or an autocorrelation plot for time-ordered data. *Fix:* time-series models (Chapter 10), clustered or mixed models (Chapter 11).
3. **N**ormality of errors: needed for exact t and F tests in small samples. *Check:* Q-Q plot, Shapiro-Wilk on residuals. With large n, the CLT protects you; normality is the *least* important assumption.
4. **E**qual variance (homoscedasticity): the spread of errors is constant. *Check:* residuals vs fitted should show a band, not a funnel; Breusch-Pagan test. *Fix:* log transform, weighted least squares, or **robust (HC3) standard errors**.
5. **No perfect collinearity** (Section 6.4).

What breaks when assumptions fail: non-linearity biases the *estimates*. Dependence and unequal variance leave the estimates unbiased but make the *standard errors, p-values and intervals wrong*.

Tests we compute by hand

- **Breusch-Pagan**: regress e^2 on the predictors; $LM = n \times R^2_{aux}$ follows χ^2 with (number of predictors) df under H_0 of equal variance.
- **Durbin-Watson**: $DW = \Sigma(e_t - e_{t-1})^2 \,/\, \Sigma e_t^2$; about 2 means no autocorrelation, below 1.5 suggests positive autocorrelation.
- **HC3 robust SE**: $\mathrm{Var}(\hat{\beta}) = (X^TX)^{-1}\, X^T\, \mathrm{diag}(e_i^2/(1-h_i)^2)\, X\, (X^TX)^{-1}$, which does not assume equal variance.

Item	Example value	Where it appears in the job
Residual vs fitted plot	Funnel shape	Delivery time noise grows with load
Breusch-Pagan	LM = 60, p ≈ 0	Formal check for the funnel
Durbin-Watson	0.6	Back-to-back delivery days are correlated

Problem 6.3.1 (heteroscedasticity and robust errors) Delivery time noise grows with load: SD = 0.05 × orders. Fit OLS of delivery time on orders. Run the Breusch-Pagan test, and compare the ordinary SE of the slope with the HC3 robust SE. Then fix the problem by regressing log(delivery time) on log(orders) and re-test.

Formula	BP: LM = $n \cdot R^2$ from regressing e^2 on x; ~ $\chi^2(1)$ under H_0. HC3 as above.
Plug in	n = 300, true slope 0.15, true noise SD = 0.05 × orders (between 5 and 50 min)
Compute	Run the code.
Answer	The BP test rejects equal variance (p near 0). The slope is 0.149 (true 0.15), so it is still unbiased. The naive SE is 0.0070 and the HC3 SE is 0.0066: here they are close, because the funnel is moderate; with a stronger funnel the two can differ by a factor of two or more, and the robust one is the honest one. Working in logs reduces the funnel (the BP statistic falls from 47.3 to 13.0) but does not remove it entirely (p = 0.0003), because the noise in this simulation is not exactly proportional to the mean.
Check	The slope estimate should be close to the truth 0.15 in all versions. Only its uncertainty changes.
Why it matters	If you report a naive p-value with a funnel in the residuals, your stated confidence is wrong. Robust errors are cheap insurance, and many practitioners use them by default.

```
rng = np.random.default_rng(62)
n = 300
u = rng.uniform(100, 1000, n)
y_h = 80 + 0.15 * u + rng.normal(0, 1, n) * 0.05 * u
Xh = np.column_stack([np.ones(n), u]); mh = ols(Xh, y_h, ["intercept",
"orders"])
e2 = mh["resid"] ** 2
aux = ols(Xh, e2, ["i", "u"])
LM = n * aux["r2"]
print("Breusch-Pagan: LM = %.1f  p = %.2e" % (LM, stats.chi2.sf(LM, 1)))
def hc3(m, X):
    X = np.asarray(X, float)
    meat = X.T @ (X * (m["resid"] ** 2 / (1 - m["h"]) ** 2)[:, None])
    return np.sqrt(np.diag(m["XtXi"] @ meat @ m["XtXi"]))
print("slope %.4f   naive SE %.4f   HC3 SE %.4f" % (mh["beta"][1],
mh["se"][1], hc3(mh, Xh)[1]))
ml = ols(np.column_stack([np.ones(n), np.log(u)]), np.log(np.maximum(y_h,
1)), ["i", "log_u"])
aux2 = ols(np.column_stack([np.ones(n), np.log(u)]), ml["resid"] ** 2,
["i", "x"])
print("after log-log: BP LM = %.1f  p = %.1e" % (n * aux2["r2"],
stats.chi2.sf(n * aux2["r2"], 1)))
```

```
Breusch-Pagan: LM = 47.3  p = 6.23e-12
slope 0.1491   naive SE 0.0070   HC3 SE 0.0066
after log-log: BP LM = 13.0  p = 3.2e-04
```

Problem 6.3.2 (non-linearity, autocorrelation and normality) (a) Generate delivery time that follows a *curve* (quadratic in orders), fit a straight line, and see the curved residual pattern through a correlation of residuals with orders². (b) Generate time-ordered delivery days whose noise carries over from one run to the next (AR(1) noise with coefficient 0.8), and compute Durbin-Watson. (c) Check normality of the residuals from the correct model with Shapiro-Wilk.

Formula	$DW = \Sigma(e_t - e_{t_{-1}})^2 / \Sigma e_t^2$
Plug in	(a) delivery time = 100 + 0.0004 × orders² + noise; (b) noise $e_t = 0.8\ e_{t_{-1}}$ + innovation
Compute	Run the code.
Answer	(a) Residuals from the straight line correlate at 0.83 with the centred squared term: the line misses the bend (although its R^2 of 0.938 still looks high!). Adding orders² brings the correlation to 0.00 and R^2 to 0.982. (b) Durbin-Watson is 0.51 for the AR(1) noise (strong positive autocorrelation) and 1.79 for independent noise. (c) Residuals of the correct model pass Shapiro-Wilk (p = 0.585).
Check	For AR(1) noise the theoretical DW is about 2(1 − 0.8) = 0.4; the sample value 0.51 is in that area. Also note the lesson in (a): a high R^2 (0.938) coexisted with a clearly wrong shape.
Why it matters	Days that follow each other share state (a backlog carried over from yesterday, tired drivers), so their errors are correlated. The standard errors you compute under "independence" are then too small. The fix is time-series modelling or averaging per week.

```
rng = np.random.default_rng(63)
n = 200
u = np.sort(rng.uniform(100, 1000, n))
y_c = 100 + 0.0004 * u**2 + rng.normal(0, 15, n)
mline = ols(np.column_stack([np.ones(n), u]), y_c, ["i", "u"])
mquad = ols(np.column_stack([np.ones(n), u, u**2]), y_c, ["i", "u", "u2"])
uc2 = (u - u.mean()) ** 2     # centred square: the 'bend' term
print("line R2 %.3f; corr(resid_line, centred u^2) = %.3f" % (mline["r2"],
np.corrcoef(mline["resid"], uc2)[0, 1]))
print("quad R2 %.3f; corr(resid_quad, centred u^2) = %.3f; coef on u^2 =
%.6f" % (mquad["r2"], np.corrcoef(mquad["resid"], uc2)[0, 1],
mquad["beta"][2]))
print("Shapiro-Wilk on quadratic-model residuals: p = %.3f" %
stats.shapiro(mquad["resid"]).pvalue)
# AR(1) noise
innov = rng.normal(0, 10, n); noise = np.zeros(n)
for t in range(1, n): noise[t] = 0.8 * noise[t - 1] + innov[t]
days = np.arange(n, dtype=float)
y_a = 50 + 0.2 * days + noise
ma = ols(np.column_stack([np.ones(n), days]), y_a, ["i", "day"])
dw = np.sum(np.diff(ma["resid"]) ** 2) / np.sum(ma["resid"] ** 2)
iid = ols(np.column_stack([np.ones(n), days]), 50 + 0.2 * days +
rng.normal(0, 17, n), ["i", "day"])
print("Durbin-Watson, AR(1) noise: %.2f   independent noise: %.2f" % (dw,
np.sum(np.diff(iid["resid"]) ** 2) / np.sum(iid["resid"] ** 2)))
```

```
line R2 0.938; corr(resid_line, centred u^2) = 0.832
quad R2 0.982; corr(resid_quad, centred u^2) = -0.000; coef on u^2 =
0.000396
Shapiro-Wilk on quadratic-model residuals: p = 0.585
Durbin-Watson, AR(1) noise: 0.51   independent noise: 1.79
```

The picture

```
# plot
fig, ax = plt.subplots(1, 3, figsize=(10, 3.2))
ax[0].scatter(mquad["fitted"], mquad["resid"], s=8, color="#2ca02c");
ax[0].axhline(0, color="k"); ax[0].set_title("Good: random band")
ax[1].scatter(mh["fitted"], mh["resid"], s=8, color="#d62728");
ax[1].axhline(0, color="k"); ax[1].set_title("Funnel: unequal variance")
ax[2].scatter(mline["fitted"], mline["resid"], s=8, color="#1f77b4");
ax[2].axhline(0, color="k"); ax[2].set_title("Curve: missed non-
linearity")
for a_ in ax: a_.set_xlabel("fitted value"); a_.set_ylabel("residual")
plt.tight_layout(); plt.savefig(f"{IMG}/ch06_residuals.png", dpi=120);
plt.close()
```


Three residual-versus-fitted plots: a healthy random band, a funnel showing unequal variance, and a U-shaped curve showing missed non-linearity

How to read it: the x-axis is the model's fitted value and the y-axis is the residual (what the model missed). Left (green): a flat, even cloud around zero is what you want. Middle (red): the cloud widens to the right like a funnel, so errors grow with the fitted value (heteroscedasticity). Right (blue): residuals curve down, then up, then down, which means a straight line is the wrong shape.

Connection to the real job

Residual plots are the first thing a reviewer asks for. In operations data, funnels (noise grows with the number of orders) and autocorrelation (days share state) are the usual violations. Diagnosing them before reporting is a mark of professional work.

Applications

- **Data Science:** model validation and model-risk review.
- **Operations:** trustworthy capacity models.
- **Economics / econometrics:** robust (HC) and clustered standard errors are standard practice.
- **Machine Learning:** residual analysis shows where a model fails and which features are missing.

COMMON MISTAKE

Testing normality of the raw *y* instead of the *residuals*, and treating a Shapiro-Wilk rejection with n = 5,000 as a disaster. Normality of errors matters least. Linearity and equal variance matter more, and independence matters most for correct p-values.

Check yourself

1. A funnel in the residual plot signals which problem? Answer: Unequal variance (heteroscedasticity).
2. Which assumption, when broken, biases the coefficients themselves? Answer: Linearity (mis-specification).
3. Durbin-Watson near 0.4 means what? Answer: Strong positive autocorrelation.

6.4 Multicollinearity and the Variance Inflation Factor (VIF)

INTUITION

Suppose the number of vans and number of orders move almost together. If delivery time goes up, was it the orders or the vans? The data cannot tell, because they never vary separately. The regression can still *predict* well, but the individual coefficients become unstable, with huge standard errors and signs that flip when you change a few rows. This is **multicollinearity**: predictors that are nearly copies of each other.

Words you need

Word	Plain meaning	Example
Collinear	One predictor is (nearly) a combination of others	vans ≈ 0.05 × orders
VIF_j	1 / (1 − R²_j), where R²_j is from regressing predictor j on the other predictors	VIF 10 means SE is 3.2× larger
Condition number	Large value of X^TX stretch; warns about numerical trouble	

The rules

- `VIF_j = 1 / (1 − R²_j)`. The variance of β̂_j is inflated by exactly this factor compared with the case of uncorrelated predictors; the SE is inflated by `√VIF`.
- Rule of thumb: VIF above 5 is a concern, above 10 is serious.
- Collinearity does **not** hurt predictions inside the range of the data, only the interpretation of the individual coefficients.
- Fixes: drop or combine variables, use domain knowledge (keep orders, drop vans), centre variables for polynomial terms, use ridge regression (Chapter 7) or PCA.

Item	Example value	Where it appears in the job
VIF of vans	25	vans and orders measure the same load
SE inflation	√25 = 5	A significant coefficient becomes insignificant
Ridge regression	Shrinks coefficients	Stable prediction with correlated features

Problem 6.4.1 (VIF by hand, and the damage) Using the earlier simulation, add `vans = 0.05 × orders + noise (SD 1)`. vans has no effect on delivery time of its own. Compute the VIF for each predictor by regressing it on the others, and compare the SE of the orders coefficient with and without vans in the model.

Formula	VIF_j = 1 / (1 − R²_j)
Plug in	For the orders column: regress orders on (intercept, distance, express, vans).
Compute	The code does each auxiliary regression.
Answer	vans and orders each have a VIF of about 159 (vans is almost an exact multiple of orders), while distance and express have VIF 1.0. The SE of the orders coefficient grows from 0.0069 to 0.0855, a factor of 12.5, which matches √159 = 12.6. The orders coefficient becomes 0.265 (true 0.15) and vans gets −2.25 with p = 0.19. R² barely changes (0.7590 to 0.7611).
Check	SE ratio ≈ √VIF_users. We print both to check.
Why it matters	If you reported "vans is not significant, so it does not matter", you would be misled: it is simply impossible to separate it from orders in this data.

```
rng = np.random.default_rng(64)
n = 200
orders = rng.uniform(100, 1000, n)
distance = rng.lognormal(3.0, 0.6, n); express = rng.binomial(1, 0.6, n)
dmin = 80 + 0.15 * orders + 0.8 * distance - 40 * express + rng.normal(0,
25, n)
vans = 0.05 * orders + rng.normal(0, 1, n)
Xa = np.column_stack([np.ones(n), orders, distance, express])
Xb = np.column_stack([np.ones(n), orders, distance, express, vans])
ma_ = ols(Xa, dmin, ["intercept", "orders", "distance", "express"]); mb_ =
ols(Xb, dmin, ["intercept", "orders", "distance", "express", "vans"])
show(mb_)
def vif(X, j):
    others = np.delete(X, j, axis=1)
    r2 = ols(others, X[:, j])["r2"] if True else 0
    return 1 / (1 - r2)
for j, nm in [(1, "orders"), (2, "distance"), (3, "express"), (4,
"vans")]:
    print("VIF %-8s = %8.1f" % (nm, vif(Xb, j)))
print("SE(orders) without vans: %.5f   with vans: %.5f   ratio %.1f
sqrt(VIF) %.1f" % (ma_["se"][1], mb_["se"][1], mb_["se"][1] / ma_["se"]
[1], np.sqrt(vif(Xb, 1))))
print("R2 without vans %.4f, with vans %.4f" % (ma_["r2"], mb_["r2"]))
```

```
term              coef       se        t         p
intercept      70.8093   6.0435   11.72    0.0000
orders          0.2647   0.0855    3.10    0.0022
distance        0.9445   0.1182    7.99    0.0000
express       -37.7678   3.6267  -10.41    0.0000
vans           -2.2543   1.7072   -1.32    0.1882
R2=0.7611 adjR2=0.7562 F=155.3 (p=1.77e-59) resid SE=24.22 n=200
VIF orders   =    158.9
VIF distance =      1.0
VIF express  =      1.0
VIF vans     =    158.7
SE(orders) without vans: 0.00685   with vans: 0.08546   ratio 12.5
sqrt(VIF) 12.6
R2 without vans 0.7590, with vans 0.7611
```

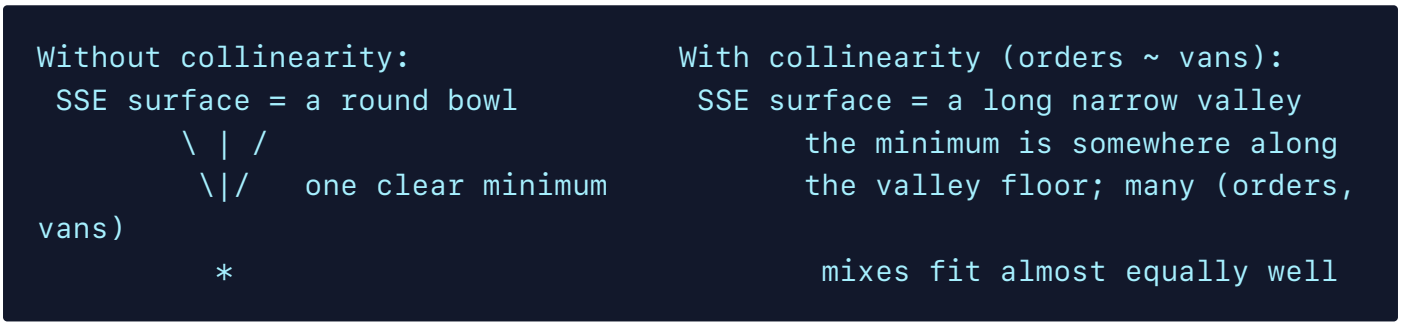
Problem 6.4.2 (instability) Draw 200 different samples from the model with vans included and record the coefficient of `orders`. Compare its spread with the model without vans.

Formula	spread = standard deviation of the estimates across repeated samples
Plug in	200 repeated datasets with the same design
Compute	Run both models on each dataset.
Answer	Without vans the orders coefficient is stable (SD 0.0069 across datasets). With vans its SD is 0.0936, about 13.6 times larger, and in 6 percent of the datasets the coefficient even has the wrong (negative) sign. The *predictions* are equally accurate in both (SD 2.34 min).
Check	The mean of the orders coefficient across datasets is near 0.15 in both versions (unbiased), only the spread differs.
Why it matters	This shows the real cost of collinearity: unstable, untrustworthy individual coefficients, even though the overall model fits fine.

```
est_a, est_b, pred_a, pred_b = [], [], [], []
for _ in range(200):
    u = rng.uniform(100, 1000, n); pl = rng.lognormal(3.0, 0.6, n); ca =
rng.binomial(1, 0.6, n)
    y_ = 80 + 0.15 * u + 0.8 * pl - 40 * ca + rng.normal(0, 25, n); cp =
0.05 * u + rng.normal(0, 1, n)
    A = np.column_stack([np.ones(n), u, pl, ca]); B = np.column_stack([A,
cp])
    ba = np.linalg.lstsq(A, y_, rcond=None)[0]; bb = np.linalg.lstsq(B,
y_, rcond=None)[0]
    est_a.append(ba[1]); est_b.append(bb[1])
    pred_a.append(np.array([1, 500, 20, 1]) @ ba);
pred_b.append(np.array([1, 500, 20, 1, 25]) @ bb)
print("orders coef without vans: mean %.4f sd %.4f" % (np.mean(est_a),
np.std(est_a)))
print("orders coef with vans   : mean %.4f sd %.4f  share negative: %.2f"
% (np.mean(est_b), np.std(est_b), np.mean(np.array(est_b) < 0)))
print("prediction at a typical point: sd without %.2f, with %.2f" %
(np.std(pred_a), np.std(pred_b)))
```

```
orders coef without vans: mean 0.1495 sd 0.0069
orders coef with vans   : mean 0.1601 sd 0.0936  share negative: 0.06
prediction at a typical point: sd without 2.34, with 2.34
```

The picture



Think of finding the lowest point in a long flat valley: a small change in the data moves the answer a long way along the valley floor.

Connection to the real job

Operational features (vans on the road, orders per hour, staff on shift) are almost always collinear. Before interpreting a coefficient, compute VIFs; before using regression for "what drives delivery time", decide which of the correlated variables you can defend. For pure prediction, collinearity is less of a problem, but regularisation (Chapter 7) helps.

Applications

- **Data Science:** feature selection, checking regression assumptions.
- **Marketing analytics:** correlated ad channels make attribution hard.
- **Economics:** correlated macro variables.
- **Machine Learning:** why ridge regression exists.

COMMON MISTAKE

Dropping a collinear variable because "it is not significant" and then concluding it has no effect. It may be a strong driver that simply shares its information with another variable. Decide using domain knowledge.

Check yourself

1. VIF = 16. By what factor is the SE inflated? Answer: $\sqrt{16} = 4$.
2. Does collinearity bias the coefficients? Answer: No, it makes them unstable (large SE).
3. Does collinearity ruin predictions within the data range? Answer: No.

6.5 Leverage, Influential Points and Cook's Distance

INTUITION

On a seesaw, a child sitting at the far end has much more influence on the tilt than one sitting in the middle. In regression, a point far from the other x-values has high **leverage**: the line is easily pulled toward it. If such a point also lies off the pattern, it is **influential**: removing it changes the fit a lot. **Cook's distance** measures this: how much all fitted values move if you delete that one point.

Words you need

Word	Plain meaning	Example
Leverage h_i	How unusual the x-values of point i are (diagonal of the hat matrix, between 0 and 1)	A day with 5,000 orders when others have ≤ 1,000
Outlier	Point with a big residual	A day that was 200 min slower than predicted
Influential point	Removing it changes the fit a lot	High leverage and a big residual
Studentised residual	Residual scaled by its own SE	About ±3 or more is unusual
Cook's distance D_i	$e_i^2\, h_i \,/\, (p\, s^2\, (1-h_i)^2)$	Above 4/n is worth a look; above 1 is serious

The rules

- Average leverage = p / n. A point with $h_i > 2p/n$ has high leverage.
- High leverage plus a large residual means an influential point.
- Never delete a point just because it is influential. Investigate: is it a data error (fix it), a different kind of unit (model it separately) or real (keep it and report the sensitivity)?

Item	Example value	Where it appears in the job
Leverage	0.83	A once-off 5,000-order holiday-sale day among normal days
Cook's D	2.4	One day drives the whole slope

Rule 4/n	0.02 for n = 200	Screening threshold

Problem 6.5.1 (one point that bends the line) Take the 200 days of delivery time vs orders (orders from 100 to 1,000, true slope 0.15). Add one holiday-sale day: 5,000 orders with a delivery time of 300 min (the "model" says 80 + 0.15 × 5,000 = 830 min, so this run is much faster than predicted, perhaps because it hit a different code path). Fit with and without this point. Compute its leverage and Cook's distance.

Formula	$h_i = x_i^T(X^TX)^{-1}x_i$; $D_i = e_i^2\, h_i / (p\, s^2\, (1 - h_i)^2)$
Plug in	p = 2, n = 201
Compute	The code compares the two fits and lists the top Cook's distances.
Answer	The extra point has leverage 0.602 (huge compared with the average 2/201 = 0.01) and a Cook's distance of 74.2, while the next largest is 0.031. It drags the slope from 0.156 down to 0.081. Without it the model recovers the truth (0.15).
Check	The average of all leverages must equal p/n = 2/201 = 0.00995. The code prints it.
Why it matters	One strange day can reverse your planning conclusions. Always list the top few Cook's distances before reporting.

```
rng = np.random.default_rng(65)
n = 200
u = rng.uniform(100, 1000, n); y_ = 80 + 0.15 * u + rng.normal(0, 25, n)
u2 = np.append(u, 5000.0); y2 = np.append(y_, 300.0)
mA = ols(np.column_stack([np.ones(n), u]), y_, ["i", "u"])
mB = ols(np.column_stack([np.ones(n + 1), u2]), y2, ["i", "u"])
print("slope without the holiday-sale day: %.4f   with: %.4f" %
(mA["beta"][1], mB["beta"][1]))
i = n
print("holiday-sale day: leverage %.3f   Cook's D %.2f   residual %.1f" %
(mB["h"][i], mB["cooks"][i], mB["resid"][i]))
print("mean leverage %.5f  (p/n = %.5f)   points with h > 2p/n: %d" %
(mB["h"].mean(), 2 / (n + 1), (mB["h"] > 4 / (n + 1)).sum()))
top = np.argsort(mB["cooks"])[::-1][:3]
print("top 3 Cook's D:", [(int(j), round(float(mB["cooks"][j]), 3)) for j
in top], "  4/n =", round(4 / (n + 1), 4))
```

```
slope without the holiday-sale day: 0.1564   with: 0.0813
holiday-sale day: leverage 0.602   Cook's D 74.21   residual -221.7
mean leverage 0.00995  (p/n = 0.00995)   points with h > 2p/n: 1
top 3 Cook's D: [(200, 74.206), (34, 0.031), (183, 0.029)]   4/n = 0.0199
```

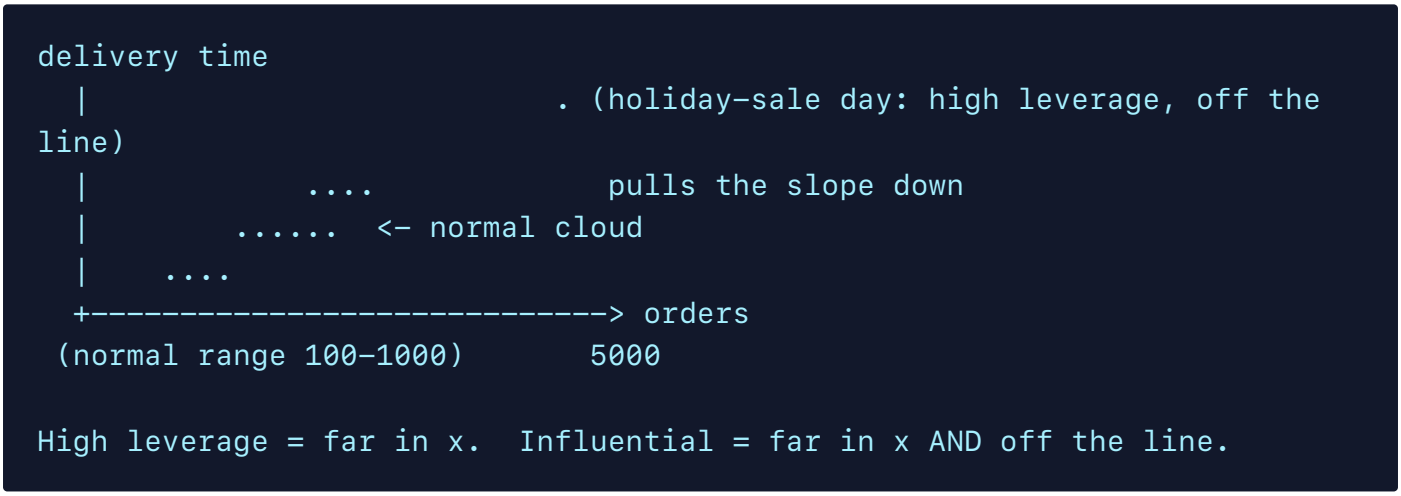
Problem 6.5.2 (an outlier that is not influential) Add a day with 550 orders (the middle of the range) and a delivery time 150 min above the line. Compare its leverage and Cook's distance with the holiday-sale day above.

Formula	Same as above.
Plug in	x = 550 (near the mean of x, so low leverage); residual of about +150.
Compute	Run the code.
Answer	The residual is huge (150 min, about 5.5 standard deviations) but the leverage is tiny (0.005), so the Cook's distance is only 0.075 and the slope barely moves (0.1564 to 0.1565). Large residual alone is not enough; you need leverage too.
Check	Slope with and without the point should differ by a tiny amount.
Why it matters	Outliers and influential points are different things. A middle outlier shifts the intercept slightly; an extreme-x point can swing the slope.

```
u3 = np.append(u, 550.0); y3 = np.append(y_, 80 + 0.15 * 550 + 150)
mC = ols(np.column_stack([np.ones(n + 1), u3]), y3, ["i", "u"])
print("slope without: %.4f  with the middle outlier: %.4f" % (mA["beta"]
[1], mC["beta"][1]))
print("middle outlier: leverage %.4f  Cook's D %.3f  residual %.1f  (s =
%.1f)" % (mC["h"][n], mC["cooks"][n], mC["resid"][n], mC["s"]))
```

```
slope without: 0.1564  with the middle outlier: 0.1565
middle outlier: leverage 0.0050  Cook's D 0.075  residual 150.3  (s =
27.5)
```

The picture



Connection to the real job

Bad rows in operational data (a cancelled order logged with a delivery time of 0, a unit mistake) are typically high-influence points. In ML, the same idea underlies robust regression and outlier handling.

Applications

- **Data Science:** model validation, data cleaning.
- **Operations:** finding bad delivery days.
- **Finance:** extreme days affecting a fitted beta.
- **Machine Learning:** influence functions, robust losses (Huber).

COMMON MISTAKE

Deleting the points that "spoil" the model fit, then reporting the improved fit. That is cherry-picking. Investigate each influential point and report results with and without it.

Check yourself

1. Average leverage with p = 4 and n = 100? Answer: p/n = 0.04.
2. Which point is more influential: high leverage with a small residual, or low leverage with a large residual? Answer: Neither alone is very influential; the combination is what hurts. A high-leverage point with a small residual follows the line and doesn't change it much.
3. A common screening rule for Cook's D? Answer: Look at points with D above 4/n, and be concerned above 1.

6.6 Interpreting Regression Honestly: Causation, Extrapolation and Omitted Variables

INTUITION

A regression describes how y *differs* between units with different x. It does not say what would happen if you *changed* x for a particular unit. Ice-cream sales and drownings are correlated because of summer heat, not because ice cream drowns people. The coefficient answers "what pattern is in the data?" not "what happens if I intervene?".

Words you need

Word	Plain meaning	Example
Omitted variable bias	A missing predictor that is related to both x and y biases the coefficient on x	Leaving out distance
Extrapolation	Predicting outside the range of observed x	Predicting 5,000 orders from data up to 1,000
Association vs causation	Pattern vs effect of an intervention	

The omitted-variable formula

If the true model is $y = \beta_1 x_1 + \beta_2 x_2 + \varepsilon$ and you leave out x_2, then the slope on x_1 estimates $\beta_1 + \beta_2 \times \delta$, where δ is the slope of x_2 regressed on x_1. The bias is $\beta_2 \delta$.

Problem 6.6.1 (omitted variable bias) x_1 = marketing spend, x_2 = season index. True model: $y = 1 \cdot x_1 + 2 \cdot x_2$ + noise. The correlation between x_1 and x_2 is 0.7 (both are high in busy seasons). What slope on x_1 will you see if you forget x_2?

Formula	biased slope = $\beta_1 + \beta_2 \delta$, with δ = slope of x_2 on x_1
Plug in	$\beta_1 = 1$, $\beta_2 = 2$, $\delta = 0.7$ (both are standardised, SD = 1)
Compute	$1 + 2 \times 0.7 = 2.4$
Answer	You will see a slope of about 2.4 instead of the true 1.0: you would overestimate the effect of marketing by 140 percent.
Check	The simulation fits both models and compares: the full model gives about 1 and 2; the short model gives about 2.4.
Why it matters	Observational regression tells the truth about the *conditional pattern*, not about interventions. This is where randomised experiments (Chapter 12) come in.

```
rng = np.random.default_rng(66)
n = 100_000
x1 = rng.standard_normal(n); x2 = 0.7 * x1 + np.sqrt(1 - 0.49) *
rng.standard_normal(n)
y = 1.0 * x1 + 2.0 * x2 + rng.standard_normal(n)
full = np.linalg.lstsq(np.column_stack([np.ones(n), x1, x2]), y,
rcond=None)[0]
short = np.linalg.lstsq(np.column_stack([np.ones(n), x1]), y, rcond=None)
[0]
print("full model :", np.round(full, 3))
print("short model:", np.round(short, 3), " (theory for slope: 1 + 2*0.7 =
2.4)")
```

```
full model : [1.000e-03 9.970e-01 2.002e+00]
short model: [-0.007  2.394]  (theory for slope: 1 + 2*0.7 = 2.4)
```

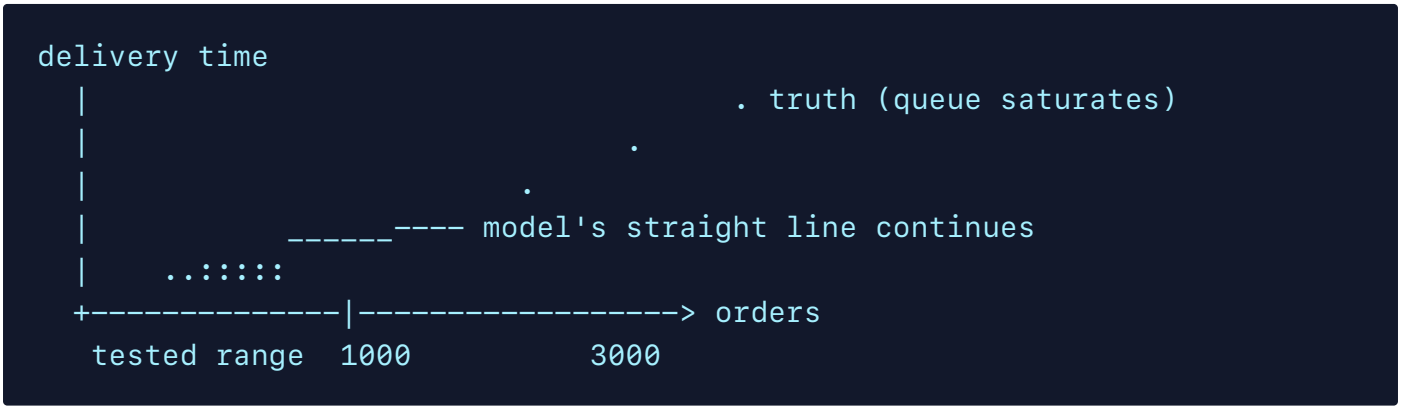
Problem 6.6.2 (extrapolation) The model was fitted on 100 to 1,000 orders. The real depot saturates: above 1,000 orders, delivery time grows much faster (we simulate a hockey-stick). What does the linear model predict at 3,000 orders versus the truth?

Formula	prediction = $\hat{\beta}_0 + \hat{\beta}_1 \times 3{,}000$
Plug in	True delivery time = 80 + 0.15 × orders for orders ≤ 1,000, and then grows with slope 0.9 per user above 1,000.
Compute	Fit a line to the observed range, then compare at 3,000.
Answer	The straight line predicts about 508 min at 3,000 orders. The true value is 80 + 150 + 0.9 × 2,000 = 2,030 min. The model is badly wrong, and the narrow prediction interval would give false comfort.
Check	The true curve at 3,000: 80 + 0.15 × 1,000 + 0.9 × 2,000 = 2,030. The model's confidence interval does not contain it.
Why it matters	In capacity planning for deliveries, the interesting regime is exactly the one you did not test. Never extrapolate a linear fit past the tested range, because queues saturate and curves bend.

```
rng = np.random.default_rng(67)
n = 200
u = rng.uniform(100, 1000, n); y_ = 80 + 0.15 * u + rng.normal(0, 25, n)
m = ols(np.column_stack([np.ones(n), u]), y_, ["i", "u"])
pred = m["beta"] @ np.array([1, 3000.0])
truth = 80 + 0.15 * 1000 + 0.9 * (3000 - 1000)
print("linear model prediction at 3000 orders: %.0f min   truth: %.0f min"
% (pred, truth))
```

```
linear model prediction at 3000 orders: 508 min   truth: 2030 min
```

The picture



Connection to the real job

In interviews, "what is the difference between prediction and causal inference?" and "what could go wrong with this regression?" are classic questions. In practice, always state the range of validity and whether the analysis is observational.

Applications

- **Data Analytics:** driver analysis with caution about confounding.
- **Operations:** capacity planning with queueing knowledge, not straight lines.
- **Economics:** causal inference methods (instrumental variables, DiD, Chapter 12).
- **Machine Learning:** distribution shift is extrapolation.

COMMON MISTAKE

Writing "increasing x by 1 causes y to rise by β" from observational data. Say "is associated with" unless the design supports causation.

The statsmodels version (not run here; the library is not installed in this environment)

```
# not run here
import statsmodels.api as sm
X = sm.add_constant(df[["orders", "distance_km", "express"]])
res = sm.OLS(df["delivery time"], X).fit()                    # classical SE
print(res.summary())                                      # coef, SE, t, p,
R2, adj R2, F, DW, Omnibus
res_robust = sm.OLS(df["delivery time"], X).fit(cov_type="HC3")
infl = res.get_influence(); print(infl.cooks_distance[0].max())
from statsmodels.stats.outliers_influence import variance_inflation_factor
print([variance_inflation_factor(X.values, i) for i in range(X.shape[1])])
```

Check yourself

1. Omitted variable bias needs the omitted variable to be related to which two things? Answer: To the response y and to the included predictor x.
2. Why is extrapolation dangerous? Answer: The relationship may change outside the observed range, and the intervals do not warn you.
3. A regression slope from observational data means what? Answer: An association after adjusting for the included variables, not necessarily a causal effect.

Chapter recap

- OLS minimises squared residuals; the solution is $\hat{\beta} = (X^TX)^{-1}X^Ty$, the projection of y onto the predictor space.
- Standard errors come from $s^2(X^TX)^{-1}$; t-tests check single coefficients, the F-test checks all slopes or groups of them.
- R^2 always rises with extra variables; use adjusted R^2 or a nested F-test to compare models.
- Coefficients mean "effect holding the others fixed"; log transforms give percent and elasticity interpretations.
- Check LINE: linearity, independence, normality (least important), equal variance; plot residuals against fitted values.
- Unequal variance or autocorrelation leave coefficients unbiased but make SEs wrong; use robust (HC3) errors or the right model.
- VIF = 1/(1 − R²_j); the SE grows by √VIF; collinearity makes coefficients unstable but not predictions.
- Leverage times a large residual gives influence; check Cook's distance (rule 4/n), investigate and never delete blindly.
- Regression shows association; omitted variables bias coefficients; never extrapolate beyond the data range.

Formula / pattern	Meaning
$\hat{\beta} = (X^TX)^{-1}X^Ty$ (`np.linalg.lstsq`)	OLS solution
$SE = \sqrt{(s^2 \cdot \mathrm{diag}((X^TX)^{-1}))}$, $s^2 = SSE/(n-p)$	Coefficient SEs
$adjR^2 = 1 - (1-R^2)(n-1)/(n-p)$	Adjusted R^2
$F = ((SSE_0 - SSE_1)/q)/(SSE_1/(n-p))$	Nested F-test
$VIF_j = 1/(1-R^2_j)$	Collinearity
$h = \mathrm{diag}(X(X^TX)^{-1}X^T)$, $D = e^2h/(p\, s^2(1-h)^2)$	Leverage, Cook's D
$LM = n\, R^2_{aux} \sim \chi^2$	Breusch-Pagan
$DW = \Sigma(\Delta e)^2/\Sigma e^2$	Durbin-Watson
`sm.OLS(y, X).fit(cov_type="HC3")`	statsmodels robust fit (not run here)

Practice set

Problem 6.7.1 Points (1, 3), (2, 5), (3, 7). What is the OLS line?

Answer: The points are exactly on y = 1 + 2x, so slope 2, intercept 1, $R^2 = 1$.

Problem 6.7.2 n = 50, SSE = 400, p = 3. What is s^2 and the residual SE?

Answer: $s^2 = 400 / 47 = 8.51$; s = 2.92.

Problem 6.7.3 What is the output? `print(round(1 - (1 - 0.64) * (100 - 1) / (100 - 5), 4))`

Answer: $1 - 0.36 \times 99/95 = 1 - 0.3751 = 0.6249$ (adjusted R^2).

Problem 6.7.4 A slope of 0.15 has SE 0.02 and n − p = 100. Roughly, is it significant at 5 percent? Give a 95 percent interval.

Answer: t = 7.5, so yes. Interval $0.15 \pm 1.98 \times 0.02 = (0.110, 0.190)$.

Problem 6.7.5 In log(y) = 3 + 0.04·x, what does an increase of 5 in x do to y?

Answer: About 5 × 4 = 20 percent more (exactly e^0.2 − 1 = 22.1 percent).

Problem 6.7.6 Find the bug: a developer fits delivery time on orders and vans (VIF 40 each) and writes "vans is not significant, remove it, so vans does not affect delivery time".

Answer: The non-significance is caused by collinearity (SE inflated by $\sqrt{40} \approx 6.3$). vans may well be a driver. Decide using domain knowledge or combine/replace the variables.

Problem 6.7.7 A model has n = 100, p = 5 and the average leverage threshold is 2p/n. Compute it. A point has h = 0.25. Is it high-leverage?

Answer: 2 × 5 / 100 = 0.10. Yes, 0.25 is above 0.10.

Problem 6.7.8 Scenario: the residual plot shows a funnel and the DW is 1.1. Name the problems and fixes.

Answer: Funnel: heteroscedasticity (log-transform, weighted least squares or HC3 errors). DW 1.1: positive autocorrelation (the errors are not independent; use a time-series model, include lagged terms, or use HAC/clustered errors).

Problem 6.7.9 (interview) "Explain what 'holding other variables constant' means in a multiple regression coefficient."

Answer: The coefficient is the average difference in y between two units that have the same values of all the other predictors in the model but differ by one unit in this predictor. It is computed by removing the part of x that the other variables explain (partial regression) and relating what is left to y.

Problem 6.7.10 (interview) "Your regression has $R^2 = 0.95$ on training data. Does that mean it's a good model?"

Answer: Not necessarily. Check out-of-sample performance (cross-validation), residual diagnostics, whether predictors are leaky or time-ordered, influential points and whether the model is used within the data range. R^2 also rises with every added variable, so use adjusted R^2 or validation.

Prompt pack

✨ AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI

```
You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional
moving into data roles, and English is my second language. Teach me
Chapter 6 topic "deriving ordinary least squares: the normal equations,
the geometry of projection, standard errors, and what the coefficient
table means". Work through a 5-point example by hand, then in NumPy. Ask
one check question after each step. End with 6 exercises and mark my
answers.
```

✨ AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI

```
You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional
moving into data roles. Teach me multiple regression interpretation:
partial effects, dummy variables, interaction terms, log transforms and
elasticities, adjusted R-squared and nested F-tests. Use a delivery time
model (orders, distance, express) as the running example. Give me 8 graded
exercises WITHOUT solutions and wait for my answers before correcting.
```

✨ AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI

```
You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional
moving into data roles. Explain regression diagnostics: the LINE
assumptions, residual plots, Q-Q plots, Breusch-Pagan, Durbin-Watson,
robust standard errors, VIF, leverage and Cook's distance. For each, show
how to check it in Python and what to do when it fails. Quiz me one
```

question at a time and stop after 8 questions.

✨ AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI

You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional moving into data roles. Review my regression analysis: [PASTE HERE]. Check the model specification, the interpretation of each coefficient, the diagnostics I ran or forgot, collinearity, influential points and any causal claims I made. Explain every problem in simple English and show me a better version of the write-up.

✨ AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI

You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional moving into data roles. Run a mock interview on linear regression for data science roles: assumptions, interpretation, multicollinearity, heteroscedasticity, influential points, omitted variable bias, extrapolation and R-squared. Ask one question at a time, wait for my answer, then give a score out of 10 and a model answer. Ask 8 questions.

CHAPTER 7

REGULARIZATION AND MODEL SELECTION

How to stop a model from memorising the past, and how to choose between models honestly.

You have 40 recently sold houses and 10 measurements per house (floor area, rooms, age of the roof, distance to the station, and so on). You fit a regression to predict the sale price. It looks wonderful on the 40 houses and then fails on the next batch of listings. This is **overfitting**: the model learned the noise, not the pattern. In this chapter you learn the two cures used every day in data work. The first is **regularization**, which gently punishes big coefficients (ridge, lasso, elastic net). The second is **model selection**, which gives honest scores to compare models (cross-validation, AIC, BIC). By the end you will fit all of them with plain NumPy, read the coefficient paths, and pick a penalty with cross-validation. We assume you know ordinary least squares (OLS) and the bias-variance idea from the earlier regression material. For the calculus of the loss function and the L1/L2 norms, see the Math PDF.

Running example: 40 training houses, 10 standardised features. Only the first 3 features truly matter (true effects 3, -2, 1.5). The other 7 are pure noise. The noise in the response has standard deviation 3, so the best possible test error is $3^2 = 9$. We also keep 2,000 fresh houses as a test set. All numbers below come from code I ran (NumPy 2.5, Python 3; `statsmodels` is not installed here, so I wrote the formulas by hand, which is also better for learning).

7.1 Why Models Overfit: Bias and Variance

INTUITION

Imagine a student who memorises last year's exam answers word for word. On last year's paper he scores 100. On this year's paper he fails, because he learned the answers, not the subject. A model with too much freedom does the same: it bends to touch every training point, including the random noise.

Words you need

Word	Plain meaning	Example

Training error	Error on the data used to fit	6.5 on the 40 houses
Test error	Error on new, unseen data	11.6 on the 2,000 fresh houses
Bias	Error from a model that is too simple	A straight line through a curve
Variance	How much the fitted model changes if the training data changes	Coefficients jumping between samples
Overfitting	Low training error, high test error	Memorising
Hyperparameter	A setting you choose, not learned by the fit	The penalty strength λ

How it works

Expected test error splits into three parts:

```
expected test error = bias² + variance + irreducible noise
```

The irreducible noise (here 9) is the floor. You cannot beat it. Bias falls when the model is more flexible; variance rises. The best model sits in the middle.

Problem 7.1.1 Fit OLS with all 10 features on the 40 training houses. Compare training and test mean squared error (MSE).

Formula	MSE = average of (actual − predicted)²
Compute	(from code) train MSE = 6.505, test MSE = 11.592
Answer	The model looks 6.5 on its own data but is really 11.6 on new data. The gap of about 5 is the cost of overfitting.
Check	The noise floor is 9, and test MSE (11.6) is above it, as it must be. Training MSE (6.5) is below the floor, which is the sign of fitting noise.
Why it matters	Training error alone is a lie. Always measure on data the model never saw.

KEY INSIGHT

OLS is unbiased, but with few rows and many columns its variance is large. Regularization adds a small, deliberate bias to buy a large drop in variance. The trade is usually worth it.

Connection to the real job. Every ML model has this problem: trees (depth), neural nets (size, epochs), and regression (number of features). A regularization knob exists in all of them.

Applications

- Data Science: predicting churn with hundreds of columns and few thousand rows.
- Machine Learning: weight decay in neural nets is ridge in disguise.
- Real estate and retail: predicting prices or sales from many measured attributes.

COMMON MISTAKE

Judging a model by its R^2 or MSE on the training rows. More columns always lower training error, even useless columns.

Check yourself

1. Can training error ever be below the noise floor? Answer: Yes, when the model fits noise. That is overfitting.
2. Which one falls as a model becomes more flexible, bias or variance? Answer: Bias falls; variance rises.
3. Is λ learned by the fit? Answer: No. It is a hyperparameter you choose, usually by cross-validation.

7.2 Ridge Regression (L2 Penalty)

INTUITION

Imagine each coefficient is tied to zero by a spring. The data pulls the coefficient to its best value, the spring pulls it back to zero. A stiffer spring (bigger λ) means a smaller coefficient. A coefficient is only allowed to be big if the data pulls hard enough to justify it.

Formal definition

OLS minimises the residual sum of squares, $RSS = \Sigma(y_i - \hat{y}_i)^2$. Ridge minimises:

$$RSS + \lambda \times \Sigma \beta_j^2 \qquad (\lambda \geq 0, \text{ the intercept is not penalised})$$

The closed form is $\hat{\beta} = (X^TX + \lambda I)^{-1} X^Ty$. Adding λ to the diagonal also fixes the case where X^TX cannot be inverted (columns that are copies of each other). **Always standardise features first** (subtract the mean, divide by the standard deviation), otherwise a column measured in bytes is punished differently from one measured in seconds.

Why is it called "ridge"? Adding λ on the diagonal of a matrix is like adding a ridge of values along it. Why L2? The penalty $\Sigma\beta^2$ is the squared L2 norm (see the Math PDF on norms).

Problem 7.2.1 (tiny numbers) One feature x = [1, 2, 3], y = [2, 4, 5]. Compute the ridge slope for λ = 0, 1, 2, 10. Centre the data first.

Step 1	Centre: $\bar{x} = 2$, $\bar{y} = 11/3 = 3.667$. So xc = [−1, 0, 1], yc = [−1.667, 0.333, 1.333].
Step 2	With one feature, $\beta = \Sigma\, xc \cdot yc \,/\, (\Sigma\, xc^2 + \lambda)$. Σ xc·yc = 1.667 + 0 + 1.333 = 3. $\Sigma xc^2 = 2$.
Step 3	λ = 0: 3 / 2 = 1.5. λ = 1: 3 / 3 = 1.0. λ = 2: 3 / 4 = 0.75. λ = 10: 3 / 12 = 0.25.
Answer	The slope shrinks from 1.5 (OLS) toward 0 as λ grows, but never reaches 0.
Check	Code printed 1.5, 1.0, 0.75, 0.25. Same.
Why it matters	Every ridge coefficient is the OLS coefficient divided by a number larger than 1. It is a shrinkage.

Problem 7.2.2 (realistic) On the running example, fit ridge for several λ and report the first 3 (real) coefficients and the test MSE. Here the penalty is $\lambda\ \Sigma\beta^2$ on standardised columns.

λ	β_1	β_2	β_3	Train MSE	Test MSE
0 (OLS)	2.93	−2.39	0.60	6.505	11.592
1	2.86	−2.34	0.60	6.513	11.367
5	2.62	−2.16	0.57	6.682	**10.823**
20	2.02	−1.71	0.43	8.086	10.947

50	1.41	−1.22	0.26	11.120	13.034
200	0.57	−0.51	0.07	18.349	18.840

- **Read the table** Training MSE only goes up as λ grows (the model is more constrained). Test MSE goes down, then up. The best test MSE is near λ = 5 to 20, and it beats OLS (10.82 vs 11.59).
- **Answer** A modest penalty cuts test error by about 7 percent here. Too much penalty (λ = 200) underfits: both errors are high.
- **Check** The test MSE never goes below 9, the noise floor.
- **Why it matters** The U-shape of test error against λ is the picture you will see in every tuning exercise.

COMMON MISTAKE

Forgetting to standardise. If the floor-area column is in square metres (30-300) and the room count is 1-8, the penalty hits them unequally and the result depends on units. Standardise using training statistics only, then apply the same numbers to test data.

Connection to the real job. `sklearn.linear_model.Ridge` (its `alpha` is this λ). Weight decay in PyTorch optimisers is the same idea. Ridge is the default when many features are all a little useful or are correlated.

Applications

- Machine Learning: baseline regressor with many correlated features.
- Data Science: stabilising regression when columns are nearly copies (multicollinearity).
- Deep Learning: weight decay on neural network weights.

Check yourself

1. If λ = 0 what is ridge? Answer: Ordinary least squares.
2. Does ridge make coefficients exactly 0? Answer: No, it only shrinks them.
3. Why standardise first? Answer: So the penalty treats all features fairly, regardless of units.

7.3 Lasso Regression (L1 Penalty)

INTUITION

Ridge is a spring on each coefficient. Lasso is a **toll**: every unit of coefficient size costs a fixed fee. If a feature does not earn more than the fee, it is not worth including, so its coefficient is set to exactly zero. Lasso therefore also does **feature selection**.

Formal definition

```
minimise  (1/2n) × RSS + λ × Σ |βⱼ|
```

The name is an acronym: Least Absolute Shrinkage and Selection Operator. There is no closed form, but **coordinate descent** works: update one coefficient at a time while holding others fixed. The one-coefficient update uses the **soft-threshold** function:

```
S(ρ, λ) = sign(ρ) × max(|ρ| − λ, 0)
```

Here ρ is the correlation of the feature with the current residual. If |ρ| is smaller than λ, the coefficient becomes exactly 0. (With standardised columns, the update is $\beta_j = S(\rho_j, \lambda)$.)

Problem 7.3.1 (tiny) Compute S(3, 1), S(−0.4, 1), S(1.5, 0.5).

Step 1	S(3, 1): |3| − 1 = 2, positive, keep the sign, so 2.
Step 2	S(−0.4, 1): |−0.4| − 1 = −0.6, below zero, so max(…, 0) = 0. The answer is 0.
Step 3	S(1.5, 0.5): 1.5 − 0.5 = 1.0.
Answer	2, 0, 1.0. Code gave 2, −0.0 (which is zero), 1.0.
Why it matters	"Shrink by λ and clip at 0" is the whole mechanism. Small signals die, big signals lose λ.

Problem 7.3.2 (realistic) Fit lasso on the running example (7 of the 10 features are noise).

λ	Non-zero coefficients	β_1	β_2	β_3	Test MSE
0 (OLS)	10	2.93	−2.39	0.60	11.592
0.1	8	2.89	−2.24	0.52	11.029

0.3	5	2.73	−2.06	0.33	**10.946**
0.6	3	2.43	−1.84	0.03	11.809
1.0	2	2.14	−1.55	0	12.150
2.0	2	1.40	−0.81	0	14.745

- **Read the table** As λ rises, noise features drop out first. At λ = 0.3, five features remain, and the test error is the best (10.95). At λ = 1.0, the real third feature (true effect 1.5) is also dropped, because its signal in 40 rows is too weak, and error rises.
- **Answer** Lasso found the two strong features and mostly ignored the noise, but with only 40 rows it cannot reliably keep the weaker third one.
- **Check** Non-zero counts fall steadily (10, 8, 5, 3, 2, 2). Test MSE has a U shape again.
- **Why it matters** If you need a short, explainable list of drivers, lasso gives it. Use it with care: the chosen set can change if the data changes.

The picture: coefficient paths

Coefficient paths for ridge and lasso

Each line is one coefficient (blue lines are the 3 real features, grey lines are noise). The x-axis is the penalty strength, from none on the left to strong on the right. The y-axis is the coefficient value. In the ridge panel, the lines glide smoothly toward 0 and never land. In the lasso panel, lines hit 0 and stay flat there. This is the difference in one image.

```
Why lasso gives exact zeros (the geometry, 2 coefficients)

   β2                        The loss contours (ellipses) grow from the OLS
    |   ridge: circle         point until they touch the penalty region.
    |   lasso: diamond        A circle is smooth: touches at a generic
point.
 ---+---   <>                 A diamond has corners on the axes: ellipses
    |                         usually touch a corner, where one β is 0.
```

COMMON MISTAKE

Treating the features lasso keeps as "the true causes". Among correlated features, lasso picks one more or less at random. A feature missing from the lasso list may be just as useful as the one chosen.

Connection to the real job. `sklearn.linear_model.Lasso` and `LassoCV`. Used for sparse models, feature screening, and sparse regression in genomics, text, and click-through data with thousands of columns.

Applications

- Data Science: pick a short list of predictors for a business model.
- Machine Learning: L1 regularised logistic regression on sparse text features.
- Signal processing: sparse recovery (compressed sensing).

Check yourself

1. Which penalty gives exact zeros, L1 or L2? Answer: L1 (lasso).
2. In S(ρ, λ), what happens if |ρ| < λ? Answer: The result is exactly 0.
3. Two features are almost identical copies. What does lasso do? Answer: It tends to keep one and drop the other, somewhat arbitrarily.

7.4 Elastic Net

INTUITION

Ridge shares credit between twin features; lasso picks one twin and fires the other. Elastic net is a mix: it keeps twin features together (ridge behaviour) and still removes useless ones (lasso behaviour).

Formal definition

$$\text{minimise} \quad (1/2n)\ \text{RSS} + \lambda \times [\ \alpha \times \Sigma|\beta_j| + (1 - \alpha)/2 \times \Sigma\beta_j^2\ ]$$

α = 1 is lasso; α = 0 is ridge; in between is elastic net. In coordinate descent the update becomes $\beta_j = S(\rho_j, \lambda\alpha) / (1 + \lambda(1 - \alpha))$ for standardised columns.

Problem 7.4.1 Build 60 rows with 5 features. Features 1 and 2 are both `base + small noise` (twins), and y = 3 × base + noise. Features 3-5 are noise. Fit lasso, elastic net (α = 0.5), and ridge, all with λ = 0.3.

Compute (from code):

Method	β_1	β_2	β_3	β_4	β_5
Lasso (α = 1)	2.85	0	0	0	0
Elastic net (α = 0.5)	1.47	1.31	0.03	0.08	0
Ridge (α = 0)	1.38	1.31	0.16	0.19	0.01

- **Answer** Lasso gives the whole 2.85 to one twin. Elastic net splits it (1.47 + 1.31 = 2.78) and keeps noise features near 0. Ridge splits it too but leaves noise features at 0.16 and 0.19.
- **Check** The twins' sum is about 2.8 to 2.85 in all three methods, which matches the true total effect of 3 (a little shrunk).
- **Why it matters** When features move together (floor area and number of rooms), elastic net gives stable and shareable results.

Connection to the real job. `sklearn.linear_model.ElasticNet(alpha=λ, l1_ratio=α)`; the two libraries name them in opposite ways, so read the docs). It is the practical default when you do not know which of ridge or lasso is best.

Applications

- Genomics and finance: thousands of correlated predictors.
- Marketing mix models: correlated channel spends.
- Pricing: correlated cost drivers.

COMMON MISTAKE

Mixing up λ and α. λ is overall strength, α is the L1/L2 balance. Tune both, using cross-validation.

Check yourself

1. What does α = 0 give? Answer: Ridge.
2. When prefer elastic net to lasso? Answer: When features are correlated and you want them

kept together.

3. Which two numbers do you tune? Answer: Total strength λ and the mix α.

7.5 Cross-Validation

INTUITION

To pick the penalty you need an honest exam. But you cannot use the test set for choosing, or it is no longer a test. So you split the training data into K parts. Each part takes a turn as the "exam" while the other K−1 parts are the "textbook". Average the K exam scores.

How it works (K-fold)

1. Shuffle the rows and cut them into K groups (folds).
2. For each fold: fit on the other K−1 folds, score on this fold.
3. Average the K scores. Do this for each candidate λ. Pick the λ with the lowest average (or the largest λ within one standard error of the best, called the "one-standard-error rule", which prefers simpler models).
4. Refit on all training data with that λ. Touch the test set once, at the very end.

Important: standardisation and any other data-driven step must be redone inside each fold, using only that fold's training part. Otherwise information leaks from the exam into the textbook ("data leakage").

Problem 7.5.1 5-fold CV for ridge on the 40 training rows (8 rows per fold). Which λ wins?

λ	CV mean MSE	CV std across folds
0.01	17.979	9.049
1	17.113	9.341
5	15.217	10.226
10	14.406	10.808
20	**14.353**	11.261

50	16.222	11.471
100	18.777	11.501
300	22.630	11.605

- **Answer** CV picks λ = 20 (14.353), nearly tied with λ = 10 (14.406). The real test curve earlier was best near 5 to 20, so CV agreed well.
- **Check** CV errors (14 to 18) are higher than the 2,000-row test MSE (about 11). That is expected: each CV model trains on only 32 rows, and 8-row folds are noisy. The standard deviation across folds (9 to 11) is big, which says the difference between λ = 10 and 20 is not meaningful.
- **Why it matters** CV gives a defensible choice without touching the test set, and the spread tells you how much to trust it.

Problem 7.5.2 Leave-one-out CV (K = n) for a linear model has a shortcut: `LOOCV = mean( (residual_i / (1 − h_ii))² )`, where h_{ii} is the diagonal of the "hat matrix" $H = X(X^TX)^{-1}X^T$. For polynomial fits of degree 1 to 6 on 50 points (true curve is a parabola), the code gave LOOCV 1.607 (degree 1), 0.773 (degree 2), 0.788 (degree 3), 0.807 (degree 4), 0.836 (degree 5), 0.916 (degree 6).

Answer	LOOCV is lowest at degree 2, the true degree. Higher degrees steadily get worse.
Why it matters	A cheap, exact CV for linear models: no refitting 50 times.

Time series warning. Random folds break time order and leak the future. For forecasts use rolling-origin evaluation (Chapter 10). For grouped data (several rows per user) use group-aware folds.

COMMON MISTAKE

Scaling or selecting features on the full data before CV. This leaks and makes CV scores too optimistic. Put every step inside a `Pipeline` so it is refit within each fold.

Connection to the real job. `cross_val_score`, `RidgeCV`, `LassoCV`, `GridSearchCV` in scikit-learn. Every model-comparison in an ML interview ends with "how did you validate?".

Applications

- Machine Learning: hyperparameter tuning for every model.
- Data Science: comparing two candidate models fairly.
- MLOps: automated retraining picks the best config by CV.

Check yourself

1. Why not tune λ on the test set? Answer: Then the test set is no longer unseen; your final score would be too optimistic.
2. Common choice of K? Answer: 5 or 10.
3. Where must scaling happen? Answer: Inside each fold, fit on the fold's training part only.

7.6 AIC and BIC

INTUITION

You are buying a model. Better fit is good, but each extra parameter has a price tag. AIC and BIC are two price lists. They need only one fit, no re-splitting.

Formal definition

For a model with k estimated parameters, n rows, and maximised log-likelihood ℓ (higher means better fit; see MLE in the Math PDF):

```
AIC = 2k − 2ℓ
BIC = k × ln(n) − 2ℓ
```

Lower is better. AIC charges 2 per parameter. BIC charges ln(n) per parameter, which is more than 2 once n > 7, so BIC prefers simpler models, especially in large data. For a linear regression with normal errors: $\ell = -(n/2) \times (\ln(2\pi \times RSS/n) + 1)$ and k counts the coefficients plus one for the error variance.

Rule of thumb: a difference of more than about 2 in AIC is meaningful; more than 10 is strong. AIC aims at good prediction; BIC aims at finding the true model if it is among the candidates.

Problem 7.6.1 n = 50 points from the parabola $y = 1 + 2x - 0.8x^2 + noise$. Fit polynomial degree 1, 2, 3. Compute AIC and BIC from RSS.

Formula	$\ell = -(n/2)(\ln(2\pi \cdot RSS/n) + 1)$; k = degree + 2.
Plug in (degree 2)	RSS = 34.19, n = 50, k = 4. $2\pi \times 34.19 / 50 = 4.2964$. $\ln(4.2964) = 1.4580$. Add 1 = 2.4580. Times −25 = −61.45.
Compute	AIC = 2 × 4 + 2 × 61.45 = 130.89. BIC = 4 × ln(50) + 122.9 = 4 × 3.912 + 122.9 = 138.54.
All degrees (from code)	

Degree	RSS	ℓ	AIC	BIC
1	72.68	−80.30	166.60	172.33
2	34.19	−61.44	**130.89**	**138.54**
3	33.50	−60.94	131.87	141.43
4	32.62	−60.27	132.55	144.02
6	28.41	−56.82	129.63	144.93

- **Answer** BIC picks degree 2 clearly (138.54, lowest). AIC also prefers degree 2 among degrees 1-5, but degree 6 (129.63) sneaks slightly below it, a difference of only 1.3, which is below the "meaningful" threshold of 2.
- **Check** RSS always falls with more terms (72.7, 34.2, 33.5, 32.6, 28.4), yet the penalty beats the small gains. The big drop is from degree 1 to 2 (38.5), then tiny gains.
- **Why it matters** AIC/BIC turn "is the extra term worth it?" into a number. Notice the disagreement at degree 6: AIC is more generous. When they disagree, check with CV.

Connection to the real job. `statsmodels` results show `.aic` and `.bic` for OLS, GLMs, and ARIMA (Chapters 8 and 10). They compare models on the **same data and same response** only. You cannot compare AIC from different datasets.

Applications

- Statistics and econometrics: choosing ARIMA orders and GLM terms.

- Data Science: quick screening of many nested models.
- Actuarial and risk work: comparing claim-count models.

COMMON MISTAKE

Comparing AIC values across models fitted on different rows (after dropping missing values), or on a transformed response (log y versus y). The numbers are not on the same scale.

Check yourself

1. Lower or higher AIC is better? Answer: Lower.
2. Which penalises complexity more for n = 50, AIC or BIC? Answer: BIC (ln 50 = 3.9 per parameter versus 2).
3. Can you compare AIC of two models on different datasets? Answer: No.

7.7 Putting It Together: A Model-Selection Workflow

Step	What	Tool
1	Split off a test set and do not touch it	`train_test_split`
2	Standardise inside a pipeline	`Pipeline` + `StandardScaler`
3	Tune λ (and α) by K-fold CV on training data	`RidgeCV`, `LassoCV`, `ElasticNetCV`
4	Compare different model families by CV score; use AIC/BIC for nested likelihood models	CV, `.aic`, `.bic`
5	Refit on all training data, score once on the test set	`.score`
6	Report the test score with uncertainty (bootstrap, Chapter 3)	`numpy`

REAL JOB TIP

Always include a trivial baseline (predict the mean). If your model cannot beat it on CV, stop and look at the data first.

PROFESSOR'S NOTE

I could not run `scikit-learn` pipelines against `statsmodels` here (`statsmodels` is not installed). The code above uses only NumPy so every number is real, but the library calls in the table are standard and should work as named. Check the argument names in your installed version.

Chapter recap

- Training error lies. Test error (or cross-validated error) tells the truth.
- Test error = bias² + variance + noise. Regularization adds a little bias to cut a lot of variance.
- Ridge (L2) shrinks all coefficients smoothly; closed form $(X^TX + \lambda I)^{-1}X^Ty$; never exactly zero.
- Lasso (L1) shrinks and sets some coefficients to exactly zero (feature selection) through the soft-threshold.
- Elastic net mixes both; best for correlated features.
- Standardise first, inside each CV fold, to avoid unit effects and leakage.
- K-fold CV chooses λ; the one-standard-error rule prefers simpler models; LOOCV has a hat-matrix shortcut for linear models.
- AIC = 2k − 2ℓ, BIC = k ln n − 2ℓ; lower is better; same data only; BIC is stricter.

Item	Formula or call	Note
Ridge	$\beta = (X^TX + \lambda I)^{-1}X^Ty$	`Ridge(alpha=λ)`
Lasso	`S(ρ, λ) = sign(ρ)·max(`	ρ
Elastic net	$S(\rho, \lambda\alpha) / (1 + \lambda(1 - \alpha))$	`ElasticNet(l1_ratio=α)`
AIC / BIC	$2k - 2\ell$ / $k \ln n - 2\ell$	`model.aic`, `model.bic`
LOOCV (linear)	$\text{mean}((e_i / (1 - h_{ii}))^2)$	Hat matrix diagonal

CV	K folds, fit on K−1, score on 1	`cross_val_score`

Practice set

1 (easy). Ridge with one centred feature has Σxc·yc = 8 and Σxc² = 4. What is β for λ = 0 and λ = 4? **Answer:** λ = 0: 8/4 = 2. λ = 4: 8/(4+4) = 1. The slope halves.

2 (easy). Compute S(−2.5, 1) and S(0.8, 1). **Answer:** S(−2.5, 1) = −(2.5 − 1) = −1.5. S(0.8, 1) = 0 because 0.8 < 1.

3 (easy). Model A has AIC 210.4 and model B has AIC 206.1 on the same data. Which is preferred and is the gap meaningful? **Answer:** B (lower). The gap is 4.3, more than 2, so it is meaningful support.

4. What is the output? A model has train MSE 2.0 and 5-fold CV MSE 9.5. What do you suspect? **Answer:** Overfitting. The model fits the training data far better than new data. Add regularization or reduce features.

5. n = 100, log-likelihoods: model 1 (k = 3) $\ell = -150$; model 2 (k = 6) $\ell = -146$. Compute AIC and BIC for both and say which each criterion picks. (ln 100 = 4.605.) **Answer:** AIC1 = 6 + 300 = 306; AIC2 = 12 + 292 = 304, so AIC picks model 2. BIC1 = 3 × 4.605 + 300 = 313.8; BIC2 = 6 × 4.605 + 292 = 319.6, so BIC picks model 1. They disagree: BIC is stricter.

6 (find the bug). A student standardises the full dataset with `StandardScaler().fit_transform(X)`, then runs `cross_val_score`. What is wrong? **Answer:** The scaler saw the validation folds' mean and standard deviation, a small leak. Put the scaler in a `Pipeline` so it is fit within each fold.

7. A lasso model on 500 features keeps 12. A colleague says "these 12 are the causes of churn". Respond. **Answer:** Lasso picks a predictive subset, not causes. Correlated features may be dropped arbitrarily, and the set can change with a new sample. Check stability by refitting on bootstrap samples, and use causal reasoning (or an experiment) for causes.

8. For 5-fold CV the fold errors for a model are 10, 12, 9, 14, 15. Compute the mean, the standard deviation, and the standard error of the mean. **Answer:** Mean = 60/5 = 12. Deviations: −2, 0, −3, 2, 3; squares: 4, 0, 9, 4, 9 = 26. Sample variance = 26/4 = 6.5, SD = 2.55. SE = 2.55/√5 = 1.14.

9 (scenario). You have 200 rows and 300 features (more columns than rows). Can you run

OLS? What do you do instead? **Answer:** OLS has no unique solution because X^TX is singular (rank at most 200). Use ridge (adding λI makes it invertible), lasso, or elastic net, with λ chosen by CV.

10 (interview). Explain in 60 seconds why ridge shrinks coefficients but lasso zeroes them. **Answer:** Both add a penalty to the least-squares loss. L2's penalty gradient shrinks in proportion to the coefficient, so it approaches zero but never reaches it. L1's penalty pulls with constant force λ, so a coefficient whose data signal is weaker than λ is clipped to exactly zero (soft-threshold). Geometrically, the L1 ball is a diamond with corners on the axes.

11 (interview). When would you choose BIC over AIC, and when CV over both? **Answer:** BIC when you want a simpler, more interpretable model or you have lots of data and believe a simple true model exists. AIC for prediction-focused choices. CV when the model is not a likelihood model (trees, neural nets), when the assumptions behind the likelihood are doubtful, or when you want a direct estimate of prediction error.

Prompt pack

✨ **AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI**

```
You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional
moving into data roles. Teach me ridge regression and the bias-variance
trade-off step by step. Use a tiny dataset with 5 numbers first, then a
NumPy example with 10 features where only 3 matter. Show why training
error always falls but test error is U-shaped as the penalty changes.
Check my understanding with 4 short questions, one at a time, before
moving on.
```

✨ **AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI**

```
You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional
moving into data roles. Explain lasso, the soft-threshold function, and
coordinate descent, with the diamond-versus-circle geometry in words. Then
explain elastic net and when it beats lasso on correlated features. Give
me 8 graded exercises with small numbers, WITHOUT solutions, and wait for
my answers before you correct them.
```

✨ **AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI**

```
You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional
```

moving into data roles. Quiz me one question at a time on K-fold cross-validation, data leakage, the one-standard-error rule, and leave-one-out CV. After each answer, tell me what is right, what is wrong, and why. Include two questions about time series and grouped data. Stop after 8 questions and give me a score.

✨ AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI

You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional moving into data roles. Review my model-selection work: [PASTE HERE]. Check whether I standardised inside the folds, whether I compared AIC or BIC on the same data, whether I read the cross-validation spread honestly, and whether my conclusions about feature importance are justified. List each mistake and show a corrected version.

✨ AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI

You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional moving into data roles. Run a mock interview on regularization and model selection: ridge versus lasso, elastic net, AIC versus BIC, cross-validation pitfalls, and overfitting. Ask one question at a time, wait for my answer, then give a score out of 10 and a model answer in simple English. Ask 8 questions, from easy to hard.

CHAPTER 8

GENERALIZED LINEAR MODELS

Regression for yes/no answers and for counts: logistic, Poisson and negative binomial models.

Ordinary linear regression predicts a number that can be anything: 120 minutes, minus 5, 3.7. But many real questions are different. "Will this parcel arrive late, yes or no?" has only two answers. "How many complaints will we get this hour?" is a count: 0, 1, 2, never 2.5 and never negative. If you force a straight line onto these, it predicts probabilities of 130 percent and error counts below zero. Generalized linear models (GLMs) fix this with one clean idea. In this chapter you learn the idea, fit logistic and Poisson regressions with a short NumPy routine, read odds ratios and marginal effects, test whether a model fits using deviance, and handle the common failure of "too much variation" with the negative binomial model. We build on OLS and MLE (see the Math PDF for MLE and log-loss) and on AIC from Chapter 7.

Two running examples, both simulated with a fixed seed so the numbers are repeatable:

- **Late deliveries:** 500 parcels, with `load` (in units of 100 orders per hour, 1 to 10) and `distance` (in 10 km units, 0 to 5). The outcome is 1 if the parcel arrived late. Result: 184 of 500 were late (36.8 percent).
- **Complaint counts:** complaints per hour against traffic (thousands of orders per hour).

`statsmodels` is not installed in this environment, so I fitted the models with my own iteratively reweighted least squares (IRLS) code. In real work you would call `statsmodels.api.GLM` or `sklearn`; the numbers match because it is the same maths. Library calls shown below are standard but "not run here".

8.1 The GLM Idea and Link Functions

INTUITION

A normal regression builds a score $\eta = \beta_0 + \beta_1 x_1 + \beta_2 x_2$. That score can be any number from minus to plus infinity. A probability must stay between 0 and 1. A count must stay at or above 0. So we pass the score through a bent pipe (a **link function**) that squeezes it into the allowed range. The score itself stays a simple straight-line formula.

Words you need

Word	Plain meaning	Example
Linear predictor η	The straight-line score `β₀ + β₁x₁ + …`	η = −0.65
Link function g	Connects the mean of y to η: `g(mean) = η`	logit, log
Inverse link	Turns η back into a mean	`1/(1 + e^(−η))`
Family	The distribution of y around its mean	Bernoulli, Poisson
Deviance	A fit score: `2 × (ℓ_saturated − ℓ_model)`, lower is better	500.8

A GLM has three parts: (1) a distribution for y (the family), (2) a linear predictor η, (3) a link `g(μ) = η`, where μ is the mean of y.

Model	Family	Link g(μ)	Mean μ in terms of η	y looks like
Linear regression	Normal	identity: μ	μ = η	any number
Logistic regression	Bernoulli / Binomial	logit: ln(μ/(1−μ))	μ = 1/(1+e^(−η))	0 or 1
Poisson regression	Poisson	log: ln μ	μ = e^η	count 0, 1, 2…
Negative binomial	Neg. binomial	log: ln μ	μ = e^η	overdispersed count
Gamma regression	Gamma	log (or inverse)	μ = e^η	positive, skewed (delivery time)

Why not just predict the mean with a straight line? Because the line leaves the allowed range. Why the log for counts? Effects become **multiplicative**: adding 1 to x multiplies the expected

count by e^{β}. That matches how busy periods tend to act on complaint counts.

How the fit works

We use maximum likelihood (MLE). For these models there is no closed formula, so we use **IRLS**: repeat a weighted least-squares fit, updating weights from the current fit, until the coefficients stop changing. This is Newton's method (see Math PDF, second-order optimisation) in a special form. It typically converges in 5 to 8 rounds. Our code converged in 6 for both examples.

Problem 8.1.1 (tiny) A model has $\eta = -0.65$. What probability does the logit link give, and what do the odds equal?

Formula	$p = 1 / (1 + e^{-\eta})$
Plug in	$e^{0.65} = 1.9155$, so $p = 1/(1 + 1.9155)$
Compute	$p = 1/2.9155 = 0.343$. Odds $= p/(1-p) = 0.343/0.657 = 0.522$, and $e^{-0.65} = 0.522$.
Answer	$\eta = -0.65$ means a 34.3 percent chance. The odds equal e^{η}.
Check	$\eta = 0$ gives $p = 0.5$; negative η must give p below 0.5. Yes.
Why it matters	η is on the "log-odds" scale; always convert before you report to a manager.

Problem 8.1.2 Poisson model with $\eta = 0.15 + 0.35 \times$ traffic. What is the expected complaint count at traffic = 4?

Step 1	$\eta = 0.15 + 0.35 \times 4 = 1.55$.
Step 2	$\mu = e^{1.55} = 4.71$.
Answer	About 4.7 complaints per hour.
Check	The result is positive, as a count's mean must be. A linear model could have given a negative number at low traffic.

COMMON MISTAKE

Reading the coefficient of a logistic or Poisson model as if it were the change in y. It is the change in η (log-odds or log-count). Convert with `exp` or compute probabilities.

Connection to the real job. `statsmodels.api.GLM(y, X, family=sm.families.Binomial())` and `…Poisson()`; `sklearn.linear_model.LogisticRegression`, `PoissonRegressor`, `GammaRegressor`. Logistic regression is the first classifier you will meet in ML.

Applications

- Data Science: churn, fraud, conversion (logistic); orders per day, tickets per hour (Poisson).
- Machine Learning: logistic regression is a one-layer neural net with a sigmoid and log-loss.
- Insurance: claim counts (Poisson, NB), claim size (Gamma).
- Operations: late-delivery probability and complaint counts as a function of order load.

Check yourself

1. Which link is used for counts? Answer: The log link.
2. In logistic regression, what does η = 0 mean? Answer: Probability 0.5 (odds 1).
3. Why is IRLS used? Answer: GLM likelihoods have no closed-form maximum, so we solve by repeated weighted least squares.

8.2 Logistic Regression and Odds Ratios

INTUITION

Horse-racing people say "3 to 1 against" instead of "25 percent". **Odds** are probability expressed as a ratio of "for" to "against". Odds are handy because they run from 0 to infinity, and their logarithm runs from minus to plus infinity, which is exactly the range of a straight-line score.

Formal definition

```
odds   = p / (1 − p)
logit  = ln(odds) = ln(p / (1 − p)) = β₀ + β₁x₁ + β₂x₂
p      = 1 / (1 + e^(−logit))
```

Each coefficient β_j is the change in log-odds for one unit of x_j, others fixed. e^{β_j} is the **odds ratio (OR)**: the factor by which the odds are multiplied. OR = 1 means no effect, above 1 raises the odds, below 1 lowers them. The likelihood to maximise is $\Sigma\,[y \ln p + (1-y) \ln(1-p)]$, whose negative is the log-loss (see Math PDF).

p	odds	log-odds
0.5	1	0
0.2	0.25	−1.386
0.8	4	+1.386
0.9	9	+2.197

Notice the symmetry: p = 0.2 and p = 0.8 have log-odds of the same size and opposite sign.

Problem 8.2.1 Fit a logistic regression for late deliveries on the 500 parcels. Report the coefficients, standard errors, odds ratios and 95 percent confidence intervals.

Formula	CI for OR = exp(β ± 1.96 × SE). The z statistic is β / SE.
Compute	(from code, 6 IRLS iterations):

Term	β	SE	z	p-value	Odds ratio	95% CI for OR
constant	−4.395	0.424	−10.36	~0	0.012	0.005 to 0.028
load (per 100 orders/hour)	0.521	0.051	10.16	~0	1.683	1.522 to 1.861
distance (per 10 km)	0.309	0.079	3.91	0.00009	1.362	1.166 to 1.590

- **Answer** Each extra 100 orders per hour multiplies the odds of a late delivery by 1.68 (68 percent higher odds), holding distance fixed. Each extra 10 km multiplies the odds by 1.36. Both intervals exclude 1, so both effects are clearly real.
- **Check** I generated the data with true values −5, 0.6, 0.4. The estimates (−4.40, 0.52, 0.31) are close, and each true value lies within about 2 SE of its estimate. Hand check: e^0.5209 = 1.683. ✓.
- **Why it matters** The odds ratio is the standard way to report logistic results.

Problem 8.2.2 (combining ideas) What is the late-delivery probability at load = 6 and distance = 2? What happens if load goes to 7?

Step 1	η = −4.395 + 0.5209 × 6 + 0.3087 × 2 = −4.395 + 3.125 + 0.617 = −0.653.
Step 2	p = 1/(1 + e^0.653) = 1/(1 + 1.921) = 0.342. Odds = 0.521.
Step 3	At load 7: η = −0.132, p = 0.467, so the new odds are 0.467/0.533 = 0.877. New odds / old odds = 0.877/0.521 = 1.683 (code: 1.6835), equal to the OR.
Answer	34.2 percent at load 6, and 46.7 percent at load 7. The probability rose by 12.5 percentage points while the odds rose by a factor of 1.68.
Check	The ratio of odds equals e^β exactly, a good test of the algebra.
Why it matters	The OR is constant but the probability change is not: it depends on where you start.

COMMON MISTAKE

Saying "the odds ratio is 1.68, so the probability is 1.68 times higher". Odds are not probabilities. Only when events are rare (p small) are the two nearly equal. Here p moved from 0.342 to 0.467, which is a factor of 1.36, not 1.68.

Marginal effects

A **marginal effect** answers "how much does the probability change per unit of x?" For logistic regression it is $p(1-p) \times \beta$, so it changes with p. The **average marginal effect (AME)** averages this over all rows. Here, AME for load = 0.0862, so on average one more 100 orders per hour adds about 8.6 percentage points of timeout probability; AME for payload = 0.0511, about 5.1 points per 10 KB. Non-linear models need this to give a plain-language answer.

The picture

Logistic S-curve and overdispersed counts

Left panel: grey dots are the 500 parcels (0 = on time, 1 = late, jittered a little so you can see them) against load. The blue S-curve is the fitted probability with distance held at 2. It is flat near 0 on the left, rises steeply in the middle, and flattens near 1 on the right. The steepest part is where p ≈ 0.5, where the marginal effect is largest (β/4 = 0.13 per unit load). The right panel belongs to section 8.4.

Fit and diagnostics

Quantity	Value (from code)	Meaning
Log-likelihood of model	−250.41	Higher is better
Log-likelihood of intercept-only	−328.94	The "no-feature" baseline
Residual deviance (−2ℓ)	500.83	Lower is better
Null deviance	657.88	Deviance with only the constant
Likelihood-ratio test	157.05 on 2 df, $p \approx 8 \times 10^{-35}$	The features help
AIC	506.83	For comparing models, as in Chapter 7
McFadden pseudo-R^2	1 − (−250.41/−328.94) = 0.239	Not like OLS R^2; 0.2 to 0.4 is already good
Accuracy at threshold 0.5	0.748	Not enough alone (see below)

The LR test is "deviance drop = null − residual = 657.88 − 500.83 = 157.05", compared with a chi-square with 2 degrees of freedom (one per added feature).

KEY INSIGHT

Logistic regression outputs a probability. The threshold of 0.5 is a business choice, not a law. If missing a late parcel is expensive, use 0.3. Evaluation with precision, recall, ROC and calibration belongs to the ML chapters.

Connection to the real job. Logistic regression is the standard baseline for any yes/no prediction: it is fast, explainable, and gives odds ratios you can show to a manager. It is also the model inside many risk scorecards at banks.

Applications

- Data Analytics: which factors raise churn odds.
- Machine Learning: baseline classifier; L1/L2 penalty from Chapter 7 applies directly (`LogisticRegression(C=…)` , where `C = 1/λ`).
- Healthcare: odds ratios for risk factors.
- Fraud and credit: scorecards.

COMMON MISTAKE

Perfect separation. If one feature lets you split yes from no without error, the MLE does not exist: the coefficient grows towards infinity and software warns or gives huge numbers. Add a penalty (Chapter 7) or remove the feature.

Check yourself

1. If β = 0.693, what is the OR? Answer: e^0.693 = 2.0. The odds double.
2. Does OR = 2 mean the probability doubles? Answer: No, only the odds double.
3. What does an OR confidence interval of 0.8 to 1.3 say? Answer: It includes 1, so no clear effect.

8.3 Poisson Regression for Counts

INTUITION

Complaints arrive at random, like cars passing a point on a road. In each hour the number of cars varies, but there is a typical rate. The Poisson model says the count in an hour is random around a rate, and that the rate itself depends on traffic. Higher traffic means a higher rate, multiplied, not added.

Formal definition

```
y ~ Poisson(μ),   ln μ = β₀ + β₁x      so   μ = e^(β₀ + β₁x)
```

A key property of the Poisson distribution is **mean = variance = μ** (see Chapter 2 on distributions). `e^β₁` is the **rate ratio**: the factor by which the expected count is multiplied for a unit increase in x.

Exposure and offsets. If hours differ in length, or counts come from systems of different size, model the rate: `ln μ = ln(exposure) + β₀ + β₁x` . The `ln(exposure)` term is an **offset**: a column whose coefficient is forced to 1 (`GLM(..., offset=np.log(exposure))` in `statsmodels` ; not run here). Without it you would compare a 10-minute window with a 60-minute window unfairly.

Problem 8.3.1 Fit Poisson regression for complaints per hour on 300 hours of traffic data.

Compute	(from code): intercept 0.1488 (SE 0.0885), traffic slope 0.3482 (SE 0.0202), 6 iterations. True values used to simulate: 0.2 and 0.35.
Answer	Rate ratio = e^0.3482 = 1.416. Each additional 1,000 orders per hour multiplies the expected complaint count by 1.42, a 42 percent rise.
Check	Slope z = 0.3482/0.0202 = 17.2: very significant. Data mean count 4.37 and variance 9.65: the variance is bigger than the mean, but part of that is explained by the changing μ across hours, not by overdispersion, as the next check shows.
Why it matters	Compounding is the point: 5 more thousand multiplies by $1.416^5 = 5.7$, not by 1 + 5 × 0.42.

Problem 8.3.2 Is the Poisson model a good fit? Use the deviance and the Pearson ratio.

Formula	Residual deviance = `2 Σ [y ln(y/μ̂) − (y − μ̂)]`. Pearson dispersion = `Σ (y − μ̂)² / μ̂ / (n − p)`.
Compute	Deviance = 347.41 on 298 degrees of freedom (300 rows − 2 parameters). Pearson ratio = 1.056.
Answer	For a well-fitting Poisson model both ratios are close to 1. Deviance/df = 1.17 and Pearson = 1.06 are fine. No sign of overdispersion.
Check	Mean and variance of residual counts should be close once μ̂ is used. Pearson near 1.0 says so.
Why it matters	This test costs nothing and prevents wrong confidence intervals.

COMMON MISTAKE

Using Poisson regression without checking dispersion. Real counts are usually more variable than Poisson. The standard errors then come out too small, and everything looks significant.

Connection to the real job. Counts per time unit (orders, tickets, defects, calls), rate modelling with exposure, and demand forecasting inputs. Also the loss in many deep-learning count models.

Applications

- Operations: tickets per day, delivery complaints per week.
- Insurance and healthcare: claim counts, hospital admissions.
- Marketing: purchases per customer.
- Web analytics: page views per session (often overdispersed, see next).

Check yourself

1. Poisson mean = 6. What is its variance? Answer: 6.
2. β = 0.2 in a Poisson model. Rate ratio? Answer: e^0.2 = 1.22.
3. What is an offset for? Answer: To model rates when exposure (time or size) differs between rows.

8.4 Overdispersion and the Negative Binomial Model

INTUITION

The Poisson model assumes every hour with the same traffic has the same complaint rate. In real life some hours are "bad days" (a flash sale, a storm) and others quiet. The rate itself wobbles, so counts vary more than Poisson allows. The negative binomial model adds one more number that measures this wobble.

Formal definition

Overdispersion means variance is greater than the mean. The negative binomial (NB) regression keeps the log link and the mean $\mu = e^{\eta}$, but the variance is

$$\text{Var}(y) = \mu + \alpha \times \mu^2 \qquad (\alpha \geq 0;\ \alpha = 0 \text{ is Poisson})$$

It arises when the Poisson rate is itself random with a Gamma distribution (a "Gamma-Poisson mixture"). A big α means lots of extra wobble.

Problem 8.4.1 Simulate 400 hours where the true model has mean e^(0.2 + 0.3 × traffic) and α = 0.5. Fit Poisson first. Then fit NB.

Step 1	Data: mean count = 3.76 but variance = 15.19. Variance is four times the mean. Red flag.
Step 2	Poisson fit: intercept 0.016, slope 0.3358 (SE 0.0192). Pearson dispersion = 2.87. A value well above 1 confirms overdispersion.
Step 3	The quasi-Poisson fix: multiply the SE by √2.87 = 1.695: slope SE becomes 0.0326, which is 1.7 times larger. The point estimate stays the same.
Step 4	NB fit by maximum likelihood (`scipy.optimize` , BFGS): intercept 0.007, slope 0.3379 (numerical SE 0.0317), α = 0.507. True α was 0.5.
Step 5	Compare: Poisson log-likelihood −1078.21, AIC 2160.4. NB log-likelihood −924.49, AIC 1854.97 (3 parameters including α).
Answer	NB wins by 305 AIC points; α is recovered correctly at 0.507. The Poisson SE (0.0192) was too small by about 40 percent compared to the NB SE (0.0317).
Check	The NB-based SE (0.0317) and the quasi-Poisson SE (0.0326) agree. LR statistic for α = 0 is 307.4 (a very large number, so overdispersion is real).
Why it matters	With the Poisson SE, you would have reported a confidence interval that is 40 percent too narrow, and "significant" results that are not.

The right panel of the figure above shows this. Grey dots are the counts. The solid line is the fitted mean. The dashed line is "mean + 2 standard deviations" under Poisson, which cuts across the cloud, so many dots lie above it. The red dotted line is the same band under NB, wider and about right.

KEY INSIGHT

The slope estimates from Poisson and NB are similar (0.336 versus 0.338). Overdispersion mostly damages the **uncertainty** (SEs, p-values), not the average effect.

Other counts problems you may meet: too many zeros (zero-inflated models), counts that can never be zero (truncated models). Both are extensions; ignore them until you see a histogram with a large spike at 0.

Connection to the real job. `sm.GLM(..., family=sm.families.NegativeBinomial(alpha=…))` or `sm.NegativeBinomial` (the latter

estimates α; not run here). In scikit-learn there is `PoissonRegressor` but no standard NB regressor.

Applications

- Web and product analytics: visits, clicks, purchases per user.
- Epidemiology: case counts by region.
- Reliability: failures per machine across a fleet.

COMMON MISTAKE

Fixing overdispersion by "just switching to linear regression on the log of counts". Zeros break the log, and the variance behaviour is still wrong. Use NB or quasi-Poisson.

Check yourself

1. Variance 15, mean 4: Poisson or NB? Answer: NB (variance far above the mean).
2. What happens to point estimates and SEs when you use Poisson on overdispersed data? Answer: Estimates stay roughly right; SEs are too small.
3. What is α = 0 in NB? Answer: The Poisson model.

8.5 Choosing the Right GLM

Outcome	First model	Check	If it fails
Yes/No	Logistic (logit)	Calibration, separation	Penalised logistic, probit, tree models
Count per time	Poisson (log) + offset	Pearson/deviance ratio near 1	NB or quasi-Poisson
Count with many zeros	Poisson/NB	Compare predicted vs actual zeros	Zero-inflated model
Positive skewed amount (delivery time, cost)	Gamma (log)	Residual plots	Log-transform + OLS, or quantile regression
Proportion out of n trials	Binomial (logit) with weights	Dispersion	Beta-binomial

Any number	Linear (identity)	Chapter on regression diagnostics	Robust regression

REAL JOB TIP

For the late-delivery problem, nothing stops you using time-of-day as a factor, or regularising with L1 (Chapter 7). A GLM is a framework: choose the family from the shape of y, choose the features from the business.

PROFESSOR'S NOTE

Mixed-effects (hierarchical) GLMs, where each customer or branch gets its own small effect, are the next step when rows are grouped. Learn the idea: partial pooling means a group with few rows borrows strength from the others. Not covered in depth here.

Chapter recap

- A GLM has a distribution (family), a linear predictor η, and a link function connecting mean to η.
- Logit link for yes/no, log link for counts, identity for ordinary regression.
- Fit by maximum likelihood using IRLS (repeated weighted least squares), 5 to 8 rounds.
- Logistic: `e^β` is the odds ratio. Odds are not probability; report marginal effects for probability changes.
- Deviance and the likelihood-ratio test compare models; AIC compares non-nested ones; McFadden pseudo-R^2 is not OLS R^2.
- Poisson: `e^β` is a rate ratio, effects multiply; use an offset for unequal exposure.
- Always check dispersion (Pearson/df near 1). If above 1, use negative binomial or quasi-Poisson.
- Overdispersion mostly corrupts the standard errors, not the point estimates.

Item	Formula	Note
Odds, logit	`p/(1−p)`, `ln(p/(1−p))`	logit = η
Inverse logit	`p = 1/(1+e^(−η))`	sigmoid

Odds ratio	`e^β`	CI: `exp(β ± 1.96·SE)`
AME (logit)	`mean(p(1−p)) × β`	percentage points
Poisson	`μ = e^η`, rate ratio `e^β`	mean = variance
NB variance	`μ + αμ²`	α = 0 is Poisson
Deviance	`2(ℓ_sat − ℓ_model)`	LR test = null dev − resid dev
Pearson dispersion	`Σ(y−μ̂)²/μ̂ / (n−p)`	near 1 is good

Practice set

1 (easy). p = 0.75. Give odds and log-odds. **Answer:** Odds = 0.75/0.25 = 3. Log-odds = ln 3 = 1.099.

2 (easy). A logistic coefficient is β = −0.7. What is the OR, and what does it say? **Answer:** e^(−0.7) = 0.497. The odds are halved for each unit increase.

3 (easy). A Poisson model has η = 2. What is the expected count? **Answer:** $e^2 = 7.39$.

4. Output: log-odds = ln(4) for a parcel. What is p? **Answer:** Odds 4, p = 4/(1+4) = 0.8.

5. A logistic model for conversion has intercept −3 and slope 0.5 per page view. Find p for 4 page views and the AME-like slope at that point. **Answer:** η = −3 + 2 = −1. p = 1/(1+e) = 0.269. Slope = p(1−p)β = 0.269 × 0.731 × 0.5 = 0.098 per page view.

6 (find the bug). A report says: "OR = 3.0 for the new UI, so users are 3 times as likely to convert." Baseline conversion was 40 percent. What is wrong, and what is the real new probability? **Answer:** OR describes odds, not probability. Baseline odds = 0.4/0.6 = 0.667. New odds = 2.0. New p = 2/3 = 0.667. Users are 1.67 times as likely (66.7 vs 40 percent), not 3 times.

7. Poisson fit gives Pearson dispersion 3.4 with SE of slope 0.02. What do you do and what is the corrected SE (quasi-Poisson)? **Answer:** Overdispersed. Use NB or quasi-Poisson. Quasi SE = 0.02 × √3.4 = 0.02 × 1.844 = 0.0369.

8. A log-likelihood is −120 for the model and −150 for the intercept-only model, with 3 extra parameters. Compute LR statistic, the McFadden R^2 and say whether it's significant (chi-square

5 percent critical value with 3 df = 7.81). **Answer:** LR = 2 × (−120 − (−150)) = 60 > 7.81, highly significant. McFadden = 1 − 120/150 = 0.20.

9 (scenario). Complaint counts are recorded for windows of 10, 30 and 60 minutes. How do you model them? **Answer:** Poisson (or NB) with a log link and offset ln(window length in minutes), so coefficients describe complaints per minute.

10 (scenario). A logistic model on 20 features has a coefficient of 18.4 on one feature and a convergence warning. What probably happened and what do you do? **Answer:** Perfect or near-perfect separation by that feature. Check the crosstab of that feature against y, remove or bin it, or add L2 regularization.

11 (interview). Explain the odds ratio to a product manager in two sentences. **Answer:** "For every extra 100 orders per hour, the odds that a parcel arrives late go up by about 68 percent (odds ratio 1.68). Odds are a different way to express chance, so in probability terms the jump depends on where you start: from 34 percent it goes to about 47 percent."

12 (interview). Why use negative binomial rather than Poisson, and what changes in your results? **Answer:** Real counts often have variance larger than the mean. Poisson assumes equality, so its standard errors are too small and p-values too optimistic. NB adds a dispersion parameter α with $\mathrm{Var} = \mu + \alpha\mu^2$. The estimated effects stay similar, but standard errors become honest and the fit (AIC) improves a lot when overdispersion is present.

Prompt pack

✨ AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI

```
You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional
moving into data roles. Teach me logistic regression from scratch: odds,
log-odds, the sigmoid link, maximum likelihood and how IRLS or gradient
descent fits it. Use a tiny 6-row dataset I can compute by hand, then a
NumPy version. Explain odds ratios and marginal effects in plain English,
and check my understanding with 4 questions, one at a time.
```

✨ AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI

```
You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional
moving into data roles. Explain generalized linear models: family, linear
predictor, link function, deviance and the likelihood-ratio test. Show how
linear, logistic, Poisson and gamma regression fit into one framework with
```

a table. Then give me 8 graded exercises WITHOUT solutions, using small numbers, and wait for my answers.

✨ AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI

You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional moving into data roles. Teach me Poisson and negative binomial regression for complaint counts per hour. Cover rate ratios, offsets for unequal time windows, overdispersion tests, and why standard errors go wrong under overdispersion. Include a statsmodels example and tell me honestly which output lines to read. Quiz me with 5 scenario questions, one at a time.

✨ AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI

You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional moving into data roles. Review my GLM analysis: [PASTE HERE]. Check that I chose the right family and link, interpreted coefficients on the right scale (odds ratio or rate ratio), checked dispersion or separation, and did not confuse odds with probability. List each problem and show a corrected interpretation in simple English.

✨ AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI

You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional moving into data roles. Run a mock interview on logistic regression, odds ratios, link functions, Poisson regression, overdispersion and negative binomial models. Ask one question at a time, wait for my answer, then give a score out of 10 and a short model answer. Ask 8 questions, easy to hard, with at least two real-world scenarios.

CHAPTER 9

BAYESIAN STATISTICS

Start with what you believe, update with data, and get answers like "there is a 96 percent chance B is better".

Your team ran an A/B test on a checkout page. The frequentist report says "p = 0.08, not significant" and the product manager asks: "So what is the chance that the new page is actually better?" A p-value cannot answer that question. It tells you how surprising the data would be if there were no difference, not how likely it is that B wins. Bayesian statistics answers the manager's question directly. In this chapter you learn the Bayesian recipe (prior, likelihood, posterior), the conjugate shortcuts that make it a few lines of arithmetic, credible intervals, a full Bayesian A/B test with decision-making, and the intuition for MCMC, the computer method used when no shortcut exists. We build on Bayes' theorem from the Math PDF and on the Beta and Gamma distributions from Chapter 2. We also compare honestly with the frequentist way from Chapters 3 and 4.

Running example: an A/B test of a checkout page. Version A: 480 purchases from 4,000 visitors (12.0 percent). Version B: 532 purchases from 4,000 visitors (13.3 percent). All outputs below are computed with NumPy and SciPy (PyMC and Stan are not installed here, so those calls are "not run here").

9.1 The Bayesian Recipe: Prior, Likelihood, Posterior

INTUITION

A doctor sees a patient with a cough. Before any test, she already has a feeling: most coughs are colds. That starting belief is the **prior**. Then she gets a test result, the **evidence**. She combines the two into an updated belief, the **posterior**. If tomorrow another test arrives, today's posterior becomes tomorrow's prior. Learning is a repeated update.

Words you need

Word	Plain meaning	Example
Parameter θ	The unknown number we want to	True conversion rate of page

	learn	A
Prior p(θ)	What we believe about θ before seeing data	"Rates are usually around 10 percent"
Likelihood p(data given θ)	How probable the data is for each possible θ	480 of 4,000 is likely if θ ≈ 0.12
Posterior p(θ given data)	Belief about θ after seeing data	Bell curve around 0.120
Evidence p(data)	A normalising number so the posterior sums to 1	Often ignored; computed by software

Formal definition

Bayes' theorem (Math PDF) applied to a parameter:

```
posterior ∝ likelihood × prior
p(θ | data) = p(data | θ) × p(θ) / p(data)
```

The symbol ∝ means "proportional to". The denominator p(data) is just a constant that makes the area equal to 1.

Frequentists treat θ as a fixed, unknown number and the data as random. Bayesians treat θ as uncertain (described by a distribution) and the data as fixed once observed. So a Bayesian can say "P(θ is between 0.11 and 0.13) = 0.95". A frequentist cannot say this about a single interval.

Problem 9.1.1 (tiny, discrete) A bag holds one coin: either fair (P(heads) = 0.5) or biased (P(heads) = 0.8). You think the bag is fair with probability 0.9. You flip 3 times and see 3 heads. What is the posterior probability that the coin is biased?

Step 1	Prior: fair 0.9, biased 0.1.
Step 2	Likelihood of 3 heads: fair $0.5^3 = 0.125$; biased $0.8^3 = 0.512$.
Step 3	Multiply: fair $0.9 \times 0.125 = 0.1125$; biased $0.1 \times 0.512 = 0.0512$. Sum = 0.1637.
Step 4	Normalise: biased = 0.0512/0.1637 = 0.313; fair = 0.687.
Answer	After 3 heads, the chance the coin is biased rises from 10 percent to 31.3 percent.
Check	Posterior probabilities add to 1 (0.313 + 0.687). The evidence moved the belief toward "biased", as it should, but 3 flips are not enough to overturn a strong prior.
Why it matters	This is the whole method: multiply prior by likelihood, then rescale.

COMMON MISTAKE

Thinking a Bayesian prior is "cheating" or "just opinion". The prior is stated openly, can be weak (let data speak) or informed by past tests, and its influence fades as data grows (section 9.2 shows it with numbers).

Connection to the real job. Spam filters (naive Bayes), A/B testing platforms, recommender cold-start, medical diagnosis, forecasting with uncertainty, and the idea of "prior" in regularization: a ridge penalty is the same as a Normal prior on the coefficients, and lasso is a Laplace prior (Chapter 7).

Applications

- Data Analytics: A/B tests with a direct "probability B is best".
- Data Science: small-data estimates where a sensible prior helps.
- Machine Learning: Bayesian regularization, Bayesian optimisation for tuning, Gaussian processes.
- GenAI: probabilistic reasoning about uncertainty in model outputs.

Check yourself

1. What are the three ingredients of the posterior? Answer: Prior, likelihood (data), and a normalising constant.
2. What does $\propto$ mean? Answer: "Is proportional to": equal up to a constant.

3. Which parameter view is Bayesian: fixed unknown, or distribution? Answer: A distribution describing uncertainty.

9.2 Conjugate Priors: Beta-Binomial, Normal-Normal and Gamma-Poisson

INTUITION

Normally combining prior and likelihood needs hard integrals. But for certain pairs, the posterior has the **same shape** as the prior, only with updated numbers. It is like a score card: you start with "2 wins, 8 losses" as your prior card, add the new wins and losses, and you have the new card. These matching pairs are called **conjugate**.

Beta-Binomial (a rate between 0 and 1)

Prior: θ ~ Beta(a, b). The Beta distribution lives on 0 to 1; read a as "prior successes" and b as "prior failures". Data: k successes in n trials. Then:

```
posterior = Beta(a + k, b + n − k)
posterior mean = (a + k) / (a + b + n)
```

Beta(1, 1) is flat: "any rate is equally likely".

Problem 9.2.1 (tiny) 3 purchases from 10 visitors, flat prior Beta(1, 1). Find the posterior, its mean, mode and 95 percent credible interval.

Step 1	Posterior = Beta(1 + 3, 1 + 7) = Beta(4, 8).
Step 2	Mean = 4/12 = 0.333. Mode = (4 − 1)/(12 − 2) = 0.30, the same as the raw rate 3/10.
Step 3	2.5th and 97.5th percentiles of Beta(4, 8) (from SciPy): 0.109 and 0.610.
Answer	With 10 visitors, the rate is probably between 11 percent and 61 percent: wide, honestly.
Check	The mean (0.333) is pulled slightly toward 0.5 (the flat prior) from 0.30. Fine.
Why it matters	Few data points give a wide interval. The Bayesian answer shows this automatically.

Problem 9.2.2 (prior sensitivity) The same 30 percent rate, seen with 10, 100 and 1,000 visitors, under four different priors. Posterior mean (and 95 percent interval):

Prior	3 of 10	30 of 100	300 of 1000
Beta(1, 1) flat	0.333 (0.109 to 0.610)	0.304 (0.219 to 0.396)	0.300 (0.272 to 0.329)
Beta(2, 8) mean 0.2, weak	0.250 (0.092 to 0.456)	0.291 (0.210 to 0.379)	0.299 (0.271 to 0.328)
Beta(20, 80) mean 0.2, strong	0.209 (0.139 to 0.290)	0.250 (0.193 to 0.312)	0.291 (0.264 to 0.318)
Beta(50, 50) mean 0.5, strong and wrong	0.482 (0.389 to 0.575)	0.400 (0.333 to 0.469)	0.318 (0.291 to 0.346)

- **Read the table** With 10 visitors, the prior dominates: the answers range from 0.209 to 0.482. With 1,000 visitors, all four are within 0.29 to 0.32. A strong wrong prior (the last row) still pulls the answer at n = 1,000 (0.318 vs 0.300) but data has mostly won.
- **Check** By hand for the last row, n = 1000: (50 + 300)/(100 + 1000) = 350/1100 = 0.318. ✓.
- **Answer** The prior matters a lot with little data, and little with a lot of data. This is exactly the behaviour you want. If your conclusion flips under reasonable priors, you do not have enough data.
- **Why it matters** Always run a sensitivity check with a weak and a stronger prior and report if

conclusions change.

Normal-Normal (a mean with known spread)

Prior: $\mu \sim \text{Normal}(\mu_0, \tau^2)$. Data: n observations, sample mean $\bar{x}$, known standard deviation σ. Work with **precision** = 1/variance:

```
posterior precision = 1/τ² + n/σ²
posterior mean = (μ₀/τ² + n·x̄/σ²) / posterior precision
```

The posterior mean is a weighted average of the prior mean and the data mean, with weights equal to the precisions.

Problem 9.2.3 Past months suggest a mean delivery time of 500 minutes with prior SD $\tau = 50$. A new sample: $n = 25$, $\bar{x} = 450$ minutes, $\sigma = 100$ minutes (assumed known). Find the posterior.

Step 1	Prior precision = 1/50² = 0.0004. Data precision = 25/100² = 0.0025. Total = 0.0029.
Step 2	Posterior mean = (500 × 0.0004 + 450 × 0.0025) / 0.0029 = (0.2 + 1.125)/0.0029 = 456.9 minutes.
Step 3	Posterior SD = 1/√0.0029 = 18.57 minutes. 95 percent interval = 456.9 ± 1.96 × 18.57 = 420.5 to 493.3.
Answer	The data got weight 0.0025/0.0029 = 86 percent and the prior 14 percent. The delivery time is about 457 minutes (420 to 493).
Check	The posterior mean lies between 450 and 500, closer to the data. The posterior SD (18.6) is smaller than both the prior SD (50) and the data's SE (100/5 = 20). Combining sources reduces uncertainty.
Why it matters	This weighted-by-precision average is also what Bayesian shrinkage, mixed models and Kalman filters do.

Gamma-Poisson (a rate of events)

Prior: $\lambda \sim \text{Gamma}(\alpha, \text{rate } \beta)$ with mean α/β. Data: counts adding up to S over m periods. Posterior = $\text{Gamma}(\alpha + S, \beta + m)$.

Problem 9.2.4 Prior for customer complaints per hour: Gamma(2, 0.5) (mean 4). We observe

60 complaints in 12 hours. Find the posterior mean and interval.

Step 1	Posterior = Gamma(2 + 60, 0.5 + 12) = Gamma(62, 12.5).
Step 2	Mean = 62/12.5 = 4.96. The raw rate (MLE) is 60/12 = 5.0.
Step 3	95 percent interval (SciPy) = 3.80 to 6.27.
Answer	About 5 complaints per hour, plausibly between 3.8 and 6.3.
Check	The mean (4.96) sits between the prior mean (4) and the data rate (5), very close to the data since the data has 12 "units" against 0.5 for the prior.
Why it matters	Count rates with credible intervals: usable for alerting thresholds.

Data type	Likelihood	Conjugate prior	Posterior update
Yes/No counts	Binomial	Beta(a, b)	Beta(a + k, b + n − k)
Counts per period	Poisson	Gamma(α, β)	Gamma(α + S, β + m)
Mean with known σ	Normal	Normal	precision-weighted average

The picture. The first panel of the figure at the end of 9.3 shows two posterior bell curves. The x-axis is the possible conversion rate, the y-axis is how plausible each rate is. A taller, narrower curve means more certainty.

Connection to the real job. Conjugate updates are used in real-time systems: each click updates two numbers (a, b) per ad. This is how many bandit and ad-ranking systems work cheaply (Thompson sampling: draw one value from each posterior, show the ad with the highest draw).

Applications

- Marketing: click-through-rate estimation for new ads with little data.
- Operations: complaint and late-delivery rates.
- Reliability: failure rates per component type.
- Machine Learning: Bayesian updating inside online learning.

COMMON MISTAKE

Using a prior that is too confident by accident (like Beta(500, 500) "to be safe"). That is 1,000 pseudo-visitors of belief. Read a + b as the prior's "sample size".

Check yourself

1. Prior Beta(5, 15), then 10 successes in 30 trials. What is the posterior? Answer: Beta(15, 35).
2. In normal-normal, which has more weight, the more precise source or the less precise one? Answer: The more precise one.
3. What does the Gamma-Poisson posterior Gamma(α + S, β + m) say about the prior? Answer: The prior counts as α events seen over β periods.

9.3 Credible Intervals and the Bayesian A/B Test

INTUITION

A 95 percent **credible interval** says exactly what people wish a confidence interval said: "given the data and the prior, there is a 95 percent chance the true value lies in this range." It is just the middle 95 percent of the posterior.

Formal definition

An **equal-tailed 95 percent credible interval** runs from the 2.5th to the 97.5th percentile of the posterior. A **highest density interval (HDI)** is the shortest interval holding 95 percent, which matters when the posterior is skewed. For Beta(3, 11), the equal-tailed interval is 0.050 to 0.454 while the HDI is 0.032 to 0.421: shorter, shifted toward the peak.

How does this differ from a confidence interval (Chapter 3)? The confidence interval's 95 percent is a statement about the *method* over repeated experiments. The credible interval's 95 percent is a statement about *this* parameter, but it depends on the prior.

Bayesian A/B test

Recipe: (1) a Beta posterior for each version, (2) draw many samples from each, (3) compare the draws.

Problem 9.3.1 A: 480 of 4,000. B: 532 of 4,000. Flat Beta(1, 1) priors. Compute the posteriors, P(B > A), the lift and the expected loss.

Step 1	Posterior A = Beta(481, 3521): mean 0.1202, 95% interval 0.1103 to 0.1304. Posterior B = Beta(533, 3469): mean 0.1332, 95% interval 0.1228 to 0.1439.
Step 2	Draw 200,000 samples from each, subtract: difference d = θ_B − θ_A.
Step 3	Mean of d = 0.0129 (1.29 percentage points). 95% credible interval for d: −0.0016 to +0.0276.
Step 4	P(B > A) = share of draws where B's rate is bigger = 0.960. Relative lift mean = +11.0 percent, 95% interval −1.2 to +24.3 percent.
Step 5	P(lift is more than half a point) = 0.858.
Step 6	**Expected loss**: if we choose B and we are wrong, how much do we lose on average? `E[max(θ_A − θ_B, 0)]` = 0.00012 (0.012 points). If we choose A and are wrong: `E[max(θ_B − θ_A, 0)]` = 0.01306 (1.3 points).
Answer	There is a 96 percent chance B is better. If we ship B, the average downside is only 0.012 points; if we keep A, the average missed gain is 1.3 points. The decision rule "ship B if expected loss is below a tolerance (say 0.1 points)" says ship B.
Check	The mean difference (0.0129) matches the raw difference 0.1330 − 0.1200 = 0.0130. The interval for d includes 0 slightly (−0.0016), consistent with P(B > A) not being above 0.975.
Why it matters	The manager asked "what is the chance B is better?" and we answered: 96 percent. No p-value gymnastics.

Problem 9.3.2 (compare with the frequentist test) Run the two-proportion z-test on the same data.

Formula	Pooled p = (480 + 532)/8000 = 0.1265; SE = √(p(1−p) × (1/4000 + 1/4000)).
Compute	SE = √(0.1265 × 0.8735 × 0.0005) = 0.007433. z = 0.0130/0.007433 = 1.749. Two-sided p = 0.0803. One-sided p = 0.0401.
Confidence interval for the difference	−0.0016 to +0.0276 (this is almost identical to the Bayesian interval, −0.0016 to 0.0276).
Answer	The frequentist test says "p = 0.08: not significant at 5 percent". The Bayesian says "96 percent chance B is better". The two agree numerically: P(B > A) = 0.960 ≈ 1 − one-sided p (1 − 0.0401 = 0.9599). With a flat prior and lots of data they carry the same information. They only differ in the question they answer and the language they use.
Check	If someone claims one method says "B wins" and the other "no difference", they are using different thresholds, not different evidence.
Why it matters	Neither method hands you the decision. Cost, risk and the size of the effect decide. The Bayesian expected loss makes that step explicit.

Problem 9.3.3 (informative prior) Past tests on this page type suggest conversion near 12 percent, worth about 1,000 visitors of information: prior Beta(120, 880) for both.

Compute	P(B > A) = 0.942 (instead of 0.960).
Answer	The informed prior shrinks both rates toward 12 percent, so the gap shrinks a bit. Conclusion is still "likely B is better", but slightly less sure.
Why it matters	A prior from history is legitimate, but state it and show the sensitivity.

Bayesian A/B posteriors, difference and an MCMC trace

Left: posterior curves for A (blue) and B (orange). They overlap a little in the middle, which is why the answer is 96 percent and not 100 percent. Middle: a histogram of the 200,000 draws of θ_B − θ_A. The black line at 0 marks "no difference". Almost all the mass sits to the right of it. Right: a Metropolis trace, explained in 9.4.

REAL JOB TIP

Report: "B is 1.3 points better on average (95% credible interval −0.2 to +2.8 points); P(B > A) = 96%; expected loss of shipping B is 0.012 points." Executives understand this faster than a p-value.

COMMON MISTAKE

"Peeking and stopping when P(B > A) hits 95 percent." Bayesian tests still need a sensible stopping rule, because early on the probability wanders. Decide the minimum sample or the expected-loss threshold in advance. Bayesian methods are less hurt by peeking than p-values are, but they are not immune.

Connection to the real job. Experimentation platforms (many internal tools and vendors use Beta-Binomial or similar), feature-flag rollouts, ad testing.

Applications

- Product analytics: conversion, retention, click-through.
- Pricing and marketing: ship decisions with a loss tolerance.
- Clinical trials: adaptive designs.
- Quality control: did the fix really reduce defects?

Check yourself

1. P(B > A) = 0.96. Is that a p-value? Answer: No. It is a posterior probability that B's true rate is higher.
2. Why report expected loss? Answer: It combines the chance of being wrong with the size of the mistake, which is what the decision needs.
3. Which interval is shorter for a skewed posterior, equal-tailed or HDI? Answer: The HDI.

9.4 When There Is No Shortcut: MCMC Intuition

INTUITION

Imagine a blind hiker on a hilly field. The height of the ground at each spot is how plausible that parameter value is. The hiker cannot see the whole field, but at any spot she can feel the height. The rule: propose a random step; if the new spot is higher, go there; if lower, go there only sometimes (with probability equal to the ratio of heights). After a long walk, the time she spends in each area is proportional to its height. Her footprints are a sample from the posterior. That is **Markov chain Monte Carlo (MCMC)**.

Why we need it

Most real models (logistic regression with priors, hierarchical models) have no conjugate shortcut. Computing the denominator p(data) needs a high-dimensional integral. MCMC avoids it: the Metropolis rule needs only the ratio of two heights, and the unknown constant p(data) cancels. A **Markov chain** is a walk where the next position depends only on the current one (see the Math PDF on Markov chains). Under mild conditions, the chain's long-run distribution is the posterior.

The Metropolis algorithm

1. Start at some θ.
2. Propose θ′ = θ + step × (a random Normal number).
3. Compute ratio r = posterior(θ′)/posterior(θ). (In logs, subtract.)
4. Accept θ′ with probability min(1, r). Otherwise stay put (and record θ again).
5. Repeat many times. Discard the first part (burn-in), because the chain starts in the wrong place.

Problem 9.4.1 Use Metropolis to sample the posterior for conversion rate A (480 of 4,000, flat prior). We know the exact answer, Beta(481, 3521), so we can check. Start at θ = 0.5, proposal SD 0.01, 20,000 steps.

Step 1	The first values: 0.5, 0.5, 0.4946, 0.4946, 0.4876... The chain starts far away (0.5 is a silly conversion rate) and walks down. Repeated numbers are rejected proposals.
Step 2	Drop the first 1,000 steps (burn-in). Acceptance rate overall: 0.508.
Step 3	Mean = 0.1202, SD = 0.00509, 95 percent interval = 0.1102 to 0.1303.
Answer	The exact posterior has mean 0.12019 and SD 0.00514. The chain matches to three digits.
Check	Exact interval from the Beta: 0.1103 to 0.1304. Matches.
Why it matters	The same code works for models with no formula for the posterior. Only `logpost` changes.

```
def logpost(th, k, n):                      # log of likelihood x flat
prior
    if th <= 0 or th >= 1: return -np.inf   # outside 0..1 is impossible
    return k*np.log(th) + (n-k)*np.log(1-th)

def mh(k, n, step, N=20000, start=0.5, seed=0):
    r = np.random.default_rng(seed); th = start; lp = logpost(th, k, n)
    chain = np.empty(N)
    for i in range(N):
        prop = th + step * r.normal()       # propose a nearby value
        lq = logpost(prop, k, n)
        if np.log(r.uniform()) < lq - lp:   # accept with prob min(1,
ratio)
            th, lp = prop, lq
        chain[i] = th                       # record (even if we stayed)
    return chain
```

Diagnosing a chain

Problem 9.4.2 Same target. What happens with a bad proposal step size?

Step SD	Acceptance rate	Mean after burn-in	SD	Lag-1 autocorrelation	Verdict

0.0001 (too small)	0.883	0.323	0.081	0.99999	Stuck, not yet converged (the true mean is 0.120)
0.01 (good)	0.509	0.1201	0.0051	0.635	Good
0.5 (too big)	0.014	0.1212	0.0052	0.981	Wastes proposals; accepts 1.4 percent

- **Answer** Too-small steps accept almost always but crawl; after 20,000 steps the chain was still walking down from 0.5 (mean 0.32). Too-large steps are almost always rejected, so the chain barely moves. A good step gives an acceptance rate somewhere around 20 to 50 percent and fast-decaying autocorrelation.
- **Check** For the good chain, autocorrelation drops: lag 1 = 0.635, lag 5 = 0.119, lag 20 = −0.015. So roughly every 5th to 10th draw is almost independent; effective sample size is a fraction of the 19,000 draws.
- **Why it matters** A chain that looks fine in the average can still be wrong. Always look at the trace, the autocorrelation, and use several chains.

Several chains and R-hat. Run 2 chains from different starts (0.9 and 0.05). After burn-in their means were 0.12015 and 0.12036. The **R-hat** statistic compares variation between chains with variation within chains; values close to 1 (here 1.0004) mean the chains agree. A common rule: R-hat below 1.01 to 1.05 depending on the guide you follow.

The right panel of the earlier figure shows the trace of the good chain: the first 600 steps. The x-axis is the step number, the y-axis is θ. The line starts at 0.5, drops quickly to about 0.12, and then wanders in a narrow band: a "hairy caterpillar" with no trends is what you want to see.

KEY INSIGHT

Metropolis is the simplest of the family. Modern tools use smarter proposals (Hamiltonian Monte Carlo, the "NUTS" sampler in PyMC and Stan) that use gradients to move efficiently in many dimensions. The ideas (burn-in, trace, R-hat, effective sample size) are the same.

PyMC sketch (not run here):

```
# not run here: PyMC is not installed in this environment
import pymc as pm
with pm.Model():
    pa = pm.Beta("pa", 1, 1); pb = pm.Beta("pb", 1, 1)
    pm.Binomial("ya", n=4000, p=pa, observed=480)
    pm.Binomial("yb", n=4000, p=pb, observed=532)
    pm.Deterministic("diff", pb - pa)
    idata = pm.sample(2000, chains=4)
```

Check names and defaults in the version you install.

Connection to the real job. PyMC, Stan, and NumPyro are the standard tools. You use MCMC for hierarchical models, Bayesian regression with uncertainty, and when a stakeholder needs an interval for something complicated.

Applications

- Data Science: hierarchical models (store-level effects with sharing across stores).
- Machine Learning: Bayesian neural nets, Gaussian processes, Bayesian optimisation.
- Pharma and engineering: calibration and uncertainty of simulation models.

COMMON MISTAKE

Trusting the posterior from a single short chain without checking the trace. The 0.0001-step chain above gave a mean of 0.32 and would have been reported as a wrong answer if nobody looked.

Check yourself

1. Why does p(data) not matter in Metropolis? Answer: Only the ratio of posteriors is used, so the constant cancels.
2. What is burn-in? Answer: The first steps, discarded because the chain started in a wrong place.
3. Acceptance rate 1 percent. Good or bad? Answer: Bad: the steps are too large.

9.5 Frequentist or Bayesian: Which to Use?

Question	Frequentist	Bayesian

What is probability?	Long-run frequency	Degree of belief
What is random?	The data (parameter is fixed)	The parameter (data is fixed)
Interval	Confidence interval (about the method)	Credible interval (about the parameter)
Prior information	Not used formally	Built in through the prior
Typical output	p-value, CI	Posterior, P(B > A), expected loss
Cost	Fast formulas	Needs priors, sometimes MCMC
Works well when	Large samples, standard tests, regulatory settings	Small data, sequential updating, decisions, hierarchical structure

PROFESSOR'S NOTE

With flat priors and plenty of data, both answers agree numerically, as in Problem 9.3.2. Choose by the question: "Is there any effect?" suits tests; "What is the chance B is better and what do we lose if we are wrong?" suits Bayes. A good analyst knows both and can explain the difference. Many data science interviews ask for exactly this.

INTERVIEW TIP

If asked "Is a Bayesian interval better?", answer: "It answers the question people actually ask, but it depends on a prior I must state and test. With lots of data and weak priors they agree."

Chapter recap

- Posterior $\propto$ likelihood × prior; yesterday's posterior is today's prior.
- Beta-Binomial, Gamma-Poisson and Normal-Normal are conjugate: updating is arithmetic on a few numbers.

- Read Beta(a, b) as a prior sample of a successes and b failures; the prior's effect fades as data grows (checked with a table).
- A 95 percent credible interval is the middle 95 percent of the posterior and means what people think a CI means; an HDI is the shortest such interval.
- Bayesian A/B test: sample both posteriors, compute P(B > A), lift, and expected loss. Here P(B > A) = 0.96, matching 1 − one-sided p.
- MCMC (Metropolis) samples a posterior using only height ratios; check burn-in, trace, acceptance rate, autocorrelation and R-hat.
- Ridge is a Normal prior and lasso a Laplace prior: Bayesian ideas appear in earlier chapters.
- Always state your prior and test sensitivity.

Item	Formula	Note
Bayes	`posterior ∝ likelihood × prior`	Normalise at the end
Beta-Binomial	`Beta(a+k, b+n−k)`	mean `(a+k)/(a+b+n)`
Gamma-Poisson	`Gamma(α+S, β+m)`	mean `(α+S)/(β+m)`
Normal-Normal	precision-weighted average	`1/τ² + n/σ²`
Credible interval	2.5th to 97.5th posterior percentile	`stats.beta.ppf`
P(B > A)	`mean(sample_B > sample_A)`	Monte Carlo
Expected loss	`E[max(θ_A − θ_B, 0)]`	for choosing B
Metropolis accept	`min(1, post(θ′)/post(θ))`	20 to 50 percent acceptance

Practice set

1 (easy). Prior Beta(1, 1), data 8 successes in 20 trials. Posterior and mean? **Answer:** Beta(9, 13), mean 9/22 = 0.409.

2 (easy). Prior Gamma(3, 1), data total 20 events over 4 periods. Posterior mean? **Answer:** Gamma(23, 5), mean 4.6.

3 (easy). A disease affects 1 percent. A test has 95 percent sensitivity and 90 percent

specificity. What is P(disease given positive)? **Answer:** True positives 0.01 × 0.95 = 0.0095. False positives 0.99 × 0.10 = 0.099. P = 0.0095/(0.0095 + 0.099) = 0.0876, about 8.8 percent.

4. The Normal-Normal case with prior N(100, 10^2), data n = 4, $\bar{x}$ = 120, σ = 20. Find the posterior mean and SD. **Answer:** Prior precision 0.01, data precision 4/400 = 0.01, total 0.02. Mean = (100 × 0.01 + 120 × 0.01)/0.02 = 110. SD = $1/\sqrt{0.02}$ = 7.07.

5. For A: 50 of 500 and B: 65 of 500 with flat priors, give the two posteriors. Is B probably better? (No simulation needed for the first part.) **Answer:** A ~ Beta(51, 451), mean 0.1016. B ~ Beta(66, 436), mean 0.1315. B is probably better, but the intervals overlap a lot, so you would compute P(B > A) by sampling: simulation gives about 0.93.

6 (find the bug). An analyst says "Our 95 percent credible interval is 0.11 to 0.13, so if we repeat the experiment 100 times, 95 of the intervals will contain the true rate." What is wrong? **Answer:** That is the confidence-interval meaning. The credible interval says: given this data and prior, there is 95 percent probability the parameter lies in 0.11 to 0.13.

7 (find the bug). A Metropolis run has an acceptance rate of 98 percent and the trace is a slowly drifting line. What is wrong and how do you fix it? **Answer:** The proposal step is too small, so the chain crawls and has not explored or converged. Increase the step size until acceptance is roughly 20 to 50 percent, run longer, and check several chains.

8. Why does the answer from Problem 9.2.2 for Beta(50, 50) at n = 1000 differ from 0.300? **Answer:** The prior carries the weight of 100 pseudo-observations at 0.5. The mean is (50 + 300)/(100 + 1000) = 0.318, still pulled by the prior.

9 (scenario). Your manager wants to stop an A/B test as soon as P(B > A) reaches 95 percent. Advise. **Answer:** Probabilities wander early in a test and can cross 95 percent by chance. Fix a minimum sample size, and a decision rule with expected loss (e.g. stop when expected loss of the leader is below 0.1 points, after at least N visitors). Simulate the rule on fake A = B data to see how often it falsely stops.

10 (scenario). A new product has 3 sales in 20 visitors; the category average is about 10 percent. How would you estimate its rate? **Answer:** Use a prior around 10 percent, e.g. Beta(10, 90) (worth 100 visitors of belief) or weaker Beta(2, 18). Posterior with Beta(2, 18): Beta(5, 35), mean 0.125. The raw 15 percent is too noisy to trust with 20 visitors.

11 (interview). Explain the difference between a confidence interval and a credible interval to a non-technical colleague. **Answer:** A confidence interval is about the procedure: if we repeated the study many times, 95 percent of such intervals would contain the true value. A credible

interval is about this one result: given the data and our starting beliefs, there is a 95 percent chance the true value is inside. People usually believe the second is what the first says.

12 (interview). What is MCMC and when would you use it? **Answer:** A way to draw samples from a posterior when we cannot calculate it exactly. A chain of random steps is built so that its long-run visits follow the posterior, using only ratios of posterior heights. Use it when the model has no conjugate shortcut (hierarchical or non-linear). Check burn-in, trace, effective sample size and R-hat, and use tools like PyMC or Stan.

Prompt pack

✨ **AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI**

```
You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional
moving into data roles. Teach me Bayesian inference from scratch: prior,
likelihood, posterior, and Bayes' theorem for a parameter. Use a tiny
discrete example (two coins), then the Beta–Binomial model for a
conversion rate with a table of how different priors behave with 10, 100
and 1000 data points. Ask me 4 check questions, one at a time.
```

✨ **AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI**

```
You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional
moving into data roles. Explain conjugate priors (Beta–Binomial, Gamma–
Poisson, Normal–Normal) with fully worked small-number examples. Then give
me 8 graded exercises WITHOUT solutions, and wait for my answers. Include
one exercise on choosing a prior for a rate when I have past data.
```

✨ **AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI**

```
You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional
moving into data roles. Walk me through a Bayesian A/B test in Python with
NumPy and SciPy: Beta posteriors, Monte Carlo draws, P(B > A), credible
interval for the lift, and expected loss. Compare it with a two-proportion
z-test on the same numbers. Then explain how I should present the result
to a product manager.
```

✨ **AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI**

```
You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional
```

moving into data roles. Explain MCMC with the blind-hiker analogy, then implement the Metropolis algorithm in NumPy for a one-parameter posterior. Show what burn-in, step size, acceptance rate, trace plots, autocorrelation and R-hat mean. Then review my code: [PASTE HERE] and point out any bugs.

✨ AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI

You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional moving into data roles. Run a mock interview on Bayesian statistics: priors, credible versus confidence intervals, Bayesian A/B testing, conjugacy and MCMC. Ask one question at a time, wait for my answer, then give a score out of 10 and a model answer in simple English. Ask 8 questions from easy to hard.

CHAPTER 10

TIME SERIES STATISTICS

Forecasting data that arrives in order: stationarity, ACF and PACF, ARIMA, exponential smoothing, and honest forecast evaluation.

You track the monthly order volume of an online shop and the warehouse team asks: "How many orders will we see next year, and how wrong could you be?" Ordinary statistics assumes rows are independent, like draws from a bag. Time series data breaks that: this month is strongly related to last month and to the same month last year. Ignore this and your confidence intervals lie and your cross-validation leaks the future. In this chapter you learn what makes a series predictable (trend, season, memory), the idea of stationarity and how to test it, how to read the ACF and PACF plots, how ARIMA and SARIMA models work, how exponential smoothing works, and how to evaluate forecasts correctly against simple baselines. We build on regression (Chapters 7 and 8), AIC from Chapter 7, and normal distributions.

Running example: 120 months (10 years) of simulated order volume in thousands, built as `100 + 0.8 × month + yearly seasonal wave + AR(1) noise`, fixed seed. We train on the first 108 months and keep the last 12 as a test. The series starts 106.0, 101.1, 108.2, ... and ends 172.8, 182.8, 187.7. `statsmodels` is not installed here, so I wrote the ACF, PACF, ADF test, Holt-Winters and ARIMA fitting in NumPy/SciPy. In real work you will call `statsmodels.tsa` (for example `ARIMA`, `SARIMAX`, `ExponentialSmoothing`, `adfuller`); those calls are "not run here" and you should check argument names in your version.

10.1 What Makes a Time Series Different: Trend, Season, Noise

INTUITION

Think of daily traffic at a shop. There is a slow upward drift (the shop is growing: **trend**), a weekly or yearly pattern (busy weekends, busy December: **seasonality**), and random bumps (a rainy day: **noise**). A forecaster's job is to separate the three, so the pattern that repeats can be projected forward and the noise is honestly reported as uncertainty.

Words you need

Word	Plain meaning	Example
Time series	Numbers recorded in time order	Orders per month
Trend	Slow long-term rise or fall	+0.8k per month
Seasonality	Pattern repeating at a fixed period	12-month cycle
Period m	Length of one season	12 for monthly data with a yearly cycle
Noise / residual	What is left after trend and season	Random wobble
Lag	How many steps back we look	Lag 12 = same month last year
Horizon h	How many steps ahead we forecast	Next 12 months

Additive decomposition

`y_t = trend_t + season_t + noise_t`. (If the seasonal wave grows with the level, use multiplicative: `trend × season × noise`, or take logs first.) Classical decomposition: (1) estimate the trend with a centred moving average over one full period, (2) subtract it, (3) average the leftovers for each month to get the seasonal pattern, then centre it to sum to zero.

Problem 10.1.1 (tiny) A 4-quarter series: Q1 = 10, Q2 = 14, Q3 = 12, Q4 = 8, with no trend. What is the seasonal index for each quarter?

Step 1	Average level = (10 + 14 + 12 + 8)/4 = 11.
Step 2	Index = value − level: Q1 = −1, Q2 = +3, Q3 = +1, Q4 = −3.
Answer	Indices −1, +3, +1, −3, which sum to 0.
Check	Sum is 0 by construction, and level + index returns the original values.
Why it matters	"Q2 runs 3 above average" is a statement the business can use.

Problem 10.1.2 (realistic) Decompose the 108 training months with a 12-month centred

moving average.

Trend	A straight line fitted through the moving average has slope 0.788 per month and intercept 100.17. We built the data with slope 0.8 and intercept 100.
Seasonal indices (Jan to Dec)	5.4, 11.0, 9.9, 7.0, 10.0, 10.7, 5.0, −6.4, −16.7, −19.2, −13.5, −3.1. The true wave (centred) was 6.0, 10.5, 10.0, 9.0, 10.0, 10.5, 6.0, −4.5, −16.0, −21.0, −16.0, −4.5.
Answer	The method recovered the trend almost exactly and the seasonal pattern to within about 3. September to November are the low months (about 14 to 19 thousand below trend).
Check	The 12 indices sum to 0 after centring. The moving average loses 6 values at each end, so we only fit the trend on the middle 96 months.
Why it matters	Capacity planning, staffing and promotions all use the season pattern.

COMMON MISTAKE

Treating the order of rows as irrelevant: shuffling, random train/test split, or random K-fold. The model then sees the future. Always split by time (train on the past, test on later months).

Connection to the real job. `statsmodels.tsa.seasonal.seasonal_decompose` and `STL` do this. Retail and operations work: order counts, footfall and queue lengths all have daily and weekly seasonality and trends from growth.

Applications

- Data Analytics: KPI dashboards (weekly seasonality adjusted).
- Data Science: demand and capacity forecasting.
- MLOps: monitoring drift and anomaly detection on shop traffic.
- Finance and supply chain: sales, inventory.

Check yourself

1. What is the period for daily data with a weekly cycle? Answer: m = 7.
2. When use multiplicative decomposition? Answer: When the seasonal swing grows with the

level of the series.

3. Why is a random train/test split wrong for time series? Answer: It leaks future information into training.

10.2 Stationarity and Differencing

INTUITION

A stationary series is like a steady heartbeat on a monitor: it goes up and down, but its average level and its wobble size stay the same over time, so the past is a fair guide to the future. A series with a trend is like a patient whose heart rate is slowly climbing: the "average" depends on when you look. Most forecasting models need stationarity. If your data is not stationary, you transform it until it is.

Formal definition

A series is (weakly) **stationary** if (1) its mean is constant over time, (2) its variance is constant, and (3) the correlation between two values depends only on how far apart they are (the lag), not on when they occur.

Examples: white noise (independent random values) is stationary. A **random walk** `y_t = y_{t−1} + e_t` is not: its variance grows with time. A series with trend or season is not.

Differencing replaces each value by the change: `Δy_t = y_t − y_{t−1}`. This removes a linear trend and turns a random walk into white noise. **Seasonal differencing** `y_t − y_{t−m}` removes a repeating season.

The ADF test

The **Augmented Dickey-Fuller (ADF)** test asks: does the series have a **unit root** (random-walk-like behaviour)? It regresses the change on the previous level: `Δy_t = a + γ·y_{t−1} + (lagged Δy terms) + error`. If γ = 0, the series is a random walk. The test statistic is `γ̂ / SE(γ̂)`, but it does NOT follow a normal or t distribution, so the critical values come from special tables. For a regression with a constant, the usual large-sample 5 percent critical value is about −2.86 (1 percent: −3.43, 10 percent: −2.57). **Null hypothesis: unit root (non-stationary). To call a series stationary you need a statistic more negative than the critical value.** The null and alternative here are the opposite way from what many people expect.

Problem 10.2.1 Compute the ADF statistic (constant, no extra lags) for three simulated series of length 300: an AR(1) with φ = 0.7, a random walk, and the differenced random walk.

Series	ADF statistic	5% critical	Decision
AR(1), φ = 0.7	−6.57	−2.86	Reject unit root: stationary
Random walk	−0.83	−2.86	Cannot reject: non-stationary
Differenced random walk	−16.37	−2.86	Reject: stationary

- **Answer** The test correctly flags the random walk as non-stationary, and differencing once makes it stationary. Our hand-made code agrees with the textbook idea; `statsmodels.tsa.stattools.adfuller` (not run here) reports the same statistic and also a p-value.
- **Check** For the random walk, the estimated γ is −0.0024, almost 0, which is what a unit root means: yesterday's level carries over fully.
- **Why it matters** Fitting regression or ARMA to a non-stationary series produces "spurious" patterns that look real and are not.

Problem 10.2.2 Apply ADF (with one lagged difference) to the running example.

Series	ADF statistic	Decision at 5% (−2.86)
Original y (trend + season)	−2.37	Cannot reject: non-stationary
First difference Δy	−6.57	Reject: stationary
Seasonal difference (lag 12)	−4.99	Reject: stationary

- **Answer** The raw series needs differencing. For a model, we use both one ordinary and one seasonal difference (d = 1, D = 1).
- **Check** The original series has a rising trend of 0.8 per month, so it cannot have a constant mean.
- **Why it matters** Number of differences d and D are model settings you choose here.

COMMON MISTAKE

Differencing too much. Differencing a series that is already stationary adds noise and a strong negative autocorrelation at lag 1. Use d = 1 or 2 only when the test and the plot demand it. Also remember ADF has low power if the series is only slightly non-stationary, and its result depends on whether you include a trend term (`regression="c"` or `"ct"` in `adfuller`).

Connection to the real job. Stationarity checks are step one before ARIMA. Variance that grows with level is fixed with a log or Box-Cox transform. In ML-based forecasting, the same idea appears as "predict the change, not the level".

Applications

- Economics and finance: returns (differenced log prices) instead of prices.
- Operations: traffic changes week to week.
- Anomaly detection: model the stationary residual, alert on its outliers.

Check yourself

1. What is the null hypothesis of the ADF test? Answer: The series has a unit root (is non-stationary).
2. ADF statistic −1.2, critical −2.86. Conclusion? Answer: Not stationary (cannot reject the unit root).
3. What does seasonal differencing with m = 12 do? Answer: Subtracts the value from 12 months ago, removing a yearly pattern.

10.3 ACF and PACF: Reading the Memory of a Series

INTUITION

The **autocorrelation function (ACF)** answers: "how similar is today to k days ago?" If traffic on lag 7 is highly correlated with today's, you have a weekly rhythm. The **partial autocorrelation function (PACF)** answers a sharper question: "how related is today to k days ago after removing the effect of all the days in between?" Think of rumours in an office: A tells B, B tells C. A and C are correlated, but only through B. The PACF strips out the middleman.

Formal definition

Autocorrelation at lag k: $r_k = \Sigma (y_t - \bar{y})(y_{t+k} - \bar{y}) / \Sigma (y_t - \bar{y})^2$. It is like a correlation coefficient between the series and itself shifted by k. About 95 percent of the ACF values of white noise lie within the band $\pm 1.96/\sqrt{n}$. Anything outside the band is likely a real pattern.

Problem 10.3.1 (tiny, by hand) y = [2, 4, 6, 5, 3]. Find r_1 and r_2.

Step 1	Mean = 20/5 = 4. Deviations: −2, 0, +2, +1, −1.
Step 2	Denominator = 4 + 0 + 4 + 1 + 1 = 10.
Step 3	Lag 1 numerator: (−2)(0) + (0)(2) + (2)(1) + (1)(−1) = 0 + 0 + 2 − 1 = 1. So r_1 = 1/10 = 0.1.
Step 4	Lag 2 numerator: (−2)(2) + (0)(1) + (2)(−1) = −4 + 0 − 2 = −6. So r_2 = −0.6.
Answer	r_1 = 0.1, r_2 = −0.6.
Check	Code printed 1.0, 0.1, −0.6 (the first is lag 0). Same.
Why it matters	Every ACF bar in a plot is this simple computation.

Reading the plots: signatures of the basic models

Model	What it means	ACF	PACF
AR(p) autoregressive	Today depends on the last p values	Decays slowly (geometric or wave)	Cuts off after lag p
MA(q) moving average	Today depends on the last q random shocks	Cuts off after lag q	Decays slowly
ARMA(p, q)	Both	Decays	Decays
Random walk or trend	Not stationary	Very slow decay, near 1	Big spike at lag 1
Seasonal (m = 12)	Repeats yearly	Spikes at 12, 24, 36	Spikes at 12 (and 24)

Problem 10.3.2 Simulate an AR(1) series `y_t = 0.7·y_{t−1} + e_t` with 300 points. Read its ACF and PACF.

Compute	ACF lags 1 to 6: 0.742, 0.552, 0.415, 0.339, 0.257, 0.198. PACF lags 1 to 6: 0.742, 0.002, 0.011, 0.059, −0.039, 0.007. The band is ±1.96/√300 = ±0.113.
Answer	ACF decays smoothly (about 0.742^k: 0.742, 0.551, 0.409... matches). PACF has one big spike at lag 1 and then nothing inside the band. This is the signature of AR(1), and r_1 = 0.742 estimates φ (true 0.7).
Check	The theory says ACF at lag k is φ^k. 0.742² = 0.551, close to the measured 0.552.
Why it matters	The plots point to the model order before you fit anything.

Problem 10.3.3 For the random walk, the ACF lags 1 to 6 are 0.991, 0.981, 0.972, 0.962, 0.953, 0.942. Interpret.

Answer	An ACF that stays near 1 and decays very slowly means the series is non-stationary. Difference it before reading the ACF.
Why it matters	A "pretty" ACF with huge bars is a warning, not a model.

Time series, ACF, PACF and forecasts

Top left: the 120 months of volume. A dashed line at month 108 separates training from test. You see a rising line with a yearly wave. Top right: the ACF bars of the AR(1) series for lags 0 to 20; red dashed lines are the ±0.113 band. Bars decay slowly from 0.74 and stay positive. Bottom left: the PACF of the same series: one bar at lag 1, then all bars inside the red band. Bottom right: the last 24 months and three 12-month forecasts (section 10.6).

COMMON MISTAKE

Reading the ACF of a non-stationary series. Always make the series stationary first. Another trap: with 20 lags, one bar in 20 will cross the 95 percent band by chance. One lone bar at an odd lag is not a pattern.

Connection to the real job. `plot_acf` and `plot_pacf` from `statsmodels.graphics.tsaplots` (not run here), `df.autocorr(lag)` in pandas. Residuals of a good model should show no ACF pattern, which you test with the Ljung-Box test (section 10.4).

Applications

- Detecting seasonality in traffic and logs.
- Feature engineering for ML: choosing lag features (lag-1, lag-7).
- Checking that a model has captured all the structure.

Check yourself

1. PACF cuts off after lag 2, ACF decays. Which model? Answer: AR(2).
2. What band do we use for white noise ACF? Answer: ±1.96/√n.
3. ACF near 0.99 at lag 1 and decays very slowly: what does it signal? Answer: Non-stationarity (trend or random walk). Difference the series.

10.4 ARIMA and SARIMA

INTUITION

ARIMA is three simple ideas glued together. **AR**: today is partly predicted by recent days. **I**: first difference the series to remove the trend. **MA**: today is also pushed by recent surprises (forecast errors) from yesterday and before. The model finds the best mix.

Formal definition

ARIMA(p, d, q):

- p = number of lagged values (AR terms)
- d = number of differences

- q = number of lagged forecast errors (MA terms)

On the differenced series `w_t` :

```
w_t = c + φ₁·w_{t−1} + … + φ_p·w_{t−p} + e_t + θ₁·e_{t−1} + … +
θ_q·e_{t−q}
```

Here `e_t` is white noise (a fresh random shock each step). Stationarity of the AR part requires φ values inside certain limits (for AR(1): |φ| < 1).

SARIMA(p,d,q)(P,D,Q)m adds the same ideas at the seasonal lag m. For example (0,1,1)(0,1,1)12, often called the "airline model": difference once, seasonally difference once, then `w_t = e_t + θ·e_{t−1} + Θ·e_{t−12} + θΘ·e_{t−13}` . The last term comes from multiplying the two MA pieces.

How do we fit? Maximum likelihood, in practice. Our code uses a simpler cousin, **conditional least squares**: choose parameters that minimise the sum of squared one-step errors `e_t` , computing each `e_t` from the previous ones. It gives nearly the same answer for long series. `statsmodels` uses exact maximum likelihood with a Kalman filter.

Problem 10.4.1 Simulate 400 points from an ARIMA(1,1,1) with true φ = 0.6 and θ = 0.3 (and a small drift). Choose p and q by AIC and BIC on the differenced series. Then forecast.

(p, q)	AIC	BIC	Estimates
(0, 0)	1475.57	1483.55	mean 0.074
(0, 1)	1232.79	1244.75	θ = 0.691
(1, 0)	1169.15	1181.11	φ = 0.734
(1, 1)	**1154.65**	**1170.60**	**φ = 0.603, θ = 0.292**
(1, 2)	1156.05	1176.00	φ = 0.652, θ = 0.239, −0.059
(2, 1)	1155.88	1175.83	
(2, 2)	1157.83	1181.76	

- **Answer** Both AIC and BIC pick ARIMA(1,1,1), and the estimates φ = 0.603 and θ = 0.292 recover the truth (0.6, 0.3). Larger models improve fit by less than the penalty (see Chapter

7).

- **Check** The simplest model's AIC (1475.6) is 321 points worse than the best. Models with more terms are within about 1 to 3 AIC points, which is within noise.
- **Why it matters** The "best" model by AIC is usually the simple correct one. Prefer parsimony.

Problem 10.4.2 (forecast and its uncertainty) Use the fitted (1,1,1) to forecast 5 steps ahead from the last value 128.21.

Step 1	Forecast of the differences: 0.891, 0.561, 0.362, 0.242, 0.169. They shrink, because the AR part pulls changes back to their small mean (0.059).
Step 2	Add them up from the last level: 128.21 + 0.891 = 129.10, then 129.66, 130.03, 130.27, 130.44.
Step 3	Uncertainty: the shock effects on the level are psi weights 1, 0.895, 0.54, 0.326, 0.197. Standard error at horizon h = `σ × √(Σ of squared cumulative psi weights)`. With σ² = 1.037, SEs are 1.02, 2.18, 3.30, 4.34, 5.28.
Answer	One step ahead: 129.10 with 95 percent interval 127.1 to 131.1. Five steps ahead: 130.44 ± about 10.4 (1.96 × 5.28).
Check	The SE at h = 1 (1.018) equals the residual SD √1.037 = 1.018, as it must.
Why it matters	Forecast intervals widen with the horizon. An ARIMA with d = 1 has no upper limit on the widening, which is honest: far-future guesses are uncertain.

Problem 10.4.3 (SARIMA on the running example) Fit SARIMA(0,1,1)(0,1,1)12 to the 108 training months by conditional least squares.

Compute	θ = −0.743, Θ = −0.623 (conditional least squares, code). Forecast the 12 test months.
Answer	First four forecasts 193.3, 199.6, 199.9, 198.1 versus actual 194.2, 208.8, 209.5, 209.6. Over the 12 test months, MAE = 5.05, RMSE = 6.23.
Check	Ljung-Box test on the residuals (10 lags): Q = 7.94, p = 0.44. A p-value this large means no leftover autocorrelation. The model has captured the structure. (The degrees of freedom were 10 − 2 = 8 for the two fitted parameters.)
Why it matters	A model is good when residuals look like white noise and forecasts beat simple baselines (section 10.6).

Fitting recipe (Box-Jenkins):

1. Plot. Transform if the variance grows with level (log).
2. Difference until stationary (ADF and plots): choose d and D.
3. Read the ACF and PACF to guess p, q, P, Q (or search with AIC).
4. Fit. Check residuals: ACF within band, Ljung-Box p above 0.05.
5. Forecast with intervals. Evaluate on a held-out future period.

```
# not run here: statsmodels is not installed in this environment
from statsmodels.tsa.statespace.sarimax import SARIMAX
m = SARIMAX(train, order=(0,1,1), seasonal_order=(0,1,1,12)).fit()
print(m.summary())                # coefficients, AIC, BIC, Ljung-Box
fc = m.get_forecast(12)
fc.predicted_mean, fc.conf_int()  # forecast and interval
```

COMMON MISTAKE

Choosing a very high-order ARIMA to chase the training fit. As in Chapter 7, more parameters always fit the past better. Use AIC and out-of-time evaluation. Another trap: comparing AIC values for models with different d. They are on different data (differenced versus not) and cannot be compared.

Connection to the real job. ARIMA/SARIMA is the classic benchmark. Even if you finally use Prophet, gradient boosting, or neural networks for forecasting, you are expected to beat a SARIMA or exponential smoothing baseline. Explaining a model using the language of ACF and residual checks is an interview topic.

Applications

- Warehouse capacity planning from order volume.
- Retail and supply-chain demand forecasts.
- Energy load forecasting.
- Finance (with caution): volatility models extend ARIMA (ARCH/GARCH, only mentioned).

Check yourself

1. What does d = 1 mean? Answer: Difference the series once before modelling.
2. SARIMA(1,0,0)(0,1,0)12: what does it do? Answer: A seasonal difference at lag 12 plus an AR(1) on the result.
3. Why check residuals? Answer: If structure is left in them, the model has missed something and its intervals are wrong.

10.5 Exponential Smoothing

INTUITION

To forecast tomorrow, take a weighted average of all past days, but give more weight to recent days. Weights fall by a constant factor each step back, like a memory that fades. This is **exponential smoothing**. A single number α (0 to 1) controls how fast memory fades: α near 1 reacts quickly to new data, α near 0 is slow and smooth.

Formal definition

Simple exponential smoothing (SES) (no trend, no season): keep a level `L`. Forecast = L. After seeing a new value y: `L_new = α·y + (1 − α)·L_old`. Equivalent: the new level = old level + α × (forecast error). It is a running average that "learns from its mistakes".

Holt's method adds a trend: level L and slope T, with smoothing β. **Holt-Winters** adds seasonal values S, with smoothing γ. Additive form:

```
forecast(t + k) = L + k·T + S(same season last cycle)
L_new = α·(y − S_old) + (1 − α)·(L + T)
T_new = β·(L_new − L) + (1 − β)·T
S_new = γ·(y − L_new) + (1 − γ)·S_old
```

Exponential smoothing and ARIMA are different families that overlap: SES is the same as ARIMA(0,1,1) with $\theta = -(1 - \alpha)$.

Problem 10.5.1 (tiny SES by hand) y = [10, 12, 11, 13], α = 0.5. Start with level = first value, 10.

Step 1	Forecast for point 2 = 10. Actual = 12, so the new level = 0.5 × 12 + 0.5 × 10 = 11.
Step 2	Forecast for point 3 = 11. Actual = 11. New level = 0.5 × 11 + 0.5 × 11 = 11.
Step 3	Forecast for point 4 = 11. Actual = 13. New level = 0.5 × 13 + 0.5 × 11 = 12.
Answer	The forecast for point 5 is 12.0. Code printed the forecasts 10, 11, 11 and final level 12.0.
Check	If α = 1 the forecast equals the last value (naive). If α = 0 it never changes. 0.5 is a balance.
Why it matters	This tiny loop is the entire algorithm; seasonal versions just keep more states.

Problem 10.5.2 Estimate α for SES on the random walk (300 points) by minimising the squared one-step error.

Answer	Best α = 0.999, essentially 1. For a random walk the best forecast of tomorrow is today, so smoothing is pointless. For a stable series with noise around a level, α would be small.
Why it matters	α is estimated from the data; it tells you how much "memory" the series has.

Problem 10.5.3 (Holt-Winters on the running example) Fit additive Holt-Winters (period 12) on the 108 training months by minimising squared one-step errors (L-BFGS-B, bounds 0.001 to 0.999).

Compute	α = 0.248, β = 0.001 (at the lower bound), γ = 0.600. SSE = 3017.3. Forecast the 12 test months: MAE = 5.29, RMSE = 5.99.
Answer	β at its bound means the trend is nearly fixed, consistent with a constant straight-line trend. γ = 0.6 means the seasonal pattern adapts fairly quickly.
Check	The result is very close to SARIMA's MAE (5.05), as is usual: both families model the same patterns.
Why it matters	Holt-Winters is simple, fast and hard to beat for monthly business series.

Connection to the real job. `statsmodels.tsa.holtwinters.ExponentialSmoothing` and the ETS family (not run here). Used for demand forecasting at scale because it fits quickly for thousands of series.

Applications

- Retail and inventory forecasting per product.
- Store staffing and footfall baselines.
- Anomaly detection: flag points far outside the smoothed forecast band.

COMMON MISTAKE

Using SES for data with trend or season. SES forecasts a flat line. Match the method to the structure: SES (level), Holt (level and trend), Holt-Winters (level, trend, season).

Check yourself

1. What does α = 1 give? Answer: The naive forecast (tomorrow equals today).
2. Which smoothing parameter controls the seasonal part? Answer: γ.
3. SES level 20, new actual 30, α = 0.2. New level? Answer: 0.2 × 30 + 0.8 × 20 = 22.

10.6 Forecast Evaluation

INTUITION

A forecast is only good compared with something. "Our model has an error of 5 thousand" means nothing until you know that "just repeat last year" has an error of 10. So always race your model against simple baselines, on data the model has never seen, in time order.

The baselines

- **Naive:** next value = last value.
- **Seasonal naive:** next value = same month last year.

The metrics

Metric	Formula	Notes
MAE	mean of abs(error)	Same units as data; easy to explain
RMSE	√ mean of error²	Punishes big misses more
MAPE	mean of abs(error/actual) × 100	In percent; breaks when actual is near 0
MASE	MAE of model / MAE of a naive forecast on training data	Below 1 means better than naive; unit-free

Here MASE uses the in-sample seasonal-naive MAE (average of $|y_t - y_{t-12}|$ over the training data) as the scale. This is the version for seasonal data.

Problem 10.6.1 Evaluate five forecasts on the 12 test months (months 109 to 120).

Method	MAE	RMSE	MAPE %	MASE
Naive (repeat last value)	13.79	16.17	7.01	1.34
Seasonal naive	10.56	11.94	5.39	1.03
Decomposition: trend line + seasonal indices	5.34	7.21	2.69	0.52
Holt-Winters (additive)	5.29	5.99	2.75	0.51

SARIMA(0,1,1)(0,1,1)12	**5.05**	6.23	**2.59**	**0.49**

- **Answer** All three real models beat both baselines by half. SARIMA has the best MAE and MAPE, Holt-Winters the best RMSE. The three are close: with only 12 test points you should not claim one is truly better.
- **Check** Naive MAE 13.79 is large because the series keeps climbing and swings with the season, so "last value" misses both. Seasonal naive (10.56) captures the season but misses a year of growth, around 0.8 × 12 = 9.6 thousand. This matches its error of about 10.
- **Why it matters** If your fancy model's MASE were above 1, it would be worse than doing nothing clever.

Rolling-origin evaluation (time series cross-validation). One 12-month test is a single draw of luck. Instead, move the forecast origin forward step by step: train up to month 60, forecast month 61; train up to 61, forecast 62; and so on, then average the errors. The training window always ends before the forecasted point, so there is no leakage. In our one-step-ahead test over months 61 to 119, MAE for naive = 6.70 and for seasonal naive = 10.37. Here, for 1-step forecasts, naive beats seasonal naive, because the AR(1) noise makes the last value very informative and yearly growth hurts seasonal naive. So the best baseline depends on the horizon: always test the horizon you will use.

Prediction intervals should be checked too: of the 12 test points, about 95 percent should fall inside the 95 percent interval. Over many origins, count how many do (coverage). Intervals that are too narrow are a common sin.

COMMON MISTAKE

Reporting MAPE when actual values can be 0 or near 0 (division blows up), or averaging errors from only one origin and calling it the "accuracy". Also scoring on data used to pick the model: set aside a final test period for the single honest score.

Connection to the real job. Business forecasting reviews, and MLOps backtests: "the model beat seasonal naive in 8 of 10 rolling windows" is a strong statement. In Python: `sklearn.model_selection.TimeSeriesSplit` , `sktime` , `statsmodels` .

Applications

- Demand and capacity: choose the model that is best at the horizon you actually plan for.

- Finance: backtesting strategies without leaking the future.
- ML: time-aware cross-validation for any model using lag features.

Check yourself

1. MASE = 0.5. Meaning? Answer: Error is half that of the naive benchmark.
2. Why not use random K-fold for forecasting? Answer: It trains on the future and tests on the past: leakage.
3. Why use rolling-origin evaluation instead of one test set? Answer: It averages over many forecast origins, so the score is less a matter of luck.

Chapter recap

- A time series has trend, season and noise; decompose it to understand and forecast it.
- Stationary means constant mean, variance and lag-dependent correlation. Difference to get there (d for trend, D for season).
- ADF tests for a unit root: the null is non-stationary; a statistic below about −2.86 (constant case, 5 percent) rejects it.
- ACF shows memory at each lag; PACF shows the direct effect. AR: PACF cuts off; MA: ACF cuts off; slow ACF decay near 1 means non-stationary.
- ARIMA(p, d, q) combines AR, differencing and MA; SARIMA adds the seasonal version. Choose orders with AIC or BIC, then check residuals (Ljung-Box).
- Exponential smoothing keeps a decaying-weight average: SES (level), Holt (+trend), Holt-Winters (+season).
- Always compare to naive and seasonal naive baselines, and evaluate in time order, with rolling origins.
- Prediction intervals widen with the horizon, and should be checked for coverage.

Item	Formula or call	Note
Difference	`Δy = y_t − y_{t−1}` ; seasonal `y_t − y_{t−m}`	removes trend / season
ACF	`r_k = Σ(y_t−ȳ)(y_{t+k}−ȳ)/Σ(y_t−ȳ)²`	band ±1.96/√n
ADF	`Δy_t = a + γy_{t−1} + …`	reject if stat < −2.86 (5%, const)

AR(1) ACF	`ϕ^k`	PACF cuts off at 1
ARIMA	`ARIMA(order=(p,d,q))`, `SARIMAX(seasonal_order=(P,D,Q,m))`	`statsmodels`
SES	`L_new = αy + (1−α)L_old`	forecast = L
MASE	MAE / naive MAE (training)	below 1 beats naive
Ljung-Box	`Q = n(n+2) Σ r_k²/(n−k)`	p > 0.05 good

Practice set

1 (easy). Monthly sales Jan to Mar of one year: 100, 120, 110. Differences? **Answer:** 20 and −10.

2 (easy). Compute r_1 for y = [1, 3, 2, 4]. (Mean 2.5.) **Answer:** Deviations −1.5, 0.5, −0.5, 1.5. Denominator: 2.25 + 0.25 + 0.25 + 2.25 = 5. Numerator: (−1.5)(0.5) + (0.5)(−0.5) + (−0.5)(1.5) = −0.75 − 0.25 − 0.75 = −1.75. r_1 = −0.35.

3 (easy). SES with α = 0.3, old level 50, new actual 60. New level? **Answer:** 0.3 × 60 + 0.7 × 50 = 18 + 35 = 53.

4. An AR(1) has φ = 0.8. What are the ACF values at lags 1, 2, 3? **Answer:** 0.8, 0.64, 0.512.

5. ACF of white noise with n = 100: what is the 95 percent band? **Answer:** ±1.96/√100 = ±0.196.

6. Model errors on 4 test points: 3, −5, 2, −6. Actuals: 50, 80, 40, 60. Compute MAE, RMSE, MAPE. **Answer:** MAE = (3 + 5 + 2 + 6)/4 = 4. RMSE = √((9 + 25 + 4 + 36)/4) = √18.5 = 4.30. MAPE = (3/50 + 5/80 + 2/40 + 6/60)/4 × 100 = (0.06 + 0.0625 + 0.05 + 0.10)/4 × 100 = 6.81 percent.

7 (find the bug). A student shuffles a monthly sales table, does 5-fold CV with lag features, and gets an error of 2 percent. In production, the error is 9 percent. Why? **Answer:** Shuffled folds train on later months and test on earlier ones, and lag features copy neighbouring values. This leaks the future. Use a time-ordered split or rolling-origin evaluation.

8 (find the bug). ADF gives −1.8 with 5 percent critical value −2.86. The analyst writes "p is not below 0.05 so the series is stationary". What is wrong? **Answer:** The ADF null is a unit root (non-stationary). Failing to reject means we cannot call the series stationary; it is probably non-

stationary. Difference it and test again.

9. The PACF of a differenced series has spikes at lag 1 and 2 only; ACF decays. Which model do you try, and how do you confirm? **Answer:** AR(2) on the differenced data: ARIMA(2,1,0). Confirm with AIC against nearby orders, residual ACF within the band, and Ljung-Box p above 0.05.

10 (scenario). Weekly traffic data has a strong weekly cycle (m = 7 daily points) and growth. Outline your forecasting approach. **Answer:** Plot and decompose. Check variance (log if the swing grows). Apply seasonal differencing (m = 7) and perhaps ordinary differencing; confirm with ADF. Fit SARIMA(p,d,q)(P,D,Q)7 or Holt-Winters with m = 7. Check residuals. Compare to naive and seasonal-naive on rolling origins, with MASE. Report forecasts with intervals.

11 (interview). What is the difference between AR and MA terms in ARIMA? **Answer:** AR terms regress the series on its own past values (memory of levels). MA terms regress on past forecast errors (memory of shocks). The PACF cutting off suggests AR; the ACF cutting off suggests MA.

12 (interview). Your forecast model has MAPE 8 percent. Is it good? **Answer:** Unknown until compared with baselines on the same test data. Check naive and seasonal naive (MASE below 1), the forecast horizon, whether the test was in time order, and whether intervals have proper coverage. Also check that MAPE is not distorted by actuals near zero, and whether the business cares about errors in units rather than percentage.

Prompt pack

✨ **AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI**

```
You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional
moving into data roles. Teach me stationarity, differencing and the
Augmented Dickey-Fuller test for time series. Use tiny hand-computable
examples first, then a NumPy simulation of a random walk versus an AR(1).
Make sure I understand the null hypothesis of ADF. Ask me 4 check
questions, one at a time, and wait for my answers.
```

✨ **AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI**

```
You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional
moving into data roles. Explain ACF and PACF with a hand computation on 5
numbers, then show me what the ACF and PACF look like for AR(1), AR(2),
MA(1) and a seasonal series. Give me 8 graded exercises WITHOUT solutions,
```

where I must name the model from a description of the plots.

✨ AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI

You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional moving into data roles. Walk me through fitting an ARIMA and a SARIMA model with statsmodels on monthly order volume: choose d and D, choose p and q with AIC, check the residuals with the Ljung-Box test, and forecast with intervals. Explain every line of the summary output in simple English. Then review my code: [PASTE HERE].

✨ AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI

You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional moving into data roles. Teach me simple exponential smoothing, Holt's method and Holt-Winters step by step with small numbers I can compute by hand, then in Python. Explain the roles of alpha, beta and gamma and how exponential smoothing relates to ARIMA. Quiz me with 5 questions, one at a time.

✨ AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI

You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional moving into data roles. Run a mock interview on time series statistics: stationarity, ACF and PACF, ARIMA and SARIMA, exponential smoothing, and forecast evaluation (naive baselines, MASE, rolling-origin evaluation, leakage). Ask one question at a time, wait for my answer, then give a score out of 10 and a model answer in simple English. Ask 8 questions.

CHAPTER 11

SURVIVAL ANALYSIS AND MIXED (HIERARCHICAL) MODELS

Two tools for data that most simple models handle badly: "time until something happens" and "data that comes in groups".

Picture two questions from a real business. First: "How long does a new subscriber stay before cancelling?" Many have not cancelled yet, so their final stay is unknown. Second: "What is the typical delivery time (in minutes) of each of our 200 depots?" Some depots have thousands of deliveries, some only three. A plain average or plain regression gives wrong or over-confident answers for both. Survival analysis solves the first problem and mixed (hierarchical) models solve the second. You will build the main ideas by hand with small numbers, reusing the exponential distribution (Chapter 2) and MLE (Chapter 3). The libraries `lifelines` and `statsmodels` are not installed where this chapter was written, so their calls are marked "not run here". Everything else uses `numpy` and `scipy`, and every number was computed.

11.1 Time-to-Event Data and Censoring

INTUITION

You start a stopwatch on ten customers the day they sign up. You must write the report on day 12. Some customers have already left. Others are still there. You cannot write "stayed 12 days" for a customer who is still active, because they may stay 40 more. But you also cannot throw them away, because "survived at least 12 days" is real information. Survival analysis is the method that keeps this half-known information instead of lying about it.

Words you need

Word	Plain meaning	Example
Event	The thing we wait for	Customer cancels, machine breaks down, loan defaults
Duration (time)	Time from the start until the event or until we stop watching	5 months

Censored	We stopped watching before the event happened, so we only know "at least this long"	Still subscribed at month 12
Survival function S(t)	Probability that the event has NOT happened by time t	S(6) = 0.46
Hazard h(t)	Risk of the event in the next instant, given you survived until t	9% per month

Each row of survival data has two columns: `time` and `event` (1 = event seen, 0 = censored).

The running example

We will use ten subscribers for the whole chapter. Time is in months.

Customer	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
time	2	3	3	5	6	6	8	9	12	12
event	1	1	0	1	1	1	0	1	0	0

Customer 3 (time 3, event 0) was lost at month 3 without cancelling. Customers 9 and 10 are still active at month 12, the end of the study.

Problem 11.1.1 What average stay do you get if you (a) average all ten times as if every customer had cancelled, and (b) average only the customers who cancelled? Why are both wrong?

Step 1	All ten times: 2+3+3+5+6+6+8+9+12+12 = 66. Mean = 66 / 10 = 6.6 months.
Step 2	Only the six cancellers (events = 1): times 2, 3, 5, 6, 6, 9, sum = 31. Mean = 31 / 6 = 5.17 months.
Answer	(a) is 6.6 and (b) is 5.17. Method (a) treats "still active at month 12" as "left at month 12", so it is too small for the people still active. Method (b) throws away the long stayers, so it is biased low.
Check	We can verify with code below: `t.mean()` and `t[e==1].mean()`.
Why it matters	Censoring is the reason ordinary averages and ordinary regression fail on duration data. Dropping censored rows always makes retention look worse than it is.

```
import numpy as np
t=np.array([2,3,3,5,6,6,8,9,12,12])
e=np.array([1,1,0,1,1,1,0,1,0,0])
print("mean naive all",t.mean(), "mean events only",t[e==1].mean())
```

Real output:

```
mean naive all 6.6 mean events only 5.166666666666667
```

Where it is used: churn and customer lifetime (Data Science), time between failures (SRE), time to readmission (Healthcare), model drift time (MLOps).

COMMON MISTAKE

Computing "average tenure" from only the customers who already left. This is the survival analysis version of survivorship bias, and it is very common in dashboards. Always ask: "who is still active, and where did they go in my calculation?"

Check yourself

1. A customer is still active at month 7. What are their `time` and `event`? Answer: time = 7, event = 0.
2. Why is deleting censored rows wrong? Answer: it removes the long stayers and biases durations low.

3. Is "machine still working after 90 days" censored? Answer: yes, we only know it lasted at least 90 days.

11.2 The Kaplan-Meier Estimator

INTUITION

Think of a marathon with runners dropping out. At each moment someone drops, ask: "Of the runners still on the road, what fraction just dropped?" The chance of lasting past that point is the previous survival chance times (1 − that fraction). Runners who leave the race for another reason (censored) simply stop counting from then on. You multiply these small survival fractions along the road.

How it works

Look at each time t_i where at least one event happened.

- n_i = number **at risk**: customers still being watched just before t_i (time ≥ t_i).
- d_i = number of events at t_i.
- Fraction who fail at that moment: d_i / n_i.
- Kaplan-Meier (KM) estimate: $S(t) = \text{product over } t_i \le t \text{ of } (1 - d_i / n_i)$.

The name: Kaplan and Meier published this in 1958. The curve is a staircase: flat between events and a step down at each event. Censored customers cause no step, but they shrink n_i later, which makes later steps bigger.

Problem 11.2.1 Four customers have (time, event): (2,1), (4,0), (5,1), (7,1). Compute the KM survival curve.

Formula	S(t) = ∏ (1 − d/n) over event times
Step 1	At t=2: n = 4 at risk, d = 1. Factor = 1 − 1/4 = 0.75. S(2) = 0.75.
Step 2	At t=4: a censoring, not an event, so no step. S stays 0.75. But the customer leaves the risk set.
Step 3	At t=5: at risk = customers with time ≥ 5 → the ones at 5 and 7, so n = 2, d = 1. Factor = 0.5. S(5) = 0.75 × 0.5 = 0.375.
Step 4	At t=7: n = 1, d = 1. Factor = 0. S(7) = 0.
Answer	S = 0.75 after month 2, 0.375 after month 5, 0 after month 7.
Check	If we wrongly treated the censored customer as an event at t=4, we would get S(4) = 0.75 × (1 − 1/3) = 0.5 and S(5) = 0.5 × (1 − 1/2) = 0.25. The correct answer 0.375 is higher, as it should be, because we do not know that customer left.
Why it matters	The same arithmetic, just with bigger tables, is what `KaplanMeierFitter` in `lifelines` does.

Problem 11.2.2 Compute the KM table for the ten-customer running example.

```
S=1.0
print("time n_risk d  q  S")
for u in sorted(set(t[e==1])):
    n=(t>=u).sum(); d=((t==u)&(e==1)).sum()
    S*=1-d/n
    print(u,n,d,round(d/n,4),round(S,4))
```

Predict first: what is S after month 6? Real output:

```
time n_risk d  q  S
2 10 1 0.1 0.9
3 9 1 0.1111 0.8
5 7 1 0.1429 0.6857
6 6 2 0.3333 0.4571
9 3 1 0.3333 0.3048
```

- **Line by line** `t>=u` counts everyone still watched at time u. At month 3 there is one event and one censoring; the censored customer leaves the risk set, so at month 5 it is 7, not 8.

- **Check by hand** 0.9 × (1 − 1/9) = 0.8; 0.8 × (1 − 1/7) = 0.6857; 0.6857 × (1 − 2/6) = 0.4571; 0.4571 × (1 − 1/3) = 0.3048.
- **Answer** The KM median survival is the first time S drops to 0.5 or below: month 6 (S = 0.4571). Estimated chance of lasting past month 9 is 30%.

In `lifelines` the same result is (not run here):

```
from lifelines import KaplanMeierFitter
kmf = KaplanMeierFitter()
kmf.fit(durations=t, event_observed=e)
print(kmf.median_survival_time_)
```

Where it is used: retention curves by cohort (Data Analytics), comparing churn of two plans (Data Science), hours until half of a disk fleet fails (Reliability), time to first purchase where non-buyers are censored (Marketing).

COMMON MISTAKE

Reading the end of a KM curve as precise. At the right end only a few customers remain at risk, so one cancellation makes a big step and the estimate is very uncertain. Always show the confidence band and the number at risk under the curve.

Check yourself

1. If nobody is censored, what does KM reduce to? Answer: the plain fraction of customers still alive (the empirical survival function).
2. Does a censored customer cause a step down? Answer: no, but they leave the risk set.
3. What is the median survival? Answer: the first time when S(t) ≤ 0.5.

11.3 Hazard, a Simple Model, the Log-rank Test and Cox Regression

INTUITION

Survival S(t) is "how many are still in the room". Hazard is "how fast people are leaving the room right now, among those still in it". Two rooms can have the same number of people now but very different exit speeds. Hazard is the speed. Models in survival analysis usually work with hazards, because it is natural to say "this plan makes the leaving speed 2 times higher".

The constant-hazard (exponential) model

If the hazard is a constant `λ` (for example 9% per month), then the time to the event follows the exponential distribution from Chapter 2, and `S(t) = e^(−λt)`. With censoring, the MLE (Chapter 3 idea) is simple:

```
λ̂ = (number of events) / (total time everyone was observed)
```

The bottom is called **exposure**: all months watched, from events and censored people alike. The **median survival** is `ln(2) / λ̂`.

Problem 11.3.1 Using the ten customers: 6 events and 66 total months of exposure. Estimate λ and the median.

Formula	λ̂ = events / exposure; median = ln 2 / λ̂
Plug in	λ̂ = 6 / 66
Compute	λ̂ = 0.0909 per month. Median = 0.6931 / 0.0909 = 7.62 months. Approximate standard error λ̂ / √events = 0.0909 / 2.449 = 0.0371.
Answer	About 9.1% of active customers cancel each month. The model says half are gone by month 7.6.
Check	KM said median 6 months; the exponential model says 7.6. They differ because ten points are very few, and a constant hazard may not be true. Always compare a parametric model with KM.
Why it matters	Events divided by exposure is the same idea as breakdowns per million machine-hours; censored time counts in the denominator.

Real output:

```
events 6 exposure 66 rate 0.09090909090909091 median 7.624618986159398
se rate 0.037113480951260276
```

Comparing two groups: the log-rank test

Suppose the first five customers are on a monthly plan (group A) and the last five on an annual plan (group B). The **log-rank test** asks: if the two groups had the same hazard, how many events would we expect in group A at each event time, given who is at risk? At each event time with `n` at risk (`nA` in A), `d` events: expected events in A is `d × nA / n`. Add up expected events, compare with observed events, and divide the squared gap by the sum of variances. The result follows a chi-square distribution (Chapter 2) with 1 degree of freedom.

Group A is times 2,3,3,5,6 (events 1,1,0,1,1). Group B is times 6,8,9,12,12 (events 1,0,1,0,0). At every event time we compute `EA = d*nA/n` and a variance `d*(nA/n)*(nB/n)*(n-d)/(n-1)`. The table from that loop:

```
logrank table: time nA nB d dA  EA  var
2 5 5 1 1 0.5 0.25
3 4 5 1 1 0.4444 0.2469
5 2 5 1 1 0.2857 0.2041
6 1 5 2 1 0.3333 0.2222
9 0 3 1 0 0.0 0.0
O 4 E 1.5634920634920635 V 0.923217435122197 chi2 6.430306338268405 p
0.011218922741739133
```

Problem 11.3.2 Read the table. What does it say?

Step 1	Group A had 4 observed cancellations (O = 4).
Step 2	If A and B had the same risk, we would expect only E = 0.5 + 0.444 + 0.286 + 0.333 + 0 = 1.563 in A.
Step 3	Test statistic = $(4 - 1.563)^2$ / 0.923 = 5.936 / 0.923 = 6.43.
Answer	The p-value is 0.011. Monthly-plan customers cancelled earlier than annual-plan customers more than chance explains, in this tiny toy sample.
Why it matters	In practice you call `lifelines.statistics.logrank_test` (not run here), but it is only "observed versus expected events at each event time".

Cox proportional hazards regression

KM and log-rank handle one grouping variable. Real questions have many: plan type, country, age, number of support tickets. **Cox regression** (David Cox, 1972) models the hazard like this:

$$h(t \mid x) = h_0(t) \times \exp(\beta_1 x_1 + \beta_2 x_2 + \ldots)$$

- $h_0(t)$ is the **baseline hazard**: an unknown curve shared by everyone. Cox's trick is that you never need to estimate it.
- $\exp(\beta)$ is the **hazard ratio (HR)**: the factor by which the hazard is multiplied when x goes up by 1. HR = 1 means no effect. HR = 0.5 means half the leaving speed.
- "Proportional" means the ratio between any two customers stays constant over time. This is the main assumption, and you must check it.

How is β found? At each event time, ask: "Given that exactly one customer in the risk set fails now, how likely is it to be the one who did?" That is $\exp(\beta \cdot x_i)$ / sum over risk set of $\exp(\beta \cdot x_j)$. Multiplying over event times gives the **partial likelihood**, which we maximise (the MLE idea of Chapter 3).

Problem 11.3.3 Fit a Cox model with one binary variable $x = 1$ for the annual plan, using our ten customers.

```
from scipy.optimize import minimize
def nll(b):                          # negative log partial likelihood
    ll=0
    for i in np.where(E==1)[0]:
        R=T>=T[i]                    # risk set at this event time
        ll+=b*G[i]-np.log(np.exp(b*G[R]).sum())
    return -ll
r=minimize(lambda z:nll(z[0]),[0.0])
b=r.x[0]; print("beta",r.x,"HR",np.exp(r.x))
h=1e-4; se=1/np.sqrt((nll(b+h)-2*nll(b)+nll(b-h))/h**2)   # curvature of
the loglik
print("se",se,"ci",np.exp(b-1.96*se),np.exp(b+1.96*se),"loglik",-r.fun,-
nll(0.0))
```

`T, E, G` are times, events and group codes (0 = monthly, 1 = annual). Real output:

```
beta [-2.39196532] HR [0.09144978]
se 1.1539892590234444 ci 0.009525486613028183 0.8779669083001508 loglik
-8.334197210954885 -11.127851046509797
```

- **Step 1** $\hat{\beta} = -2.392$.
- **Step 2** Hazard ratio = e^(−2.392) = 0.0914.
- **Step 3** 95% CI for β: −2.392 ± 1.96 × 1.154, then exponentiate: from 0.0095 to 0.878.
- **Answer** The annual plan has about 91% lower cancellation hazard in this toy sample. But the interval is huge (0.01 to 0.88) because there are only 10 customers and 6 events.
- **Check** The log-likelihood improved from −11.13 (β = 0) to −8.33. Twice the gap is 5.59, a likelihood-ratio statistic comparable to the log-rank 6.43; the two tests are closely related, as theory says.
- **Why it matters** In a real churn model you would add many columns. Reading `exp(coef)` as "this feature multiplies the leaving speed by this factor" is the whole skill.

Note: our loop uses Breslow handling of tied event times; `lifelines` uses Efron by default, so its numbers can differ slightly. With 10 customers, do not trust the effect size.

With `lifelines` (not run here):

```
from lifelines import CoxPHFitter
cph = CoxPHFitter()
cph.fit(df, duration_col="time", event_col="event")   # df has time,
event, plan_annual, ...
cph.print_summary()                                   # shows coef,
exp(coef)=HR, CI, p
cph.check_assumptions(df)                             # tests proportional
hazards
```

Applications: churn drivers with confidence intervals (Data Science), effect of firmware on time to failure (Reliability), time to default (Finance), survival forests that predict a whole curve per customer (Machine Learning, same data format).

COMMON MISTAKE

Treating a hazard ratio as a ratio of probabilities or of times. HR 0.5 means half the instantaneous risk, not half the time to the event and not "50% more likely to survive". Also: never ignore the proportional hazards assumption. If a feature's effect fades over time (a promotion that helps for 2 months), HR is not constant and one number misleads.

Check yourself

1. 12 events in 400 customer-months: what is λ̂? Answer: 12 / 400 = 0.03 per month.

2. exp(β) = 1.8 for "has a support ticket". Meaning? Answer: the cancellation hazard is 1.8 times higher.
3. What does Cox regression NOT need to estimate? Answer: the baseline hazard shape.

11.4 Grouped Data and the Idea of Partial Pooling

INTUITION

You record delivery times for 200 depots. Depot A has 3 deliveries, average 400 minutes. Depot B has 3,000 deliveries, average 400 minutes. Do you believe both equally? No. The mean of A is shaky. A good analyst pulls the shaky mean a bit toward the typical depot, and leaves the solid mean almost alone. That pulling is called **shrinkage**, and the model that does it automatically is a **mixed (hierarchical) model**.

The problem with the two simple answers

- **Complete pooling**: one global average; erases real differences.
- **No pooling**: each group alone; noisy for small groups, and the extreme groups are mostly noise.
- **Partial pooling**: a compromise whose weight depends on each group's amount of data.

The random-intercept model

For observation j in group g:

$y_{gj} = \mu + a_g + \varepsilon_{gj}$, with $a_g \sim \text{Normal}(0, \tau^2)$ and $\varepsilon_{gj} \sim \text{Normal}(0, \sigma^2)$

- μ is the overall mean (a **fixed effect**: one number you want to know).
- a_g is the group's own deviation (a **random effect**: you do not care about each exactly, you model them as draws from a population of groups).
- τ^2 = variance between groups. σ^2 = variance inside groups (noise).
- The **intraclass correlation (ICC)** = $\tau^2 / (\tau^2 + \sigma^2)$: the share of total variance that belongs to groups. It also equals the correlation between two measurements from the same group.

Given known τ^2, σ^2, the best estimate for group g with n observations and sample mean $\bar{y}$ is

$\text{estimate} = w \times \bar{y} + (1 - w) \times \mu$, where $w = \tau^2 / (\tau^2 + \sigma^2/n)$

`w` is the weight on the group's own data. It goes to 1 for large `n` and towards 0 for small `n`. This formula comes from Bayes thinking in Chapter 1 and the Math PDF: a prior (the population of groups) combined with data.

Problem 11.4.1 Three depots with mean delivery times: A has n = 1, $\bar{y}$ = 400 min. B has n = 4, $\bar{y}$ = 300. C has n = 25, $\bar{y}$ = 220. Suppose $\mu = 250$, $\tau^2 = 400$, $\sigma^2 = 900$. Compute the partially pooled estimates.

Formula	$w = \tau^2 / (\tau^2 + \sigma^2/n)$; estimate = $\mu + w(\bar{y} - \mu)$
Plug in	(A) $w = 400 / (400 + 900/1) = 400 / 1300 = 0.3077$. (B) $w = 400 / (400 + 225) = 0.64$. (C) $w = 400 / (400 + 36) = 0.9174$.
Compute	(A) $250 + 0.3077 \times 150 = 296.15$. (B) $250 + 0.64 \times 50 = 282.0$. (C) $250 + 0.9174 \times (-30) = 222.48$.
Answer	A's single 400-minute delivery is pulled hard, to 296 min. B is pulled a little, to 282. C, with 25 observations, hardly moves (220 to 222.5).
Check	Each estimate lies between $\bar{y}$ and μ, and the one with more data stays closer to its own mean. ICC = 400 / 1300 = 0.31.
Why it matters	Without shrinkage, the "slowest depot" list is dominated by depots with few deliveries. This is a classic ranking error (also seen in "best-rated restaurant with one 5-star review").

Estimating τ^2 and σ^2 from data

Usually μ, τ^2, σ^2 are unknown. A mixed model estimates them by maximum likelihood (or REML, a version that corrects a small-sample bias in the variance estimates). This means choosing numbers to maximise the probability of seeing your data (Chapter 3). Below we do this by hand with `scipy.optimize`. The data is simulated: 8 endpoints with 3 to 60 measurements each, true values $\mu = 250$, $\tau = 30$, $\sigma = 40$.

```
from scipy.optimize import minimize
rng=np.random.default_rng(7)
ns=[3,5,5,8,10,20,40,60]
true=rng.normal(250,30,8)                       # true group means (tau =
30)
data={g:rng.normal(true[g],40,ns[g]) for g in range(8)}   # sigma = 40
def nll(p):                           # negative log-likelihood, random-
intercept model
    mu,lt,ls=p; tau2=np.exp(lt); sig2=np.exp(ls); ll=0
    for v in data.values():
        v=np.array(v); n=len(v); ybar=v.mean(); ssq=((v-ybar)**2).sum()
        logdet=(n-1)*np.log(sig2)+np.log(sig2+n*tau2)
        quad=ssq/sig2+n*(ybar-mu)**2/(sig2+n*tau2)
        ll+=-0.5*(n*np.log(2*np.pi)+logdet+quad)
    return -ll
r=minimize(nll,[250,np.log(500),np.log(500)],method='Nelder-Mead')
mu,tau2,sig2=r.x[0],np.exp(r.x[1]),np.exp(r.x[2])
print("mu",mu,"tau",np.sqrt(tau2),"sig",np.sqrt(sig2),"icc",tau2/(tau2+sig
2))
print("g n true_mean nopool pool w   err_nopool err_pool")
en=[];ep=[]
for g,v in data.items():
    w=tau2/(tau2+sig2/len(v)); pool=mu+w*(v.mean()-mu)
    en.append(v.mean()-true[g]); ep.append(pool-true[g])
    if g in (0,2,5,7):
print(g,len(v),round(true[g],1),round(v.mean(),1),round(pool,1),round(w,3)
,round(abs(en[-1]),1),round(abs(ep[-1]),1))
print("(rows 1, 3, 4, 6 omitted here)")
print("rmse nopool",np.sqrt(np.mean(np.square(en))),"rmse
pool",np.sqrt(np.mean(np.square(ep))))
```

Each group has covariance $\sigma^2 I + \tau^2 J$ (J = matrix of ones); we optimise log-variances so variances stay positive. `data` maps group to its list of measurements (simulated with seed 7). Real output:

```
mu 235.42360650224833 tau 27.111764766589932 sig 34.74153480227205 icc
0.37849611266801203
g n true_mean nopool pool w   err_nopool err_pool
0 3 250.0 241.7 239.5 0.646 8.3 10.5
2 5 241.8 187.1 199.0 0.753 54.7 42.7
5 20 220.3 227.9 228.4 0.924 7.6 8.2
7 60 290.2 282.8 281.5 0.973 7.4 8.7
(rows 1, 3, 4, 6 omitted here)
rmse nopool 21.855767120709817 rmse pool 17.655586280690347
```

Problem 11.4.2 Interpret the output.

Step 1	The model recovered $\tau \approx 27.1$ (true 30), $\sigma \approx 34.7$ (true 40), ICC ≈ 0.38.
Step 2	Group 2 (n = 5): raw mean 187.1, true 241.8, pooled 199.0, so the error falls from 54.7 to 42.7.
Step 3	Overall RMSE falls from 21.9 (no pooling) to 17.7 (partial pooling).
Answer	Partial pooling made the estimates better on average, mostly by helping small groups. It does not help every group: groups 0, 1, 5, 6 and 7 got slightly worse. Gains are on average, not guaranteed for each group.
Check	The weights increase with n (0.646 at n = 3, 0.973 at n = 60), as the formula says.
Why it matters	One seed and 8 groups is a demonstration, not a proof; the gain is an average effect.

With `statsmodels` (not run here, standard usage):

```
import statsmodels.formula.api as smf
m = smf.mixedlm("delivery_min ~ 1", df, groups=df["depot"]).fit()
print(m.summary())        # shows the fixed intercept, the group variance
and the residual variance
```

Applications: fair ranking of stores or depots (Data Analytics), A/B tests across many countries and repeated measures per user (Data Science), target encoding of high-cardinality columns, which is partial pooling in disguise (Machine Learning), user and item biases in recommenders.

COMMON MISTAKE

Treating 1,000 rows from 10 users as 1,000 independent observations ("pseudoreplication"). Rows from the same user are correlated, so standard errors are far too small and p-values far too optimistic. Use a mixed model, or cluster-robust errors, or aggregate per user first.

Check yourself

1. A group has n = 1. Is its w large or small? Answer: small; its mean is pulled strongly to the overall mean.
2. $\tau^2 = 100$, $\sigma^2 = 300$: what is the ICC? Answer: 100 / 400 = 0.25.

3. Fixed or random effect: "the effect of plan type" versus "the effect of each of 5,000 stores"? Answer: plan type fixed; stores random.

11.5 Random Slopes and Going Further

A random intercept says "each depot has its own starting level". A **random slope** adds "each depot also reacts differently to order volume". Each group gets its own line, shrunk toward the average line: `y = (μ + a_g) + (β + b_g) × volume + ε`. In `statsmodels`: `smf.mixedlm("delivery_min ~ load", df, groups=df["depot"], re_formula="~load")` (not run here). Ignore for now: crossed random effects, non-normal outcomes (generalized linear mixed models, which join Chapter 8's GLMs with random effects), Bayesian hierarchical models (Chapter 9 priors do the shrinking), and survival "frailty" models. "Mixed", "multilevel", "hierarchical" and "random-effects" model all name the same family.

Chapter recap

- Duration data has censoring: for some people you only know "at least this long". Deleting them, or treating them as events, biases results.
- Kaplan-Meier multiplies (1 − d/n) at each event time; censored people only shrink the risk set.
- Exponential rate = events / exposure; the log-rank test compares observed and expected events between groups.
- Cox regression gives hazard ratios `exp(β)` without a baseline; check proportional hazards.
- Mixed models handle grouped data and avoid pseudoreplication.
- Partial pooling pulls small-group means toward the overall mean; ICC says how much the group matters.

Formula / command	Meaning
$S(t) = \prod (1 - d_i/n_i)$	Kaplan-Meier
$\hat{\lambda}$ = events / exposure; median $\ln 2 / \hat{\lambda}$	Exponential model
`h(t\	x) = $h_0(t) \exp(\beta x)$`

`ICC = τ²/(τ²+σ²)` ; `w = τ²/(τ²+σ²/n)`	Mixed model
`KaplanMeierFitter` , `CoxPHFitter` , `smf.mixedlm`	Libraries (not run here)

Practice set

Problem 11.6.1 A customer is still subscribed 9 months after sign-up. What do you record?

Answer: time = 9, event = 0 (censored): they lasted at least 9 months.

Problem 11.6.2 5 cancellations over 200 customer-months. Estimate the monthly rate and the median lifetime.

Answer: 5 / 200 = 0.025 per month; median = ln 2 / 0.025 = 27.7 months.

Problem 11.6.3 Four customers (time, event): (2,1), (4,0), (5,1), (7,1). What is S(5)?

Answer: S(2) = 3/4 = 0.75. At t=5 two customers remain at risk, so S(5) = 0.75 × (1 − 1/2) = 0.375.

Problem 11.6.4 What is the output? `print(np.cumprod(1 − np.array([1,1])/np.array([4,3])))`

Answer: `[0.75 0.5]` (4 at risk with 1 event, then 3 at risk with 1 event).

Problem 11.6.5 Cox model: HR = 0.5 for "uses the mobile app". Interpret it and find β.

Answer: Half the instantaneous cancellation hazard, other features fixed. β = ln 0.5 = −0.693.

Problem 11.6.6 Find the bug: churn = cancellations / customers, comparing a plan with many new sign-ups against an old plan.

Answer: New sign-ups had little time to cancel, so that plan looks better. Use KM or events / exposure.

Problem 11.6.7 $\tau^2 = 100$, $\sigma^2 = 400$, a group has $n = 4$, $\bar{y} = 60$, $\mu = 50$. Pooled estimate and ICC?

Answer: w = 100 / (100 + 100) = 0.5, estimate = 50 + 0.5 × 10 = 55. ICC = 100 / 500 = 0.20.

Problem 11.6.8 (Interview) Why not run linear regression on tenure after deleting customers who have not churned?

Answer: Deleting them removes the long stayers and biases durations low. Survival methods

keep censored rows in the risk sets without pretending the event happened.

Problem 11.6.9 (Interview) 1,000 page-load times from 20 users; you test a new design. What do you watch for?

Answer: Rows are clustered by user, so they are not independent. Use a mixed model with a random intercept per user, or average per user. A plain t-test on 1,000 rows gives standard errors that are too small.

Prompt pack

✨ AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI

```
You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional
moving into data roles, and English is my second language. Explain Chapter
11 topic "censoring and the Kaplan–Meier estimator" step by step with a
small churn table of 8 customers. Compute the survival curve by hand with
me, one row at a time. After each step, ask me one question and wait. At
the end, ask me to explain in my own words why censored customers must not
be deleted.
```

✨ AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI

```
You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional
moving into data roles. The topic is the Cox proportional hazards model
and hazard ratios. Explain with a churn example, show how to read the
exp(coef) column of a lifelines summary, and explain the proportional
hazards assumption and how to check it. Then give me 8 graded exercises
WITHOUT solutions, from easy to hard, and wait for my answers before
marking them.
```

✨ AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI

```
You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional
moving into data roles. Teach me random-intercept mixed models and partial
pooling (shrinkage), using depot delivery times with very different sample
sizes. Use the weight w = tau2/(tau2 + sigma2/n) with real numbers. Quiz
me one question at a time, starting easy, and tell me when my answer shows
I confuse fixed and random effects.
```

✨ AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI

```
You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional
moving into data roles. Review my Chapter 11 work (survival analysis or
mixed models): [PASTE HERE]. Check censoring mistakes, pseudoreplication,
wrong reading of hazard ratios or ICC, and arithmetic. Explain each
problem slowly in simple English and show the corrected version with
numbers.
```

✨ AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI

```
You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional
moving into data roles. Run a mock interview on survival analysis and
hierarchical models for a data science job. Ask me 8 questions, one at a
time, mixing concept questions (censoring, hazard, shrinkage), a
calculation, and a business scenario. After each answer, score it out of
5, show a model answer, and tell me what to practise next.
```

CHAPTER 12

EXPERIMENTAL DESIGN AND CAUSAL BASICS

How to tell "this change caused that result" from "these two things just moved together".

Your team ships a new caching feature and conversion goes up 14 percentage points among users who turned it on. The manager says, "Great, roll it out to everyone." Should you? This chapter shows you why the honest answer is often "we do not know yet", and what to do about it. You will learn how randomization removes bias, how confounding creates fake effects (you met the idea as Simpson's paradox in Chapter 1), how to size and sanity-check an experiment, and how difference-in-differences gives a fair estimate when you cannot randomize. Testing mechanics (p-values, power, peeking, multiple testing) are in Chapters 4 and 5, so we point to them instead of repeating them. Every number below was computed with `numpy` and `scipy` (fixed seeds).

12.1 Correlation, Causation and Potential Outcomes

INTUITION

You want to know if a new route to office saves time. You try the new route on Monday (rainy) and the old route on Tuesday (sunny). The new route took longer. Did the route cause it, or the rain? You can never live both versions of the same Monday. That is the whole problem of causal inference: for each person we see only one of two worlds.

Words you need

Word	Plain meaning	Example
Treatment	The thing we change	Feature on / off
Outcome Y	What we measure	Converted (1) or not (0)
Potential outcomes Y(1), Y(0)	The outcome if treated, and if not treated	Y(1) = 5 purchases, Y(0) = 3
Individual effect	Y(1) − Y(0), never observed for one person	2

ATE (average treatment effect)	Average of Y(1) − Y(0) over everyone	1.5
Confounder	A hidden third thing that influences both who gets treated and the outcome	"Power user"
Counterfactual	The world that did not happen	What this user would do without the feature

Problem 12.1.1 Four users have these potential outcomes (monthly purchases). We can never see both columns in real life, but here we pretend we can.

User	Y(1) with feature	Y(0) without	Effect
u1	5	3	2
u2	4	4	0
u3	6	2	4
u4	3	3	0

(a) What is the true ATE? (b) Suppose only u1 and u3, the keenest users, switch the feature on. What does the naive comparison say?

- **Step 1** ATE = (2 + 0 + 4 + 0) / 4 = 6 / 4 = 1.5 purchases.
- **Step 2** Treated users (u1, u3) show their Y(1): 5 and 6, average 5.5. Untreated (u2, u4) show their Y(0): 4 and 3, average 3.5.
- **Step 3** Naive difference = 5.5 − 3.5 = 2.0.
- **Answer** The truth is 1.5, but the naive comparison says 2.0. The extra 0.5 is **selection bias**: the people who chose the feature were the people who gain most from it.
- **Check** The treated would have bought (3 + 2) / 2 = 2.5 without the feature, versus 3.5 for the untreated. They were different kinds of users from the start.
- **Why it matters** If users choose the treatment themselves, the groups differ before the treatment even starts. Any difference afterwards mixes the feature effect with that starting difference.

KEY INSIGHT

Randomization fixes this by breaking the link between "who gets treated" and everything else. If a coin decides, the treated and untreated groups are alike on average in everything, including things you never measured.

Item	Example value	Where it appears in the job
Treatment	New checkout page	Product A/B tests
Confounder	Power user, season, region	Any observational dashboard
ATE	+2 percentage points	The number you report to the business
Counterfactual	Sales without the campaign	Marketing attribution

Applications: A/B tests (Data Science, Product Analytics), marketing uplift, policy and pricing studies (Economics), clinical trials (Healthcare), ML model comparisons in production (MLOps).

COMMON MISTAKE

Comparing "users who used feature X" with "users who did not" and calling the gap the effect of X. Users who chose X differ from the rest in motivation, size and history.

Check yourself

1. Why can't we see the individual effect $Y(1) - Y(0)$? Answer: each person is observed in only one world.
2. What does randomization do to confounders? Answer: it balances them on average between groups, even unmeasured ones.
3. In Problem 12.1.1, if all four users were treated by a coin flip, what would the average difference approach? Answer: the ATE, 1.5, over many repeats.

12.2 Confounding in Action: a Simulation

INTUITION

Hospitals have more deaths than hotels. Does hospital cause death? No: sick people go to hospitals. "Sickness" sits behind both. In your product, power users both adopt features more and buy more.

We simulate 100,000 users. 30% are power users. Power users adopt the feature with probability 0.7, regular users with 0.2. Power users convert at base rate 0.30, regular users at 0.05. The feature adds exactly **+0.02** to everyone's conversion chance. So the truth is known: 0.02.

Predict first: will the naive gap be close to 0.02?

```
import numpy as np
rng=np.random.default_rng(12)
N=100000
power=rng.random(N)<0.3
adopt=rng.random(N)<np.where(power,0.7,0.2)
base=np.where(power,0.30,0.05)
conv=rng.random(N)<(base+0.02*adopt)
print("share power",power.mean(),"adopt rate",adopt.mean())
print("naive diff",conv[adopt].mean()-conv[~adopt].mean(),
conv[adopt].mean(),conv[~adopt].mean())
adj=0
for s in (True,False):
    m=power==s
    a=conv[m&adopt].mean();b=conv[m&~adopt].mean()
    print("power" if s else "regular", m.sum(), a,b,a-b)
    adj=adj+(a-b)*m.mean()
print("adjusted",adj)
```

Real output:

```
share power 0.29948 adopt rate 0.34886
naive diff 0.1359253173938073 0.2181964111678037 0.08227109377399637
power 29948 0.31590963139120093 0.2936232208898353 0.02228641050136565
regular 70052 0.06998052088593897 0.048708867968179956 0.02127165291775901
adjusted 0.021575552518897527
```

Problem 12.2.1 Explain the output and compute the adjusted effect.

Step 1	Naive: adopters convert at 21.8%, non-adopters at 8.2%, gap 13.6 percentage points. That is almost 7 times the true 2 points.
Step 2	Why? Among adopters, power users are 60.3% of the group (they adopt 70% of the time); among non-adopters only 13.7% are power users. Adopters are mostly the high-converting kind.
Step 3	Compare like with like. Inside power users the gap is 0.0223. Inside regular users it is 0.0213.
Step 4	Weight by the share of each type (0.30 and 0.70): 0.0223 × 0.2995 + 0.0213 × 0.7005 = 0.0216.
Answer	After stratifying by user type, the effect is 2.2 points, close to the true 2.0. The naive 13.6 was mostly confounding.
Check	Both strata gaps are near 0.02, which matches how we built the data.
Why it matters	Stratifying (also called adjusting, or "controlling for") works only for confounders you have measured. If "power user" were not in the data, you could not fix it this way.

Now the randomized version: a coin decides who gets the feature, same population.

```
rand=rng.random(N)<0.5
conv2=rng.random(N)<(base+0.02*rand)
print("randomized diff",conv2[rand].mean()-
conv2[~rand].mean(),conv2[rand].mean(),conv2[~rand].mean())
print("balance power share
rand",power[rand].mean(),power[~rand].mean(),"adopt",power[adopt].mean(),p
ower[~adopt].mean())
```

```
randomized diff 0.018161492916233563 0.14341147291783343
0.12524998000159987
balance power share rand 0.3014641171293703 0.29749620030397567 adopt
0.6026772917502723 0.13703658199465552
```

- **Answer** With a coin, the power-user share is 30.1% in treatment and 29.7% in control, so the groups are balanced. The estimate 0.0182 is near 0.02. The difference from 0.02 is random noise (we only have about 50,000 per group; the standard error of a difference of two proportions near 0.14 with that size is about 0.002).

- **Check** Adoption was unbalanced (60.3% vs 13.7% power users); the coin made it balanced (30.1% vs 29.7%). Balance is the sign that randomization worked.

```
Observational:  power user ---> adopts feature ---> converts
                     \_____________________________/^
                       (power user also converts more: the back door)
Randomized:     coin ---> feature ---> converts      (the back door is
cut)
```

How to read it: an arrow means "influences". In the observational picture there are two routes from "adopts" to "converts": the direct one we want, and a back-door route through "power user". A coin has no arrows into it except from nothing, so the back door is closed. This kind of picture is a **causal diagram (DAG)**, and the back door idea is the heart of causal reasoning.

Applications: Data Science (why dashboards of "feature users vs non-users" mislead), Machine Learning (training on historical data where past decisions depended on the features, e.g. credit approved only for good customers), MLOps (offline vs online metric gaps), Healthcare (observational drug studies).

COMMON MISTAKE

Adding every available column as a "control". Controlling for a **collider** (something caused by both treatment and outcome) or a **mediator** (something on the path from treatment to outcome) can create bias or hide the real effect. Pick controls using a causal story, not by habit.

Check yourself

1. In 12.2, why was the naive gap so large? Answer: adopters were mostly power users, who convert more anyway.
2. Does stratification fix unmeasured confounders? Answer: no.
3. What does the coin do in the randomized version? Answer: it cuts the link between user type and treatment.

12.3 Designing a Good Experiment

INTUITION

An experiment is a fair race. You need runners drawn the same way, a start line that is the same for everyone, and enough runners to separate a small difference from luck. Design means deciding these before the race.

Steps of a design

1. **Question and metric**: one primary metric (for example, conversion), decided in advance. Guard-rail metrics (refund rate, complaints) must not get worse.
2. **Unit of randomization**: user, session, or something bigger like a store. If the same user can see both versions, results mix.
3. **Randomization**: use a random number, or a stable hash of the user ID, so a user always sees the same version.
4. **Sample size**: choose from the smallest effect you care about (the minimum detectable effect), the significance level and the power (Chapter 4).
5. **Run for full cycles** (whole weeks, because weekdays differ), and do not stop early when the p-value dips below 0.05 (Chapter 5 explained peeking).
6. **Sanity checks**: balance of groups, and the sample ratio check below.

Sample size for two proportions

For two groups with rates p_1 and p_2, significance α, power $1 - \beta$:

$n \text{ per group} = \left(z_{\alpha/2} \times \sqrt{2\,\bar{p}\,(1-\bar{p})} + z_{\beta} \times \sqrt{p_1(1-p_1) + p_2(1-p_2)} \right)^2 / (p_2 - p_1)^2$, where $\bar{p} = (p_1 + p_2)/2$.

Problem 12.3.1 Baseline conversion is 10%. You want to detect a lift to 12% with α = 0.05 (two-sided) and power 80%. How many users per group?

Formula	the formula above, with $z_{\alpha/2} = 1.960$ and $z_\beta = 0.8416$.
Plug in	$\bar{p} = 0.11$; $2 \times 0.11 \times 0.89 = 0.1958$; $\sqrt{0.1958} = 0.4425$. And $p_1(1-p_1) + p_2(1-p_2) = 0.09 + 0.1056 = 0.1956$; $\sqrt{0.1956} = 0.4423$.
Compute	$1.960 \times 0.4425 = 0.8673$; $0.8416 \times 0.4423 = 0.3722$; sum = 1.2395; squared = 1.5364. The gap squared is $0.02^2 = 0.0004$. So $n = 1.5364 / 0.0004 = 3{,}841$.
Answer	About 3,841 users per group, or about 7,682 in total.
Check	Code gives 3840.85, which rounds up to 3,841. Halving the effect (10% to 11%) needs about 14,751 per group, roughly 4 times more: small effects are expensive.
Why it matters	If you only have 2,000 users per week, this test needs about 4 weeks. Knowing this before launch avoids "inconclusive" tests.

```
from scipy.stats import norm
p1,p2=0.10,0.12
za,zb=norm.ppf(0.975),norm.ppf(0.80)
pb=(p1+p2)/2
n=((za*np.sqrt(2*pb*(1-pb))+zb*np.sqrt(p1*(1-p1)+p2*(1-p2)))**2)/(p2-
p1)**2
print("n per arm",n)
```

```
n per arm 3840.847482436276
```

The sample ratio mismatch (SRM) check

You planned a 50/50 split of 100,000 users. You got 50,600 and 49,400. Is that a harmless wobble? Use a chi-square goodness-of-fit test (Chapter 4): $\chi^2 = \Sigma\ (\text{observed} - \text{expected})^2 / \text{expected}$.

Problem 12.3.2 Test 50,600 vs 49,400 against an expected 50,000 each.

Formula	$\chi^2 = \Sigma\ (O - E)^2 / E$, with 1 degree of freedom.
Plug in	$(50{,}600 - 50{,}000)^2 / 50{,}000 + (49{,}400 - 50{,}000)^2 / 50{,}000$
Compute	$360{,}000 / 50{,}000 + 360{,}000 / 50{,}000 = 7.2 + 7.2 = 14.4$.
Answer	$p = 0.000148$. A split this lopsided almost never happens by chance, so something is broken: a bug in assignment, bots, a redirect that loses users in one arm. Do not read the results; fix the pipeline first.
Check	For 50,100 vs 49,900 the statistic is 0.4 and $p = 0.527$, a normal wobble.
Why it matters	SRM is the cheapest and most powerful alarm in experimentation. Teams use $p < 0.001$ as the trigger because they run it on every experiment.

REAL JOB TIP

Run an A/A test (both groups see the same thing) before trusting a new experiment platform. About 5% of A/A tests should show $p < 0.05$, no more. If you see 20%, the platform is broken.

Blocking and stratified randomization

If you know a strong factor (country, device), randomize inside each block, so both arms get the same mix. It reduces noise. It is the experiment-design cousin of stratified sampling (Chapter 3). When you cannot randomize individuals (for example, a pricing change per city) you randomize clusters and analyze at the cluster level.

COMMON MISTAKE

Stopping the test the day the p-value first dips below 0.05, or testing 10 metrics and reporting the one that "won". Both inflate false positives (Chapter 5). Decide metric, sample size and stop date before launch.

Check yourself

1. Which three numbers decide the sample size? Answer: minimum effect, significance level, power (plus baseline variance).
2. 10,300 vs 9,700 in a 50/50 test: SRM? Answer: $\chi^2 = 300^2/10{,}000 \times 2 = 18$, $p = 0.00002$. Yes, SRM.

3. Why run whole weeks? Answer: user behavior changes across weekdays; partial weeks bias the result.

12.4 Difference-in-Differences

INTUITION

You cannot randomize, because the new payment flow launched in one region only. Comparing "that region after launch" with "other regions after launch" ignores that the regions were different anyway. Comparing "that region before and after" ignores things that changed everywhere (a holiday, better weather). Difference-in-differences (DiD) uses both: it measures how much the treated region changed, subtracts how much the untreated region changed, and calls what remains the effect.

Setting: average delivery time in minutes; a new dispatch process launched in one region.

Group	Before	After	Change
Treated region (new flow)	420	330	−90
Control region (old flow)	400	370	−30

Problem 12.4.1 Compute the DiD effect and compare with the naive answers.

Formula	DiD = (treated after − treated before) − (control after − control before)
Plug in	(330 − 420) − (370 − 400)
Compute	(−90) − (−30) = −60.
Answer	The new flow reduced delivery time by about 60 minutes. The "before and after" answer (−90) credits the new flow with the 30-minute drop that happened everywhere. The "after only" answer (330 vs 370 = −40) ignores that the treated region started 20 minutes slower.
Check	Without the new flow, the treated region would have fallen by the same 30 minutes as control, from 420 to 390. The actual 330 is 60 below that.
Why it matters	DiD removes two kinds of bias: fixed differences between groups, and shared trends over time.

The same number from regression

Regression with an interaction gives DiD as a coefficient: $y = b_0 + b_1 \cdot \text{treated} + b_2 \cdot \text{post} + b_3 \cdot (\text{treated} \times \text{post})$. Here b_3 is DiD. We simulate 500 users per cell with the four cell means above plus noise (SD 40):

```
reg=np.repeat([0,1],2*n);post=np.tile(np.repeat([0,1],n),2)
mu=np.array([[400,370],[420,330]])          # rows: control, treated;
columns: before, after
y=mu[reg,post]+rng.normal(0,40,len(reg))
X=np.c_[np.ones(len(y)),reg,post,reg*post]
b=np.linalg.lstsq(X,y,rcond=None)[0]
res=y-X@b; se=np.sqrt(res.var(ddof=4)*np.diag(np.linalg.inv(X.T@X)))
print("coef",b)
print("se",se,"ci",b[3]-1.96*se[3],b[3]+1.96*se[3])
```

($n = 500$.) Real output:

```
coef [399.39429281  19.18808005 -32.73655078 -57.64677991]
se [1.75522506 2.48226308 2.48226308 3.51045011] ci -64.52726212326162
-50.76629768809265
```

- **Answer** $b_3 = -57.6$ minutes with 95% interval −64.5 to −50.8. It is near the true −60 and the interval contains it. The other coefficients: 19.2 is the treated-minus-control gap before

launch, −32.7 is the shared time change.

- **Check** 399.4 + 19.2 = 418.6 is the treated "before" mean, near 420.

```
delivery (min)  before          after
treated         420 ----------> 330   (actual)
                 \
                  `------------>  390  (counterfactual: control's drop of
30)
control         400 ----------> 370
DiD effect = actual 330 − counterfactual 390 = −60 min
```

Read the picture: each row is one region, left to right is time. The middle arrow shows where the treated region would have gone if it had only followed the control's drop. The gap between that imagined 390 and the real 330 is the effect.

The key assumption: parallel trends. Without the treatment, both groups would have changed by the same amount. You cannot prove this, but you can check that the two groups moved in parallel in several periods **before** the launch. If they did not, DiD is unreliable.

Applications: policy and pricing changes by region (Economics), feature launches without randomization (Product Analytics), marketing campaigns in some cities, process changes at some depots (Operations), minimum-wage studies.

COMMON MISTAKE

Using DiD when the groups were already moving in different directions, or when something else happened only to the treated group at the same time (a competitor opened). Plot the pre-period trends first.

Check yourself

1. Treated 50 to 40, control 48 to 45. DiD? Answer: (−10) − (−3) = −7.
2. What is the main assumption? Answer: parallel trends.
3. Why not just compare the groups after launch? Answer: they differed before the launch.

12.5 Other Causal Tools, and What You Do Not Need Yet

Randomization is the gold standard. When it is impossible, know the names:

Method	Idea in one line	Needs
Stratification / regression adjustment	Compare like with like on measured confounders	All confounders measured
Matching, propensity scores	Pair treated with similar untreated users	The same
Difference-in-differences	Change vs change	Parallel trends
Regression discontinuity	Compare people just above and just below a cutoff (score 700 gets a loan)	A sharp cutoff
Instrumental variables	Use a nudge that affects treatment but not outcome directly	A valid instrument (hard)

Ignore the last two until a project needs them. Also be honest about limits: every observational method rests on assumptions that data cannot fully prove. An interview-ready sentence: "I trust randomized evidence most; for observational data I state the assumptions and check what I can."

PROFESSOR'S NOTE

Causal inference is a huge field. This chapter gives you the vocabulary to ask the right question: "What is the counterfactual, and what could make the groups differ besides the treatment?"

Chapter recap

- We never see both potential outcomes for one person, so causal effects are estimated by comparing groups.
- Self-selected treatment creates selection bias; our simulation showed a naive gap of 13.6 points against a true 2.
- Randomization balances measured and unmeasured confounders; stratification fixes only measured ones.
- Decide the metric, sample size and stop rule before launch; whole weeks.

- Check sample ratio mismatch with a chi-square test; run A/A tests.
- Difference-in-differences = (treated change) − (control change); it needs parallel trends.
- Pick controls using a causal story; do not control for colliders or mediators.

Formula / pattern	Meaning
`ATE = mean(Y(1) - Y(0))`	Average treatment effect
$n = (z_{\alpha/2}\sqrt{2\bar{p}(1-\bar{p})} + z_{\beta}\sqrt{p_1q_1+p_2q_2})^2 / (p_2-p_1)^2$	n per arm, two proportions
$\chi^2 = \Sigma\ (O-E)^2/E$	SRM check
`DiD = (T_after - T_before) - (C_after - C_before)`	Difference-in-differences
`scipy.stats.norm.ppf`, `chi2.sf`	z values and p-values

Practice set

Problem 12.6.1 Treatment group average 5.5, control 3.5, true ATE 1.5. What is the selection bias?

Answer: 2.0 − 1.5 = 0.5.

Problem 12.6.2 In a 50/50 split with 20,000 users you get 10,300 and 9,700. Compute χ^2 and decide.

Answer: $(300^2 / 10{,}000) \times 2 = 18$, p = 0.000022. SRM: do not trust the results.

Problem 12.6.3 Baseline conversion 20%, target 25%, α = 0.05, power 80%. Users per group?

Answer: About 1,094 per group (1,093.7 from the formula, rounded up).

Problem 12.6.4 Treated: 50 before, 40 after. Control: 48 before, 45 after. Find DiD.

Answer: (40 − 50) − (45 − 48) = −10 + 3 = −7.

Problem 12.6.5 What is the output? `print(1-0.95**20)`

Answer: 0.6415 (the chance of at least one false positive in 20 independent tests at 5%; see Chapter 5).

Problem 12.6.6 Find the bug: "Users who opened the new dashboard retained 20 points better, so the dashboard improves retention."

Answer: Users who chose to open it are more engaged to begin with (self-selection). Randomize who is shown it, or at least adjust for prior engagement.

Problem 12.6.7 A DiD estimate is −60 minutes but treated and control delivery times were already diverging for 6 months before launch. What do you conclude?

Answer: Parallel trends fails, so the estimate mixes the old divergence and the effect. Model the trend, pick a better control, or do not trust it.

Problem 12.6.8 (Interview) Why does randomization let us ignore confounders we never measured?

Answer: A coin assigns treatment independently of every user trait, so on average each trait, measured or not, has the same distribution in both groups. Remaining differences are random and are accounted for by the standard error.

Problem 12.6.9 (Interview) Product wants to stop an A/B test after 3 days because p = 0.03. Your reply?

Answer: The planned sample size was not reached, and checking repeatedly inflates false positives (Chapter 5). Continue to the planned end, or use a sequential method designed for peeking. Also confirm no SRM and that full weeks are covered.

Problem 12.6.10 (Scenario) A new fraud rule launched in India only. How do you estimate its effect?

Answer: Use DiD with similar regions as control. Check parallel trends before launch, make sure nothing else changed only in India, and report an interval.

Prompt pack

✨ **AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI**

```
You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional
moving into data roles, and English is my second language. Teach me
Chapter 12 topic "potential outcomes, confounding and why randomization
works". Use tiny numbers, like four users with Y(1) and Y(0). After each
idea, ask me one check question and wait for my answer. At the end, ask me
to explain selection bias in my own words using a shop or product example.
```

✨ **AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI**

```
You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional
moving into data roles. Teach me how to design an A/B test: metric choice,
unit of randomization, sample size for two proportions, sample ratio
mismatch and A/A tests. Show each calculation with real numbers. Then give
me 8 graded exercises WITHOUT solutions and wait for my answers before
marking them.
```

✨ **AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI**

```
You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional
moving into data roles. Explain difference-in-differences with a delivery-
time example (treated region vs control region, before and after). Draw an
ASCII picture, explain parallel trends, and show how the same number comes
from a regression with an interaction term. Quiz me one question at a
time, starting easy, and correct my mistakes slowly.
```

✨ **AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI**

```
You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional
moving into data roles. Review my Chapter 12 work on experiments or causal
inference: [PASTE HERE]. Look for confounding, selection bias, peeking,
wrong sample size, SRM, collider or mediator controls, and parallel-trends
problems. Explain each issue in simple English and show a corrected plan
with numbers.
```

✨ **AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI**

```
You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional
moving into data roles. Run a mock interview on experimental design and
causal basics for a data scientist job. Ask 8 questions one at a time:
concepts, a sample-size calculation, an SRM scenario, a difference-in-
differences calculation and a business case. Score each answer out of 5,
show a model answer, and finish with a list of what to practise.
```

CHAPTER 13

OPTIMIZATION TECHNIQUES AND AN INFORMATION THEORY REFRESHER

How machines find the best numbers, how to solve planning problems with constraints, and how to measure surprise.

Almost everything you train or plan is an optimization problem: "find the numbers that make this score as small (or as large) as possible". Fitting a regression, training a neural network and scheduling jobs on machines are the same game with different rules. In this chapter you will see why convex problems are easy, run gradient descent and its popular variants on real numbers, solve constrained problems with Lagrange multipliers and KKT, solve a planning problem with linear programming in `scipy`, and refresh entropy, KL and mutual information. The Math PDF already covers derivatives, optimizers, loss functions and entropy/KL, so we revise quickly and spend time on numbers you can check. `PuLP`, `OR-Tools`, `cvxpy` and `Optuna` are not installed here ("not run here"). All other numbers were computed with `numpy` and `scipy`.

13.1 Convexity: Why Some Problems Are Easy

INTUITION

A bowl has one lowest point. Put a ball anywhere, it rolls to the same bottom. A mountain range has many valleys; where the ball ends depends on where you drop it. A **convex** function is a bowl. Convex optimization means "there are no traps".

How it works

A function `f` is **convex** if the line segment between any two points on its graph lies on or above the graph. For a smooth function of one variable, this is the same as `f''(x) ≥ 0` everywhere. For many variables, the **Hessian** (the matrix of second derivatives) must be positive semi-definite (all its eigenvalues are ≥ 0). For a convex function, **every local minimum is a global minimum**. A **convex set** is one where the line between any two of its points stays inside the set (a disc is convex, a doughnut is not).

Problem 13.1.1 Is $f(x) = x^2$ convex? Is $f(x) = x^4 - 3x^2 + x$?

Step 1	For x^2: $f'(x) = 2x$, $f''(x) = 2$, which is positive everywhere. So it is convex, and its one minimum, $x = 0$, is global.
Step 2	For the quartic: $f'(x) = 4x^3 - 6x + 1$ and $f''(x) = 12x^2 - 6$. At $x = 0$, $f'' = -6$, which is negative. At $x = 1$, $f'' = +6$. The sign changes, so it is not convex.
Step 3	Run a local minimizer from two starts:

```
from scipy.optimize import minimize
f=lambda x:x**4-3*x**2+x
for s in (-2,2):
    r=minimize(lambda z:f(z[0]),[s]);print("start",s,"->",r.x,r.fun)
```

```
start -2 -> [-1.30083949] -3.5139050389347464
start 2 -> [1.13090187] -1.0702301817735662
```

- **Answer** The quartic has two valleys: a deep one at $x \approx -1.30$ ($f = -3.51$) and a shallower one at $x \approx 1.13$ ($f = -1.07$). Starting at 2 you land in the worse one.
- **Check** $f(1.13) = 1.63 - 3.83 + 1.13 = -1.07$. Yes.
- **Why it matters** Linear regression and logistic regression losses are convex, so training always reaches the best answer. Neural network losses are not convex; the starting point, learning rate and randomness matter.

KEY INSIGHT

In high dimensions, deep-learning losses have many **saddle points** (flat in one direction, curved in another, like a horse saddle). Where `f' = 0`, the Hessian has both positive and negative eigenvalues. Noise from stochastic gradient steps helps escape them.

Applications: SVM, logistic regression and Lasso are convex (Machine Learning); neural networks are not, so initialization matters (Deep Learning); portfolio optimization with `cvxpy` (Finance).

COMMON MISTAKE

Expecting a neural network to train to the same model twice. Non-convex problems have many solutions; fix seeds to compare experiments.

Check yourself

1. Is f(x) = |x| convex? Answer: yes, though not differentiable at 0.
2. In a convex problem, is a local minimum also global? Answer: yes.
3. What does a negative Hessian eigenvalue tell you? Answer: the surface curves downward in that direction; it is not a minimum.

13.2 Gradient Descent: Batch, Stochastic and Mini-Batch

INTUITION

You stand on a foggy hillside and want the valley. You feel the slope under your feet and step downhill. The size of each step is the **learning rate**. Too small and you take all day; too big and you jump over the valley. The slope under your feet is the **gradient**.

Update rule

`θ_new = θ − η × ∇L(θ)`, where `η` (eta) is the learning rate and `∇L` the gradient of the loss. **Convergence** means the steps shrink toward zero near a minimum.

Problem 13.2.1 Minimise `f(x) = x²` from x = 5 with learning rate 0.1, then 0.5, 1.0 and 1.1.

Formula	f'(x) = 2x, so x_new = x − η·2x = x(1 − 2η).
Plug in	For η = 0.1 the factor is 1 − 0.2 = 0.8. For 0.5: 0. For 1.0: −1. For 1.1: −1.2.
Compute	η = 0.1: 5 → 4 → 3.2 → 2.56 → 2.048 → 1.6384. η = 0.5: 5 → 0 (done in one step). η = 1.0: 5 → −5 → 5 → −5 (bounces forever). η = 1.1: 5 → −6 → 7.2 → −8.64 → 10.37 (grows).
Answer	The step size must satisfy |1 − 2η| < 1, which means 0 < η < 1 here. Above 1 the method diverges.
Check	Code for η = 1.1 prints `[5.0, -6.0, 7.2, -8.64, 10.368, -12.4416, 14.9299]`.
Why it matters	"Loss going to NaN" in training is almost always this: a learning rate too high for the curvature.

Batch, stochastic and mini-batch

The loss is usually an average over `n` data rows. Three ways to compute the gradient:

Variant	Rows per step	Pros	Cons
Batch	all n	Exact, smooth path	Slow for big data
Stochastic (SGD)	1	Fast steps, noise helps escape saddles	Noisy path
Mini-batch	e.g. 32 to 512	Fast, GPU friendly, mild noise	One more setting to tune

Problem 13.2.2 Fit $y = w_0 + w_1 x$ to x = 1,2,3,4,5 and y = 2.1, 3.9, 6.2, 7.8, 10.1 by gradient descent on the mean squared error (MSE). Start at w = (0, 0), η = 0.02.

Formula	gradient of MSE = (2/n) $X^T(Xw - y)$, where X has a column of ones and a column of x.
Step 1	At w = 0: Xw − y = −y, so the gradient is −(2/5)(Σy, Σxy). Σy = 30.1 and Σxy = 2.1 + 7.8 + 18.6 + 31.2 + 50.5 = 110.2. Gradient = −(12.04, 44.08).
Step 2	Update: w = 0 − 0.02 × (−12.04, −44.08) = (0.2408, 0.8816).
Step 3	Repeat in code (`x` and `y` are the arrays above).

```
import numpy as np
x=np.arange(1,6.); y=np.array([2.1,3.9,6.2,7.8,10.1])
X=np.c_[np.ones(5),x]
print("OLS",np.linalg.lstsq(X,y,rcond=None)[0].round(4))
w=np.zeros(2)
for i in range(1,4):
    g=2/5*X.T@(X@w-y); w=w-0.02*g
    if i in (1,3): print("step",i,"grad",g,"w",w)
w=np.zeros(2)
for i in range(3000):
    g=2/5*X.T@(X@w-y); w-=0.02*g
print("batch 3000",w.round(4))
rng=np.random.default_rng(0); w=np.zeros(2)
for ep in range(3000):                          # SGD: one row per step,
eta = 0.005
    for k in rng.permutation(5):
        w-=0.005*2*X[k]*(X[k]@w-y[k])
print("sgd",w)
```

```
OLS [0.05 1.99]
step 1 grad [-12.04 -44.08] w [0.2408 0.8816]
step 3 grad [ -3.229248 -12.262144] w [0.43076096 1.59164288]
batch 3000 [0.05 1.99]
sgd [0.04800144 1.99251151]
```

- **Answer** Batch GD after 3,000 steps reaches (0.05, 1.99), exactly the least-squares answer (also found in closed form by `np.linalg.lstsq`). SGD (one row per step, η = 0.005, 3,000 passes) gets (0.048, 1.9925): very close but never exactly settled because of noise.
- **Check** By hand, slope = Sxy/Sxx = 19.9/10 = 1.99 and intercept = 6.02 − 1.99 × 3 = 0.05.

Applications: training linear and logistic models (Machine Learning), mini-batch SGD as the default (Deep Learning, GenAI), online learning on streams (Data Engineering).

COMMON MISTAKE

Features on very different scales (age 0 to 100, income 0 to 1,000,000). The loss surface becomes a long thin valley, and GD zig-zags. Standardize features first.

Check yourself

1. Why does GD stay stable at η = 0.5 but not 1.1 for x^2? Answer: the factor $|1 - 2\eta|$ is 0 at 0.5 but 1.2 at 1.1.

2. What is mini-batch's advantage over batch? Answer: faster steps on big data, while still averaging out some noise.
3. What happens to the gradient near the minimum? Answer: it shrinks to zero.

13.3 Momentum, Adaptive Rates, Adam and Schedules

INTUITION

A ball with weight (momentum) rolls through small bumps and keeps going down a long gentle slope. Adaptive methods give each parameter its own learning rate: big steps for weights that rarely get a gradient, small steps for ones that always do.

Words you need and the update rules

Let g be the gradient at the current point, η the learning rate.

Method	Update	Idea
Momentum	$v = 0.9\,v + g$; $\theta = \theta - \eta\,v$	Keep a running velocity
Nesterov (NAG)	gradient at look-ahead point $\theta - \eta \cdot 0.9 \cdot v$	Look before you leap
AdaGrad	$s \mathrel{+}= g^2$; $\theta \mathrel{-}= \eta\, g / (\sqrt{s} + \varepsilon)$	Per-parameter rate that only decreases
RMSProp	$s = 0.9\,s + 0.1\,g^2$; $\theta \mathrel{-}= \eta\, g / (\sqrt{s} + \varepsilon)$	Forget old gradients
Adam	momentum on g (m) and on g^2 (s), bias-corrected	Most popular default
AdamW	Adam with weight decay applied separately from the gradient	Better regularization; standard for transformers

ε is a tiny number (1e-8) that avoids division by zero. **Learning-rate schedules** change η over time: step decay (cut η by half every N epochs), cosine decay (smooth fall), warm-up (start tiny, rise, then decay: used for transformers).

A test: a long narrow valley

Use `f(x, y) = 0.5(x² + 25y²)` : flat in x, steep in y (condition number 25). Start at (10, 1). Count steps until the distance to the minimum is below 10^{-6} (cap 2,000).

```
import numpy as np
A=np.array([1,25.])
def run(method,eta,cap=2000):
    p=np.array([10,1.]);v=np.zeros(2);s=np.zeros(2);m=np.zeros(2);eps=1e-8
    for k in range(1,cap+1):
        if method=="nag":
            g=A*(p-eta*0.9*v)
        else: g=A*p
        if method=="gd": p=p-eta*g
        elif method in("mom","nag"): v=0.9*v+g; p=p-eta*v
        elif method=="adagrad": s+=g*g; p=p-eta*g/(np.sqrt(s)+eps)
        elif method=="rms": s=0.9*s+0.1*g*g; p=p-eta*g/(np.sqrt(s)+eps)
        elif method=="adam":
            m=0.9*m+0.1*g; s=0.999*s+0.001*g*g
            p=p-eta*(m/(1-0.9**k))/(np.sqrt(s/(1-0.999**k))+eps)
        if np.linalg.norm(p)<1e-6: return k,p
    return None,p
for me,e in [("gd",.07),("gd",.04),("mom",.01),("nag",.01),("rms",.1),
("adagrad",3.0),("adam",.3)]:
    k,p=run(me,e);print(me,e,k,p.round(2))
```

Real results (steps to converge):

```
gd 0.07 223 [ 0. -0.]
gd 0.04 395 [0. 0.]
mom 0.01 272 [-0. -0.]
nag 0.01 209 [-0. -0.]
rms 0.1 None [0.05 0.05]
adagrad 3.0 71 [ 0. -0.]
adam 0.3 278 [-0. -0.]
```

Problem 13.3.1 Explain these results and check the plain GD count by hand.

Step 1	For plain GD on this function, the x coordinate shrinks by $(1 - \eta)$ per step and y by $\lvert 1 - 25\eta \rvert$. Stability needs $\eta < 2/25 = 0.08$. At $\eta = 0.07$: x factor 0.93, y factor $\lvert 1 - 1.75 \rvert = 0.75$. The slow coordinate is x.
Step 2	Steps needed: $10 \times 0.93^k < 10^{-6} \rightarrow k > \ln(10^7) / (-\ln 0.93) = 16.118 / 0.0726 = 222.1$, so 223. It matches the code.
Step 3	The steepest direction caps η (0.08) while the flat direction crawls: ill-conditioning. Momentum and NAG converge in 272 and 209 steps with a much smaller η, because velocity builds up along the flat x direction.
Answer	All but RMSProp converged. AdaGrad was fastest (71 steps, with a tuned $\eta = 3.0$). RMSProp with $\eta = 0.1$ never reached tolerance: its steps stay about η in size, so it bounces around the minimum at distance about 0.05.
Why it matters	One toy function proves nothing general; the lesson is the mechanism. Adam is a good default but still needs a sensible η. A smaller or decaying η would let RMSProp settle.

REAL JOB TIP

In practice use Adam or AdamW with η around 1e-3 (small models) to 1e-5 (fine-tuning large models) plus warm-up and decay, and tune η first, before anything else.

COMMON MISTAKE

Adding an L2 penalty to the loss with Adam and calling it weight decay. With adaptive methods they differ; prefer AdamW.

Check yourself

1. What limits plain GD's learning rate on an elongated valley? Answer: the steepest direction.
2. What does RMSProp do that AdaGrad does not? Answer: it forgets old squared gradients, so the rate does not shrink to zero.
3. Why use warm-up? Answer: early gradients are noisy and a large η can destabilize the start.

13.4 Second-Order Methods: Newton and L-BFGS

INTUITION

The gradient says which way is downhill. The Hessian says how curved the ground is. If you know the curvature, you can jump straight to the bottom of the bowl instead of inching.

Newton's method updates `θ_new = θ − H⁻¹ g`, where `H` is the Hessian. On a quadratic bowl it lands at the minimum in **one** step.

Problem 13.4.1 Apply Newton to `f = 0.5(x² + 25y²)` from (10, 1). Then use Newton's idea to find √2 as the root of `x² − 2`.

Step 1	g = (x, 25y) = (10, 25). H = diag(1, 25), so $H^{-1}g$ = (10, 1).
Step 2	New point = (10, 1) − (10, 1) = (0, 0). One step, no matter the condition number.
Step 3	For root finding, `x_new = x − (x² − 2)/(2x)`. From x = 1: 1.5, 1.41667, 1.414216, 1.4142136, 1.41421356237. True √2 = 1.41421356237.
Answer	Newton needs just one step for the quadratic and about 4 steps to get 7 correct digits for √2. The number of correct digits roughly doubles per step.
Check	Code prints the same sequence: 1.5, 1.4166666666666667, 1.4142156862745099, 1.4142135623746899, 1.4142135623730951.
Why it matters	Cost: for p parameters the Hessian has p^2 entries and inverting costs about p^3 operations, impossible for a model with millions of weights.

Quasi-Newton methods (BFGS, and its memory-saving cousin **L-BFGS**) build an approximation to the curvature from recent gradients and never form H. L-BFGS is the default solver for logistic regression in scikit-learn and many classic models. Test on the Rosenbrock function, a curved narrow valley with its minimum at (1, 1), start (−1.2, 1):

```
from scipy.optimize import minimize
ros=lambda p:(1-p[0])**2+100*(p[1]-p[0]**2)**2
r=minimize(ros,[-1.2,1],method="L-BFGS-B")
print("lbfgs",r.x,r.nit,r.nfev)
r=minimize(ros,[-1.2,1],method="BFGS"); print("bfgs",r.x,r.nit)
```

```
lbfgs [0.9999969  0.99999379] 37 138
bfgs [0.99999547 0.99999094] 32
```

- **Answer** Both methods reach (1, 1) to about 5 digits in 30 to 40 iterations. Plain GD with a fixed step needs thousands on this function.

COMMON MISTAKE

Calling `minimize` without a good starting point, tolerances or gradients on a non-convex function and trusting the output. Always check `r.success`, try several starts, and compare the final loss.

Check yourself

1. How many Newton steps for a quadratic? Answer: one.
2. Why not use Newton on a neural network? Answer: the Hessian is too big to compute and invert.
3. What does L-BFGS store? Answer: a few recent gradient and step vectors, not the full Hessian.

13.5 Constrained Optimization: Lagrange Multipliers, KKT and Duality

INTUITION

"Find the lowest point of the hill, but you must stay on the road." At the best point on the road, the road runs exactly along a contour line of the hill; otherwise you could slide along the road to go lower. That means the hill's gradient points straight across the road, so it is a multiple of the road's gradient. That multiple is the **Lagrange multiplier**, usually called λ.

Equality constraints

To minimise `f(x, y)` subject to `g(x, y) = 0`, form `L = f − λ g` and set all partial derivatives (including with respect to λ) to zero.

Problem 13.5.1 Minimise `x² + y²` subject to `x + y = 1`.

Formula	$L = x^2 + y^2 - \lambda(x + y - 1)$
Step 1	$\partial L/\partial x = 2x - \lambda = 0$ and $\partial L/\partial y = 2y - \lambda = 0$, so $x = y = \lambda/2$.
Step 2	The constraint $x + y = 1$ gives $\lambda/2 + \lambda/2 = 1$, so $\lambda = 1$ and $x = y = 0.5$.
Answer	The closest point to the origin on the line is (0.5, 0.5), with value 0.25 + 0.25 = 0.5.
Check	`scipy` (SLSQP) gives `[0.5 0.5]` and 0.4999999999999998.
Why it matters	The same idea derives PCA (maximise variance subject to unit length, Math PDF) and the Lagrangian form of Ridge regression (Chapter 7).

Inequality constraints and the KKT conditions

For $g(x) \le 0$, the **Karush-Kuhn-Tucker (KKT) conditions** say, at the optimum: (1) the gradient condition $\nabla f + \mu \nabla g = 0$, (2) the constraint holds, (3) the multiplier $\mu \ge 0$, (4) **complementary slackness**: $\mu \times g = 0$, meaning either the constraint is active ($g = 0$) or its multiplier is zero (the constraint does not matter).

Problem 13.5.2 Minimise $(x - 3)^2 + (y - 3)^2$ subject to $x + y \le 4$.

Step 1	Try ignoring the constraint: the minimum is (3, 3), but $3 + 3 = 6 > 4$. It violates the constraint, so the constraint must be active: $x + y = 4$.
Step 2	$L = f + \mu(x + y - 4)$. Then $2(x - 3) + \mu = 0$ and $2(y - 3) + \mu = 0$, so $x = y = 3 - \mu/2$.
Step 3	Active: $x + y = 4$ gives $6 - \mu = 4$, so $\mu = 2 \ge 0$ and $x = y = 2$.
Answer	The best feasible point is (2, 2), with value $1 + 1 = 2$, and $\mu = 2 \ge 0$ as KKT requires.
Check	`scipy` returns `[2. 2.]` and value 2.0000000000001954. The best value as a function of the limit L is $2(L/2 - 3)^2$, whose slope at $L = 4$ is -2, which equals $-\mu$: the multiplier is the price of the limit.
Why it matters	The SVM is exactly this kind of problem; the training points with $\mu > 0$ are the support vectors.

Duality in brief. Every constrained ("primal") problem has a "dual" built from the multipliers. For convex problems the best dual value equals the best primal value (strong duality). SVM solvers

use it. Remember: multipliers are prices.

COMMON MISTAKE

Forgetting the sign condition $\mu \geq 0$ and the check that constraints are satisfied. A stationary point of the Lagrangian with a negative μ means the constraint should not be active.

Check yourself

1. At the optimum, why is the objective's gradient a multiple of the constraint's? Answer: otherwise we could slide along the constraint and improve.
2. What does complementary slackness say? Answer: $\mu \times g = 0$: an inactive constraint has zero multiplier.
3. In 13.5.2, if the limit were $x + y \leq 8$, what is the answer? Answer: (3, 3) with $\mu = 0$; the constraint is inactive.

13.6 Linear Programming with scipy

INTUITION

A linear program (LP) is a planning problem where the goal and every limit are straight-line sums. You run a test lab: two kinds of nightly jobs compete for the same machines. How many of each should you run to get the most value?

Setting up

An LP: maximise (or minimise) $c^{\mathsf{T}}x$ subject to $A\,x \leq b$ and $x \geq 0$. **Feasible region**: all points obeying every limit. Its corners are called **vertices**. The key fact: **an optimum, if it exists, is at a vertex**. The **simplex method** walks from vertex to vertex; modern solvers (such as HiGHS inside `scipy`) also use interior-point methods. `scipy.optimize.linprog` always **minimises**, so to maximise, negate `c`.

Problem 13.6.1 Job A earns 40 value points, job B earns 30. Each A needs 2 CPU-hours, each B needs 1. You have 100 CPU-hours and 80 runner slots (each job takes one slot). At most 40 A jobs. Find the best plan.

Formula	maximise 40a + 30b subject to 2a + b ≤ 100, a + b ≤ 80, a ≤ 40, a, b ≥ 0.
Step 1	List the vertices. (0,0): value 0. (40,0): 1600. (40,20): 2200 (meets a = 40 and 2a + b = 100). (20,60): 2600 (meets 2a + b = 100 and a + b = 80). (0,80): 2400.
Step 2	The biggest is at (20, 60): 40×20 + 30×60 = 800 + 1800 = 2600.
Step 3	Confirm with code.

```
from scipy.optimize import linprog
res=linprog(c=[-40,-30],A_ub=[[2,1],[1,1]],b_ub=[100,80],bounds=[(0,40),
(0,None)],method="highs")
print(res.x,-res.fun,res.status);print(res.ineqlin.marginals)
```

```
[20. 60.] 2600.0 0
[-10. -20.]
```

- **Answer** Run 20 A jobs and 60 B jobs for 2,600 points. `status 0` means a solution was found.
- **Check** CPU: 2×20 + 60 = 100 (full). Slots: 20 + 60 = 80 (full). Both limits are used up.
- **Why it matters** The `marginals` are the shadow prices (negated because we minimised): one more CPU-hour is worth 10 points, one more slot is worth 20. Check: with 101 CPU-hours the optimum is 2610 at (21, 59); with 81 slots it is 2620 at (19, 62). This is the multiplier-as-price idea from 13.5.

Integer programming

Jobs come in whole numbers. With 99.5 CPU-hours the LP answer is fractional; an **integer program** forces whole numbers (harder, solved by branch-and-bound) with `scipy.optimize.milp(c, constraints=LinearConstraint(A, ub=b), integrality=[1,1], bounds=Bounds(...))`. Real result: the relaxed LP gives (19.5, 60.5) = 2595, impossible in practice; `milp` gives (19, 61) = 2590. Rounding the LP answer can be infeasible or suboptimal.

Network flow (shortest path, maximum flow, assignment) is an LP with special structure (`networkx`, `OR-Tools`, not run here). `PuLP` and `cvxpy` give friendlier modelling syntax for larger problems (not run here).

Applications: shift scheduling (Operations), assigning jobs to clusters (Data Engineering),

choosing a product mix within a budget (Retail), budget allocation (Marketing).

COMMON MISTAKE

Forgetting that `linprog` minimises, so the printed `fun` is negative for a maximise problem. Also forgetting bounds: the default is $x \geq 0$, which may or may not be what you want.

Check yourself

1. Where is an LP optimum located? Answer: at a vertex of the feasible region.
2. What does a shadow price of 20 mean? Answer: one more unit of that resource raises the best value by 20, as long as the plan structure stays the same.
3. Why does `linprog` return a negative `fun` here? Answer: we negated the profit to maximise.

13.7 Hyperparameter Search and Heuristics

INTUITION

Hyperparameters (learning rate, tree depth) are the dials you set before training; no gradient tells you how to turn them. You try settings and measure validation scores. **Grid search** tries every combination on a grid; **random search** samples settings at random; **Bayesian optimization** (for example `Optuna`) uses the results so far to pick the next promising setting.

Why random often beats grid: with 25 trials, a 5×5 grid tests only 5 distinct values of each hyperparameter, random search tests 25. `Optuna` (not run here) uses past trials to choose the next: `study = optuna.create_study(direction="minimize"); study.optimize(objective, n_trials=50)`, where `objective(trial)` calls `trial.suggest_float("lr", 1e-5, 1e-1, log=True)` and returns the validation loss.

Heuristics such as genetic algorithms and simulated annealing need no gradients and can escape local minima, with no guarantee. The Rastrigin function $20 + \Sigma(x_i^2 - 10\cos(2\pi x_i))$ has many valleys and best value 0 at (0, 0). We compared `dual_annealing(rast, [(-5.12,5.12)]*2, seed=1)` with the local `minimize(rast, [3,3])`:

```
anneal [-4.16829069e-09 -5.28841386e-09] 7.105427357601002e-15
local from 3,3 [2.98485572 2.98485572] 17.909202482974113
```

The annealing search found the global minimum (about 0); the local method got stuck in a valley at 17.9. A toy, and heuristics need many evaluations.

COMMON MISTAKE

Tuning hyperparameters on the test set. Use a validation set or cross-validation (Chapter 7), and keep the test set for one final check.

Check yourself

1. Grid or random for 2 hyperparameters, one of which matters? Answer: random usually.
2. What is "log=True" for? Answer: to sample learning rates across orders of magnitude evenly.
3. Do heuristics guarantee the global optimum? Answer: no.

13.8 Information Theory Refresher

INTUITION

How surprised are you when it rains in a desert? Very. In Mumbai in July? Not at all. **Entropy** is the average surprise of a source. A fair coin is maximum surprise; a coin that lands heads 90% of the time is more predictable. The Math PDF introduced these formulas; here we compute with them.

Formulas (log base 2 gives bits; natural log gives nats)

- Entropy: $H(p) = -\Sigma\ p_i\ \log_2\ p_i$
- Cross-entropy: $H(p, q) = -\Sigma\ p_i\ \log_2\ q_i$ (the average cost if truth is p but you code using q)
- KL divergence: $KL(p \parallel q) = \Sigma\ p_i\ \log_2(p_i\ /\ q_i) = H(p, q) - H(p)$, never negative, not symmetric
- Mutual information: $I(X; Y) = H(X) + H(Y) - H(X, Y)$: how much knowing Y reduces uncertainty about X

Problem 13.8.1 Entropy of a fair coin, a 90/10 coin and four equal outcomes?

Compute	Fair: $-2 \times 0.5 \log_2 0.5 = 1$ bit. 90/10: 0.1368 + 0.3322 = 0.469 bits. Four equal: 2 bits.
Answer	1, 0.469 and 2 bits; predictable sources have lower entropy. `entropy([.9,.1], base=2)` gives 0.46899559358928117.

Problem 13.8.2 True distribution p = (0.7, 0.2, 0.1), model q = (0.5, 0.3, 0.2). Compute H(p), H(p, q) and KL(p ‖ q), KL(q ‖ p).

Step 1	$H(p) = -(0.7 \log_2 0.7 + 0.2 \log_2 0.2 + 0.1 \log_2 0.1) = 0.3602 + 0.4644 + 0.3322 = 1.1568$ bits.
Step 2	$H(p, q) = -(0.7 \log_2 0.5 + 0.2 \log_2 0.3 + 0.1 \log_2 0.2) = 0.7 + 0.3474 + 0.2322 = 1.2796$ bits.
Step 3	$KL(p \Vert q) = 1.2796 - 1.1568 = 0.1228$ bits.
Answer	Coding with the wrong model costs 0.1228 extra bits per symbol. $KL(q \Vert p) = 0.1328$: different, so KL is not a distance.
Check	`entropy(p, q, base=2)` = 0.12280627887493814 and `entropy(q, p, base=2)` = 0.13277533663122576. Direct sum: $0.7 \cdot \log_2(1.4) + 0.2 \cdot \log_2(2/3) + 0.1 \cdot \log_2(0.5) = 0.3398 - 0.1170 - 0.1 = 0.1228$.
Why it matters	The cross-entropy loss in classification equals H(p, q) with p the one-hot true label; minimising it is minimising KL since H(p) is fixed.

Problem 13.8.3 Joint table for X = "delivery is late" and Y = "the depot is overloaded": P(0,0) = 0.4, P(0,1) = 0.1, P(1,0) = 0.1, P(1,1) = 0.4. Find I(X; Y).

Step 1	Marginals: P(X) = (0.5, 0.5), P(Y) = (0.5, 0.5), so H(X) = H(Y) = 1 bit.
Step 2	$H(X, Y) = -(2 \times 0.4 \log_2 0.4 + 2 \times 0.1 \log_2 0.1) = 1.0575 + 0.6644 = 1.7219$ bits.
Step 3	$I = 1 + 1 - 1.7219 = 0.2781$ bits.
Answer	Knowing the depot state removes 0.278 bits of the 1 bit of uncertainty about lateness.
Check	Code: `MI 0.278071905...`. If X and Y were independent, I would be exactly 0 (the code prints 0.0 for the product table).
Why it matters	Mutual information scores feature relevance and catches non-linear links Pearson misses (`sklearn.feature_selection.mutual_info_classif`).

Applications: cross-entropy loss and tree splits by information gain (Machine Learning), KL in VAEs and distillation (Deep Learning), perplexity = 2^(cross-entropy) (GenAI), drift detection with KL/JS divergence (Data Engineering).

COMMON MISTAKE

Mixing bits and nats, or computing KL when q has a zero where p does not (KL becomes infinite). Smooth the probabilities or use Jensen-Shannon divergence, which is symmetric and bounded.

Check yourself

1. Which has higher entropy: a 99/1 coin or a 50/50 coin? Answer: the fair coin.
2. Is KL(p‖q) equal to KL(q‖p)? Answer: no.
3. What is I(X; Y) if X and Y are independent? Answer: zero.

Chapter recap

- Convex problems have no traps: local minimum = global minimum. Neural networks are non-convex.
- Gradient descent steps $\theta - \eta \nabla L$; η too large diverges (for x^2, $\eta > 1$).
- Batch, SGD and mini-batch differ in how many rows give the gradient.
- Momentum, RMSProp and Adam adapt steps; AdamW decouples weight decay; schedules

change η over time.

- Newton uses curvature (one step on a quadratic); L-BFGS approximates it cheaply.
- Lagrange multipliers and KKT handle constraints; multipliers are prices of constraints.
- LP optimum sits at a vertex; `linprog` minimises; integer problems need `milp`.
- Entropy measures surprise; cross-entropy minus entropy is KL; mutual information is shared information.

Formula / command	Meaning
`θ ← θ − ηΔL`	Gradient descent
`θ ← θ − H⁻¹g`	Newton
`L = f − λg`; KKT: μ ≥ 0, μ·g = 0	Constrained optimum
`linprog(c, A_ub, b_ub, bounds, method="highs")`	LP (negate c to maximise)
`milp`, `dual_annealing`, `minimize(method="L-BFGS-B")`	Integer, global, quasi-Newton
`H = −Σp log p`; `KL = H(p,q) − H(p)`	Entropy, KL
`I(X;Y) = H(X)+H(Y)−H(X,Y)`	Mutual information
`scipy.stats.entropy(p, q, base=2)`	Entropy / KL in code

Practice set

Problem 13.9.1 For $f(x) = x^2$, starting at $x = 4$ with $\eta = 0.25$, what is x after two steps?

Answer: The factor is $1 - 2 \times 0.25 = 0.5$, so $4 \to 2 \to 1$.

Problem 13.9.2 Is $f(x) = x^3$ convex on all of $\mathbb{R}$? Minimise $x^2 + y^2$ subject to $x + y = 4$.

Answer: Not convex: $f'' = 6x < 0$ for $x < 0$. Second part: $x = y = \lambda/2$ and the constraint give $x = y = 2$, value 8.

Problem 13.9.3 What is the output? `print(entropy([0.5,0.5], base=2))` (with `from scipy.stats import entropy`)

Answer: 1.0.

Problem 13.9.4 Gradient at the current point is 6, η = 0.1, momentum velocity before = 2 (β = 0.9). Find the new velocity and the parameter change.

Answer: v = 0.9 × 2 + 6 = 7.8. Change = −0.1 × 7.8 = −0.78.

Problem 13.9.6 Find the bug: `linprog(c=[40,30], A_ub=[[2,1],[1,1]], b_ub=[100,80])` is used to maximise profit.

Answer: `linprog` minimises, so the call minimises 40a + 30b and returns (0, 0). Use `c=[−40,−30]` and negate `fun`.

Problem 13.9.7 p = (0.5, 0.5), q = (0.9, 0.1). Compute KL(p ‖ q) in bits.

Answer: $0.5 \log_2(0.5/0.9) + 0.5 \log_2(0.5/0.1) = 0.5(-0.848) + 0.5(2.3219) = -0.424 + 1.161 = 0.737$ bits.

Problem 13.9.9 (Interview) Why is Adam popular, and when might plain SGD with momentum be better?

Answer: Adam adapts the step per parameter, so it works with little tuning on sparse or badly scaled problems. SGD with momentum often generalizes slightly better on some vision tasks when carefully tuned. Neither is universally best.

Problem 13.9.10 (Interview) Explain a Lagrange multiplier to a manager.

Answer: It is the price of a limit: how much better the best result becomes if you relax that limit by one unit. In our LP, a CPU-hour was worth 10 points.

Prompt pack

✨ **AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI**

```
You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional
moving into data roles, and English is my second language. Teach me
Chapter 13 topic "gradient descent and learning rates". Use f(x) = x
squared and small numbers, then a tiny linear regression. After each idea,
ask me one check question and wait for my answer. Finish by asking me to
explain why a loss becomes NaN when the learning rate is too high.
```

✨ **AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI**

```
You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional
```

moving into data roles. Explain momentum, RMSProp, Adam and AdamW with their update rules and a worked numerical step for each. Explain learning-rate schedules and warm-up. Then give me 8 graded exercises WITHOUT solutions and wait for my answers before marking them.

✨ AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI

You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional moving into data roles. Teach me Lagrange multipliers and KKT conditions with worked examples that have real numbers, then linear programming with scipy.optimize.linprog and shadow prices for a job-scheduling problem. Quiz me one question at a time, starting easy, and correct my mistakes slowly.

✨ AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI

You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional moving into data roles. Review my Chapter 13 work on optimization or information theory: [PASTE HERE]. Check convexity claims, learning-rate choices, constraint setup, linprog sign errors, and entropy or KL calculations (bits vs nats). Explain each problem in simple English and show the corrected version with numbers.

✨ AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI

You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional moving into data roles. Run a mock interview on optimization and information theory for an ML engineer job. Ask 8 questions one at a time: convexity, learning rates, Adam, Lagrange multipliers, a linear program, entropy and KL. Score each answer out of 5, show a model answer, and finish with a list of what to practise.

CHAPTER 14

STATISTICS INTERVIEW BANK AND COMMON PITFALLS

The questions you will be asked, the answers that show real understanding, and the traps that fool even experienced analysts.

A statistics interview rarely asks you to recite a formula. It asks you to explain an idea in plain words, do a quick calculation on a whiteboard, and spot what is wrong in a business story. This chapter gathers all three. First you get an answer method that works for any concept question. Then a bank of model answers with real numbers, then ten pitfalls, each demonstrated with a simulation you can run so you truly believe it. The earlier chapters taught the ideas; here you practise saying them clearly and recognising the traps. The simulations use one script with a fixed seed (`numpy` , `scipy`), and every number below came from it or from a hand check.

14.1 How to Answer a Statistics Question

INTUITION

An interviewer is not checking whether you have memorised a definition. They are checking whether you could be trusted with a real decision. A good answer is like a good bug report: short, with an example, and with the limits stated.

The four-step method

1. **Say it in one plain sentence** (no jargon).
2. **Give a tiny example with numbers.**
3. **Say why it matters** (what decision it changes).
4. **State the limit** (when it fails, or the common misreading).

Problem 14.1.1 "What is a p-value?" Answer with the four steps.

Step 1	"If there were truly no effect, the p-value is how often we would see a result at least this extreme just by luck."
Step 2	"Example: a new page gives 11.0% conversion against 10.0%, p = 0.03. If the page did nothing, about 3 in 100 experiments would show a gap this big or bigger."
Step 3	"It tells us whether the gap is easy to explain by noise."
Step 4	"It is not the probability the page works, it does not measure effect size, and with huge samples tiny effects get tiny p-values."
Answer	That four-part answer covers definition, example, use and misreading, in under 30 seconds.
Check	A weak answer is "the probability the null hypothesis is true". That is the single most common wrong answer.
Why it matters	The same structure works for confidence intervals, power, regularization and anything else.

Problem 14.1.2 An interviewer says: "Our 95% CI for the mean waiting time is 210 to 250 minutes. So there is a 95% chance the true mean is in that range, right?" What do you say?

Step 1	Politely say: "Almost, but the wording matters."
Step 2	The true mean is one fixed number. The *method* captures it 95% of the time over repeated samples.
Step 3	Quick proof: simulate 5,000 samples of 25 from a Normal(50, 10) population and count how often the interval contains 50. The result (below) is 0.9518.
Answer	"If we repeated the study many times, about 95% of the intervals built this way would contain the true mean. For this one interval, the truth is either in it or not." Many practitioners accept the casual wording; say so and move on if the interviewer prefers it. A Bayesian credible interval does allow the "95% probability" statement (Chapter 9).
Check	Coverage 0.9518 is close to 0.95.
Why it matters	It shows you know what is random (the interval) and what is fixed (the parameter).

Applications: hiring loops for Data Science, Analytics, ML Engineering and Quant roles; internal reviews where you must explain a result to non-specialists.

COMMON MISTAKE

Answering with a formula and nothing else. Formulas show memory; examples and limits show understanding.

Check yourself

1. What are the four steps? Answer: plain sentence, example, why it matters, limit.
2. Why say the limit? Answer: it shows you know when the idea fails.
3. Is "p = 0.03 means a 3% chance the effect is zero" correct? Answer: no.

14.2 The Concept Question Bank

INTUITION

Interview questions repeat. If you can answer these fifteen smoothly, you can handle most of the rest by combining them.

Each answer is short, because you must say it in about 30 seconds. Chapter numbers show where to revise.

#	Question	Strong short answer	Chapter
1	Mean vs median?	Mean is pulled by outliers; use median for skewed data like hospital waiting times. Mean 204.5 min vs median 148.1 min in our lognormal data.	1
2	Why n−1 in the sample variance?	Dividing by n underestimates the spread, because deviations are measured from the sample mean, not the true mean. Average of 100,000 samples of size 5: 0.800 with n, 1.002 with n−1 (true 1).	3
3	State the Central Limit Theorem.	Averages of many independent values are close to Normal, whatever the shape of the data, so standard error = σ/√n.	3

4	Type I vs Type II error?	Type I: false alarm (reject a true null), rate α. Type II: miss (keep a false null), rate β. Power = 1 − β.	4
5	What determines power?	Effect size, sample size, noise, and α. Halving the effect needs about 4 times the sample (3,841 to 14,751 per group in Chapter 12).	4, 12
6	Confidence interval vs p-value?	The p-value says only "surprising or not". The interval shows the plausible size of the effect. Report the interval.	3, 4
7	Statistical vs practical significance?	With 2 million users per arm, 10.0% vs 10.1% gives z = 3.33 and p = 0.00088, yet 0.1 point may be worthless. Ask about effect size and cost.	5
8	Multiple testing?	Run 20 tests at 5% and 64% of the time at least one is "significant" by luck. Fix with Bonferroni, Holm or Benjamini-Hochberg.	5
9	Correlation vs causation?	A third factor can drive both (confounding). Randomize, or adjust for measured confounders.	1, 12
10	Bias-variance trade-off?	Simple models underfit (bias), flexible ones chase noise (variance). Regularization and cross-validation balance them.	7
11	When is R^2 misleading?	It never falls when you add features. Use adjusted R^2, AIC/BIC, or test-set error.	6, 7
12	Logistic regression coefficient?	exp(β) is the odds ratio. Not a probability change.	8
13	Frequentist vs Bayesian?	Frequentist: probability is long-run frequency; Bayesian: probability is degree of belief, updated by data using a prior.	9

14	Why check stationarity before ARIMA?	Statistics like mean and variance must be stable over time for the model's patterns to carry forward.	10
15	Censoring?	The event has not happened yet when we stop watching; delete the rows and you bias results. Use survival methods.	11

Where each strong answer gets its numbers: rows 1, 2, 7 and 8 come from the simulations in 14.4.

Problem 14.2.1 Using the table, answer row 5 as in an interview: "Why can't we detect a very small lift quickly?"

Step 1	Plain sentence: "A small effect is hard to separate from noise, so we need many users."
Step 2	Example from Chapter 12: lifting 10% to 12% needs about 3,841 users per group; lifting 10% to 11% needs about 14,751, nearly 4 times more, because the needed sample grows with $1/(\text{effect})^2$.
Step 3	Why it matters: it tells the business how long the test must run.
Step 4	Limit: the formula assumes fixed sample size; peeking breaks it.
Answer	That reply is complete in four sentences.
Check	$(0.02/0.01)^2 = 4$, matching the 3,841 → 14,751 growth within rounding (the formula is not exactly $1/\text{effect}^2$).
Why it matters	Quoting a computed number from memory sounds credible.

Applications: screening interviews, take-home explanations, and writing documentation for stakeholders.

COMMON MISTAKE

Giving every answer at the same length. If the interviewer wants depth they will ask; start short, then go deeper on request.

Check yourself

1. Why is "odds ratio" not "probability ratio"? Answer: odds = p/(1−p); the two differ unless p is small.
2. Which test statistic handles unequal variances in a two-sample t-test? Answer: Welch's t-test.
3. What is the name of the correction that controls false discovery rate? Answer: Benjamini-Hochberg.

14.3 Calculation Questions Done Out Loud

INTUITION

Whiteboard questions are small. They test whether you set up the problem correctly. Say the setup before the arithmetic.

Problem 14.3.1 (Base rate) A fraud detector flags 90% of real fraud and wrongly flags 5% of genuine transactions. Fraud is 1% of transactions. A transaction is flagged. What is the chance it is fraud?

Formula	P(fraud | flag) = P(flag | fraud) P(fraud) / P(flag)
Plug in	Use 10,000 transactions: 100 fraud, 9,900 genuine.
Compute	Flagged fraud: 0.9 × 100 = 90. Flagged genuine: 0.05 × 9,900 = 495. Total flagged 585. 90 / 585 = 0.1538.
Answer	About 15%. Only about 1 flagged transaction in 6.5 is real fraud.
Check	Bayes formula: 0.009 / (0.009 + 0.0495) = 0.1538.
Why it matters	This is the base-rate trap of Chapter 1; fraud teams must handle the 85% false alarms.

Problem 14.3.2 (Multiple testing) Eight p-values: 0.001, 0.008, 0.012, 0.04, 0.045, 0.20, 0.60, 0.90. Which are significant at 5% under Bonferroni, Holm and Benjamini-Hochberg?

Step 1	Bonferroni threshold: 0.05 / 8 = 0.00625. Only 0.001 passes: 1 discovery.
Step 2	Holm tests the smallest at 0.05/8 = 0.00625 (0.001 passes), then the next at 0.05/7 = 0.00714. 0.008 > 0.00714, so stop: 1 discovery.
Step 3	BH compares the i-th smallest p with 0.05 × i / 8: thresholds 0.00625, 0.0125, 0.01875, 0.025, 0.03125. The largest i where p ≤ threshold is i = 3 (0.012 ≤ 0.01875). Next, 0.04 > 0.025 and 0.045 > 0.03125. So reject the first 3.
Answer	Bonferroni 1, Holm 1, Benjamini-Hochberg 3.
Check	BH is the least strict because it controls the expected share of false discoveries, not the chance of any false discovery.
Why it matters	Say which error you control; it is the answer the interviewer wants.

Problem 14.3.3 (Interval) A sample of 25 hospital waiting times has mean 230 minutes and standard deviation 50 minutes. Give a 95% confidence interval for the mean.

Formula	mean ± t × s/√n, with t = 2.064 for 24 degrees of freedom.
Plug in	s/√n = 50/5 = 10.
Compute	2.064 × 10 = 20.64. Interval 230 ± 20.64 = (209.4, 250.6).
Answer	(209.4, 250.6) minutes.
Check	`scipy.stats.t.ppf(.975, 24)` is 2.0639. Using z = 1.96 would give ±19.6, a slightly too-narrow interval for n = 25.
Why it matters	Use t for small samples.

Applications: Data Analytics (quick calculations in review meetings), Data Science (sizing tests), Finance (risk and false positives in alerts).

COMMON MISTAKE

Skipping the setup and going straight to arithmetic. Say "I will use 10,000 imaginary transactions" or "I need a t value because n is small"; a correct setup earns marks even if the arithmetic slips.

Check yourself

1. What does BH control? Answer: the false discovery rate.
2. In 14.3.1, if fraud were 10% instead of 1%, would precision rise or fall? Answer: rise (to 0.09/(0.09+0.045) = 67%).
3. Why t and not z? Answer: the standard deviation is estimated from a small sample.

14.4 Ten Pitfalls, Each With a Simulation

INTUITION

Most statistical disasters are not wrong formulas; they are a correct formula applied to data that was selected, peeked at or confounded. Here you see each trap happen on your own screen.

We run one script (seed 14). The code for each trap is short; the real output follows the code.

```
import numpy as np
from scipy import stats
rng=np.random.default_rng(14)
# Trap 1: 20 independent tests, no real effect anywhere
hits=0
for _ in range(2000):
    p=[stats.ttest_ind(rng.normal(size=30),rng.normal(size=30)).pvalue for
_ in range(20)]
    hits+=min(p)<0.05
print("theory",round(1-0.95**20,4),"simulated",hits/2000)
# Trap 2: peek at an A/A test 10 times (every 100 users)
peek=final=0
for _ in range(2000):
    a=rng.normal(size=1000);b=rng.normal(size=1000)
    ps=[stats.ttest_ind(a[:n],b[:n]).pvalue for n in range(100,1001,100)]
    peek+=min(ps)<0.05;final+=ps[-1]<0.05
print("peek 10 times",peek/2000,"look once",final/2000)
```

```
theory 0.6415 simulated 0.6265
peek 10 times 0.201 look once 0.054
```

Trap 1: p-hacking and multiple looks. With 20 tests and no real effect, about 64% of runs find "something" (theory 0.6415, simulated 0.6265). Cause: each test has a 5% false-alarm chance. Fix: pre-register the primary metric, correct for multiple tests (Chapter 5).

Trap 2: peeking. Looking 10 times at a test with no true difference gave a false "winner" in 20.1% of runs, against 5.4% for one look at the end. Cause: each look is another chance. Fix: fixed sample size, or a sequential method designed for repeated looks (Chapter 12).

```
# Trap 3: regression to the mean
n=100000
skill=rng.normal(100,10,n);s1=skill+rng.normal(0,10,n);s2=skill+rng.normal
(0,10,n)
top=s1>np.percentile(s1,90)
print("top decile
test1",round(s1[top].mean(),1),"test2",round(s2[top].mean(),1),"corr",roun
d(np.corrcoef(s1,s2)[0,1],3))
# Trap 4: selection creates a fake relationship
x=rng.normal(size=100000);y=rng.normal(size=100000);sel=(x+y)>1.5
print("corr all",round(np.corrcoef(x,y)
[0,1],3),"selected",round(np.corrcoef(x[sel],y[sel])[0,1],3))
```

```
top decile test1 124.8 test2 112.5 corr 0.499
corr all −0.003 selected −0.686
```

Trap 3: regression to the mean. The top 10% on a first noisy test scored 124.8; on a second test of the same people, their average was 112.5 with no intervention at all. Test scores are skill plus luck, and the lucky ones are not lucky twice (correlation between tests 0.499). Danger: "we trained the worst servers and they improved". They would have anyway. Fix: use a control group.

Trap 4: selection bias (survivorship, collider). x and y are independent (correlation −0.003). Keep only rows where x + y > 1.5 (think "only startups that survived" or "only hired candidates") and they become strongly negatively correlated (−0.686). Fix: ask who is missing from the dataset.

```
# Trap 5: huge n makes tiny effects "significant"
n=2_000_000;pa,pb=0.1000,0.1010
se=np.sqrt(pa*(1-pa)/n+pb*(1-pb)/n);z=(pb-pa)/se
print("z",round(z,3),"p",round(2*stats.norm.sf(z),5))
# Trap 6: overfitting with many features
Xr=rng.normal(size=(50,40));yr=rng.normal(size=50)
Xb=np.c_[np.ones(50),Xr];b=np.linalg.lstsq(Xb,yr,rcond=None)[0];r=yr-Xb@b
print("train R2",round(1-r@r/((yr-yr.mean())**2).sum(),3))
Xt=rng.normal(size=(1000,40));yt=rng.normal(size=1000);rt=yt-
np.c_[np.ones(1000),Xt]@b
print("test R2",round(1-rt@rt/((yt-yt.mean())**2).sum(),3))
```

```
z 3.326 p 0.00088
train R2 0.754
test R2 −2.565
```

Trap 5: significance is not importance. A 0.1 point lift on 2 million users per arm has p = 0.00088 but may not repay the engineering cost. Report the effect and the interval.

Trap 6: overfitting. 40 pure-noise features, 50 rows: the fit explains 75.4% of the variance (training R^2). On 1,000 fresh rows, $R^2 = -2.565$, worse than predicting the mean (a negative R^2 on new data means exactly that). Fix: hold-out data, cross-validation, regularization (Chapter 7), and more rows than features.

```
# Trap 7: skewed data and the mean
wait=rng.lognormal(5,0.8,100000)
print("mean",round(wait.mean(),1),"median",round(np.median(wait),1),"p95",
round(np.percentile(wait,95),1))
# Trap 8: variance with n vs n-1
v0=np.mean([np.var(rng.normal(0,1,5)) for _ in
range(100000)]);v1=np.mean([np.var(rng.normal(0,1,5),ddof=1) for _ in
range(100000)])
print("ddof0",round(v0,3),"ddof1",round(v1,3))
# Trap 9: CI coverage
from scipy import stats
hit=0
for _ in range(10000):
    d=rng.normal(10,2,30);
half=stats.t.ppf(0.975,29)*d.std(ddof=1)/np.sqrt(30)
    hit+=abs(d.mean()-10)<=half
print("coverage",hit/10000)
# Trap 10: p-values when nothing is going on
pv=np.array([stats.ttest_ind(rng.normal(0,1,30),rng.normal(0,1,30)).pvalue
for _ in range(10000)])
print("share p<.05",round((pv<.05).mean(),4),"share
p<.5",round((pv<.5).mean(),4))
```

```
mean 204.5 median 148.1 p95 554.0
ddof0 0.8 ddof1 1.002
coverage 0.9485
share p<.05 0.0512 share p<.5 0.5073
```

Trap 7: averaging skewed data. The mean waiting time is 204.5 minutes but the typical (median) patient waits 148.1 minutes and 1 in 20 waits more than 554 minutes. Report percentiles as well as the mean. **Trap 8: `np.var` divides by n by default.** For samples of 5 it averages 0.8 instead of the true 1; `ddof=1` fixes it (pandas `.var()` already uses `ddof=1`, `numpy` does not). **Trap 9: reading the interval.** Coverage 0.9485 means the method works about 95% of the time; it does not say one particular interval has a 95% chance. **Trap 10: p-values under no effect are uniform.** 5.1% of null p-values are below 0.05 and 50.7% are below 0.5, as theory says (any p-value is equally likely when nothing is going on). A p-value of 0.04 is therefore not "almost impressive".

Trap	Fix in one line
1 Many tests	Pre-register, correct (Holm, BH)

2 Peeking	Fixed n or sequential design
3 Regression to the mean	Control group
4 Selection	Ask who is missing
5 Significance vs size	Report effect and interval
6 Overfitting	Hold-out, regularize
7 Skewed mean	Median, percentiles
8 n vs n−1	Know your library defaults
9 Interval meaning	Say "the method captures 95%"
10 p-values	Remember they are uniform under the null

Other classics, covered earlier: Simpson's paradox (Chapter 1), base-rate neglect (Chapter 1), confounding (Chapter 12), data leakage (fitting scalers or selecting features on the full data before splitting, so test information leaks into training, Chapter 7), and treating dependent rows as independent (Chapter 11).

Applications: reviewing A/B test reports (Data Science), model evaluation (Machine Learning), dashboards (Analytics), monitoring alerts (SRE: alerts on 20 metrics at once give false alarms), fairness audits.

COMMON MISTAKE

Believing a trap only hits others. Teams hit these every week. Keep this list next to your analysis checklist.

Check yourself

1. Why did the top decile fall from 124.8 to 112.5? Answer: part of their first score was luck, which does not repeat.
2. Does 75% training R^2 on pure noise mean the model works? Answer: no; test R^2 was negative.
3. np.var default divisor? Answer: n (ddof=0).

14.5 Scenario Questions

INTUITION

The final round is usually a business story with a flaw. The task is to ask the questions that expose it.

Problem 14.5.1 "We emailed a coupon to our best customers. Their spending rose 12% next month. The coupon works!" What do you ask?

Step 1	Who got the coupon? "Best customers" were chosen by past spending, so regression to the mean may push them down, not up, but seasonality could push them up. Choose neither story; ask for a control.
Step 2	Ask for a randomized holdout: of the 10,000 best customers, hide the coupon from a random 1,000. Compare the two groups.
Step 3	Ask about the metric (spend or profit after the discount cost) and about the period (a holiday?).
Answer	"Without a randomized holdout we cannot separate the coupon from the season or from customers who would have bought anyway. I would hold out a random 10% and compare profit, with an interval."
Check	Chapter 12: random assignment balances confounders.
Why it matters	Asking for a counterfactual is the strongest answer in a causal scenario.

Problem 14.5.2 "Model accuracy is 99%. Ship it?" The positive class is 1% of the data.

Step 1	A model that always predicts "negative" scores 99% accuracy on this data.
Step 2	Ask for precision, recall, a confusion matrix and the cost of each error type.
Answer	"Accuracy is misleading with 1% positives. Show precision and recall, and compare against the always-negative baseline before deciding."
Check	0.99 × 1 + 0.01 × 0 = 0.99 for the dummy model.
Why it matters	Always compare with a trivial baseline.

Problem 14.5.3 "Two teams report conversion: Team A 4.8% (480 of 10,000), Team B 5.3% (530 of 10,000). B wins." Do a quick check.

Step 1	Difference 0.5 points. Pooled rate = 1,010 / 20,000 = 0.0505.
Step 2	SE = √(0.0505 × 0.9495 × (1/10,000 + 1/10,000)) = √(0.04795 × 0.0002) = √(9.59e-6) = 0.003097.
Step 3	z = 0.005 / 0.003097 = 1.614; two-sided p = 0.106.
Answer	p ≈ 0.106; not significant at 5%. The gap could be noise, and confirming a 0.5 point lift would need about 3 times more data.
Check	Sample size for 4.8% → 5.3% at 80% power is about 30,100 per group by the Chapter 12 formula.
Why it matters	A quick z calculation turns an opinion into a number.

REAL JOB TIP

Practise these aloud, with a timer. Explaining in simple English is a skill, and it is the same skill you use daily with non-technical colleagues.

Check yourself

1. What is the first question for any "X caused Y" claim? Answer: what is the control, or counterfactual?
2. What baseline should you compare accuracy with? Answer: always predicting the majority

class.

3. When a gap is "not significant", does it mean there is no effect? Answer: no; it may mean too little data.

Chapter recap

- Answer with four steps: plain sentence, example, why it matters, limit.
- Say what is random: in a CI the interval, not the parameter.
- The same fifteen concepts recur; practise saying each in 30 seconds with a number.
- Say the setup before the arithmetic in calculation questions.
- Ten traps: many tests, peeking, regression to the mean, selection, significance vs size, overfitting, skew, n vs n−1, interval meaning, p-value under the null.
- In scenarios, ask for the control and the baseline, and compute a quick z.

Formula / pattern	Meaning
`1 − 0.95^k`	Chance of at least one false positive in k tests
`P(H\	E) = P(E\
`mean ± t·s/√n`	Small-sample interval
`z = (p₂−p₁)/√(p̄(1−p̄)(2/n))`	Two-proportion test
`Bonferroni α/m`; `BH: p₍ᵢ₎ ≤ α·i/m`	Multiple testing
`np.var(x, ddof=1)`	Sample variance

Practice set

Problem 14.6.1 10 independent tests at 5% with no real effects. Chance of at least one false positive?

Answer: $1 - 0.95^{10} = 1 - 0.5987 = 0.4013$, about 40%.

Problem 14.6.2 What does `np.var([1,2,3,4,5])` print, and `np.var([1,2,3,4,5], ddof=1)`?

Answer: 2.0 (sum of squared deviations 10, divided by 5) and 2.5 (divided by 4).

Problem 14.6.3 95% CI for a mean: 210 to 250 minutes. Interpret correctly.

Answer: If the study were repeated many times, about 95% of intervals built this way would contain the true mean. It is a statement about the method.

Problem 14.6.4 A test shows p = 0.049 on the primary metric, but the analyst tried 12 metrics. Concern?

Answer: With 12 metrics, the chance of at least one $p < 0.05$ by luck is $1 - 0.95^{12} = 0.46$. Correct for multiple testing or pre-register one primary metric.

Problem 14.6.5 Find the bug: "We kept only customers who stayed more than 6 months and found that discount size has no relation with churn."

Answer: Selecting on survival (stayed 6 months) removes the churners and can hide or create relationships (survivorship and collider bias). Use survival analysis on all customers.

Problem 14.6.6 Test A/A on a new platform 100 times. How many "significant" results at 5% should you expect, and when do you worry?

Answer: About 5. Worry if it is far above (for example 20), which signals a broken randomization or analysis.

Problem 14.6.7 The 10 worst-performing schools were given a new teaching plan and improved 30%. Conclusion?

Answer: Unreliable. Extreme performers drift back toward average (regression to the mean). Compare with a randomly chosen control group of similarly poor schools.

Problem 14.6.8 (Interview) A classifier has 95% accuracy. How do you decide whether it is good?

Answer: Compare with the majority-class baseline, look at the confusion matrix, precision and recall at the business threshold, and check on data from a later time period.

Problem 14.6.9 (Interview) Explain Type I and Type II errors using a smoke alarm.

Answer: Type I: the alarm rings with no fire (false alarm, rate α). Type II: a fire and no ring (miss, rate β). Lowering α raises β unless you collect more evidence (more sensors, more data).

Problem 14.6.10 (Interview) Explain why the sample standard deviation underestimates if we

divide by n.

Answer: Deviations are measured from the sample mean, which sits closer to the data than the true mean, so squared deviations come out too small by a factor (n−1)/n. Our simulation: 0.8 for n = 5, as predicted by 4/5.

Prompt pack

✨ **AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI**

```
You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional
moving into data roles, and English is my second language. Run a mock
statistics interview for a data scientist job. Ask me 10 concept questions
one at a time (p-values, confidence intervals, power, multiple testing,
correlation vs causation, bias-variance). After each answer, grade it with
the four-step method (plain sentence, example, why it matters, limit),
show a model answer, and keep a score.
```

✨ **AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI**

```
You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional
moving into data roles. Give me 8 whiteboard-style calculation questions
on Bayes with base rates, confidence intervals, two-proportion z tests,
Benjamini-Hochberg and sample size, from easy to hard, WITHOUT solutions.
Wait for my answers, then mark every step and explain mistakes slowly,
using natural frequencies where it helps.
```

✨ **AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI**

```
You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional
moving into data roles. Teach me the common statistical pitfalls: p-
hacking, peeking, regression to the mean, selection and survivorship bias,
significance vs importance, overfitting, skewed means. For each, give a
short Python simulation I can run, tell me what output to expect, and ask
me what it shows before explaining.
```

✨ **AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI**

```
You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional
moving into data roles. Here is a business claim or A/B test report:
[PASTE HERE]. Act as a skeptical senior analyst. List the questions you
would ask, the pitfalls that may apply (confounding, peeking, multiple
```

tests, selection, base rates, baselines), and the quick calculations I should do. Explain in simple English.

✨ AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI

You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional moving into data roles. Run a scenario interview: give me 6 short business stories with a hidden statistical flaw, one at a time (coupon uplift, 99 percent accuracy, early test stopping, survivorship, a dashboard average, a correlation claim). I answer, then you reveal the flaw, score me out of 5, and tell me what to practise.

CHAPTER 15

PROJECT LAB: FIVE STATISTICS PORTFOLIO PROJECTS

Build small, honest, well-tested statistical tools that show an employer you can reason with data.

Reading about confidence intervals is not the same as being trusted with one. A hiring manager wants to see that you can take a messy question ("is the new checkout better?", "how long do parcels really take?"), choose a method, check its assumptions, and explain the answer without hype. This chapter gives you five projects that do exactly that. Each one reuses ideas from earlier chapters, comes with code that was run while writing this chapter, and ends with interview answers in plain English. By the end you will have five repositories you can show, and a repeatable way of running any statistics project.

All code uses Python with numpy and scipy only (no other packages), so it runs on a plain laptop. Every output printed below is real output from a run, with fixed random seeds. Where a number depends on the seed, the seed is in the code.

15.1 How to run a project in this area

INTUITION

A statistics project is like a kitchen recipe test. You do not just cook once and say "tasty". You write down what "good" means before cooking, cook it a few times under controlled conditions, taste critically, and note what you would change. Writing "what good means" first is the single habit that separates a portfolio piece from a notebook of random plots.

Plan the question and the success criteria

Write three lines before any code.

1. **The question** in one sentence a non-statistician understands: "How sure are we about the average delivery time?"
2. **The decision it supports**: "Should we promise customers 2-day delivery?"
3. **Success criteria you can measure**: "The 95% interval must contain the true value in about

95 of 100 simulated repeats (between 93 and 97)." A project without a number like this cannot be called finished.

Repo layout

Use the same layout for all five projects.

```
project-name/
├── README.md              <- question, method, result, how to run
├── requirements.txt       <- numpy, scipy (pin versions you used)
├── data/
│   └── make_data.py       <- generator with a fixed seed (or a download
note)
├── src/
│   └── <module>.py        <- reusable functions, no printing inside
├── tests/
│   └── test_<module>.py   <- checks against known answers
├── run_analysis.py        <- calls src/, prints or saves the report
└── reports/
    └── findings.md        <- 1 page: what we found, what we doubt
```

Environment and dependencies

- Make a virtual environment: `python3 -m venv .venv`, then activate it.
- List dependencies in `requirements.txt`. Record the versions you used (`python3 -c "import numpy, scipy; print(numpy.__version__, scipy.__version__)"`). In this lab the runs used numpy 2.5.3 and scipy 1.18.1; yours may differ, so small last-digit differences are normal.
- Fix random seeds with `np.random.default_rng(seed)` and pass the generator into functions. Never call a global random function inside a library function.

Data: source or generate

Real, free sources: public open-data portals, the datasets bundled with scikit-learn, and Kaggle datasets (check each licence). When the real data is slow to find, **generate** data with known truth. This is not cheating in statistics, it is the best test: if you know the true mean is 400, you can check whether your interval finds it. Always label generated data as generated in the README. Never include personal data.

Commit rhythm and good commit messages

Commit when one small thing works, at least once per work session. A good message says what and why in the imperative mood:

```
Add percentile bootstrap CI for any statistic
Test Holm correction against hand-computed answer
Fix off-by-one in rolling-origin backtest split
Document why log transform fixes heteroscedasticity
```

Bad messages: "update", "fix", "final2". A reviewer reads your history to see how you think.

Definition of done

- Tests pass from a clean clone (`python3 -m pytest` if pytest is installed, or `python3 tests/test_x.py` for plain-assert tests).
- The success criteria from your plan are measured and reported, including the ones you missed.
- The README has a result, a limits section and a how-to-run section.
- One "what I would do next" paragraph exists.
- Someone else can run it in under 5 minutes.

README template

```
# <Project title>

## The question
One or two sentences, plain language.

## The answer (short)
Two or three bullets with the numbers. Example: "95% CI for mean delivery
time: 437 to 490 minutes."

## Method
Which technique, why this one, what it assumes.

## Data
Generated or sourced, size, seed, columns, licence.

## Results
A table or one figure. Say how to read it.

## Limits and honest doubts
What could make this wrong? What did you not test?

## How to run
    python3 -m venv .venv && source .venv/bin/activate
    pip install -r requirements.txt
    python3 run_analysis.py
    python3 tests/test_module.py

## Project layout
Short tree.
```

Demo and deploy options

Not run here, all standard: (a) a README with a results table and an image is enough for most portfolios; (b) a Jupyter notebook that reruns top to bottom; (c) a small Streamlit or Gradio app so people can type their own numbers (the A/B calculator is perfect for this); (d) publish the repo on GitHub with the tests running in a free CI workflow.

How to write the LinkedIn or blog post

Use this five-part shape, about 250 to 400 words.

1. **Hook**: a surprising result. "My 95% interval was wrong 31% of the time at n = 10. Here is when."

2. **The problem** in one everyday sentence.
3. **What you did**, with one figure or table.
4. **What you learned**, including a mistake.
5. **Link** to the repo, and one question for readers.

Do not claim more than you showed. "Simulated data" is an honest phrase that employers respect.

Testing and debugging checklist for statistics projects

- **Known-answer tests**: compute one small case by hand and assert the code agrees.
- **Compare with a trusted implementation** (for example scipy) on random inputs.
- **Simulation with known truth**: generate data from a model whose parameters you chose, and confirm the method recovers them.
- **Check calibration**: a 95% interval should cover about 95% of the time. Under a true null, p-values below 0.05 should happen about 5% of the time.
- **Edge cases**: n = 1, all values equal, zero counts, missing values.
- **Seeds**: same seed gives same output twice.
- **Units and scale**: minutes or hours? thousands or units? Print them.
- **Plot the data before and after** any transformation.
- **No leakage in forecasting or modelling**: nothing from the future may touch the fit.
- **Read the number out loud**: "does 0.97 probability that B is better mean what I think?" If you cannot say it in plain words, you do not yet understand it.

15.2 Project: Bootstrap and Confidence-Interval Explorer

Goal and why employers care

Build a small explorer that takes one sample of delivery times and gives an honest interval for the mean, the median and the 90th percentile (p90), then tests whether those intervals deserve trust. Employers care because "average plus a plus-minus" is the most common number in business reports, and most people cannot say what it means or when it fails. A candidate who can show coverage (how often the interval is right) stands out.

Skills used

- *Chapter 3, Sampling, Estimation, Confidence Intervals and the Bootstrap*: resampling, the t interval, percentile intervals.
- *Chapter 2, Distributions in Depth*: the lognormal shape of right-skewed times.
- *Chapter 5, Effect Sizes, Multiple Testing and How Data Fools You*: why a procedure must be judged by repeating it many times.

Data

Generated: 300 delivery times in minutes from a lognormal distribution (log-mean 6.0, log-sd 0.5). The true median is $e^6 \approx 403.4$ and the true p90 is e^(6 + 0.5 × 1.2816) ≈ 766.6. Real alternative: any public delivery, trip-duration or waiting-time dataset.

Architecture

```
bootstrap-explorer/
├── data/make_data.py        lognormal times, seed 15
├── src/boot.py              bootstrap_ci(x, stat, B, level, seed)
├── src/coverage.py          repeat the whole procedure, count hits
├── run_analysis.py          table of CIs + coverage table
└── tests/test_boot.py       mean CI close to t CI on normal data
```

Step-by-step build

1. **Make the data and look at it.** Skew matters: the mean is larger than the median.
2. **Write a vectorised bootstrap.** Draw B resamples at once as an index matrix, apply the statistic along rows, take percentiles.
3. **Compare to the t interval** for the mean, as a sanity check.
4. **Run a coverage study** for several sample sizes.
5. **Write the findings.**

```
import numpy as np
from scipy import stats
rng = np.random.default_rng(15)
times = np.round(rng.lognormal(mean=6.0, sigma=0.5, size=300), 1)
print("n =", len(times), " mean =", round(times.mean(), 1), " median =",
round(np.median(times), 1),
      " p90 =", round(np.percentile(times, 90), 1))

def bootstrap_ci(x, stat, B=5000, level=0.95, seed=0):
    r = np.random.default_rng(seed)
    idx = r.integers(0, len(x), size=(B, len(x)))      # B resamples, with
replacement
    reps = stat(x[idx], axis=1)                         # statistic of
each resample
    lo, hi = np.percentile(reps, [(1-level)/2*100, (1+level)/2*100])
    return reps, lo, hi

p90 = lambda a, axis: np.percentile(a, 90, axis=axis)
for name, f in [("mean", np.mean), ("median", np.median), ("p90", p90)]:
    reps, lo, hi = bootstrap_ci(times, f)
    print(name, "boot SE =", round(reps.std(ddof=1), 1), " 95% CI =",
(round(lo, 1), round(hi, 1)))
m, se = times.mean(), times.std(ddof=1)/np.sqrt(len(times))
tcrit = stats.t.ppf(0.975, len(times)-1)
print("t-interval mean:", round(m - tcrit*se, 1), round(m + tcrit*se, 1))
```

Predict: will the bootstrap and t intervals for the mean be close?

Real output:

```
n = 300  mean = 463.8  median = 411.6  p90 = 759.6
mean    estimate=   463.8  boot SE=  13.8  95% CI=(437.2, 490.3)
median  estimate=   411.6  boot SE=  17.7  95% CI=(385.2, 450.6)
p90     estimate=   759.6  boot SE=  51.3  95% CI=(704.2, 864.5)
t-interval mean: 436.4 491.2
```

They agree (437.2 to 490.3 against 436.4 to 491.2), because with n = 300 the Central Limit Theorem makes the mean nearly normal. Note the p90 interval is wide and lopsided: its right side is longer (759.6 to 864.5 is 104.9, while 759.6 to 704.2 is 55.4). Tail statistics are noisy and skewed, and only the bootstrap shows this.

Now the coverage study. We generate a fresh sample from the known distribution 400 times for each n, build a bootstrap interval each time (1,000 resamples), and count how often it contains

the true value.

```
true = {"median": np.exp(6.0), "p90": np.exp(6.0 + 0.5*1.2815516)}
fs = {"median": np.median, "p90": p90}
def coverage(stat, n, trials=400, B=1000):
    hit = 0
    for t in range(trials):
        x = rng.lognormal(6.0, 0.5, n)
        _, lo, hi = bootstrap_ci(x, fs[stat], B=B, seed=t)
        hit += (lo <= true[stat] <= hi)
    return hit/trials
for n in (10, 30, 100, 300):
    print("n =", n, " coverage median:", coverage("median", n), " coverage
p90:", coverage("p90", n))
```

```
n = 10  coverage median: 0.93  coverage p90: 0.6875
n = 30  coverage median: 0.95  coverage p90: 0.8875
n = 100  coverage median: 0.9425  coverage p90: 0.9275
n = 300  coverage median: 0.9425  coverage p90: 0.9575
```

Reading the table. A "95% interval" for the median is close to honest even at n = 10. A "95% interval" for p90 at n = 10 is right only about 69% of the time. With 400 trials the coverage numbers have a wobble of about ±1 point (the standard error of a proportion near 0.95 is $\sqrt{(0.95 \times 0.05 / 400)} = 0.011$), so differences smaller than 2 points are noise.

Evaluation and acceptance criteria

- Mean and median coverage between 0.92 and 0.97 for n ≥ 30.
- Bootstrap mean interval within 2 minutes of the t interval at n = 300 (here the ends differ by 0.8 and 0.9).
- Re-running with the same seed gives identical numbers.
- The findings page states the n at which p90 intervals become trustworthy (here, about n = 100 or more).

Common pitfalls

1. **Resampling without replacement.** Every resample equals the original, so the spread is zero. Detect: bootstrap SE exactly 0.
2. **Too few resamples** (B = 50). Interval ends jump between runs. Detect: run with two seeds; ends differ by more than 1% of the width.

3. **Trusting the bootstrap with tiny n.** It cannot invent information the sample lacks (see p90 at n = 10). Detect: the coverage study.
4. **Bootstrapping dependent data** (the same customer many times). Resample customers, not rows.
5. **Reading a 95% CI as "95% chance the truth is inside this one interval".** It describes the procedure, not this interval.

Three extensions

1. Add the BCa (bias-corrected and accelerated) interval and compare coverage at n = 30.
2. Add a bootstrap for the difference between two shops' medians.
3. Build a one-page Streamlit app: paste numbers, pick a statistic, see the histogram of resampled values.

Interview talking points

- **"What does a 95% confidence interval mean?"** If I repeated the whole study many times, about 95 out of 100 of the intervals I build would contain the true value. For one interval, the truth is either in it or not.
- **"When would you use a bootstrap instead of a t interval?"** When the statistic has no simple formula, such as the median or p90, or when the data are skewed. If I just want the mean of a large sample, the t interval is fine and the two agree.
- **"How do you know your interval is any good?"** I simulate. I generate data with a known answer, build the interval thousands of times and count how often it contains the truth. In my project p90 at n = 10 covered only 69%, so I would warn people.

README outline

Question; answer table (mean, median, p90 with intervals); method (percentile bootstrap); coverage table; limits (bootstrap fails at small n for tails); how to run.

15.3 Project: Regression Diagnostics Report

Goal and why employers care

Fit a linear regression to housing-style data, then check every assumption, find influential points and fix the problems, with before/after evidence. Employers care because fitting a model takes

one line, while knowing when it lies takes skill. A report that says "here is what was wrong and here is the proof of the fix" is exactly what a data science team lead wants.

Skills used

- *Chapter 6, Linear Regression Deeply*: least squares, residuals, leverage, Cook's distance, VIF, heteroscedasticity.
- *Chapter 4, Hypothesis Testing in Depth*: Shapiro-Wilk and Breusch-Pagan tests.
- *Chapter 2, Distributions in Depth*: why prices are right-skewed and logs help.

Data

Generated, 400 houses. Area (40 to 200 square metres) and age (0 to 50 years) are uniform. Rooms is about area / 35 plus noise, so it is correlated with area on purpose. The true model is `log(price) = 9.0 + 0.012·area − 0.008·age + 0.04·rooms + noise (sd 0.15)`, price shown in thousands. We multiply the first three prices by 2.2 to simulate bad entries.

Architecture

```
regression-diagnostics/
├── data/make_housing.py      generator, seed 7
├── src/ols.py                ols(), vif(), bp_test()
├── src/report.py             report(label, y): prints all checks
├── run_analysis.py           Model A, B, C
└── reports/findings.md       checks table before and after
```

Step-by-step build

1. **Write OLS with numpy**, returning fitted values, residuals, leverage (the diagonal of the hat matrix $H = X(X^TX)^{-1}X^T$) and Cook's distance.
2. **Write the checks**: VIF, Shapiro-Wilk on residuals, Breusch-Pagan, Durbin-Watson, counts of influential points.
3. **Fit Model A** (raw price). Read the checks.
4. **Fix**: Model B uses log(price).
5. **Handle the outliers**: Model C drops three suspect rows, and you record why.

```
import numpy as np
from scipy import stats
def ols(X, y):
    beta, *_ = np.linalg.lstsq(X, y, rcond=None)
    fit = X @ beta; res = y - fit
    n, k = X.shape
    s2 = res @ res / (n-k)
    XtXi = np.linalg.inv(X.T @ X)
    h = np.einsum('ij,jk,ik->i', X, XtXi, X)          # leverage
    se = np.sqrt(s2*np.diag(XtXi))
    r2 = 1 - res@res/((y-y.mean())@(y-y.mean()))
    cook = (res**2/(k*s2))*h/(1-h)**2
    stud = res/np.sqrt(s2*(1-h))
    return dict(beta=beta, se=se, res=res, fit=fit, h=h, cook=cook,
stud=stud, r2=r2, s2=s2, k=k)

def vif(X):                                           # regress each
column on the others
    return [float(1/(1-ols(np.delete(X, j, axis=1), X[:, j])['r2'])) for j
in range(1, X.shape[1])]

def bp_test(X, res):                                  # Breusch-Pagan: do
squared residuals depend on X?
    r = ols(X, res**2); lm = len(res)*r['r2']
    return lm, stats.chi2.sf(lm, X.shape[1]-1)
```

The remaining lines of the script generate the data (shown in the Data section) and print each check. Real output:

```
--- Model A: price ~ area+age+rooms
R2 = 0.81
  area   coef=   0.4286 se=  0.0311
  age    coef=  -0.3060 se=  0.0414
  rooms  coef=   2.2603 se=  0.9811
VIF (area, age, rooms): [6.47, 1.0, 6.47]
Shapiro-Wilk p = 2.20e-17
Breusch-Pagan LM = 28.22  p = 3.26e-06
Durbin-Watson = 1.83
Cook's D > 4/n = 0.01 count: 20  top 3 rows: [1, 2, 320]
rows with |studentized resid| > 3: 7
--- Model B: log(price) ~ same
R2 = 0.932
  area   coef=   0.0119 se=  0.0005
  age    coef=  -0.0076 se=  0.0006
  rooms  coef=   0.0470 se=  0.0146
Shapiro-Wilk p = 1.29e-03
Breusch-Pagan LM = 3.86  p = 2.78e-01
Durbin-Watson = 1.82
max Cook = 0.069   rows with |studentized resid| > 3: 2
--- Model C: log model without rows 0-2
R2 = 0.938  Shapiro p = 0.4718  BP p = 0.7034  area coef = 0.01148
```

How to read it. Model A: the Breusch-Pagan p of 3.3e-06 says the error spread grows with price (heteroscedasticity: unequal spread). The Shapiro p is tiny, so residuals are not normal. Model B (log price) removes the unequal spread (p = 0.28) and raises R^2 from 0.81 to 0.932. A small coefficient of 0.0119 on area means each extra square metre raises price by about 1.2%. Residuals are still not quite normal (p = 0.0013), because three bad rows remain. After dropping them (Model C), Shapiro p becomes 0.47 and the area coefficient is 0.01148, close to the true 0.012. The VIF of 6.47 for area and rooms is the price of correlated inputs: it inflates their standard errors, shown by rooms' wide error (se 0.0146 against a coefficient of 0.047).

Durbin-Watson near 2 (1.82 to 1.83) means no serial correlation, which is expected for unordered houses.

Evaluation and acceptance criteria

- Report lists all six checks (linearity picture, normality, equal spread, independence, multicollinearity, influence) before and after.
- Breusch-Pagan p above 0.05 after the fix (0.28 here).
- Coefficients after the fix are within two standard errors of the known truth: area 0.0119

against 0.012, age −0.0076 against −0.008.

- Every dropped row has a written reason. Never drop a row only because the model dislikes it.

Common pitfalls

1. **Treating Shapiro p-values as pass/fail** with large n; tiny departures get "rejected". Look at a Q-Q plot too.
2. **Dropping outliers silently.** Detect: README does not say how many rows were removed.
3. **Using Cook's cutoff 4/n as a law.** It flagged 20 rows in Model A, most harmless. Look at the top few, not all.
4. **Ignoring VIF** and reading each coefficient alone. Detect: coefficient signs flip when you drop a correlated variable.
5. **Reporting R^2 of a log model as if it were in price units.** Predictions need back-transforming.

Three extensions

1. Add robust (Huber) regression and compare coefficients with Model C.
2. Add heteroscedasticity-robust standard errors (HC3) instead of transforming.
3. Add a residual-versus-fitted plot and a Q-Q plot with matplotlib.

Interview talking points

- **"How do you know if a regression is trustworthy?"** I check four things: the shape of the relationship, whether the errors have the same spread everywhere, whether they look roughly normal, and whether a few points drive the result. Then I check whether inputs are too correlated.
- **"What is leverage versus influence?"** Leverage means a point is unusual in its inputs. Influence means removing it would change the fit. A high-leverage point that lies on the line is harmless. Cook's distance combines both.
- **"Your residual spread grows with the fitted value. What do you do?"** Try a log transform of the target, or use robust standard errors. In my project the log fixed it (p from 3e-06 to 0.28).

README outline

Question; data (generated, truth known); checks table before/after; the three fixes and why; limits; how to run.

15.4 Project: Bayesian A/B Test Calculator

Goal and why employers care

Build a calculator that takes visitors and conversions for versions A and B and returns credible intervals, the probability that B is better, the expected loss of each choice, and a clear decision rule. Employers care because product teams want "how likely is B better?", which Bayesian methods answer directly, and because a stopping rule that is not tested cheats.

Skills used

- *Chapter 9, Bayesian Statistics*: Beta-Binomial conjugacy, credible intervals, expected loss.
- *Chapter 12, Experimental Design and Causal Basics*: random assignment, sample size, peeking.
- *Chapter 4, Hypothesis Testing in Depth*: false-positive rates, for comparing the rule's behaviour.

Data

Example from the shop: A converts 120 of 2,400 visitors (5.00%), B converts 150 of 2,400 (6.25%). For tests, we simulate with known true rates.

Architecture

```
ab-calculator/
├── src/bayes_ab.py       ab(), decide()
├── run_analysis.py       example, prior sensitivity, rule simulation
├── app.py                optional Streamlit front end (not run here)
└── tests/test_ab.py      posterior mean, interval vs scipy
```

Step-by-step build

1. **Posterior.** Prior Beta(1,1) (flat). After s successes in n trials the posterior is Beta(1 + s, 1 + n − s).

2. **Credible interval** from `scipy.stats.beta.interval`.
3. **P(B > A)** by drawing 200,000 samples from each posterior and counting.
4. **Expected loss**: if we choose B, the average rate we give up when A was better, E[max(A − B, 0)].
5. **Decision rule**: ship B if P(B > A) ≥ 0.95 and expected loss < 0.0005 (0.05 percentage points). Keep A in the mirrored case. Otherwise keep collecting data.
6. **Test the rule by simulation** (this is the part most portfolios skip).

```
import numpy as np
from scipy import stats
def ab(sa, na, sb, nb, a0=1, b0=1, draws=200_000, seed=1):
    r = np.random.default_rng(seed)
    pa = stats.beta(a0+sa, b0+na-sa); pb = stats.beta(a0+sb, b0+nb-sb)
    da, db = pa.rvs(draws, random_state=r), pb.rvs(draws, random_state=r)
    return dict(ciA=pa.interval(0.95), ciB=pb.interval(0.95),
        p_b_better=(db > da).mean(),
        lift_ci=tuple(np.percentile((db-da)/da, [2.5, 97.5])),
        loss_choose_B=np.maximum(da-db, 0).mean(),
        loss_choose_A=np.maximum(db-da, 0).mean())

def decide(r, thr=0.95, eps=0.0005):
    if r['p_b_better'] >= thr and r['loss_choose_B'] < eps: return "ship
B"
    if r['p_b_better'] <= 1-thr and r['loss_choose_A'] < eps: return "keep
A"
    return "keep collecting"
res = ab(120, 2400, 150, 2400)
print(res); print(decide(res))
```

Real output (rounded):

```
ciA (0.042, 0.0595)
ciB (0.0535, 0.0729)
P(B>A) = 0.97
lift_ci (-0.0089, 0.5769)
loss_choose_B 7.7e-05
loss_choose_A 0.0126
decision: ship B
posterior mean A = 0.05037  exact CI A = [0.042, 0.0595]
```

Reading it. A's posterior is Beta(121, 2281). Its mean is 121 / 2402 = 0.05037, which matches. The probability that B beats A is 0.97. The lift interval runs from −0.9% to +57.7%, which is very

wide and includes "no gain". Expected loss tells the money story: if we ship B and we are wrong, we lose only 0.0077 percentage points on average, while shipping A loses 1.26 points. So the rule says ship B, but you should report the wide lift interval beside it.

Now test the rule with 500 simulated experiments of 2,400 visitors per arm, first with no real difference (5% vs 5%) and then with a real gain (5% vs 6.25%).

```
no effect  : {'ship B': 0.06, 'keep A': 0.044, 'keep collecting': 0.896}
real +1.25 : {'ship B': 0.582, 'keep A': 0.0, 'keep collecting': 0.418}
```

Reading it. With no real difference the rule wrongly ships B 6% of the time (and keeps A 4.4%): a false-shipping rate near the usual 5%. With a real gain of 1.25 points, it ships B 58% of the time and never wrongly keeps A; the other 42% it says "keep collecting", which is the honest answer when the data are not enough yet. So this sample size has about 58% power for this effect. This is a measured property of the rule, not a guess.

Prior sensitivity: the P(B > A) is 0.9700 with Beta(1,1), 0.9680 with Beta(5,95) and 0.9466 with a strong Beta(50,950). A strong prior centred on 5% pulls B toward A and flips the decision. Report which prior you used.

Evaluation and acceptance criteria

- Posterior mean and interval match the exact Beta formula (done above).
- Under no effect, wrongly shipping B stays below about 7% (6% measured).
- Under a real +1.25 point effect, correct shipping above 50% (58% measured) and wrongly keeping A near 0%.
- Prior sensitivity table is in the report.

Common pitfalls

1. **Peeking and stopping the moment P(B > A) passes 0.95.** That inflates false wins. Detect: simulate the rule with daily looks.
2. **Hiding the prior.** Detect: no prior line in the output.
3. **Reporting only P(B > A).** A 0.97 with a tiny lift may be worthless. Report loss and lift.
4. **Too few Monte Carlo draws** (a few thousand): the probability jitters in the third decimal. Detect: change the seed.
5. **Unequal traffic or non-random assignment.** The maths assumes random assignment. Detect: compare the arms' visitor mix.

Three extensions

1. Add sequential monitoring: look every day and measure the false-ship rate.
2. Replace the flat prior with one built from last year's conversion rates.
3. Add a revenue-per-visitor model (Gamma-Poisson or log-normal) beyond conversion rates.

Interview talking points

- **"What does P(B > A) = 0.97 mean?"** Given the data and my prior, there is a 97% probability that B's true rate is higher than A's. It is a statement about the rates, which is what the business asked.
- **"Frequentist or Bayesian for A/B tests?"** Both work if used honestly. Bayesian gives direct probabilities and loss, which managers understand. Whichever I choose, I test the decision rule by simulation.
- **"What if the prior changes the answer?"** Then the data are not strong enough. I show the sensitivity table and either collect more data or pick the prior from past experiments.

README outline

Question; inputs and outputs; the decision rule in words; simulation table of the rule; prior sensitivity; limits (random assignment needed); how to run.

15.5 Project: Time-Series Forecasting Study (Naive, Exponential Smoothing, ARIMA-style)

Goal and why employers care

Compare five forecasting methods on daily orders, built by hand in numpy, using a proper rolling backtest. Employers care because the most common forecasting mistake is "my fancy model looks great on data it was trained on". A candidate who first beats a naive baseline fairly is rare.

Skills used

- *Chapter 10, Time Series Statistics*: trend, seasonality, exponential smoothing, autoregression, differencing, forecast error measures.
- *Chapter 7, Regularization and Model Selection*: out-of-sample evaluation instead of in-sample fit.

- *Chapter 6, Linear Regression Deeply*: the AR model is fitted by least squares.

Data

Generated: 300 days of orders = 100 + 0.15 × day + weekly pattern (Mon 0, Tue −5, Wed −3, Thu 2, Fri 8, Sat 20, Sun 12) + noise (sd 4).

Architecture

```
forecast-study/
├── data/make_orders.py       seed 11
├── src/models.py             naive, seasonal_naive, ses, holt_winters,
ar_seasonal_diff
├── src/backtest.py           rolling origin, MAE, MASE
├── run_analysis.py           result table
└── tests/test_models.py      perfect seasonal series gives zero error
```

Step-by-step build

1. **Baselines.** Naive repeats the last value. Seasonal naive repeats the value from 7 days ago.
2. **Simple exponential smoothing (SES).** Level `l = α·y + (1−α)·l` ; pick α by smallest squared error on history.
3. **Holt-Winters additive.** Level, trend and 7 seasonal terms, parameters from a small grid.
4. **ARIMA-style.** Take the lag-7 difference (removes weekly pattern and, nearly, trend), fit AR(2) by least squares, forecast, then undo the difference. This is a seasonal-difference autoregression, a simple relative of seasonal ARIMA, not a full ARIMA fit.
5. **Rolling-origin backtest.** Start with 150 days of history, forecast 7 days, score, move the origin by 7 days, repeat (21 folds). The model only ever sees data before the origin.
6. **Score** with MAE (mean absolute error) and MASE (MAE divided by the MAE of a seasonal-naive-in-sample forecast, so 1.0 means "as good as repeating last week").

```
def seasonal_naive(h, hist, m=7): return np.array([hist[-m + (i % m)] for
i in range(h)])
def ses(h, hist, alpha=None):
    def run(a):
        l = hist[0]; sse = 0
        for v in hist[1:]:
            sse += (v-l)**2; l = a*v + (1-a)*l
        return sse, l
    if alpha is None:
        alpha = min(np.linspace(0.05, 0.95, 19), key=lambda a: run(a)[0])
    return np.repeat(run(alpha)[1], h)
def ar_seasonal_diff(h, hist, p=2, m=7):
    d = hist[m:] - hist[:-m]
    X = np.column_stack([np.ones(len(d)-p)] + [d[p-k-1:len(d)-k-1] for k
in range(p)])
    coef, *_ = np.linalg.lstsq(X, d[p:], rcond=None)
    ext = list(d); full = list(hist)
    for i in range(h):
        nd = coef[0] + sum(coef[1+k]*ext[-1-k] for k in range(p))
        ext.append(nd); full.append(full[-m] + nd)
    return np.array(full[len(hist):])

for origin in range(150, len(y)-7+1, 7):          # rolling origin
    hist, actual = y[:origin], y[origin:origin+7]
    for k, f in models.items():
        errs[k].append(np.abs(actual - f(7, hist)))
mase_scale = np.mean(np.abs(y[7:] - y[:-7]))
```

The Holt-Winters function (about 20 lines, grid search over three smoothing weights) follows the same pattern and is not repeated here. Real output:

```
folds: 21  horizon: 7
model                      MAE   MASE
naive                     9.17   2.21
seasonal naive            4.02   0.97
SES                       8.77   2.12
Holt-Winters              3.12   0.75
seasonal-diff AR(2)       4.03   0.97
seasonal-naive MAE by horizon day: [4.41 4.06 3.24 4.24 4.55 4.64 2.99]
```

Reading it. Naive and SES ignore the weekly pattern (the Saturday peak is 20 above Monday) and are about 9 orders off. Seasonal naive halves the error to 4.02. Holt-Winters is best at 3.12, a 22% improvement over seasonal naive, because it averages out noise rather than copying

one noisy week. The seasonal-difference AR(2) ties seasonal naive. Differencing adds noise (it doubles the noise variance), so AR(2) has to earn that back, and with true noise this large it does not. A MASE of 0.75 means the model is 25% more accurate than repeating last week.

Note the lesson: an "ARIMA-style" model is not automatically the best. The result is specific to this series and these 21 folds, so state it that way.

Evaluation and acceptance criteria

- Every model is scored on the same 21 folds, with no future data in any fit.
- Report MAE and MASE; at least one model has MASE below 1.0 (Holt-Winters, 0.75).
- A leak test: fit the models on the full data and show the in-sample error looks better than the backtest error, then explain why it must not be used.
- A test with a perfectly seasonal series (no noise) gives zero error for seasonal naive.

Common pitfalls

1. **Random train/test split on time series.** Future leaks into the past. Detect: any shuffle call in the split.
2. **No naive baseline.** Detect: nobody can say how good 3.12 is. The baseline makes it meaningful.
3. **Choosing parameters on the test fold.** Detect: the grid search sees `actual`. Here it only sees `hist`.
4. **Scoring one origin only.** One lucky week proves nothing. Use many folds.
5. **Forgetting to undo differencing**, giving forecasts near zero. Detect: plot forecast against history.

Three extensions

1. Add prediction intervals from backtest errors (empirical quantiles).
2. Test a longer horizon (28 days) and show how the ranking changes.
3. Compare with a full seasonal ARIMA from a library, if available (not run here).

Interview talking points

- **"How do you evaluate a forecast?"** With a rolling backtest: train on the past, forecast the next block, move forward, repeat. I compare against a naive baseline and report a scaled error like MASE.

- **"Why not a random train/test split?"** Because time has order. A random split lets the model peek at the future, so the score is too good.
- **"What does differencing do?"** It subtracts an earlier value (for example 7 days ago) so that trend and weekly pattern drop out, leaving something steadier to model. You add it back when you forecast.

README outline

Question; data; the five methods in one sentence each; backtest design (with a picture of the origins); result table; honest limits (one series, one seed); how to run.

15.6 Project: Hypothesis-Testing Toolkit

Goal and why employers care

Write a small Python module with a one-sample t test, Welch t test, chi-square test of independence, one-way ANOVA, a permutation test, and Bonferroni, Holm and Benjamini-Hochberg corrections, all tested against known answers. Employers care because it proves you understand tests as formulas, not as buttons, and that you test your code like an engineer.

Skills used

- *Chapter 4, Hypothesis Testing in Depth*: t, chi-square and F statistics, degrees of freedom, permutation tests.
- *Chapter 5, Effect Sizes, Multiple Testing and How Data Fools You*: family-wise error and false discovery rate.
- *Chapter 2, Distributions in Depth*: t, chi-square and F distributions (we use scipy only for their tail probabilities).

Data

No data file. Tests use tiny hand-checkable inputs and random numbers with fixed seeds.

Architecture

```
hypo-toolkit/
├── hypo.py              all functions
├── test_hypo.py         plain assert tests, runnable without pytest
└── README.md
```

Step-by-step build

1. **Write each statistic from its formula**, then get the p-value from the matching tail function.
2. **Write the first test by hand before the code.** For [2, 4, 6, 8] against mean 3: $\bar{x} = 5$, $s^2 = 20/3$, standard error = $\sqrt{(s^2/n)} = \sqrt{(5/3)}$, $t = 2 / \sqrt{(5/3)}$.
3. **Compare with scipy** on random data.
4. **Add the permutation test.** Shuffle group labels, recompute the difference, count how often it is as extreme. Use (count + 1) / (permutations + 1) so a p-value is never exactly zero.
5. **Add corrections**, each with a hand-worked answer.
6. **Simulate the guarantees**: permutation p-values under the null are small only about 5% of the time; BH keeps the false discovery proportion under 5%.

The full module (about 60 lines):

```
import numpy as np
from scipy import stats

def one_sample_t(x, mu0):
    x = np.asarray(x, float); n = len(x)
    t = (x.mean() - mu0) / (x.std(ddof=1) / np.sqrt(n))
    return t, 2 * stats.t.sf(abs(t), n - 1)

def welch_t(a, b):
    a, b = np.asarray(a, float), np.asarray(b, float)
    va, vb = a.var(ddof=1)/len(a), b.var(ddof=1)/len(b)
    t = (a.mean() - b.mean()) / np.sqrt(va + vb)
    df = (va + vb)**2 / (va**2/(len(a)-1) + vb**2/(len(b)-1))
    return t, df, 2 * stats.t.sf(abs(t), df)

def chi_square_independence(table):
    obs = np.asarray(table, float)
    exp = obs.sum(1, keepdims=True) * obs.sum(0, keepdims=True) /
obs.sum()
    chi2 = ((obs - exp)**2 / exp).sum()
    df = (obs.shape[0]-1) * (obs.shape[1]-1)
    return chi2, df, stats.chi2.sf(chi2, df)
```

```
def one_way_anova(*groups):
    groups = [np.asarray(g, float) for g in groups]
    allx = np.concatenate(groups); k, n = len(groups), len(allx)
    ssb = sum(len(g) * (g.mean() - allx.mean())**2 for g in groups)
    ssw = sum(((g - g.mean())**2).sum() for g in groups)
    F = (ssb/(k-1)) / (ssw/(n-k))
    return F, (k-1, n-k), stats.f.sf(F, k-1, n-k)

def permutation_test(a, b, n_perm=10_000, seed=0):
    rng = np.random.default_rng(seed)
    a, b = np.asarray(a, float), np.asarray(b, float)
    obs = a.mean() - b.mean(); pool = np.concatenate([a, b]); na = len(a)
    count = 0
    for _ in range(n_perm):
        rng.shuffle(pool)
        count += abs(pool[:na].mean() - pool[na:].mean()) >= abs(obs) -
1e-12
    return obs, (count + 1) / (n_perm + 1)

def bonferroni(p):
    p = np.asarray(p, float); return np.minimum(p * len(p), 1.0)

def holm(p):                                    # step-down: smallest p
gets the biggest multiplier
    p = np.asarray(p, float); m = len(p); order = np.argsort(p)
    adj = np.empty(m); run = 0.0
    for rank, i in enumerate(order):
        run = max(run, (m - rank) * p[i]); adj[i] = min(run, 1.0)
    return adj

def benjamini_hochberg(p):                      # step-up from the largest
p
    p = np.asarray(p, float); m = len(p); order = np.argsort(p)[::-1]
    adj = np.empty(m); run = 1.0
    for rank, i in enumerate(order):
        run = min(run, p[i] * m / (m - rank)); adj[i] = run
    return adj
```

Four of the eight tests (the others compare Welch with scipy, check the permutation test against the t test, and check that the permutation null is calibrated):

```
def test_chi_square_known_answer():
    chi2, df, p = hypo.chi_square_independence([[10, 20], [20, 10]])   #
expected 15 each
    close(chi2, 4 * 25 / 15); assert df == 1

def test_anova_known_answer():
    F, df, p = hypo.one_way_anova([1, 2, 3], [2, 3, 4], [5, 6, 7])
    close(F, (26/2) / (6/6)); assert df == (2, 6)

def test_corrections_known_answer():
    p = [0.01, 0.04, 0.03, 0.005]
    assert np.allclose(hypo.bonferroni(p), [0.04, 0.16, 0.12, 0.02])
    assert np.allclose(hypo.holm(p), [0.03, 0.06, 0.06, 0.02])
    assert np.allclose(hypo.benjamini_hochberg(p), [0.02, 0.04, 0.04,
0.02])

def test_fdr_controls_false_discoveries():
    rng = np.random.default_rng(4); fdp = []
    for _ in range(200):
        p = np.concatenate([rng.uniform(size=90), rng.uniform(0, 0.001,
10)])  # first 90 are true nulls
        rej = hypo.benjamini_hochberg(p) < 0.05
        fdp.append(rej[:90].sum() / max(rej.sum(), 1))
    assert np.mean(fdp) < 0.05
```

Real output of `python3 test_hypo.py`:

```
PASS test_one_sample_t_by_hand
PASS test_welch_matches_scipy
PASS test_chi_square_known_answer
PASS test_anova_known_answer
PASS test_permutation_agrees_with_t_test
PASS test_permutation_null_is_uniform_ish
PASS test_corrections_known_answer
PASS test_fdr_controls_false_discoveries
8 tests passed
```

Checking the hand answers. Chi-square: in the table [[10, 20], [20, 10]] every expected count is 30 × 30 / 60 = 15, and each cell contributes (±5)² / 15 = 1.667, so the total is 4 × 1.667 = 6.667 = 4 × 25 / 15. ANOVA: group means 2, 3, 6, grand mean 11/3; SSB = 26, SSW = 6 (each group contributes 2), so F = (26/2) / (6/6) = 13. Corrections: sorted p-values 0.005, 0.01, 0.03, 0.04 with m = 4. Bonferroni multiplies by 4. Holm multiplies by 4, 3, 2, 1, then keeps the running maximum: 0.02, 0.03, 0.06, 0.06. BH computes p × 4 / rank, then keeps the running minimum

from the top: 0.02, 0.02, 0.04, 0.04 (0.01 × 4/2 = 0.02; 0.03 × 4/3 = 0.04; 0.04 × 4/4 = 0.04; 0.005 × 4/1 = 0.02).

Evaluation and acceptance criteria

- All tests pass from a clean clone, including the hand-computed ones.
- Each test statistic agrees with scipy to 6 decimal places (the p-value of Welch to 9).
- The permutation p-value is within 0.01 of the t-test p-value on normal data.
- Under a true null, about 5% of permutation p-values fall below 0.05 (accepted range here: 2% to 9% over 300 runs).
- Average false discovery proportion of BH below 5%.

Common pitfalls

1. **Using Student's t when variances differ.** Prefer Welch. Detect: test with groups of sizes 20 and 30 and SDs 1 and 2.
2. **Chi-square with tiny expected counts** (below about 5). Detect: print the expected table.
3. **A permutation p-value of exactly 0.** Use (count + 1) / (n + 1).
4. **Applying a correction to p-values that were already selected** as the best ones. Detect: m must equal all tests run.
5. **Mixing up Holm's step direction.** Detect: the known-answer test above.

Three extensions

1. Add Tukey's HSD after ANOVA.
2. Add a bootstrap and a permutation version of the correlation test.
3. Add effect sizes (Cohen's d, Cramér's V, eta squared) beside each p-value.

Interview talking points

- **"What is a p-value?"** If there were truly no effect, it is the chance of seeing a result at least this extreme. It is not the chance that the effect is real.
- **"Bonferroni versus Benjamini-Hochberg?"** Bonferroni controls the chance of even one false alarm and is strict. BH controls the share of false alarms among the things I flag, so it keeps more power when I run many tests.
- **"Why a permutation test?"** It needs few assumptions. If the label did not matter, shuffling labels should give similar differences, and I count how often the shuffles beat the real one.

README outline

Question; list of functions with formulas; testing strategy (hand answers, scipy, simulation); example report; limits; how to run.

Chapter recap

- Plan the question, the decision, and the measurable success criteria before writing code.
- Use generated data with known truth to test methods, and say clearly that it is generated.
- A bootstrap interval is a procedure; judge it by coverage. Tail statistics at small n are the weak spot (p90 covered 69% at n = 10).
- Regression: check normality, equal spread, independence, multicollinearity and influence, then fix and show before/after.
- Bayesian A/B: report the posterior, the probability of being better, the expected loss and the prior, and test the decision rule by simulation.
- Forecasting: always use a rolling backtest and a naive baseline, and use a scaled error such as MASE.
- A testing toolkit must be tested: hand answers, scipy comparisons and calibration simulations.
- Every project needs a README with a result, limits and how to run.

Item	Pattern
Percentile bootstrap	resample with replacement B times, take the 2.5% and 97.5% percentiles
Cook's distance flag	$D > 4/n$ (a starting point, not a law)
Leverage flag	$h > 2k/n$
VIF	$1 / (1 - R^2)$ of one input on the others
Beta-Binomial posterior	$\text{Beta}(a + s, b + n - s)$
Expected loss of choosing B	$E[\max(A - B, 0)]$
MASE	MAE / MAE of the lag-7 seasonal forecast on history

Holm	sort p, multiply by m, m−1, ..., 1, running max
BH	p × m / rank, running min from the largest

Practice set

Task 1 (easy). Apply Bonferroni to p-values 0.01, 0.04, 0.03, 0.005. What are the adjusted values and which are below 0.05?

Answer: Multiply by 4: 0.04, 0.16, 0.12, 0.02. Only the first and the last are below 0.05.

Task 2. A has 120 conversions in 2,400 visitors, with a Beta(1,1) prior. What is the posterior and its mean?

Answer: Beta(121, 2281). Mean = 121 / 2402 = 0.0504.

Task 3. For n = 400 houses, what is Cook's distance flag 4/n?

Answer: 4 / 400 = 0.01. Rows above it deserve a look, not automatic removal.

Task 4. A model has MASE 0.75. In plain words?

Answer: Its average error is 75% of the error of repeating last week, so it is 25% more accurate than that baseline.

Task 5 (find the bug). `idx = rng.choice(len(x), size=len(x), replace=False)` is used for a bootstrap. The standard error comes out as 0. Why?

Answer: Without replacement, each resample is just the data shuffled, so the mean never changes. Use `replace=True` (or `rng.integers`).

Task 6. A VIF of 6.47 for area. What R^2 does that mean for area regressed on the other inputs?

Answer: VIF = 1 / (1 − R^2), so R^2 = 1 − 1/6.47 = 0.845. Area is 84.5% explained by the other inputs.

Task 7 (interview). Your 95% bootstrap interval for p90 covered the truth 69% of the time at n = 10. Explain and advise.

Answer: With 10 points, the top 10% is about one value, so resamples cannot show how far the real tail extends. Advise collecting more data (coverage reached 93% at n = 100) or using a method with a model for the tail, and say plainly that the interval is too narrow.

Task 8 (interview). A teammate fits a forecast on all 300 days, then reports the error on days 250 to 300. What is wrong and how do you fix it?

Answer: The model saw those days while fitting (leakage), so the error is too small. Use a rolling-origin backtest where each forecast uses only earlier data, and compare against a seasonal naive baseline.

Prompt pack

✨ **AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI**

```
You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional
moving into data roles. Help me plan a statistics portfolio project: a
bootstrap and confidence-interval explorer on a delivery-times dataset.
Ask me three questions about my goals, then help me write the question,
the decision it supports, and three measurable success criteria. Then
propose a repo layout and a commit plan for five working sessions of one
hour each. Check my understanding by asking me to explain, in my own
words, what coverage of a confidence interval means.
```

✨ **AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI**

```
You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional
moving into data roles. I built a regression diagnostics report on a
housing-style dataset. Review my work step by step: check whether my
assumption checks (linearity, equal spread, normality, independence,
multicollinearity, influence) are complete, whether my fixes are
justified, and whether my README is honest about limits. Point out any
claim I cannot support. Here is my report: [PASTE HERE]. End with five
questions an interviewer might ask me about it.
```

✨ **AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI**

```
You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional
moving into data roles. I am building a Bayesian A/B test calculator with
Beta-Binomial posteriors and a decision rule. Help me debug it. My code
and output are here: [PASTE HERE]. Check the posterior parameters by hand,
check that my probability that B beats A is stable across random seeds,
and tell me how to simulate the decision rule under no effect and under a
real effect. Explain each step in simple English and say what each number
means.
```

✨ AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI

```
You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional
moving into data roles. Review my time-series forecasting study that
compares naive, exponential smoothing and an autoregressive model with a
rolling backtest. Check for data leakage, for a missing baseline, for
parameter choices made on the test data, and for too few folds. My code
and results are here: [PASTE HERE]. Give me a prioritised list of fixes,
then quiz me one question at a time about how rolling-origin evaluation
works.
```

✨ AI prompt: copy and paste into any AI

```
You are my patient, practical professor. I am a working professional
moving into data roles. I wrote a small hypothesis-testing module (t, chi-
square, ANOVA, permutation test, Bonferroni, Holm, Benjamini-Hochberg).
Help me design known-answer tests: give me eight small inputs I can
compute by hand, without the answers, then wait for my answers and check
them. After that, review my test file for gaps: [PASTE HERE]. Also suggest
two simulation tests that check that p-values and false discovery rates
behave as promised.
```

APPENDIX

CHEAT SHEET

Every key formula, command and pattern from Chapters 1 to 14, grouped by chapter. Use it for revision, not for first learning.

Read a row, then ask yourself: "Can I explain this in plain words and give a number?" If not, go back to the chapter named in the heading. Commands assume `import numpy as np`, `from scipy import stats`. Library calls for `statsmodels`, `lifelines`, `PuLP`, `OR-Tools`, `cvxpy` and `Optuna` were not run while writing this document, so test them in your own environment.

Chapter 1: Probability Through Problem Solving

Formula / pattern	Meaning
`C(n,k) = n!/(k!(n-k)!)`, `n!/(n-k)!`	Unordered and ordered choices
`P(≥1) = 1 − P(none)`	Complement trick
`P(A|B) = P(A and B)/P(B)`	
`P(H|E) = P(E|H)P(H)/P(E)`	
`posterior odds = prior odds × LR`	Odds form
`E[aX+b] = aE[X]+b`, `Var(aX+b) = a²Var(X)`	Linear transforms
`Var(X+Y) = VarX + VarY + 2Cov`	Variance of a sum
`stats.pearsonr / spearmanr / kendalltau`	Correlations; always plot

Chapter 2: Distributions in Depth

Formula / pattern	Meaning
`stats.binom(n,p).pmf/cdf/sf`	Count of yes in n tries

`stats.poisson(lam).ppf(0.99)`	Capacity quantile; mean = variance
`stats.expon(scale=1/rate)`	Waiting time (scale = mean)
`stats.lognorm(s=σ, scale=exp(μ))`	Waiting-time-like skewed data
`stats.weibull_min(c=k, scale=λ)`	Time to failure
`t = Z/√(χ²/k)`, `F = (χ²₁/d₁)/(χ²₂/d₂)`	Recipes for t and F
`E[Y| x] = μ_Y + ρσ_Y/σ_x (x−μ_x)`	
`π P = π`	Markov chain stationary distribution

Chapter 3: Sampling, Estimation, Confidence Intervals and the Bootstrap

Formula / pattern	Meaning
`SE = s/√n`	Standard error of a mean
`x̄ ± t*·SE` (`stats.t.interval`)	CI for a mean
`SE(p̂) = √(p̂(1−p̂)/n)`	Proportion SE
`stats.binomtest(k,n).proportion_ci(method="wilson")`	Proportion CI
`upper ≈ 3/n`	Rule of three (zero failures)
`λ̂ = n/Σx`	Exponential MLE
`x[rng.integers(0,n,(B,n))]`, `np.percentile(stat, [2.5,97.5])`	Bootstrap CI

Chapter 4: Hypothesis Testing in Depth

Task	Function
One-sample / Welch / paired t	`ttest_1samp`, `ttest_ind(equal_var=False)`, `ttest_rel`
Chi-square	`chisquare`, `chi2_contingency`, `fisher_exact`
ANOVA and post-hoc	`f_oneway`, `tukey_hsd`
Rank tests	`mannwhitneyu`, `wilcoxon`, `kruskal`
Permutation, normality, variance	`permutation_test`, `shapiro`, `kstest`, `levene`
Sample size	$n = 2(z_{\alpha/2} + z_{\beta})^2\sigma^2/\delta^2$ per group

A p-value is $P(\text{data this extreme} \mid H_0)$; it is uniform when H_0 is true. Halving the effect needs about 4 times the sample.

Chapter 5: Effect Sizes, Multiple Testing and How Data Fools You

Formula / pattern	Meaning
$d = (\bar{x}_1 - \bar{x}_2)/s_p$	Cohen's d
$OR = (a/b)/(c/d)$, $SE(\ln OR) = \sqrt{1/a+1/b+1/c+1/d}$	Odds ratio and its CI
$1 - (1-\alpha)^m$	Chance of at least one false alarm
Bonferroni $p \cdot m$; Holm step-down; BH $p \cdot m/k$	Adjusted p-values
`stats.false_discovery_control(p)`	BH in scipy
$PPV = \text{power} \cdot \text{prior}/(\text{power} \cdot \text{prior} + \alpha(1-\text{prior}))$	Share of significant findings that are real

Chapter 6: Linear Regression Deeply

Formula / pattern	Meaning
$\hat{\beta} = (X^TX)^{-1}X^Ty$ (`np.linalg.lstsq`)	OLS
$SE = \sqrt{(s^2 \cdot \text{diag}((X^TX)^{-1}))}$, $s^2 = SSE/(n-p)$	Coefficient SEs
$adjR^2 = 1-(1-R^2)(n-1)/(n-p)$	Adjusted R^2
$VIF_j = 1/(1-R^2_j)$	Collinearity
$D = e^2h/(p\ s^2(1-h)^2)$; rule $4/n$	Cook's distance
`sm.OLS(y,X).fit(cov_type="HC3")`	Robust errors (not run here)

Chapter 7: Regularization and Model Selection

Formula / pattern	Meaning
Test error = bias² + variance + noise	The trade-off
Ridge $\beta = (X^TX+\lambda I)^{-1}X^Ty$	L2 shrinkage
Lasso soft-threshold `sign(ρ)·max(`	ρ
$AIC = 2k - 2\ell$, $BIC = k \ln n - 2\ell$	Lower is better, same data only
$\text{mean}((e_i/(1-h_{ii}))^2)$	LOOCV for linear models
`cross_val_score`, `RidgeCV`, `LassoCV`	scikit-learn tools

Chapter 8: Generalized Linear Models

Formula / pattern	Meaning
Family + linear predictor η + link	GLM recipe
$\text{logit} = \ln(p/(1-p))$, $p = 1/(1+e^{-\eta})$	Logistic
e^{β}	Odds ratio (logistic), rate ratio (Poisson)

`AME = mean(p(1−p))·β`	Average marginal effect
NB variance `μ + αμ²` ; Pearson dispersion near 1	Overdispersion check
`Deviance = 2(ℓ_sat − ℓ_model)`	Compare models

Chapter 9: Bayesian Statistics

Formula / pattern	Meaning
`posterior ∝ likelihood × prior`	Bayes
Beta-Binomial `Beta(a+k, b+n−k)`	Conversion rates
Gamma-Poisson `Gamma(α+S, β+m)`	Event rates
`stats.beta.ppf([.025,.975], a, b)`	Credible interval
`mean(sample_B > sample_A)`	P(B > A)
Metropolis accept `min(1, post(θ′)/post(θ))`	MCMC; check trace, R-hat

Chapter 10: Time Series Statistics

Formula / pattern	Meaning
`Δy = y_t − y_{t−1}` ; seasonal `y_t − y_{t−m}`	Differencing
ACF band `±1.96/√n`	Is a lag significant?
ADF: reject non-stationarity if stat < about −2.86	Stationarity test
`ARIMA(p,d,q)` , `SARIMAX(seasonal_order=(P,D,Q,m))`	`statsmodels` models
SES `L_new = αy + (1−α)L_old`	Exponential smoothing
`MASE = MAE / naive MAE` ; Ljung-Box p > 0.05	Baseline check and residual check

Chapter 11: Survival Analysis and Mixed Models

Formula / pattern	Meaning
Row = (time, event); event 0 = censored	Data layout
$S(t) = \prod (1 - d_i/n_i)$	Kaplan-Meier; median = first S ≤ 0.5
$\hat{\lambda}$ = events/exposure, median $\ln 2/\hat{\lambda}$	Exponential model
`h(t\	x) = $h_0(t) \cdot \exp(\beta x)$, HR = e^{β}`
`KaplanMeierFitter`, `CoxPHFitter`, `logrank_test`	`lifelines` (not run here)
$y = \mu + a_g + \varepsilon$; $ICC = \tau^2/(\tau^2+\sigma^2)$	Random-intercept model
$w = \tau^2/(\tau^2+\sigma^2/n)$; estimate $= \mu + w(\bar{y}-\mu)$	Partial pooling
`smf.mixedlm("y ~ x", df, groups=df["g"])`	`statsmodels` (not run here)

Chapter 12: Experimental Design and Causal Basics

Formula / pattern	Meaning
$ATE = \text{mean}(Y(1) - Y(0))$	Average treatment effect
$n = (z_{\alpha/2} \cdot \sqrt{(2\bar{p}(1-\bar{p}))} + z_{\beta} \cdot \sqrt{(p_1q_1+p_2q_2)})^2/(p_2-p_1)^2$	n per arm, two proportions (10% to 12%: 3,841)
$\chi^2 = \Sigma(O-E)^2/E$	Sample ratio mismatch check (alarm at $p < 0.001$)
$DiD = (T_{after}-T_{before}) - (C_{after}-C_{before})$	Difference-in-differences; needs parallel trends
$y = b_0 + b_1 \cdot treat + b_2 \cdot post +$	Regression DiD; b_3 is the effect

$b_3 \cdot \text{treat} \cdot \text{post}$	
Randomize, stratify, A/A test	Design habits

Chapter 13: Optimization and Information Theory

Formula / pattern	Meaning
$f'' \geq 0$ (Hessian PSD)	Convex: local minimum = global
$\theta \leftarrow \theta - \eta \nabla L$	Gradient descent; for x^2, need $0 < \eta < 1$
$v = \beta v + g;\ \theta \leftarrow \theta - \eta v$	Momentum
$s = 0.9s + 0.1g^2;\ \theta \mathrel{-}= \eta g/(\sqrt{s}+\varepsilon)$	RMSProp; Adam adds momentum and bias correction; AdamW decouples weight decay
$\theta \leftarrow \theta - H^{-1}g$	Newton (one step on a quadratic); `minimize(method="L-BFGS-B")`
$L = f - \lambda g$; KKT: $\mu \geq 0$, $\mu \cdot g = 0$	Constrained optimum; multipliers are prices
`linprog(c, A_ub, b_ub, bounds, method="highs")`	LP; negate c to maximise; `res.ineqlin.marginals` = shadow prices
`milp(c, constraints, integrality, bounds)`, `dual_annealing`	Integer and global search
$H = -\Sigma p \log p$, $KL = H(p,q) - H(p)$, $I = H(X)+H(Y)-H(X,Y)$	Entropy, KL, mutual information
`stats.entropy(p, q, base=2)`	Entropy / KL in bits

Chapter 14: Interview Bank and Pitfalls

Pattern	Use
Plain sentence, example, why it matters, limit	Answer method

$1 - 0.95^k$	False positives in k tests (20 tests: 64%)
$\text{mean} \pm t \cdot s/\sqrt{n}$	Small-sample CI (t = 2.064 for n = 25)
$z = (p_2 - p_1)/\sqrt{\bar{p}(1-\bar{p})(2/n)}$	Quick two-proportion test
`np.var(x, ddof=1)`	numpy default is ddof=0
Ask for the control and the baseline	Every scenario question

An Honest Closing Note

What you can now do. You can solve probability problems and check them by simulation. You can choose a distribution from a story, build and interpret confidence intervals and bootstraps, and run and explain hypothesis tests with effect sizes and multiple-testing corrections. You can fit and diagnose linear models and GLMs, regularize and compare models, reason in a Bayesian way, handle time series, censored durations and grouped data, design and sanity-check an experiment, estimate effects with difference-in-differences, run gradient descent and linear programs, and use entropy and KL. Most importantly you have a habit: ask what the data really are, how they were chosen, and what could fool you.

What this document does not cover. There is no deep derivation of the maths (see your Math PDF for linear algebra, calculus and probability basics). Causal inference is only introduced: propensity scores, instrumental variables and regression discontinuity are named, not taught. Survival analysis and mixed models are introductions: no competing risks, time-varying covariates, crossed random effects or GLMMs. Multivariate methods (factor analysis, MANOVA), kernel smoothing, state-space models, deep learning theory and large-scale optimization are left for other documents. The library calls for `lifelines`, `statsmodels`, `PuLP`, `OR-Tools`, `cvxpy` and `Optuna` were not run while writing, so run them yourself before trusting them.

What to practise next.

1. Take one real dataset (delivery times or exam marks work well) and write a one-page analysis: distribution, interval, test, effect size, assumptions and limits.
2. Re-implement three methods from scratch (a bootstrap, a Kaplan-Meier curve, gradient descent) without looking.
3. Run an A/B test simulation with a sample-size calculation, an SRM check and a peeking

experiment.

4. Do the Chapter 14 scenario prompts aloud, with a timer, until your answers sound calm and short.
5. Move on to machine learning, using this document as the foundation, and return here whenever a result looks too good.

Statistics is a skill of doubt used well. Doubt your data, doubt your p-value, then act on the best evidence you have. That is what employers pay for.